

Forum IAS

RED BOOK

INDIAN SOCIETY AND SOCIAL ISSUES

GENERAL STUDIES PAPER - I & 2

For Civil Services Examination

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1. SALIENT FEATURES OF INDIAN SOCIETY

The Greek philosopher **Aristotle** has said, “Man is by nature, a social animal and society is something that precedes an individual.” But what does being a social animal mean? What is the meaning of the term ‘society’, and what role does it play for an individual? Let us begin with some basics. Different scholars have defined society differently, such as:

R.M. Maclever has defined society as “a web of social relations which is always changing.”

According to **J.H. Fichter**– “A society may be defined as a network of interconnected major groups viewed as a unit and sharing a common culture.”

It has to be noted that society is not just a random collection of people. It is a highly functional aggregate of individuals along with their interactions, relationships and various social institutions. Society is a group of individuals sharing spatial territory, having cultural affinities and typically subjected to same political authority. Further, society is not a monolith, but it is characterized by cooperation, tolerance and conflicts, depending upon time and context. Society is a very dynamic abstract entity. It is an abstract concept in a sense that it cannot be seen or perceived with senses; and dynamic in the sense that it evolves over time.

However, society has a deep impact on survival, development and wellness of humans. It is the ability of humans to create a society and social institutions that has helped them emerge as the dominant specie on earth. Society provides a safe environment for people to work and prosper. It has been widely accepted that social capital is an important determinant of success of people. It provides a support system when people are in trouble. Society also includes family and friends with whom a person can share their happiness. Further, society has enabled humans to overcome limitations and constraints that a single human cannot surpass. There are multiple services that we take for granted, but which cannot be provided without society. For example, in case of education or agriculture, no single person can know everything or produce food for himself alone. These are outcomes of collective efforts.

India is one of the world’s oldest civilizations and it is continuously evolving. Our ability to absorb and assimilate new ideas has made this continuity possible. During its long journey, Indian civilization has evolved various practices and customs, which now have become salient features of our society. These practices and customs are still undergoing continuous transformation. Due to her uniqueness and distinctness, India has earned the sobriquet ‘**the epitome of the world**’.

1.1. Major sources of diversity in Indian context

Diversity refers to differences which mark off one group of people from another. These differences may be biological, religious, linguistic, etc. For example, we have racial diversity on the basis of biological differences. India is a multi-cultural, multi-religious and multi- linguistic society. It is one of the most diverse societies of the world with plurality rooted in its social and cultural richness. Diversity does not mean deprivation; infact, the diverse elements of Indian society have retained their inherent value and are equally important in their own domains. Being one of the oldest civilizations, India had extensive time period to develop and evolve various social institutions and cultures resulting in diversity of society.

Foreign influence in the form of influx of various religions, ethnicities and cultures due to foreign invasions (Turks, Mughals, Britishers), proximity to trade routes connecting Central Asia and Europe, and visit of travellers (Fa-Hein, Ibn Battuta, Hiuen Tsang, etc.) led to cultural interaction and assimilation of foreign features in our society. Geographical barriers such as the Himalayas in the north, hill ranges (Vindhya and Satpura) in central India and presence of dense forests restricted free movement of people. It led to

societies developing their unique identity and culture on the basis of food habits, dressing patterns, festivals and cultural activities across these divisions. For example- cultural differences between the Aryan and Dravidian communities. Similarly, dense forests led to the isolation and a distinct growth of tribal culture. Additionally, the presence of numerous kingdoms since ancient times and their distinct set of policies led to the development of many local languages and diverse socio- cultural practices. For example: Bengali language developed under the patronage of the Pala kings.

The philosophies of *Vasudhaiva-Kutumbakam*, tolerance and open outlook of India have heavily contributed to the enrichment of India's diversity. For example- the persecuted communities such as Parsis and Jews were granted asylum in India and their culture influenced our social practices, especially culinary traditions. The diversity of the Indian society has also led to a vibrant Indian culture i.e. the general customs and beliefs of a particular group of people. The Indian cultural mosaic consists of various elements such as religion, castes, languages, traditions, races, art and architecture. Observing the rich diversity of India, Thomas Berry has said "*the greater the diversity, the greater the perfection*". In the next section, we shall discuss major elements of diversity in the Indian context.

1.1.1. Caste

Caste is a unique feature of Indian society and also an element of cultural diversity of India. There are more than 3,000 castes in India. The word caste has its genesis in the Portuguese word 'casta', meaning species, race, or kind. It is **derived from the varna system – based on the occupational division of society**. Each *varna* is further segmented into a hierarchy of caste or *Jatis*. The term is also synonymous with *Jat*, *Biradri*, and *Samaj*. Caste system is characterized by notion of purity and pollution. It indicates the association of higher status with purity and lower status with pollution. The most commonly cited defining features of caste are:

1. Caste is determined by birth i.e. a child is born into caste of parents.
2. Membership in caste involves strict rules about marriage.
3. Caste membership also involves rules about food consumption and sharing.
4. It is a system consisting of many castes arranged in hierarchy and rank.
5. Caste also involves sub division i.e., castes almost always have sub-castes, sub-sub castes etc.
6. Castes were traditionally linked with occupations.

The caste system is not confined to Hindus alone. It is prevalent among **Muslim, Christian, Sikh** as well as other communities. One may have heard of the hierarchy of **Shaikh, Saiyed, Mughal** and **Pathan among Muslims**. Furthermore, there are castes like **teli (oil pressers), dhobi (washerman), darjee (tailor)**, etc. as well. Since a vast majority of Christians in India are converted from Hindu fold, the converts have carried the caste system into Christianity. **Among the Sikh** too, we have castes like **Jat Sikh and Mazhabi Sikh** (lower castes).

1.1.2. Class

Class can be defined as a group of people sharing similar position in the social hierarchy. In ancient times, stratification of traditional Indian society was based upon caste system, wherein, social hierarchy was fixed, rigid and transmitted across generations. In the administrative context, society was classified as the ruling class, nobility, officials/bureaucracy, common man and the slaves or '*dasas*'. The '*Arthashastra*' says that, a man could become a slave, by birth, by voluntary selling himself, by being captured in a war or by means of a punishment. Feudalism also gave rise to a new social structure and classes in the form of landlords and peasants, based on land and property ownership/rights. However, with the advent of modernization, these systems are slowly getting flexible and giving rise to new classes. The emergence of a middle class with rational

outlook is a testimony to the fact. Society can now be classified into various classes such as upper, middle, lower etc. based on a number of factors including birth, economic status, financial and social achievements, etc.

1.1.3. Region

India is divided into **28 states and 8 UTs** with **each state** having its **unique cultural & traditional identity** due to differences in **geographical, cultural & socio-economic conditions**. Even within a state, diversities exist. For example, **Maharashtra** comprises in itself many **sub-regional identities** like Vidharbha, Konkan, Marathwada & west Maharashtra due to differences in socio-economic & geographic factors. Regional differences also affect cultural traditions, for instance, in North India, there are mostly patrilineal groups and marriage is prohibited between the same gotra or clan, whereas, in Southern India, matrilineal and matrilineal systems also exist and marriage alliances are often made within the members of extended family. Cooking styles and habits, clothing patterns, festivals, etc. also vary across regions. The people living in mountainous regions have a 'pahadi' culture and have dependence on dairy and poultry, whereas habits of people living in coastal areas are influenced by the hot and humid climate and staple diet includes seafood.

Regional identities are also based on a strong sense of attachment to a place, i.e., topophilia, which has sometimes given rise to secessionist expressions, for example, the demand for 'Dravida Nadu' by the southern states. India has dealt with these regional diversities by providing a platform for engagement with different states through **interstate and zonal councils**. Recently constituted **GST council** is also a good example for ensuring competitive and cooperative federalism.

In the context of the diversity of India, can it be said that the regions form cultural units rather than the States? Give reasons with examples for your view point. (UPSC 2017)

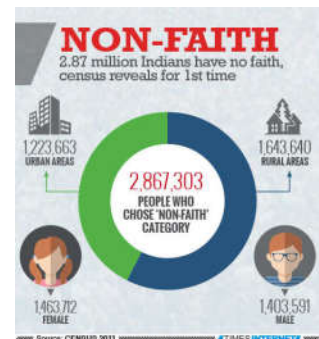
1.1.4. Religion

India is the land where almost all the major religions of the world are practiced by their respective followers. Religious diversity is one of the most important features of our culture. All major religions from Hinduism, Islam, Sikhism, Christianity, Buddhism, Jainism and Zoroastrianism can be found in India. India has a history of accepting, nurturing and influencing different religious ideas and beliefs. For example- Sufism which was a broader, less conservative and transcending version of Islam has been deeply influenced by the liberal Indian values. Among all, Hinduism is the followed by majority of people in India.



Religion	Percentage	Estimated population (In crores)
Hindu	79.80%	96.62
Muslim	14.23%	17.22
Christian	2.30%	2.78
Sikh	1.72%	2.08
Buddhist	0.70%	84.43
Jain	0.37%	44.52
Other Religion	0.66%	79.38
Not stated	0.24%	28.67

Figure 1: All India Religion Census Data 2011



Religious life but secular state:

India is home to 1.4 billion people belonging to a variety of ethnicities and religions. While the majority religion is Hinduism, there is also substantial population of Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains and adherents of folk religions. In a 2015 Pew Research Centre survey, eight-in-ten Indians said that religion is very important in their lives. Religion dominates India's value system, worldview and overall way of life. However, the Indian Constitution mandates that the Indian State be secular and has provided religious freedom to all, as a Fundamental Right, under Article 25. According to the Constitution-makers, only a secular state could realize its objectives to ensure that- numerical strength of majority does not become 'tyranny of majority', that some members do not dominate other members of the same religious community; and that the State does not enforce any particular religion nor take away the religious freedom of individuals.

Sects within religion:

There are sects within each religion as well. Hinduism, for example, has many sects including **Shaiva**, **Shakti**, and **Vaishnava**. More recently, some new cults have come up such as **Radha Soami**, **Saibaba**, etc. Similarly, **Islam** is divided into **Shia** and **Sunni**; Sikhism into **Namdhari** and **Nirankari**; Jainism into **Digambar** and **Shwetambar**; and Buddhism into **Hinayana** and **Mahayana**.

Despite the presence of diverse religions, there are elements of commonality across them. Indian society and culture preaches respect, love, compassion and non-violence for all living beings. Central to the Indian philosophy are the concepts of '*Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*' (the world is one family) and '*Atithi devo bhavah*' (Guest is like God- one of the taglines of Indian Tourism). The ideologies of *Dharma*, *Karma*, *Varna* and *Purushartha* are also integral to the Indian way of living. *Dharma* here does not mean religion, but it stands for duty, obligation, righteousness and upholding of the natural law. It is a way of life in which ethical values are considered supreme and everyone is expected to perform his or her duty according to their position in society and stage of life (*ashrama*). The four *ashrama* are: *brahmacharya*, stage of studentship; *grihastha*, stage of the householder; *vanaprastha*, life in the forest; and *sanyasa*, renunciation. The concept of four ends of life (*Purushartha*) is also very important as they are needed for fulfilment of human aspirations. These are righteousness (*dharma*), worldly gains (*artha*), fulfilment of desires (*kama*) and liberation (*moksha*). In the *Bhagavad-Gita*, selfless action (*Nishkama karma*) is advocated. It is a desire-less action which is required to be performed without consideration of personal consequences i.e., duty needs to be performed without expectation of fruits.

1.1.5. Language

India is called as a "tower of veritable languages" due to its linguistic diversity. According to 2001 Census, India has 122 major and 1599 minor languages. As per the latest analysis of Census 2011, more than 19,500 languages or dialects are spoken in India as mother tongue. For instance, under the "Hindi" language grouping, there are nearly 50 other languages. Bhojpuri (spoken by more than 5 crore people, and with its own cinema, theatre, literature, vocabulary and style) comes under "Hindi". Similarly, various Rajasthani dialects spoken by more than 3 crore people of Rajasthan also come under Hindi. To preserve linguistic identities, Indian Constitution recognizes 22 languages under Eighth Schedule and also recognizes linguistic minorities and their right to preserve their language under Article 29. In a pluri-lingual land like India, this linguistic diversity has varied from age to age. Sanskrit, Arabic or Persian, Hindi and English have been used as official languages by rulers and administrators over the years.



India is a vibrant multilingual country with a variety of languages and dialects. Language is a source of cultural diversity as well as unity and a collective identity for Indians. A. R. Desai rightly calls India a spectacle of 'Museum of tongues'. For example, there are 200 words describing snow in the Himalayan region alone. The diversity is also apparent from the presence of many languages like Hindi, Urdu, Punjabi (Indo-Aryan), Tamil, Telugu, Kannada and Malayalam (Dravidian), tribal languages of central India (Austic), the tribal languages of North Eastern India (Sino-Tibetan languages), an old form of Portuguese spoken in villages close to Mumbai, a form of Japanese spoken in parts of Gujarat, etc.

Languages spoken in India can be divided into different families such as:

1. **Tibeto-Burman language family:** mostly spoken in the North Eastern States. Example: Assamese, Manipuri, Bodo, etc.
2. **Dravidian language family:** mostly spoken in the southern part of India by **20 percent** of India's population. **Malayalam, Kannada, Tamil, and Telugu** are the four major Dravidian languages.
3. **Indo-Aryan language family:** Languages like Hindi, Sanskrit, Urdu, Bengali, Kashmiri, Marathi etc. are part of this family and are spoken in most of the parts of North India. The languages of the Indo-Aryan family are spoken by 75 percent of India's total population.
4. **Austro-Asiatic language family:** Most of the tribal languages spoken in Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Odisha are part of this family e.g., Khasi, Santhali, Meitei, etc.

According to UNESCO, any language that is spoken by less than 10,000 people is potentially endangered. The People's Linguistic Survey of India conducted in 2010, found that 600 of our indigenous languages were dying. Examples of such languages include Wadari (Karnataka, Maharashtra), Moran (Assam), Kolhati (Maharashtra), etc. The Bo language in Andaman disappeared in 2010 and the Majhi language in Sikkim disappeared in 2015. When a language disappears it goes forever, taking with it the knowledge gathered over centuries. With it also goes a unique world view. As a result, the 2001 UNESCO 'Universal Declaration on Cultural Diversity' accepted the principle of "Safeguarding the linguistic heritage of humanity". UNESCO has also launched a linguistic diversity network and brought out an **Atlas** of the World's languages in danger, which highlights the central place of language in the world's heritage.

Linguistic conflicts in India:

Post-independence India has experienced various types of linguistic conflicts such as demands for the **organization of states based on language** that led to enactment of **State Reorganization Act 1956**, issue of a National language for India, **anti-Hindi** agitations in Tamil Nadu in 1960s that had acquired secessionist overtones, etc. Present day **Gorkhaland issue** is also based on linguistic conflicts. The National Education Policy 2020 also recommends the 'three language formula' (which is a cause of conflict due to allegations of Hindi imposition) to be followed in all the states, with the medium of instruction to be in the mother-tongue/local language in primary classes.

Three-Language Formula (Kothari Commission 1968) includes study of "Hindi, English and modern Indian language (preferably one of the southern languages) in the Hindi speaking states and Hindi, English and the regional language in the non-Hindi speaking states"

Classical languages of India:

The **criteria** evolved by the Government of India to determine declaration of a language as a **Classical language** is as under:

1. High antiquity of its early texts/recorded history over a period of 1500-2000 years;
2. A body of ancient literature/texts, which is considered a valuable heritage by generations of speakers;
3. The literary tradition be original and not borrowed from another speech community;
4. The classical language and literature being distinct from modern, there may also be a discontinuity between the classical language and its later forms or its offshoots.

At present there are **6** languages declared by the Government as a classical language. These are Tamil (2004), Sanskrit (2005), Kannada (2008), Telugu (2008), Malayalam (2013) and Odia (2014). The following **benefits** are available for languages which are declared as classical languages:

1. Two major annual international awards for scholars of eminence in the concerned language.
2. A Centre of Excellence for Studies in Classical Languages can be set up.
3. The University Grants Commission can be requested to create, to start with at least in Central Universities, a certain number of professional chairs for classical languages, for scholars of eminence in the concerned language.

1.1.6. Race and Ethnicity

India is a melting pot of races and is an ethnological museum. The ancestors of majority of the present population, have migrated to India from surrounding territories. According to the Anthropological Survey of India, Indian population is constituted of major races of the world such as:

1. **Negritos:** They are the people who belong to the black racial stock as found in Africa. They have black skin color, frizzle hair, thick lips, etc. In India, some of the tribes in South India, such as the **Kadar**, the **Irula**, and the **Paniyan** have distinct Negrito strain. In Andaman and Nicobar, some Negritos are found like **Onge** and **Jarawas**.
2. **Proto-Australoid:** The Proto-Australoid race consists of an ethnic group, which includes the Australian aborigines and other peoples of southern Asia and Pacific islands. In India, the tribes of Middle India belong to this strain. Some of these tribes are the **Ho** of **Singhbhum, Bihar, and the Bhil** and **Chenchus** of the **Vindhya ranges**.
3. **Mongoloids:** **North Eastern regions** have tribes of Mongoloid strain. A slightly different kind of Mongoloid racial stock is found in the Brahmaputra Valley. The Mikir- Bodo group of tribes and the Angami Nagas represent the best examples of Mongoloid racial composition in India. Naga, Garo, Khasi, Mizo, Daflas and Mishmi tribe of North-East have the strain of Mongoloids.
4. **Mediterranean:** The Mediterranean races relate to the white race. In India, South India has the tribes of Mediterranean Strain.
5. **Western Brachycephals:** The Western Brachycephals are divided into the following three sub- groups:
 - a. **Alpenoid:** The Alpenoid are characterized by broad head, medium stature, and light skin, found amongst Bania castes of Gujarat, the Kayasthas of Bengal, etc.
 - b. **Dinaric:** They are characterized by a broad head, long nose, tall stature, and dark skin color, found amongst the Brahmins of Bengal, the non-Brahmins of Karnataka.
 - c. **Armenoid:** They are characterized by features similar to Dinaric. The Armenoid have a more marked shape of the back of the head, a prominent and narrow nose. The Parsis of Bombay show typical characteristics of the Armenoid race.
6. **Nordic:** The Nordic races belong to the physical type, characterized by tall stature, long head, light skin and hair, and blue eyes. In India, they are found in different parts in the north of the country, especially in Punjab and Rajputana.

Discrimination based on race is present in India. For instance – discrimination against northeast people based on physical appearance. However, despite presence of several races, comparatively, racism is not a big problem in India as **intermixing among races** has been much more than the inter mixing of caste (limited due to caste endogamy). For example- Nordic race mixed with the Mediterranean race constitutes the major portion of the population of North India. This has led to an increase in inter – race tolerance and solidarity. **Racism** in India and racial hierarchy does not have backing of any scripture or text. In **absence of legitimizing support** of race superiority, **race has not been the basis of power and privileges** in India. Thus, racism has not developed into as big a problem in India, as casteism (the **hierarchy** engrained in **caste system** – based on purity and pollution, finds its base in **Sanskrit text of Hindu religion** and thus it is sacred.) Moreover, unlike west, which has a historical burden related to racism, slavery and doctrine of white man's supremacy, India does not have a legacy of race-based discrimination and subjugation.

Ethnicity:

An ethnic group is one whose members share a distinct awareness of a common cultural identity, separating them from other groups around them. India is a colourful canvas portraying a unique assimilation of ethnic groups displaying varied cultures and religions. The variety in race, culture, religion, etc. accounts for the existence of different ethnic groups who, although, live within the sanctums of one single nation, profess different social habits and characteristics.

Ethnic diversities in India are primarily found among tribal areas of **Central India & North East India**. Policy of “**Tribal Panchsheel**” followed by India has ensured that tribals integrate with mainstream according to their own pace at which they feel comfortable. In order to **protect their unique culture & traditions**, these areas are **classified as scheduled areas** in Constitution and **given special status through Schedules 5 and 6**.

1.1.7. Tribes

Tribes are groups of people engaged in primitive modes of production and sustenance, at secluded places, away from civilization and mainstream society. They are not homogenous and possess a diversity in their characteristics and geographical spread. They live at different levels of socio-economic development and are prevalent all over the country, from the foot hills of the Himalayas to the lands tip of Lakshadweep and from the plains of Gujarat to the hills in the North-East. The Indian tribes are not monolithic as compared to tribes of other countries. People belonging to same tribes can have different characteristics in different regions. For example, the Mundas of Jharkhand are multi-lingual, speak chaste Hindi and chew tobacco; while that of Odisha speak Odia and chew paan; whereas the Mundas of West Bengal speak Bengali and consume fish. The tribal population of India constitutes nearly 8 percent of the total population.



The present popular meaning of ‘Tribe’ in India refers to a category of people, included in the list of Scheduled Tribes by the government. The term ‘scheduled tribe’ is primarily an administrative and constitutional concept. Article 366 (25) of the Constitution of India refers to Scheduled Tribes as those communities, who are in accordance with Article 342 of the Constitution. The essential characteristics laid down by the Lokur Committee, for a community to be identified as Scheduled Tribes are primitive traits, distinctive culture, shyness of contact with the community at large, geographical isolation and social and economic backwardness. The PVTGs (Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups) are the marginalized sections of the Scheduled tribes of India. PVTG is not a Constitutional category, nor are these constitutionally recognized communities. They are a government of India classification created with the purpose of enabling improvement

in the conditions of certain communities with particularly low development. The criteria followed for determination of PVTGs are as under:

1. A pre-agriculture level of technology;
2. A stagnant or declining population;
3. Extremely low literacy; and
4. A subsistence level of economy.

Among the 75 listed PVTGs, the highest number are found in Odisha (13), followed by Andhra Pradesh (12), Bihar including Jharkhand (9), Madhya Pradesh including Chhattisgarh (7), Tamil Nadu (6), Kerala and Gujarat having five groups each. The remaining PVTGs live in West Bengal (3) Maharashtra (3), two each in Karnataka and Uttarakhand and one each in Rajasthan, Tripura and Manipur. All the four tribal groups in Andaman, and one in Nicobar Islands, are recognised as PVTGs. The Saharia people of Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan are the largest among the PVTGs with population more than 4 lakhs. The smallest population size among the PVTGs are the Sentinelese (as per the last contact effort on March 9, 2005, groups of 32 and 13 persons were sighted at different places).

1. What makes the Indian society unique in sustaining its culture? Discuss. (UPSC 2019)
2. Do we have cultural pockets of small India all over the nation? Elaborate with examples. (UPSC 2019)
3. Describe any four cultural elements of diversity in India and rate their relative significance in building a national identity. (UPSC 2015)

1.2. Social systems and institutions

1.2.1. Family, Joint Family and kinship

Family is a group of individuals connected by **conjugal relationships** based on marriage of two individuals or **consanguineal relationships** based on blood relations between kin. Family system is one of the most cohesive, cementing force at the heart of traditional Indian society. It is an institution and a typical symbol of the collectivist culture of India, right from the ancient times. Family structure refers to the **way power is shared** and exercised within family, relationship pattern and hierarchy, roles and responsibilities of different family members, size of the family etc.



Types of family:

1. **Nuclear family:** It can be defined as a small family composed of a **single couple and their offspring**, that constitute a unit.
2. **Joint family:** A joint family, also known as undivided family, is an extended family arrangement consisting of many generations living in the same household, bound by common relationships. Joint family in India, has been regarded more as a value than a mere practice. However, various changes in society and the social mindset have led to a decline in the incidence of joint families.

Reasons for breakdown of Joint family system:

Both State and market have led to the breakdown of joint family system in India. Legally, the enactment of the Land Ceiling Act, meant that people had to register family lands in the name of family members to retain their hold on the land. Earlier, sole control lay in the hands of the 'karta'. Consequently, in case of family feuds, it became easier for divisions to occur- leading to breakdown of the family, which was earlier held together by economic dependence. Property inheritance rights also made it easy for family members to

demand their share and leave as opposed to earlier control of the head of the family. Further, with the enactment of legislations providing social security to individuals in times of crises such as sickness, old age, delivery, death etc. the importance of joint family as an agency of social insurance has been relegated to the background.

New occupations requiring higher mobility have also been a very important cause for joint families disintegrating into nuclear units. Increasing family incomes have made it possible to have separate households now. Industrialization and urbanization have necessitated smaller, more mobile units of family than a large joint family. Moreover, high cost of living in urban areas necessitates keeping smaller families in cities.

Growing individualism has made living in smaller families more convenient to new goals of self-growth and progress. With consumerism as a guiding ideology, quest to earn more and more, places higher importance on mobility. Moving nuclear family is much simpler than moving the entire joint family. This has been aided by rising rental housing societies, hotels, etc. Moreover, increasing secularization of society has made relations more for personal convenience and commitment than as a religious duty.

Many of the functions of the joint family- providing economic security in case of losses, care for the aged, child care, etc. are now performed by house-helpers, social security and pensions, old age homes, schools and child care homes. But this situation is not universal as there are instances of increasing joint families in urban areas. Also, the families have shown “functional jointness” wherein they come together in times of need despite living at different places.

1. *“Indian society has witnessed a breakdown of the joint family system.” Discuss the reasons behind it. What emerging trends can be seen in the institution of family in contemporary times?*
2. *The life cycle of a joint family depends on economic factors rather than social values. Discuss. (UPSC 2014)*

However, changes have been observed in the institution of family in contemporary times. For instance, the traditional authority held by elders has become more democratized. Patriarchal make-up of the family is witnessing a decline. Even the earlier subordinate women in the family, have come to occupy an important role in the decision making in the family. Both husband and wife now play an instrumental and effective role, as compared to the earlier rigid role differentiation. For example, increasing cases of both parents doing full-time work. Additionally, relations have become more individualistic and collective. There is a growing emphasis on understanding in the family than on obligations. Newer forms of families like live-in families, single-parent families have also started to make an appearance.

Patriarchy:

It refers to **male domination in social life**. According to the sociological **theory**, patriarchy is the result of sociological constructions that are passed down from generation to generation. In this type of social system men hold the primary power, predominate in the roles of **political leadership, moral authority, special privilege and control of property**. They also hold the power in the domain of the family, as fatherly figures. For example, male child preference, honour killing, etc.

Changes in laws by the government have also impacted the pattern of relationships in family. For instance, independent India enacted personal codes (like Hindu Marriage Act) and prohibited polygamy in India (except for Muslims and some other sections) and monogamy became the norm. Acts related to domestic

violence and inheritance rights have empowered women, which have led to better status of women in families. Government programs to control population have led to reduced average size of family. Law against child marriage has pushed up the average age of marriage and impacted the family structure. **Court judgements** like **decriminalization of section 377 (Navtej Singh Johar case)** have legalized the concept of same-sex marriages and family in India. The Joseph Shine case that decriminalized adultery has also weighed more towards individual rights than on the institution of marriage and family.

The changes in this traditional system are more visible in the modern age with integration of diverse cultural values and forces of globalization. Change in **economic structure** has transformed into more women entering the job market and earning money. This has resulted in **improved status** and decision-making **authority of working women** in family, made her more independent, changed perceived role in family and division of labour has become more fluid. **Migration of men** from rural to urban areas for work has resulted in substantial number of **female-headed rural households**. The family left behind in rural areas have different structure composed of senior citizens, children and young brides. With both husband and wife working, **senior citizens (grand-parents) are moving in with the family** to provide care for young children. Alternate institutions like hospitals, crèches, old-age homes etc. are taking up the traditional functions of joint family. Due to working parents, children are relying more on their peer groups for emotional support. There is a **decline in the close bond** between parents and children and parents are seen **replacing time** spent with children by providing them **money**. New means of entertainment like cinemas, malls, etc. have reduced the reliance of individual on family for entertainment.

Education and awareness regarding **rights and liberties** have changed the family structure. Now parents cannot **exercise absolute dominance on their children**. Young men and women are free to choose their own way of life. Earlier mostly parents used to take decisions in families but nowadays **children also participate in decision making**. **Education** has brought about changes in attitudes, beliefs, values and ideologies of the people. It has also created individualistic attitudes among the educated persons. **Inter-caste and inter-religion marriages** are increasing in number due to better education and diluting social divides in urban areas. **Live-in relationships** are also increasing in urban areas. Change in age of marriage, freedom in partner selection, **divorce and remarriage** have become more acceptable and the stigma attached to them is declining.

The change in social structure has **intended and unintended consequences** on family structure. However, the **evolving family structures** ensures that the relationship and power equation within the family is reflecting the current reality and **women are emerging as equal partners** in the family. Women have become conscious of their rights. Patriarchal nature of family is fast changing towards a more egalitarian one. Some of the negative consequences of changed family system like growing isolation of individual, neglect of elderly and excessive focus on materialism is causing strain on traditional Indian culture. In this context, we must remember that our family system has always promoted the values of tolerance, patience, democratic attitude and social cohesion. These values need to be preserved and practiced for our generations to come. Despite the emerging new trends, what remains the same is that family continues to be an important social institution in our society, where individuals look for peace and happiness in their fast-paced lifestyles.

Kinship:

Kinship is a system of social organization based on real or assumed family ties. The family takes its form with the help of kinship rules, norms, and patterns. Since India is a land of immense diversity, its different regions reflect different systems of kinship. In sociology, all blood relationships are known by a technical term, **consanguinity**. Similarly, all relationships through marriage are given the term **affinity/conjugal**.

Patrilineal society:

A society in which descent/ancestry is determined through father's line and continued through father is termed as a patrilineal society. Property and family names are also inherited through father.

Patrilocal society:

A society in which, there is change in residence of the wife to the village/house of the husband, after marriage, is called a patrilocal society. Such societies are also patriarchal and patrilineal in nature. This is also a reason why daughters were forbidden from inheriting property earlier, as such a property would be transferred to her husband's family after marriage. Daughters were therefore given movable property like jewellery, household items, etc. and this came to be known as 'stree-dhan' and gave rise to the evil custom of dowry.

Matrilineal society:

A matrilineal society is the opposite of patrilineal society. In it, descent is determined through mother's line and also continued through mother. Property and family name are also carried forward through mothers. For example, matrilineal families are found among Garo and Khasi tribes in Meghalaya and among the Nayars of Kerala.

Matrilocal society:

A society in which husband comes to reside in the house/village of the wife upon marriage, is termed as a matrilocal society. Such a society is also matriarchal and matrilineal in nature.

1.2.2. Marriage

Marriage is a legally and culturally recognized **consensual social contract** between two people, **establishing rights and responsibilities** between them, legitimizing interpersonal/sexual relationship and implying a permanent union. It is more or less a **universal social institution in India** and is an **interfamilial affair** rather than just an interpersonal one. Children born out of marriage are considered the legitimate offspring of the married couple. This legitimacy is important in the matter of inheritance and succession.

The different forms of marriage are as discussed below:

1. **Monogamy:** It is the practice of marrying or state of being married to **one person at a time**. It is a general practice among all sections of society.
2. **Polygyny:** It is the **marriage of a man to several women at a time**. In **Islam**, polygyny is allowed. A Muslim man can have as many as four wives at a time, provided all are treated as equals.
3. **Polyandry:** It is the **marriage of a woman to several men at a time**. Polyandry is less common than polygyny. A few **Kerala castes** practiced polyandry until recently. The **Toda of the Nilgiris in Tamil Nādu, the Khasa of Jaunsar Bawar in Dehradun district** of Uttaranchal and some north Indian castes practice polyandry.

The custom in which one has to marry within its own group is called **endogamy**. The penalties for transgressing endogamous restrictions have varied greatly among cultures and have ranged from death to mild disapproval. When marriage to an outside group is mandated, it is referred to as **exogamy**.

Marriage is traditionally regarded as the **backbone of society**; it is as old an institution, as the institution of family. It gives sanctity to reciprocate interpersonal feelings, but recent changing patterns in intimate relationships are challenging this age-old institution. Marriages have evolved in the following ways:

Features	Traditional marriages	Modern marriages
Rituals/ceremony	Elaborate, religious significance.	Minimized, social significance.
Purpose of marriage	For fulfilment of Dharma and procreation.	Life-long companionship between husband and wife.
Selection of partner	Selected by elders, often man and woman did not see each other before marriage.	Increased role of consent of men and women in marriage, often they select their own life partner.
Endogamy	Strictly within own caste.	Caste restrictions are diminishing.
Age of marriage	Men and women were married at a very young age; child marriage was common.	Age of marriage has gone up significantly due to education and legislations.
Dowry system	Voluntary, considered as mark of affection for daughter.	Considered as a social evil; strict laws are there to prevent it; still exists in practice; often involuntary.
Widow remarriage	Prohibited.	Allowed. Further stigma attached to widow remarriage has been declining.
Separation	No provision of separation; marriage used to be a life-long bond.	Divorce allowed and number of divorces have been increasing.
Role	Clear cut division of labour within family. Women confined to household work. Men went to work outside house.	Gender roles are getting diluted and man and woman share roles and responsibilities within family.
Joint Family	Bride used to live the joint family of husband (joint Family).	Bride moves out with the husband to start new life (nuclear family).

However, many features of traditional marriage still persist, like higher social status of man at home and concentration of decision-making power with him, reluctance to seek divorce, element of trust, compromise and sacrifice, etc. Despite these, modern system of marriages also poses certain challenges. Institution of marriage is becoming purely a personal affair. Singlehood life along with its freedom also brings **new issues of economic distress, social and sexual exploitation, sexually transmitted diseases** and deprivation of social security of joint families. Late marriages result in **rise in abortions** which does not augur well with religious ethos. These along with same sex marriages are **reducing procreation capacity of society. Cohabitation** though easier to establish and dissolve without legal cost associated with divorces, is bringing forth the issues of **emotional cruelty, blackmailing, misuse of each other's personal space and joint assets**. According to a survey, **separation is three times more common than divorces in India**, as many women especially those with children do not remarry as frequently as men. This creates the issue of **rise in number of single parent babies** depriving them of love of the other parent.

These changes in institution of marriage can be attributed to multiple economic and social factors. The process of **urbanization** has influenced social institutions like marriage and family. For example, men and women in urban areas prefer to choose their own life partner and the concept of arranged marriages is becoming less popular. Also, **globalization** has led to **homogenization and hybridization of culture**, affecting our deep-rooted customs, traditions and the values of marriage. **Modernization** has **changed** the conservative **attitude** of people towards inter-caste marriages and widow remarriages. The **legislations and court judgements** related to age at marriage, choice of life partner, regulation of number of spouses, dissolution of marriage, dowry and remarriage are also responsible for changes in marriage system. For

instance, in Hadiya case the Supreme Court decided that everyone has the right to choose their own spouse. Thus, the current institution of marriage is a hybrid system where some features of traditional marriage are preserved, while many features have changed with time. Today traditional indicators of society- marriage, family and motherhood are changing fast; hence a makeover of our social and legal institutions is needed to cope up with emerging challenges to safeguard both individual liberty and social good.

The changing pattern in intimate relationships in Indian society, poses a challenge to traditional institution of marriage. Comment.

1.2.3. Rural society

Indian society is primarily a rural society, though urbanisation is growing. The majority of India's people live in rural areas (68.84 per cent, according to the 2011 Census). Agriculture is the primary occupation and for most people in rural area. It is not just a form of livelihood; but also a way of life. Rural people remain in close contact with nature and many of their cultural practices and patterns can be traced to agrarian backgrounds. For example, most of the New Year festivals in different regions of India such as



Pongal in Tamil Nadu, Bihu in Assam, Baisakhi in Punjab and Ugadi in Karnataka actually celebrate the main harvest season and herald the beginning of a new agricultural season. Rural relationships are intimate relationships, often comprising of joint and extended families; and almost every person knows every other person residing in that village. Rural society also supports many traditional occupations like storytellers, astrologers, priests, goldsmith, washermen, potters, etc. The society is characterized with greater association between man and animals, often found living in the same hamlet. Class and caste hierarchy is visible in the form of separate settlements for people belonging to lower castes, often at the boundary of the village area or near local cemeteries, drains, etc., indicating stronger elements of caste discrimination.

Rural societies have more visible expression of patriarchy. Generally, females do not possess decision making powers, cover their faces under a veil, are denied health and education facilities that are already very scarce, are denied existence due to prevalence of female foeticide and infanticide, are considered as a burden because dowry has to be given in their marriages, etc. Women are seen as bearer of family prestige and thus often become victims of mutual rivalries. Panchayats and Lok-Adalats form important justice delivery institutions in the villages, which generally give decisions based on majority, strong orthodox beliefs and sometimes on superstitions and dogmas as well. Such societies are also characterized by lower wages, low standards of living and therefore more poverty. Migration to urban areas for better sources of income and livelihood has become a distinguishing feature of rural societies. The extent of mass migration was visible during the lockdown period due to COVID-19, when lakhs of migrant workers started on foot, their journey back to their villages as all economic activities in cities were brought to a halt.

Impact of Green Revolution on rural society:

Green revolution was a set of productivity improvement initiatives, based on adoption of modern cultivation inputs like HYV seeds, chemical fertilizers and pesticides, farm machinery, irrigation facilities etc. introduced initially in the regions of Punjab, Haryana and western UP during the late 1960s. This led to a paradigm shift in agriculture and subsequently in rural society. It led to the **empowerment of intermediate castes**, i.e. the dominant landed class, like- Jats, Yadavas, Gujjars, etc. and subsequent mandalization of politics or **casteization of politics**. Moreover, it led to **rural inequalities** (between rich farmers who could afford high input costs and peasants who could not) and **regional inequalities** between western and eastern

India. It also led to the rise of footloose labour in the rural society who worked under miserable conditions and undertook **seasonal migration**.

Green Revolution also resulted in **strengthening of patriarchy** with greater subordination of women. In western India, women lost jobs as cultivators on field having been replaced by machines. With this loss of economic strength, a female child became even more undesirable, leading to higher **female infanticide and foeticide**. Thus, the regions where Green revolution flourished also have one of the lowest CSR (child sex ratio). However, it also led to **feminization of agriculture** in the eastern belt i.e. Bihar and West Bengal primarily because male members migrated to Green revolution regions thereby leaving women behind to work on the fields. Cases of **drug abuse and alcoholism** amongst the youth of these regions began to increase due to displacement from agriculture and lack of alternative employment; for example, in Punjab youth unemployment is 16.6% while national average is 10.2%. This displacement has created a sense of worthlessness leading to frustration which provides a fertile ground for seeking drugs. Thus, although Green revolution helped to transform India from a begging bowl to a bread basket, the impact on rural society has been that of a double-edged sword.

1.2.3. Markets

In most agrarian societies around the world, periodic markets (example- weekly haats) are a core feature of social and economic organisation. Weekly markets bring together people from surrounding villages, who come to sell their agricultural or forest or other produce and to buy essentials like salt and haldi (turmeric), or agricultural implements or manufactured goods like bangles and jewellery, that are not available in their villages. But for many visitors, another reason to come to the market is social – to meet people, to discuss marital alliances, exchange gossip, and so on. They attract traders from outside the local area, as well as moneylenders, entertainers, astrologers, and other experts offering their services. In rural India, there are also specialised markets that take place at less frequent intervals, for instance, cattle markets, utensils for old clothes exchange markets, tribal haats, etc. Sociologists view markets as social institutions that are constructed in culturally specific ways and are hierarchical in nature. For example, markets are often controlled or organised by particular social groups, classes or castes, with higher caste groups being engaged in trade of high value goods and services.

There is also a close connection in between caste and markets. In fact, 'Vaishyas' indicate the importance of merchants and of trade in Indian society since ancient times. Although there are 'Vaishya' communities (such as Baniyas in North India and Chettiars in South India), whose traditional occupation has been trade or commerce for a long time, there are some caste groups that have entered into trade and tend to acquire 'Vaishya' status in the process of upward mobility. The 'traditional business communities' in India include other groups as well, such as the Gujratis, Marwaris, Parsis, Sindhis, Bohras, or Jains.

1.3. Unity in diversity

Indian society is characterized by its unity amidst diversity. There are undercurrents of commonality and oneness, encompassing our diverse way of life. The factors of unity can be seen in the context of cultural heritage – such as common practices of pilgrimage across the region, common value system, secularism, rural and agrarian society (agriculture being the predominant occupation of India), Indian Constitution and its uniqueness, parliamentary form of government providing for federal structure, educational system, unified transportation and communication, industrialization and urbanization and so on. Uniqueness of India as a nation, lies in the fact that it



is inhabited by people belonging to diverse religions, linguistic groups, castes & ethnicities. The people, irrespective of their different identities, are united under a composite national identity characterized by a rich history of cultural evolution and common national anthem, flag, citizenship and constitutional values.

Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat:

In order to institutionalize process of cultural engagement between people of different states, government of India, has launched “Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat” (EBSB) campaign to celebrate unity in diversity, foster sense of common identity among people of different states by showcasing each other’s heritage and promote cooperation between various states by sharing best practices & experiences.

Under EBSB, pre-decided pairs of states & UTs will enter into cultural engagements for one year & prepare action plan containing different activities & implementation responsibilities in consultation with each other. Activities like translation of local language books in each other’s language, cultural exchange programs, educational tours between students, literary & film festivals, culinary festivals, mutual tourism, etc. would be taken up. Recently, Madhya Pradesh participated in Sangai Mahotsav being organized in its partner state of Manipur & likewise, teams from Nagaland & Manipur will participate in Lok Rang and Bal rang programs in MP spreading awareness about their culture among people of MP.

“Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat” is an attempt to promote the spirit of national integration through a deep and structured engagement between all Indian States and UTs. Discuss.

1.3.1. Mutual respect and tolerance

Mutual respect and tolerance refer to the ability of accepting and accommodating the views, beliefs, or ways of living of others even if they are opposite to ours. Mutual respect between groups has been the identity of India since ancient times. This is also reflected in the Indian Constitution, for instance in the form of the secularism principle.

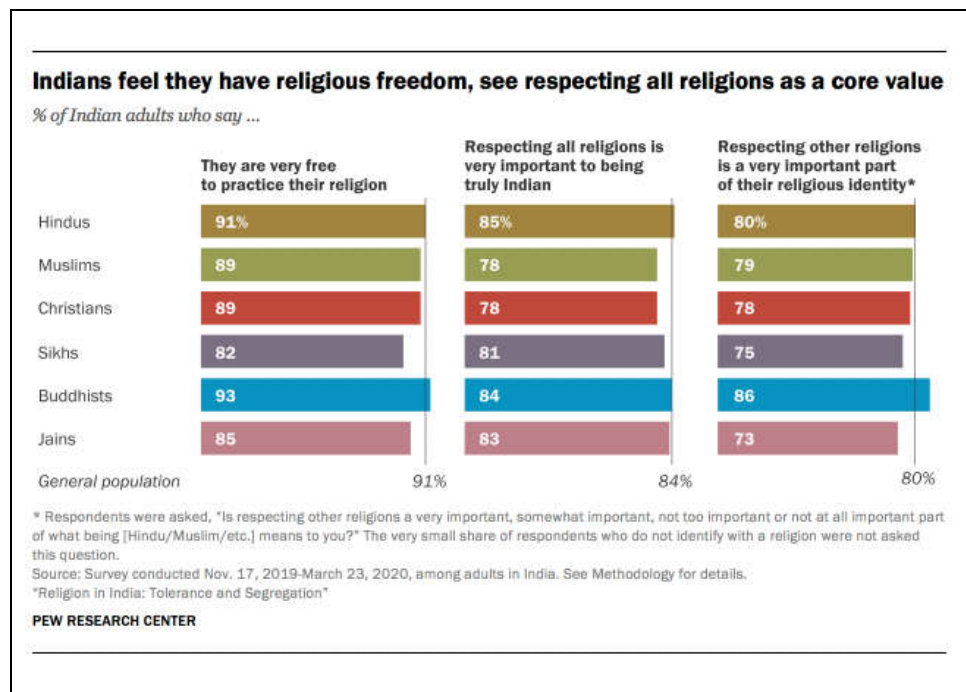
Is intolerance increasing in India?

Tolerance is a core principle of Indian ethos. However, with the advent of modernization and globalization, the incidences of inter-community strife are on the rise. This communal disharmony has generated debate over intolerance in society. Historically, the policy of ‘divide and rule’ adopted by the British, the communal riots during partition or sporadic incidents of communal tensions in recent times have created turbulences in the pluralistic ethos of India. This has manifested in decreasing acceptance for diverse views. For example, murder of rationalist like Gauri Lankesh, protest against movies/books, increase in cases of mob behavior and lynching- cases of Akhlaq and Pehlu Khan, alienation among youth and increased distrust- exodus of people of north-east from Bangalore, etc. Social instability and disturbance in social fabric also leads to change in location of industries, diversion of Foreign Direct investments and most of all the image of India is maligned.

There are various causes behind acts of intolerance, such as spread of false information and fake news at fast pace due to digital/social media, to get higher TRPs/attention by spreading a sensational news item; high unemployment amongst youth which has raised their frustration level; weak law & order and delayed justice delivery system, etc. Increase in extremist ideology across the world is also another reason for the recent incidents of hate crimes, mob lynching and xenophobia, which have categorically manifested in decline of mutual tolerance and understanding.

As India is home to diverse cultures, right to dissent and tolerance of dissent are *sine qua non* of our liberal democratic society. The incidences of intolerance such as over religion, food habits, etc. that were reported from few states are episodic, and it might not be correct to say that the overall intolerance level of the society has increased based on a few of them. Indian society has overcome these social undercurrents time and

again with strong accommodative credentials, and the value of tolerance continues to guide our social relations. We have a strong criminal justice system as well that has helped time and again in upholding of Constitutional values- specifically the Fundamental Rights for all citizens of the country. Our history, system of polity, and cultural heritage teach us about tolerance and respect for diverse humanity. Therefore, 'pluralistic ethos' which is the core strength of India, should be preserved. Appropriate actions should be taken by government like creation of social media hub to keep a check on fake news, etc. Emphasis should also be laid on the fundamental duty of promoting harmony and the spirit of common brotherhood amongst all the people, to promote the spirit of tolerance.



1.3.2. How has India managed its diversity?

Diversity has been a feature of the Indian society since its beginning and is not an appendage. India has survived and thrived irrespective of its inherent differences. Even after independence, India stayed unified and its segmentation was overcome only by accepting this immensely complex diversity and not addressing it as an obstacle to the process of nation-in-the making. India managed its diversity in several ways, made possible by the prominent leaders of independent India—Jawaharlal Nehru, Sardar Patel, Maulana Azad, Rajendra Prasad—who were not associated with any one region, language, religion, or caste. Another major factor that kept India away from disintegration was the willingness of the Congress party to conciliate and accommodate, to listen and to appease the opposition parties and dissenting groups. Parties having diverse ideologies like communism, socialism, capitalism, etc. were assimilated within the political spectrum. Additionally, administrative services, army services were started based upon individual merit, irrespective of caste or religion, from all regions and linguistic areas. States Reorganization Act, 1956 was another major step towards managing cultural and lingual diversity.

The Preamble of the Indian Constitution also opted India as a secular country so that every caste, culture, and religion could enjoy their customs and practices. Fundamental Rights under the Constitution provided inalienable rights for the individual, such as Article 15 (against discrimination on grounds of religion,

race, caste, sex or place of birth), Article 17 (Abolition of untouchability), Article 25 (Freedom of conscience and free profession, practice and propagation of religion in) etc. This **accommodative approach** towards multiple religious, cultural & linguistic diversities has not only **kept India united** but also **promoted social cohesion** among various diversities. It also provided for a federal structure with a strong Centre but also a great deal of autonomy for the states. The makers of the Constitution kept in view the difference between decentralization and disintegration and between unity and integration and centralization.

Pluralistic Nationalism of India:

Nationalism is a political & socio-economic system characterized by the promotion of interests of a particular nation, especially with the aim of gaining & maintaining sovereignty over the shared territory. Its roots lay in 16th century Europe. It believes in leveling out diversities. For example, extreme nationalism emerged in Germany under the leadership of Hitler in 20th century and emphasized superiority of Aryan race. **Pluralistic nationalism of India** was born as a reaction against colonial exploitation & hence demanded unity. It promoted a feeling of unity amongst people belonging to different regions. People with diverse socio-cultural-economic life came together and put up a fight against the colonial power.

Hence, while **conventional nationalism** on one side believes in **uniting everyone under one socio-cultural identity** of majority or a powerful community, **pluralistic nationalism**, which India decided to follow, on the other side, promotes coexistence of multiple identities and **believes in idea of unity in diversity**. Post-independence, this inclusive & pluralistic aspect of Indian nationalism got reflected in the Constitution and the policies Indian state adopted towards various diversities. As a result, on one side, ethnically diverse **countries** like Sri Lanka, Myanmar, etc. followed path of conventional nationalism and consequently failed to integrate their ethnic minorities in mainstream & **faced civil wars**, **India** on the other hand, followed the path of pluralistic nationalism and was **able to integrate its minorities** and promote social cohesion among them.

While nationalism conventionally privileges one socio-cultural identity over others, India's pluralistic nationalism celebrates the coexistence of multiple identities. Discuss.

1.3.3. Is diversity good or bad for India?

Diversity is India's greatest asset. It is a strength of our nation. People in India are united in spite of the diversity of races, religions, castes, sub-castes, communities, languages and dialects. We can never forget the freedom movement championed by the people of all sects and communities of India to gain independence. Diversity has also given rise to the rich cultural heritage, which is very much helpful in promoting tourism in India, diversity of ideas, innovations and promote tolerance toward other cultures and religions. Diversity of thoughts and opinions is also necessary precondition for democratic governance.

However, problems arise when diversity and difference become reasons for prejudices and deprivations. This leads to certain drawbacks of diversity in India, such as, diversity being used for divisive purposes and being transformed into disruptive tendencies, like communalism, casteism and linguistic or regional exclusiveness. Politically, presence of diversifying factors naturally tends to breed sub-national aspirations in people leading from **pluralism to fragmentation**. For example, demand of having separate flag by the state of Karnataka, secessionist demands from Jammu & Kashmir & Naga tribes, etc. Even maintaining the balance between diverse socio-cultural traditions and Constitutional ideals, has been a bone of contention for our policy makers. During **Constituent Assembly** debates as well, there was a lack of consensus on **Uniform civil code (UCC)** due to diversity of customs, practices and traditions. Another topic of debate was related to

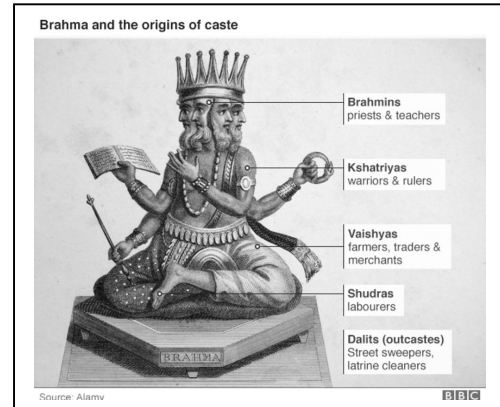
secularism and freedom to practice, profess and propagate one's religion. However, this is leading to a shift in the Indian society from **pluralism to polarization** in recent times. For instance, the principle of secularism is being challenged by **sectarian** and **communal forces**. Similarly, continuation of practices like restrictions on entry of women in some religious places, Santhara (fasting unto death-practiced by Jain community), etc., which are integral to their respective religions, pose a set of unique legal challenges.

The problems of regionalism, communalism, ethnic conflicts, conflicts in societal reforms, etc. have arisen because the fruits of development haven't been distributed equally; or cultures of some communities haven't been accorded due recognition; or our legislative and political process have failed to generate social consensus for reforms. Hence, Constitution and its values must form guiding principles of our society. Any society which has tried to forcefully homogenize itself, has witnessed stagnation in due-course and ultimately decline. For instance, the case of Pakistan which tried to impose its dominant culture on East-Pakistan, ultimately leading to a war and creation of Bangladesh. There is also a need of persuasion by eminent people, and political willingness to increase **awareness** on such issues to build social consensus over them. In a country as diverse as India we need both – a legal push in the form of Constitutional ideals and a social push for building social consensus, to push forward as an enlightened and just society. Pluralism and celebration of diversity are central to Indian philosophy. Our society has lived with the idea of unity in diversity for centuries beginning from ancient Vedic times. The problem therefore, is not of diversity per se, but the handling of diversity in Indian society.

India's pluralistic society in order to conserve its socio – cultural tradition, has always posed a threat to our Constitutional ideals. Comment. In light of recent judgments, discuss how the judiciary has kept a check on such practices.

2. CASTE SYSTEM

A unique feature of Indian society is caste system. The term 'caste' is generally used in two senses, sometimes as 'Varna' and sometimes as 'jati'. Varna system finds its origin in the *Purusha Sukta* hymn of the 10th Mandala of Rigveda which talks about the four-fold division of Indian society. According to it- "From the mouth of *Brahma*, originated the *Brahmins* (generally priest and scholars), *Kshatriya* (ruler and soldier) from the shoulders, *Vaishya* (merchant) from thighs and *Shudra* (peasant, labour, servant) from feet." This division was based on occupations of members of society. However, from Post-Gupta age onwards, the Varna system grew rigid and became based on birth implying no outside person could enter any Varna.



'Jati' refers to the institution of caste system and it is a form of social stratification (hierarchy), which governs the pattern of social interaction among various social groups. *Jati* can be defined as a hereditary endogamous group, having a common name, traditional occupation and culture. It is relatively rigid in matters of mobility due to distinctiveness of status, thereby resulting in the formation of a single homogeneous community. 'Jati Panchayats' were held for punishing people who changed their caste. *Jati*/caste groups were traditionally linked to occupations. Each caste had a specific occupation and could not change the occupation. Thus, there was lack of unrestricted choice of occupation. The precise relationship between *varna* and *jati* has been subjected to much debate among scholars. Some of the key differences between them are as follows:

Varna System	Jati/Caste System
<i>Varna</i> is a broad all India aggregative classification . Varna system is antecedent of jati . Varna model only provides a broad framework within which the innumerable variations of castes throughout India are found.	<i>Jati</i> is a social identity ascribed by birth, with regional or local sub-classification which varies from region to region .
There are only four varnas i.e., <i>Brahmanas</i> , <i>Kshatriyas</i> , <i>Vaishyas</i> and <i>Shudras</i> .	There are thousands of castes and sub-castes in India.
In the beginning (during <i>Rig Vedic</i> period), there was fluidity in Varna System. However, Varna hierarchy got fixed during later Vedic period and it has not changed till today – i.e., Brahmins at the top and followed by <i>Kshatriya</i> , <i>Vaishya</i> and <i>Shudra</i> .	The caste hierarchy is not fixed and social mobility occurs, even if it is slow. A caste, may change its hierarchy by achieving economic, political and education status (<i>Sanskritization</i>), but people cannot change their caste.
Varna System does not account for untouchability and untouchables do not form a part of it.	Untouchables lie at the lowermost level of caste hierarchy.

Theories regarding caste system:

Herbert Risley in his **Racial theory** says that the caste system originated in India due to the emigration of Indo-Aryans from Persia who considered themselves as superior to the original inhabitants (dark in colour), both in cultural and racial features. The term *varna* literally means colour and it was originally used to refer to the distinction between *Arya* and *Dasa*, in ancient India. They enslaved the non-Aryans and sometimes even entered into marital relations (hypergamy and hypogamy) with them, which resulted in the origin of caste. The off-springs of such stray marriages were considered as belonging to the lower caste.

In Hypergamy, woman is typically of lower social status than the man. Hypogamy is the opposite of Hypergamy, wherein, woman belongs to the higher status of the two.

As per the **Ritual theory**, caste of a person could be identified on the basis of the rituals they performed. For instance, Brahmans would perform Vishnu Shanti Yajna, Kshatriya would perform Ashwamedha Yajna, Vaishya would perform rituals for their personal benefit, while Shudras would engage in tantricism in graveyards. This was not a popular theory.

Newfield in his **Occupational theory** held that caste system evolved from Varna system itself. With better economy and modernization, people began to specialize in their field of occupations. For example, oil pressing activities were called 'teli' and later this came to be identified as their caste. Similarly, Mali, Nai, Lohar, Sonar, Chamar, etc came into existence. Occupations that were regarded as better and respectable made the people performing them, superior and of higher caste as compared to the rest.

Functional importance of caste system during ancient times:

Caste accorded a fixed status to an individual in the society, who automatically enjoyed that status as soon as he was born. This ascriptive status of the individual was permanent, for "neither poverty nor wealth, neither success nor failure could remove him, unless, he so violated standards of behaviour laid down by the caste." In this way, caste provided him with psychological security. Besides, it also provided him with social security and sometimes even paid for his funeral. Caste played a crucial role in the process of socialisation as well, by teaching individuals the culture, traditions, values and norms of their society. It guided the individual in his day-to-day activities, for example, clothes, diet, ceremonial observances, and rituals at birth, marriage and death, etc. Another important function of caste was to help decide the life partner. Caste acted as an integrator and social stabilizer by efficiently organizing the Hindu society without letting class frictions and factions create rifts. Additionally, caste system preserved skilled labour by transmitting vocational skill from generation to generation. It thus made progress possible and maintained the continuity of professions and crafts. The caste system through Jajmani relationships (an economic system most notably found in villages of India in which lower castes performed various functions for upper castes and received grain or other goods in return) bound the families of various castes into a hereditary, permanent and multiple relationships.

Sanskritization of caste:

According to sociologist M.N. Srinivas, sanskritization refers to a process in which members of a caste (usually middle or lower caste) attempted to raise their own social status by adopting the rituals and domestic practices of a caste (or castes) of higher status, often Brahmins and Kshatriyas. For instance, people belonging to lower caste aimed at upward social mobility by adopting vegetarianism, wearing sacred thread, performing religious ceremonies of Brahmins, etc.

Dominant caste:

It is a term used to refer to those castes which had a large population and were granted land rights by partial land reforms effected after independence. After they acquired land rights these castes grew in economic power. Their large number gave them leverage in political power. Thus, these intermediate castes (between upper and lower castes) become the dominant caste, particularly in villages, and played a decisive role in

regional politics and the agrarian economy. For example, Yadavas of Bihar and UP, Lingayats and Vokkaligas of Karnataka, Reddys and Khammas of Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana, Marathas of Maharashtra, Jats, Ahir, Kurmi of Haryana and Punjab, Patidars of Gujarat, etc. wield substantial amount of power and hold positions of dominance. By virtue of their dominance, these castes are demanding a share in protective and positive discrimination such as naming them as OBCs, which is an attempt to further consolidate their dominance in education and employment.

Caste-based discrimination in India:

The caste system is deeply entrenched in our societal values and it is for this reason that we see the dominance of the caste factor in almost every aspect of our daily life. Caste-based discrimination involves massive violations of civil, political, economic, social and cultural rights of people who are considered inferior and untouchables. This discrimination manifests in various forms such as:

1. **Discrimination in employment:** Majority of those involved in manual scavenging, garbage collection belong to the Dalit community. Often, these groups are involved in low-income business and cannot grow due to paucity of financial credit from institutional and traditional creditors.
2. **Discrimination in education:** Dalit students find themselves differentiated from other students of upper caste due to the virtue of their caste. This leads to low self-esteem and depression in Dalit students which impacts negatively in their academic background.
3. **Urban and rural segregation:** In most of the cities and villages of India, lower caste community reside in a specific and particular area, which is mostly underdeveloped and lacks basic amenities like water supply, electricity and pukka road connectivity.
4. **Discrimination in health sector:** The village has separate health centres for different social groups with the centres meant for Dalits having poor facilities. Most health officials in the village belong to the upper castes and therefore, Doctors and nurses refrain from touching a Dalit patient during diagnosis, display indifferent and offensive behaviour and interrupt them while speaking.
5. **Physical violence:** All these day-to-day silent discrimination results into assault, lynching, honour killing of various people belonging to lower caste in India.

Reasons for continuance of the caste-based discrimination in this modern age:

1. **Sense of caste prestige:** Feeling of one's caste superiority over other castes is one of the main factors. Members of a particular caste or sub-caste have the tendency of developing loyalty to their own caste which often results into treating other lower castes with disrespect.
2. **Caste endogamy:** Caste endogamy refers to marriage within the same caste. Caste endogamy is therefore responsible for the continuance of the feeling of casteism.
3. **Impact of urbanisation:** Urbanisation indirectly favouring casteism. Due to the impact of industrialization, people migrate from rural areas to urban areas. When they go to a new place, naturally they seek the help of caste groups.
4. **Increase in the means of transport and communication:** Advancement and improvement in the means of transport and communication leads to a better organization of caste-groups. The feeling of casteism is also rapidly propagated through the medium of newspapers.
5. **Illiteracy:** Lack of literacy often leads to narrow-mindedness. As a result, it is the illiterate people who generally have more casteist feelings.
6. **Belief in religious dogmas:** Due to illiteracy, people are governed by beliefs in religious dogmas, blind and unfounded customs and superstitions. Due to the practice of 'Jati Dharma' they often take anti-caste issues very negatively.
7. **Social distance:** Specially in rural areas, people belonging to the higher caste maintain social distance from the lower castes. They maintain it through different restrictions like ban on inter-caste mintages, inter-dinning etc.

Comparison between caste and racial discrimination:

The social division based upon caste has parallel in the world in the form of discrimination based upon race. Both involve, massive violations of civil, political, economic, social and cultural rights. Race refers to categorization of human species into groups based on **biological features**. Racism is a belief that people belonging to different races can be arranged in a hierarchy solely based on their physical appearances which results in prejudices, discriminations and antagonism. On the other hand, casteism is a belief that provides for **superiority of one's caste over other castes**. It prescribes that interest of one's own castes should be promoted even at the cost of interests of other castes which results in inter-caste rivalry.

Racial discrimination occurs when a person is treated less favorably, or not given the same opportunities, as others in a similar situation, because of their race, the country where they were born, their ethnic origin or their skin colour. Discrimination based on race is also found in India. For example- discrimination against northeast people. However, it is not as severe as casteism.

Caste	Race
The system of caste originated from the Varna system, the occupational division of society.	Racial discrimination is based on biological differences. It began during Trans-Atlantic slave trade when European colonies imported black African slaves to USA, for plantation agriculture.
The genesis of caste has the approval of religious scriptures.	The exploitation of black (Negroids) people is justified by creating a "scientific" theory of white superiority and black inferiority, thereby creating rigid hierarchies.
Strict caste hierarchies are practiced such as endogamy. Caste endogamy is therefore responsible for the emergence of the feeling of casteism. Lower castes are segregated such as Dalits.	Cultural and political segregation of the public space for black people.
Economic distress to lower castes due to low level of occupation.	Black people face severe problems in gaining employment and attaining standard of living.

However, caste and race aren't entirely mutually exclusive and share a strong correlation. Most of the people belonging to Negritos and Proto- Australoids race also belong to the SC/ST category. So, what looks explicitly as casteism is also implicitly racism towards them. Also, varna which formed the basis of the caste system means "colour". So, colour (physical trait) itself became the basis of the caste system.

Changes in the caste system:

There have been significant yet paradoxical changes in the caste system in contemporary times. These are discussed below:

1. Invisibility of caste

The caste system now appears to be invisible **for upper castes, urban middle and upper classes**, as the urban class has become more important than the upper caste. This is due to the fact that post-independence, these groups have leveraged their position in the social hierarchy to gain the benefits of rapid economic development. These elites also benefited from subsidized education, thereby getting hold of skill development and employment opportunities. Over generations, these groups began to believe that their advancement has no relation with their caste, as social status became independent of the caste but rather became dependent upon social and economic achievements.

2. Visibility of caste

For **Scheduled Castes (SCs) and other backward castes**, their caste identities and consciousness have

further strengthened. The unequal distribution of development benefits to these castes and the prevalent social discrimination against them, steered them to demand for their rights in the form of strict implementation of laws (like the Prevention of atrocities against SC/ST Act), reservations in education, employment and promotions, etc. This has led to their caste becoming their primary identification factor. This is also evident from the rise of Bahujan Samaj Party in India. In India, it is generally said that people don't cast their vote rather they vote their caste. This is because people believe that their caste, language and such identity-based parties will invariably work for their interest.

3. **Decline in supremacy of Brahmins and disassociation between caste and hereditary occupation.** The superior social status of Brahmins has shown a decline, especially in the urban context. Moreover, no longer can one deduce a person's caste by looking at their occupation. This is also because of the decline in the institute of caste panchayats, who earlier used to regulate the behaviour of people with regard to their occupation, but now seem to have lost their power.
4. Society is also more tolerant of **inter-caste marriages**. According to the 2017 study conducted by the Indian Statistical Institute, inter-caste marriages are more frequent in rural areas (5.2%) than urban areas (4.9%). The survey also found that inter-caste marriages are more common among poor people (5.9%) than rich people (4.0%). This has also been aided by government schemes that offer financial awards to inter-caste couples, if one of them is a Dalit.

Views of scholars on caste system:

"Turn in any direction you like; caste is the monster that crosses your path. You cannot have political reform, you cannot have economic reform, unless you kill this monster (caste)". This idea of **annihilation of caste** was propagated by the maker of modern India, **Dr. B R Ambedkar** and it refers to the abolition of caste system. According to him, social reform has to take precedence over political and religious reforms and urged that one caste is not fit to rule another caste. Following are some excerpts from his speech on annihilation of caste – *"Caste may be bad. Caste may lead to conduct so gross as to be called man's inhumanity to man. All the same, it must be recognized that the Hindus observe caste not because they are inhuman or wrong-headed. They observe caste because they are deeply religious. People are not wrong in observing caste. In my view, what is wrong is their religion, which has inculcated this notion of caste. If this is correct, then obviously the enemy you must grapple with, is not the people who observe caste, but the Shastras which teach them this religion of caste."*

For this very reason, Dr. Ambedkar aimed at reconstruction of the Indian society on the basis of equality of human beings. He therefore advocated the promotion of- education, industrialization, urbanization, inter-caste marriages, destruction of religious scriptures, breaking of the hereditary practice of priesthood and adopting the method of selection of priests through exams etc. According to him, it is education which is the right weapon to cut the social slavery and it is education which will enlighten the downtrodden masses to come up and gain social status, economic betterment and political freedom. In 1923, he founded the 'Bahishkrit Hitkarini Sabha' to spread education among the marginalized and to improve their economic conditions.

Mahatma Gandhi believed in caste system as a just system based on a person's occupation. According to him, caste, which is a product of Varnashrama Dharma, is division of labour and it led to a well-functioning economy and thereby a well-functioning society. The only problem with the caste system is untouchability and discrimination practiced by some castes. For instance, in 1921, he wrote in his journal Navajivan, *"If Hindu society has been able to stand, it is because it is founded on the caste system"*. He believed that there should be no hierarchy between castes and that all castes should be considered equal. He tried to remove the blot of untouchability from Hinduism and was of the opinion that it is the penance that a caste Hindu owes to himself. He said that work is worship and so, even a manual scavenger's job is equal in respect to a Brahmin's work of reading religious scriptures. He exhorted the upper caste people to give equal respect to their lower castes brethren, especially the untouchables. He gave a new name to the untouchables: Harijan, meaning the people of

Hari (an incarnation of Lord Vishnu). He even published a weekly magazine called “Harijan”, to enlighten the upper caste people. Gandhi ji was of the view that caste system should continue, sans the untouchability.

By 1930s, however, he had become critical of the caste system and he felt that India must stop accepting caste as a social norm. When he went to Noakhali in eastern Bengal (in 1947) to tackle the communal violence there, he advised the upper-caste Hindu women to – “*Invite a Harijan every day to dine with you. Or, at least ask the Harijan to touch the food or the water before you consume it. Do penance for your sins*”. In April 1947, he also announced that he would give his blessings only to weddings between Dalits and non-Dalits. Gandhi ji was also the first one to propose the idea of appointing a Dalit man or woman as the first President of independent India. He believed that this would be a ‘strong symbolic move’ towards eradication of caste differences. The need was for an all-embracing, inclusive pan-India movement of social, cultural and economic transformation. According to him, even the reservation system required a fundamental relook in order to study its impact, need for continuance and reforms needed. To zero down caste-based discrimination, state must proactively enforce the law in letter and spirit and act to protect the citizen’s fundamental right to equality.

Karl Marx was the first foreign thinker to draw attention to the negative impact of caste on Indian society. In his essay on- ‘**The Future Results of British Rule in India**’, Karl Marx characterized the Indian castes as “the most decisive impediment to India’s progress and power”. He argued that the caste system of India was based on the hereditary division of labour, which was inseparably linked with the subsistence economy of the Indian village community. He also believed that the industrialization and commercialization of India under British rule, facilitated by the spread of railways, would lead to the breakdown of the traditional village communities, and with them the caste system as well. However, that was not the case. For him, the abolition of the caste hierarchy and the oppression and exploitation of the ‘lower’ castes could not be separated from the Marxian form of class struggle.

In today’s era, modernization and globalization have strengthened primordialism (idea that nations or ethnic identities are fixed) across the world as they play an instrumental role in guiding individuals and groups through the phase of change. This is also true with caste identities such as caste consciousness and casteism. There is a need to sensitize the public about the evils of casteism and discrimination based on it. Eradication of this social evil will help us to achieve the goals of equality, liberty, and fraternity as enshrined in the Preamble of our Constitution. Dominance of constitutional values, rule of law, and enlightenment of individuals is essential to overcome caste-based discrimination in India. Further, it is important to improve education, rise in economic status, market reforms transforming the lives of millions of Dalits living in degraded conditions. We must remember the words of **Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar**- “We are entering an era of political equality. But economically and socially we remain a deeply unequal society. Unless we resolve this contradiction, inequality will destroy our democracy,” and put our thoughts into action to end caste-based discrimination happening in our daily life. Ambedkar’s essence lies in heralding a systemic change, instead of craving for political freedom. To bring this in and practice his philosophy in true sense of the term, along with massive socio-political awareness, economic strength of the Dalit community must be enhanced. The annihilation of the caste may take longer, but steps towards the same should be continued.

1. Has caste lost its relevance in understanding the multi-cultural Indian society? Elaborate your answers with illustrations. (UPSC 2020)
2. “Caste system is assuming new identities and associational forms. Hence, caste system cannot be eradicated in India.” Comment. (UPSC 2018)
3. Debate the issue whether and how contemporary movements for assertion of Dalit identity work towards annihilation of caste. (UPSC 2015)

3. EFFECTS OF GLOBALIZATION ON INDIAN SOCIETY

Globalization refers to the growing interdependence between different people, regions and countries in the world as social and economic relationships start expanding worldwide. In very simple terms, globalization can be defined as increasing global interconnectedness.

3.1. Introduction

R.G. Harris defines globalization as an economic process. It is guided by the rationale of capitalists who call for free market, free competition and survival of the fittest. According to **Thomas Friedman** globalization is *'that loose combination of free trade agreements, the Internet and the integration of financial markets that is erasing borders and uniting the world into a single, lucrative, but brutally competitive marketplace'*. The interconnectedness between the world is primarily an exchange of social, economic, political, cultural and technological attributes. These attributes happen to interchange when societies of the world come in contact with one another. Though this exchange process is going on from time immemorial, this process was termed as 'globalization' for the first time around the second half of 20th century.

Some scholars are of the opinion that the world has experienced five waves of globalization. According to them, the process of globalization or the first wave, started ever since the beginning of mankind and affected everyone and influenced all cultures but in varying degrees. Thousands of years of trade, migration and conquests in the ancient period denotes the extent of interconnectedness of the world. Example of the earliest forms of globalization include the trade links between the Sumerian civilization and the Indus Valley Civilization, between Parthian Empire, the Roman Empire, and the Han Dynasty and between various countries like India, Egypt, Greece, and so on. The popularity of trade relations led to the development of various trade routes like the Silk Route.

The second wave was marked by European age of exploration (1400s to 1800s), when Europeans conquered large parts of Asia, Africa and Latin America. This was the beginning of economic interdependency, global politics and global trade. The age of Imperialism (1870-1914) is often regarded as the third wave of globalization. Development of steam power, railways and telegraph aided in the imperialist ambitions of the European nations and also led to spread of capitalism. The **Industrial Revolution** in the 19th century was one of the major periods in the history of globalization. Due to the industrial revolution, there was a significant increase in the quantity and quality of the products. This led to higher exports and better trade and business relations.

Post World Wars era is denoted as the fourth wave of globalization, which was an era of both global cooperation and conflict, led by United States and USSR. It led to rise in multilateral institutions like United Nations, World Bank, International Monetary Fund and GATT (General Agreement on Tariffs and Trades). Modern day globalization began from late 1980 onwards, which is marked by extreme interdependence among nations. Today, globalization has been driven forward above all, by the development of **information and communication technologies** (ICT) that have intensified the speed and scope of interaction between people all over the world. In India, modern day globalization started with the opening of the Indian economy in 1991.

Traditionalism, Modernization and Westernization:

Traditionalism is the upholding or maintenance of tradition and values. Accepting or adopting modern style or modern ways and ideas of thinking, living, etc. is called '**modernization**'. In other words, modernization is a change or modification which offers the promise of the preservation of the past. So, modernity is connecting to the new and the contemporary, rejecting the old. **Westernization** is a sub-process of

modernization. It is a process of imitation of western countries by non-western countries, whereby societies come under or adopt the western culture. On the other hand, modernization has a wider connotation. In fact, with the passage of time, Indian society has also evolved and challenged traditionalism, but it has never rejected traditionalism completely and accepted modernity; rather it has established a balance between both. Example: We adopted modern attire and food, but we also celebrate yoga day.

Factors contributing to globalization:

Globalization, in the modern sense of the term, came into existence after the Second World War. One of the main factors for this was the plan by the world leaders to break down the borders for fostering trade relations between nations. This led to rise of multilateral institutions like the World Trade Organization, in 1994, to aid in increasing economic relations between the countries of the world by reduction in tariffs and non-tariff barriers. It also led to the increase in free trade agreements among various countries. In India, the 1991 Liberalisation, Privatization, Globalization (LPG) reforms led to greater economic relaxations and deregulations, which in turn increased India's interaction with the rest of the world.

Moreover, **ICT** has reduced the speed of communication. The transition from telephonic communication to satellite digital communication has resulted in increasing the quantity and quality of information transfers. Financial transactions can now take place instantaneously by the click of a mouse, helping in shifting of huge funds by banks, corporates, individuals, etc. in a shorter span of time. The phenomenon of social media too has made distance insignificant– people in faraway places can feel closer together as they can communicate immediately. The global economy is also adding a new category of goods– the 'weightless' goods. These goods or products are information based or electronic, such as computer software, applications, films and music or information services rather than actual tangible, physical goods such as food, clothing or automobiles. Improved and faster transport systems have also made global travel easier.

Reduction in capital barriers by countries has increased the ability of the firms to receive adequate finance and investments. It has also increased the interconnectedness of global financial markets. Globalization has also been aided by MNCs or Multinational corporations which utilize resources from around the globe and sell their products and services in global markets leading to greater interaction. These factors have helped in economic liberalization and globalization and have facilitated the world in becoming a “**global village**”.

3.2. Effects of Globalization**3.2.1. Effects on society and culture**

Globalization is an important development that has impacted Indian social life. It has impacted different sections of the society with internet and communication technologies acting as an agent of change. It has led to certain transformations in social and cultural processes and institutions, some of which have been discussed below:

Effects of globalization on the family system:

Globalization has led to improvement in position of women in the family and therefore promoting overall gender equality. It has also led to reduced conservative and orthodox beliefs and eradication of some social evils like child marriage. Another consequence of globalization is that it has led to rise in nuclearization of families. Nuclear families, characterized by individuality, independence, and desire for privacy are gradually replacing the joint family system. Even the institution of marriage seems to be breaking down at a fast rate. **Globalization** has led to **homogenization and hybridization of culture**, affecting our deep-rooted customs, traditions and the values of marriage. **Modernization** has **changed** the conservative **attitude** of people towards inter-caste marriages and widow remarriages. Rise in the number of working parents has increased the

importance of the **nanny system**. Due to an increase in the cost of living in cities, people leave their dependant parents behind in their villages or send them to old-age homes and show less respect for them like in movie "**Baghban**". The concept of the head of the family is deteriorating and importance is being given to breadwinners.

**we have already read in Section 1.2 as to how globalization and urbanization have impacted the family system and the institution of marriage in India.*

Effects of globalization on children:

Globalization has impacted children in direct and indirect ways. The positive effects of globalization are that the children are now more aware of the world happenings and this is creating more avenues for learning, recreation, jobs and other amenities in life. They are now more future ready and exposed to values like competition, tolerance. Globalization has also helped in developing a cosmopolitan attitude among children.

However, the rise in children belonging to nuclear families has resulted in a weak connection with their kin and relatives. Further, children are exposed more to electronic gadgets and online modes of entertainment, cutting them off from the real world. Consequently, they are influenced by negative behaviour patterns (aggression, trolling, violence) represented in mass media through television, newspaper, movies, social networking sites, etc. This often leads to a change in their temperament and makes them physically, mentally and emotionally weak. Intense competition can also cause depressing tendencies, which is evident from increasing suicide rates in Kota, Rajasthan (hub for IIT JEE preparation). Globalization is also changing life styles, food habits of children, especially in cities. They are becoming addicted to consuming unhealthy junk food over homemade food. This has resulted in the intake of an unbalanced diet- devoid of nutrients that are required for their healthy development. Instead of playing outdoor games, children are also increasingly becoming addicted to mobile / gaming systems. Internet crimes such as bullying, pornography etc. can cause mental imbalance and also lead to extreme steps as seen in Blue Whale challenge. Thus, there is a need to protect the children through strengthening the support system by value education, proactive parenting, participation of NGOs, investment in child health etc.

Think about the effect of globalization on a child's mental health.

Effects of globalization on women:

Since ancient times, women in India have faced problems due to patriarchy, caste-based discrimination and social restrictions. But globalization has challenged this institution of patriarchy. As nuclear families have become more common, it has become easier for women to assertively claim their rights and ask for equality. Globalization has opened new avenues for not only working men but also women, who are becoming a larger part of the workforce. There is an increase in women workforce in white collar jobs, thus contributing to GDP growth. The voice of women is also increasingly being heard in legislatures, courts and in the streets. Globalization has indeed promoted ideas and norms of equality for women that have brought about awareness and acted as a catalyst in their struggle for equitable rights and opportunities. Increased participation of women in the economy is **a boon to both the National economy and family incomes**. The much conservative political sector has gradually increased participation of women because of the modern ideas propagated by globalization, for example, **women sarpanchs in India**. The roles of women in India have been changing and they are now emerging from the past traditions into a new era of freedom and rights due to globalization. It is widely felt that earning power allows them to voice their opinions on bigger decisions.

On the negative side, globalization has resulted in women juggling between **domestic responsibilities** and full-time **professional work**. There is also an increase in the number of **low paid, part-time** and **exploitative jobs for women**. Women in rural areas are overburdened, as migration of men has led to **feminization of agriculture**. Because of globalization, **crimes like women trafficking** and **exploitation of women at workplace** have also increased.

Discuss the positive and negative effects of globalization on women in India? (UPSC 2015)

Effects of globalization on other vulnerable groups:

Globalization has impacted almost all sections of society, particularly the vulnerable groups. With respect to **tribals**, globalization has helped in providing them with greater opportunities to receive education and skills training, leading to digital and economic inclusion. This may also help to bring them in mainstream. Ideally, urban and educated tribals should have benefitted from the increased work opportunities that came with the influx of foreign companies and investments. However, these have led to displacement of tribals from their place of abode, owing to mining, construction and other related activities. Despite intense industrial activity in the tribal belt, the tribal employment in modern enterprises is also negligible. The tribals are forced to live in juxtaposition with alien capitalist relations and cultures, with traumatic results. They are forced into low paid, insecure and transient labour market. Even pattern and methods of ownership of resources have changed.

Globalization has led to increased awareness amongst the **differently-abled** and also other people about their right to life and to live a dignified life. Events such as Paralympics have acted as a motivational force for them and also help in instilling a feeling of pride and achievement among the participants. Globalization has also aided in increased availability of funds for societies and NGOs working for the 'divyang'. This has enabled them to perform improved research and development activities for their betterment. It has also enabled replication of best practices regarding capacity building (use of prosthetics, hearing aids, visual aids, etc.) and engagement in economic activities. Funds can be utilized for creation of infrastructure in the form of library and schools and other disabled friendly facilities. For example, the Marrakesh Treaty makes the production and international transfer of specially-adapted books for people with blindness or visual impairments easier. However, in some cases, the competition through globalization has led to slow growth and near neglect of the disabled. It has reduced the role of state further in provision of public services like education, health etc. Moreover, digitization in telecom sector has led to loss of jobs which was a major employer for the disabled.

For the **elderly**, globalization has led to mixed results. On one hand, geriatric healthcare has become more accessible and efficient and average life expectancy has increased, because of improvement in technology, medical facilities, and living standards. In terms of remittances, globalization has aided in easier and quicker money transfer options for children employed abroad, who wish to transfer money back home. On the other hand, more and more nuclear families have resulted in isolation, rejection and loneliness of aged persons leading to psychological distress and increased crimes against older people. Digital divide has also contributed to the marginalization of the elderly with respect to delivery of online based services.

Critically examine the effects of globalization on the aged population in India. (UPSC 2013)

The emergence of **LGBTQ+** (lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender and Queer) rights movements and their increased visibility are seen as signs of **globalization**. **Pew research centre** states that "society as a whole has become more accepting of gays and lesbians". U.S Supreme Court judgment in **Obergefell vs. Hodges in 2015** which legalized same sex marriages, strengthened similar demands in India. Infact Gay rights activism in India coincided with similar activism across the world. For instance, the first petition against Section 377 in 1980s was inspired by a stonewall inn incident in U.S. Subsequently, majority of democratic nations like Indonesia, Germany, Australia, etc. have legalized homosexuality. It is not only the government but also social media that has played an important role in bringing the issue to mainstream. June is celebrated as the 'Pride Month' in many countries of the world, including India, to dedicate it to the LGBTQ community and their struggle against discrimination and social ostracization. Picnics, marches, public events and initiatives are held for the community and media coverage of these events also help in creating awareness about them.

Therefore, it can be said that Globalization has come forward as a mixed bag. Government and society, in response, have to work in tandem to ensure that its ill effects are nullified while its benefits are reaped.

1. Globalization has led to an increased level of interconnectedness among the people of the world and affected their lives, work and families. Critically examine the impact of globalization on vulnerable groups.
2. Had it not been for globalization, the rights granted to LGBT community in India would have been a distant dream? Discuss.

Effects of globalization on the education system:

Increased internet penetration has created a robust knowledge ecosystem for learning anything, anytime, and anywhere. The positive effects of globalization on education system have **made the otherwise obsolete education systems up-to-date**. Globalization has also promoted assimilation of knowledge of the latest events, technologies, facts, developments, and discoveries which is very much essential for the development of any society. It has made possible, the conduct of student exchange programs and increased collaboration with reputed global universities, thereby providing diverse exposure to students. Globalization has also promoted new tools and techniques such as **e-learning, flexible learning, distance education programs, and overseas training**.

However, there are certain **negative effects** of globalization on education system. The worst impact of globalization on education can be seen in the rapid **commercialization of education** and over-emphasis on **market-oriented courses**. Due to globalized education, subjects like **social sciences and humanities have been undermined**, which has a detrimental effect on society. A globalized education system prepares the students to earn their living, rather than focusing on the development of mental horizons and personalities of the students. Educational institutions are putting more and more emphasis on courses that create skills for the market, while social, cultural, political, traditional, and moral education is being neglected and being termed as irrelevant and obsolete.

Challenges to global health:

As borders disappear, people, goods and thoughts are increasingly free to move, creating new challenges to global health. Noted economist **Milton Friedman** claims that “world is flat proves that political borders are becoming lesser hindrance to the movement of people and thoughts across the modern world”. But simultaneous challenge of global health issues has arisen which has become a major concern for national as well as international governments. Increased migration has raised the possibilities of communicable, non-communicable diseases. The world is already witnessing the devastating impact of COVID-19 on their societies. Even other serious diseases like **SARS, swine flu, Nipah virus** pose a severe threat to the world population. Similarly, **trafficking of illegal organs** is another major concern. Another issue is that changing food preferences from healthy homemade food to unhealthy junk food is causing problems like **obesity, cardiovascular diseases**. Increased exchange of thoughts is also leading to behavioural changes like increased **materialistic tendencies and individualism** which are getting manifested in depression, suicide, etc. Due to shift in manufacturing to developing countries like China and India, **level of pollution** has increased significantly causing **respiratory problems** among people.

Globalization however, has also ensured the fruits of research and development done in the developed world to reach other parts of the world. Technological changes in many advanced countries have led to a substantial increase in health spending. The health sector is now explicitly recognised as an industry as well as a service sector. Global transportation and the communications revolution have enabled rapid response to epidemics and catastrophes and ensured quick availability of essential drugs, saving thousands of lives. Many countries started manufacturing and exporting masks, ventilators, test kits and sanitisers to

other countries during the coronavirus pandemic. Indian medicinal exports, for instance of hydroxychloroquine (HCQ)- an early preventive drug for COVID- to US and other countries can also be recognised as an example of globalization. India is called as a pharmaceutical hub and one of the largest producers of generic medicines in the world (about 20%). More than 80% of the world's anti retro-viral drugs come from India. India is also the largest producer of vaccines even before the COVID pandemic and controlled more than 50% of global supplies. Medical tourism is also one of the effects of globalization and it is estimated to grow and become a 9 billion dollar industry in India.

Effects of globalization on religion:

Globalization has brought a culture of pluralism, i.e., religions “with overlapping but distinctive ethics and interests” are seen interacting with one another. India's leading religious traditions teach values such as human dignity, equality, freedom, peace, and solidarity. Some of the **positive effects** of globalization on religion are that of exchange of values. Globalization allows for religions previously isolated from one another to have regular contact, thereby **enriching each other**. Religions are using the communication easily available through advanced technology to focus more on the **humane and pluralistic forms of their teachings** such as human dignity and human freedom. It has **increased the level of tolerance** among various religions. Followers of different religions are living side by side respecting the religious traditions of each other.

However, there are also certain negative effects of globalization. In an era of globalization, religious organizations set universal standards upon all members, causing individuals to believe that they are not fairly represented. Due to globalization, collective identity is reduced to a number of cultural religious characteristics. Religious affinity becomes stronger in comparison to national affinity. Many religions follow their religious leaders sitting in another country without giving it much thought that would it be harmful for the nation or not. For example, some Indians basing their opinions on and getting radicalized by listening to provocative speeches made by Zakir Naik, who is wanted in India for hate speech and money laundering.

Globalization and culture:

There are many ways in which globalization has affected culture. The last three decades have seen major cultural changes leading to fears that our local cultures would be overtaken. So, there is always a suspicion of the outside world due to its likely impact on domestic culture and traditions. As a result, globalization has generated debate and dilemmas about changes in clothes, styles, music, films, languages, etc. Online multi-player games like PUB-G, Dota, CS, etc. that can be played with players belonging to different countries at a time, can also be seen as an example of globalization. The recent ban on PUB-G by the Indian government in 2020, had created a huge furore and a mixed reaction from youth and their parents. Globalization has also led to strengthening of a feeling of fear among locals against migrant outsiders, who are perceived to be taking away their jobs. Further, there is a contention that globalization has led to homogenization of cultures. Due to opening up of food joints like Dominos, KFC, Burger King, there has been a homogenization of food available across the country. Fast food and chinese dishes have replaced samosa and paratha joints. There is also an increasing tendency towards **glocalization** of cultures.

Glocalization refers to the mixing of the global with the local. It is not entirely spontaneous nor is it entirely delinked from the commercial interests of globalization. It is a strategy often adopted by foreign firms while dealing with local traditions in order to enhance their marketability. For example, in India, we find that foreign television channels like Star, MTV, Channel V and Cartoon Network use Indian languages to expand their reach among the Indian masses. Even McDonalds sells only vegetarian and chicken products in India and not its beef products, which are popular abroad and goes vegetarian during the Navaratri festival. In the field of music, one can see the growth of popularity of 'Bhangra pop', fusion music and even remixes. Popularity of foreign movies has increased- Hollywood movies and Korean dramas are quite popular among the urban youth. Dubbing of these foreign movies in local languages is also a testimony of increased glocalization.

Globalization has also led to the revival of Yoga in the country as well as at the international level. This can be seen in the celebration of International Yoga day across the world and the popularity of the 'Art of Living' course by Ravi Shankar. There is also an increasing demand for local textiles and handicraft products in global markets, such as Chikankari or bandhani or embroidery. Due to increasing global tourism, locals also make efforts to preserve their diversity and revive their age-old traditions.

Terms related to globalization:

Monoculturalism– It is the policy or process of supporting, advocating, or allowing the expression of the culture of a single social or ethnic group in a specific area. It may also involve the process of assimilation whereby other ethnic groups are expected to adopt the culture and practices of the dominant ethnic group. Some experts are of the opinion that, since globalization results in an integrated global society and cultural homogeneity, it leads to monoculturalism on a global scale.

Melting Pot– A cultural melting pot refers to a society wherein all the immigrant cultures are mixed and amalgamated without state intervention. Example– present United States society.

Multiculturalism– In comparison to the above two approaches, multiculturalism is a view, or policy, according to which everyone, including immigrants, should be able to preserve their cultures and interact peacefully with each other. Today, this is the official policy of Canada, Australia, and the UK. Indian society is also a multicultural society since ancient times. Multiculturalism has been described as preserving a “cultural mosaic” of separate ethnic groups, like a “salad bowl” and in this way is contrasted to a “melting pot” that mixes them.

1. *Is diversity and pluralism in India under threat due to globalization? Justify your answer. (UPSC 2020)*
2. *Are we losing our local identity for the global identity? Discuss. (UPSC 2019)*
3. *'Globalisation is generally said to promote cultural homogenisation but due to these cultural specificities appear to be strengthened in the Indian society.' Elucidate. (UPSC 2018)*
4. *To what extent globalisation has influenced the core of cultural diversity in India? Explain. (UPSC 2016)*

2.2.2. Effects on economy

Globalization has led to an increase in India's growth rate and trade. India's trade with world has increased both in terms of volume and value, with exports worth \$295.8 billion in 2017. Globalization has also strengthened service sector of our economy which now constitutes more than half of India's GDP. Our per capita GDP has increased to \$1709 and forex reserves have risen to unprecedented levels of \$400 billion. Globalization has improved the standard of living of people in India and improved their purchasing power capacity due to rise in incomes. It has helped Indian consumers by giving them a choice to enjoy high quality global brands as well.

However, fruits of growth because of globalization have not been evenly distributed among the sectors of the Indian economy and among the sections of Indian society. Share of agriculture in GDP has decreased since 1991 from 29% to 14% whereas share of service sector has risen to 55%. It has also adversely affected the manufacturing sector as domestic manufacturing companies failed to keep pace with global manufacturing ones after the opening up of the economy with LPG reforms. This also subsequently limited the growth of MSME's at large. Globalization also led to an increase in regional disparities. Metropolitan cities of India like Delhi, Bombay benefited the most from Globalization and certain regions like eastern and north-east India have remain untouched. Post-globalization, a substantial increase in urban-rural divide along with intra and inter-state inequalities has also been witnessed. Globalization has also been aided by and led to, a further rise in

MNCs which are now seen expanding their domain to even political affairs of the country. For instance, the KITEEX textile group in Kerala, which employs about 11000 workers, took part in local body elections (won majority of the seats), in order to influence investment decisions pertaining to that Panchayat area.

Effects of globalization on agriculture:

Agricultural sector is the mainstay of the rural Indian economy around which socio-economic privileges and deprivations revolve. Therefore, any change in its structure is likely to have a corresponding impact on the existing pattern of social equity. Globalisation has opened up the doors of Indian economy and consequently agriculture sector has undergone massive changes. The positive impact of globalization on agriculture is that India has been experiencing an increase in the production of food-grains, particularly after the inception of new agricultural strategy (Green revolution) and adoption of new technology and internationally best agriculture practices. Another important emerging trend of agriculture due to globalisation is the increasing volume of agricultural exports. Agricultural exports are playing an important role in expanding economic activities along with generating employment opportunities. With globalization, farmers are being encouraged to shift from traditional crops to export- oriented 'cash crops' such as cotton and tobacco. This shift has generated more income to the farmers.

Globalisation has ensured ample scope for the development and expansion of food processing industry, increasing Foreign Direct Investment in this sector and has encouraged contract farming which has helped farmers. However, globalization has affected Indian agriculture negatively as well. Demand for cash crops has increased farmer's focus on these crops. This can have major implications if farmer's deviation from food crops undermines food security in the country. Globalisation has also shifted public discourse from agriculture sector to industrial sector, this has caused low investment in agriculture leading to agrarian distress. Contract farming and corporate farming could act as possible solutions to problems of Indian Agriculture, but they will be unviable on small sized and fragmented landholdings. Further, limit on global subsidies by WTO and non-discriminatory approach to be followed has made many crops economically non-viable.

Due to increasing role of private players, the sphere of state has shrunk. This in turn has increased the vulnerability and risk of farmers to external fluctuations. This, along with other factors has further aggravated agrarian distress in India. The spate of **farmers' suicides** that has been occurring in the different parts of the country since 1997-98 can be linked to the '**agrarian distress**' caused by structural changes in agriculture and changes in economic and agricultural policies. These include the changed pattern of landholdings; changing cropping patterns especially due to the shift to cash crops and liberalization policies that have exposed Indian agriculture to the **forces of globalization**.

Globalisation and employment:

The relationship between employment and globalization is another key issue in the present times. Here too there is an uneven impact of globalization. For the middle-class youth from urban centres, globalization and the IT revolution have opened up new career opportunities. Instead of pursuing BSc/BA/BCom. degree from colleges, youth can now learn basic computer skills or computer programming languages or take up jobs at call centres or Business Process Outsourcing (BPO) companies. The advent of shopping malls and multiplexes has also opened up new types of jobs for the youth of today, especially in the gig economy. Yet the lower rate of job growth trends in employment is disappointing as globalization has led to jobless growth phenomena. Weak levels of education and vocational skills do not allow huge labour availability to translate into effective employment opportunities. Globalization has also resulted in the casualization of labour and therefore forced migration. Global competition has tended firms to shift from formal wage workers to informal employment arrangements without minimum wages, assured work, or benefits. As more and more men enter the informal

economy, women tend to be pushed to the lowest income end of the informal sector. Moreover, the transition from labour intensive to capital intensive industries has also resulted in high rate of unemployment in India.

Gig economy is characterized by short-term contracts or freelance work as opposed to permanent jobs. It often involves connecting with customers through an online platform. For example, delivery boys of app-based food/medicines/other products, consultants, bloggers. In India, there are about 3 million gig workers and as per the estimates of the firm Team Lease, in the 2nd half of 2018-19, 13 lakh Indians joined the gig economy. Despite being the biggest job provider, most of these workers don't see the gig economy as a full-time option due to job insecurity, amplified by complex contracts, the changing rates of incentives, and the lack of control over impossible targets. Gig economies work outside the traditional employment structures excluding them from minimum-wage protection and social security. During COVID induced lockdowns, platform workers were responsible for the delivery of essential services during the pandemic at great personal risk to themselves. They have also been responsible for keeping platform companies afloat despite the pandemic-induced financial crisis. Despite all this, gig workers faced a continuous dip in pay and no rewards for being essential workers. For instance, the base pay of Swiggy workers was reduced from Rs. 35 to Rs. 10 per delivery order. All India Gig Workers Union was also formed to protest against this discrimination.

'It is often argued that although globalisation has been an effective instrument in India's growth trajectory, it has enaendered selective growth with restricted impact on Socio-economic fabric of India'. Discuss.

2.2.3. New middle class

Globalization has led to the creation of a new middle class. It is represented as a social group, which is negotiating India's new relationship globally, in both cultural and economic terms. This group is not a homogenous group but it is rather disjointed based on social position and ideology on one hand and earnings and occupation on the other. It is a new class of salaried professionals which has developed its own subculture having characteristics such as achievement-orientation, focus on higher education and consumerism. They face challenges with respect to work pressure, family issues and often suffer from stress, health issues and unrest in personal lives. The new middle class has an increasingly equitable participation of women and has altered the pre-existing norms of gender status, roles, privileges, child-care, well-being of the elderly and balance between work and family life. The gap between males and females is seen to be declining and new gender roles are being formed and exercised.

Globalization is not only desirable but inevitable. It has natural advantages for society as well as economy. However, it has to be ensured that globalization is fair, inclusive and sustainable. The national governments, international institutes, multi-national corporations, civil society organizations and other stakeholders can do this by ensuring fair wages, poverty alleviation, universal healthcare and education, infrastructure development, etc.

4. WOMEN AND CHILDREN ISSUES

4.1. Women issues and empowerment

Women's empowerment is the act of giving women- **power or authority** and removing social restrictions and disabilities that act as an obstacle for them in performing to the best of their potential. Empowerment is an active multi-dimensional process that enables women to have the "power to say yes and the right to say no". Most countries today consider gender equality and women's empowerment to be essential for the development and well-being of families, communities, and nations. No nation, society, and family can flourish and be happy if women and girls, are not respected, free and happy.

The status of women in India has been subject to many changes over the past few millennia. During the Vedic period, it is noted that women enjoyed equal rights, sometimes even better status than men. During the post Gupta period onwards, the status of women declined and practices like Sati among some communities, child marriages and a ban on widow remarriages became part of social life in India. In modern India, reformers like Raja Ram Mohan Roy, Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar, Jyotiba Phule, etc. fought for the upliftment and empowerment of women during British rule and some progressive steps were taken like the enactment of the Child Marriage Restraint Act in 1929, and Widow Remarriage Act in 1856, etc. During India's freedom struggle, women too played a significant role. Smt. Sarojini Naidu, an acknowledged poet, and a freedom fighter was the first Indian woman to become the President of the Indian National Congress. Women in independent India, have been holding high-level positions in administration, corporate sector and politics. They have been at the position of the President of India, Prime Minister of India, Speaker of Lok Sabha, etc., in Indian Parliament. Despite these facts, women in today's India are discriminated against and exploited by various customs like honour killing, harassment at workplace, dowry, pardah, female infanticide, wife burning, acid attacks, sexual violence, domestic violence, etc.

The need for women's empowerment is felt because they suffer from **patriarchal structures and ideologies** and experience gender inequalities and subordination. They are victims of social prejudices and lag behind men in all indicators of social and human development. Although the life expectancy of women is higher than that of men but quality of their life in terms of health, nutritional and educational levels are significantly lower than that of men.

Women face a life cycle of discrimination: from womb till death. If a girl child is detected in womb, it leads to foeticide. Since 1991, 80% of districts in India have recorded a declining sex ratio. Sex selective abortions are common in regions having firm belief in usefulness of a male heir. If the girl child survives, she is subjected to neglect. Low priority is given to health and nutrition of a girl child as compared to the health of a boy child. Gender roles are assigned in the childhood itself where the girl child is treated subordinate to brother and expected to take care of other family members. She often becomes the first victim of poverty. She is removed from schools and made to participate in household chores or made **victim of child labour**. She is made to sacrifice her studies for education of other siblings. According to **Census 2011**, literacy rate in women was around 64 percent, that is 18 percent lower than males. Practice of child marriage in the garb of traditions, customs and financial obligations is another injustice. UNICEF estimates suggest that each year, at least 1.5 million girls under the age of 18 are married in India. This translates into no freedom in choice of nutrition, food or family planning. From her adolescence, she is subjected to eve teasing, sexual harassment and gender stereotyping and time and again she is asked to behave 'like a girl'. At the adolescent age, 70% of the girls are anaemic and their problems related to their menstrual health and hygiene often go unaddressed.

As they grow older, they suffer from further exploitation. A woman in the Indian society is never perceived to be independent. Her father has authority over her in childhood, her husband in youth, and her son in old ages. Women are concentrated in low skilled and low paid jobs, they get lower wages and lower income than men and hardly own and/or control property and means of production. The participation of women in political and social decision-making is also abysmally low. They are underrepresented in Parliament and State Legislatures. The 17th Lok Sabha has 78 (14.4 percent of 542 MPs) and Rajya Sabha 25 (just over 10 percent of 245 MPs) women MPs. This figure of political representation is not proportionate to women population in the country.

Is biology the reason behind patriarchy?

Patriarchy is based on the notion that men are physically stronger but this does not appear to be a valid argument. Men have been seen to dominate over certain positions and professions which do not require physical fitness, for example- priesthood or positions of public service or financial positions, that were not open to women earlier. Moreover, the modern world rewards and gives more importance to mental labour than physical labour, therefore, believing that the social power is proportional to physical power might not be an ideal thing. Patriarchy infact, has deeper socio-economic roots rather than just the superficial physical reasons.

How does patriarchy impact the position of a middle-class working woman in India? (UPSC 2014)

Even in the judiciary, the Supreme Court has only four women judges as against a sanctioned strength of 34 judges. There has never been a female Chief Justice of India. This figure is consistently low across the High Courts which have only 77 women judges out of the sanctioned strength of 644 judges (data as of September 2021). Women labour force participation in India is also lower than the global average. It is accorded to low education qualification, lack of freedom to join workforce and patriarchal mind-set of society. Higher illiteracy and lack of awareness among women also deprive them of government social security benefits like insurance and pension. With the **feminization of agricultural sector** (Economic Survey 2017-18), about 80-100 million women are engaged in agriculture, constituting 33% of cultivators and about 47% percent of agricultural labourers. However, they are awarded only 10% of the income. Paid maternity leave to women has also affected them adversely. Since pregnant women have to be given 26 weeks of maternity leave according to recent amendment to Maternity Benefits Act, employers tend to hire male workers. In higher positions, **glass ceiling** is at work which does not let women to hold higher positions of management where their numbers are very low.

Around 70 percent of world's poor are women. Even in India, **women living under poverty are higher**. It deprives women of their opportunity to participate completely in society while also violating their right to a dignified and meaningful life. This reflects in their **low health indices**. As per National Family Health Survey-4, more than half of the children and women are anaemic in 13 of the 22 States/UTs. Malnutrition is higher among girl child as compared to their male counterpart. **Nutritional deprivation** is a major reason for different ailments in women. Women face other markers of discrimination as well. They face hardships due to digital divide which further hampers their progress. On growing older, they suffer through identity crisis when their role as a primary caregiver

Honour Killing:

Honour killing refers to the murder of young people (who choose to marry outside the prescribed family norms), in the name of caste purity, patriarchy and family pride. Such murders are presently reported under IPC Section 301 and 304, however, there is no separate law to deal with them. These are generally carried out under the aegis of Khap Panchayats (especially in North India), who claim to be the protectors of social order and carry out moral vigilantism. Supreme Court in various cases has ruled that it is illegal for the Khap Panchayats to interfere in the marriage of two consenting adults and directed the police to provide protection to the couple.

is over in old age. They are treated as burden and hence one can find large old widowed female population abandoned in religious places like Mathura, Vrindavan, Varanasi, etc.

Women in society are under constant fear due to increasing **instances of violation of their physical self**. Safety and security of women in society has become a matter of concern. Women face sexual harassment, domestic violence and abuse, adultery and marital rapes. **According to the UN**, one out of every three women experiences violence. This means over one billion women and girls all over the world experience violence. The **National Crime Records Bureau** data reflects that incident of rapes and crimes against women are increasing. In recent years, the majority of cases categorized as crimes against women were reported under 'cruelty by husband or his relatives' (32.6%), followed by 'assault on woman with intent to outrage her modesty' (25%), 'kidnapping and abduction of woman' (19%) and 'rape' (11.5%). According to a global study conducted by **Thomson Reuters**, India is the **"fourth most dangerous country"** in the world for women, with India reporting as many as 87 rape cases in a day (as per NCRB). The laws also perpetuate this injustice which is seen in cases where courts mediate between the victim and the perpetrator and ask the rape-accused to marry the victim as a form of punishment. Judiciary is also unwilling to recognize marital rape as a crime as they believe it can bring harm to the social fabric.

Sex Ratio is the ratio between the number of women and men in the population. In some countries it is calculated as the number of males per thousand females. In India, the sex ratio is worked out as the **number of females per thousand males**. The sex ratio is an important information about the status of women in a country. As per the population projections report, the sex ratio of the total population (females per 1000 males) is expected to increase (i.e. become more feminine) from 943 in 2011 to 957 during 2036. Tribals have better sex ratios (STs-990, whereas for SCs-945 as per Census 2011) due to prevalence of matrilineal societies, better agency for women, lack of access to sex determination clinics and high female labour force participation rate. Migration also affects the sex ratio as males are generally the dominant sex who migrate. For example, Kerala has a sex ratio of 1084 where men migrate to middle eastern countries. Though overall sex ratio in India has shown some sign of improvement but continuous declining trend of child sex ratio is serious cause of concern for policy makers. (* to be discussed in section 4.2)

The phrase "missing women" was coined by Amartya Sen when he showed that in parts of the developing world, the ratio of women to men in the population is suspiciously low. According to a report titled **"Declining sex-ratios – a matter of concern"** by **UNICEF** India, Indian female deficit in 1901 was 3.2 million, but in hundred years this deficit magnified 10 times to 35 million in 2001. Most of this decline is seen in 0–6-year segment, which is alarming. In states like Punjab, Haryana, Jammu Kashmir, Chandigarh and Delhi, sex ratio has declined below 900. Haryana with a sex ratio of 879 is the lowest in the country. A confounding problem is that these states are one of the most prosperous states of the country. Traditional patriarchal desires for male child due to ritualistic necessities and propagation of lineage manifests in a more visible manner in agricultural states. Male child is seen as a more valuable asset for carrying out agricultural activities. Earlier, women used to work in agricultural fields, but mechanization and increased use of cheap migrant labourer have reduced their utility in agriculture. Further, green revolution has brought prosperity in region resulting in easy access to sex determination technologies and sex selective abortions. As a result, **patriarchal social outlook** has translated into a prejudiced and compulsive preference for boys with discrimination against the girl child. **Regressive practices such as dowry** continue to be practiced despite being declared illegal, as a result of which a girl child is seen as a liability.

Decrease in the women population has wider social costs as it directly impacts the growth of population since women are primary nurturers. For example, China's family planning program has led to decrease in number of women drastically and hence created a skewed decline in population growth rate. Also, declining number of women is leading to forced **delay in marriage of males** i.e., increase in

bachelorhood. This temporary bachelorhood in search of bride sometimes turns into permanent one and directly affects the reproductive age group population. **Out-migration** in search of bride leads to added pressure on population growth. For example, men from Punjab/Haryana are shifting to southern states like Karnataka, Kerala or 'importing' brides from poorer states creating concerns of human trafficking- also called the 'Bengali bride diaspora'. There are other negative effects as well, for example, increasing crime rate specially against women, and increasing incidents of rapes and abductions. Theories of the social consequences of imbalanced sex ratios posit that **men will exercise strict control over women's behaviour** when women's relationship options are plentiful and men's own options are limited. The system of **patriarchy becomes stronger as a result**.

1. How do you explain the statistics that show that the sex ratio in Tribes in India is more favourable to women than the sex ratio among Scheduled Castes? (UPSC 2015)
2. Why do some of the most prosperous regions of India have an adverse sex ratio for women? Give your arguments. (UPSC 2014)

Impact of covid-19 on women:

Covid-19 has emerged as a shadow pandemic for women. Women were the first to lose jobs when the lockdown was imposed. They not only suffered from their own job loss but also became victim of domestic violence when their husbands lost their jobs or suffered pay-cuts. Increased tension and anxiety in family caused by financial crisis made women targets for venting up the frustration of male members of the household. Data from National Crime Record Bureau shows large spike in reporting of domestic violence cases during lockdown. Agencies like police, NGOs etc. which are the first responders to women's distress were preoccupied in COVID management, resulting in reduced support system. Scholars estimate the problem to be even much larger as vast number of crimes remain unreported.

On one hand, care giver role of women has further increased during the pandemic and on the other hand, her own health has become even more neglected. Data shows reduction in institutional delivery and immunization cover since March 2020. Different surveys have suggested reduced nutritional intake in both rural and urban households due to financial crisis in families. Disproportionate burden of hunger is again borne by women, as she is the last one to eat and first one to go hungry in most households.

COVID-19 lockdown also robbed families their "away time" resulting in flaring up of past tensions and higher rate of divorce during the period. This has put women in a difficult spot where job market is down denying chance of living independently while it is becoming increasingly difficult to cope up with the crisis at home. Loss of husband, child and loved ones to the disease has added to the mental pressure and agony of women. More and more women have sought professional psychological support during COVID-19. The economic crisis at home has forced some women to take up dicey and risky employment opportunities such as surrogacy to support their families. Overall, Covid-19 has disproportionately affected women and caused havoc in their personal as well as professional life.

East – West distinction in gender discrimination:

Gender is a socially created concept which attributes differing social roles and identities to men and women. Due to patriarchal society, gender discrimination and biases exists throughout India. However, **manifestation** of this gender discrimination and biases **vary** and exhibit themselves in completely **different forms** in western and eastern India. In **western** India, these discriminations exhibit themselves in form of **lower sex ratio** due to **access to sex determination technologies** like ultra sound leading to **sex selective**

abortions (female feticide). Western India has a case of “**missing girls**”. Whereas, in **eastern** India, gender discriminations exhibit themselves in form of **son-meta preference** (case where multiple girl child are born in hope of male child) due limited access to modern medical technologies. So, eastern India has a case of “**unwanted girls**”. **Lack of reproductive rights** of women in **western** India manifest itself in form of **forced abortions** whereas in **eastern** India, it manifests as **forced pregnancies and multiple deliveries**. Both of them take physical as well as psychological toll on women.

In **western** India, green revolution, technological adaptation and **income improvement** has pushed women out of agriculture and **confined them within household**. On the contrary, in eastern India, **wide-spread poverty** has pushed women in **agriculture and other menial jobs** to support income of the family. However, in both the cases women have limited role in taking decisions or no control over income. In western India, due to **poor sex ratio**, a new forms of exploitation are emerging like “**gram vadhu**”, “**mulki pratha**”, **buying of bride** etc. On the other hand, sex ratio in **eastern** India is relatively better and women face problems like **trafficking, selling of young girls, kidnapping** etc. The **eastern** India act as a **source** region and **western** India as **sink** region for many trafficked girls.

What are the continued challenges for women in India against time and space? (UPSC 2019)

Constitutional provisions for women:

1. The **Preamble** to the Constitution of India assures justice, social, economic and political; equality of status and opportunity and dignity to the individual. Thus, it treats both men and women equal.
2. The Constitution of India guarantees equality to all under **Article 14**.
3. The constitution under **Article 15(1)** says that State can't discriminate against the women.
4. Article 15(3) empowers the State to take affirmative actions in favour of women.
5. Equal opportunity for all has been guaranteed under **Article 16**.
6. The constitution under **Article 39 (a)** provides that the state direct its policy towards securing for men and women equally the right to an adequate means of livelihood.
7. Equal pay for equal work is mentioned under (**Article 39(d)**).
8. Constitution also allows for provisions to be made by the State for securing just and humane conditions of work and for maternity relief (**Article 42**)
9. Under (**Article 51(A) (e)**) it is mentioned to renounce the practices derogatory to the dignity of women.

Ways to empower women in India:

Women's empowerment would require changing patriarchal thinking and structures, giving women control over resources. The **political empowerment of women** and their representation in political decision-making acts as a catalyst in achieving **gender equality**. Political participation means not only exercising the right to vote but also power-sharing, co-decision making, co-policy making at all levels of governance of the state. In India, the Ministry of Human Resource Development (MHRD) and the National Commission for Women (NCW) have been working to safeguard the rights and legal entitlement of women. The political participation of women in India is not impressive when compared with men. According to **UNICEF**, political participation of women has the potential to change societies. It can have an impact on outcomes for women and children especially in the distribution of community resources. In this regard, the **73rd and 74th** Amendments (1992) to the Constitution of India have provided some special powers to women for reservation of seats in institutions of local self-government (33%). However, more needs to be done such as **Women's Reservation Bill** [The Constitution (108th Amendment) Bill, 2008] must be passed by the government in order to bring **equality**.

Women's Reservation Bill, 2008:

There has been a recurring demand for women reservation in India and as a result, **Women's Reservation Bill** had also been introduced in the Parliament. It proposed to amend the Constitution to reserve 33% of all seats in the Lok Sabha and the State Assemblies for women. However, the bill lapsed with the 15th Lok Sabha. There is a need of affirmative action by the government to break the shackles of patriarchy and bring out the women at the forefront of development. Reservation would increase the participative decision making process and lead to empathetic and inclusive governance. However, it has also been observed that reservation for women in local self governments has led to election of proxies in place of women. The 'sarpanch pati' culture has made in-roads with women remaining as faceless sarpanchs, while their husbands carry out the actual public affairs work. Even the Prime Minister took cognizance of this issue and recognized it as a hurdle to women's progress.

"The reservation of seats for women in the institutions of local self- government has had a limited impact on the patriarchal character of the Indian Political Process." Comment. (UPSC 2019)

Due to the increased participation of women in India we have seen women chief ministers, women President, different political parties' leaders, well-established businesswomen, etc. The most notable amongst these are Indira Gandhi, Pratibha Patil, Sheila Dixit, Mayawati, Sonia Gandhi, Brinda Karat, Najma Heptulla, Indira Nooyi (Pepsico), Sushma Swaraj, 'Narmada Bachao' leader Medha Patkar, Nirmala Sitharaman, Kiran Mazumdar Shaw etc. Research on *Panchayats* (local councils) in India discovered that the number of drinking water projects in areas with women-led councils was 62 per cent higher than in those with men-led councils. Therefore, in order to gain women development, the governments must ensure women-led development.

Social Empowerment is heavily dependent on many **different variables** that include geographical location (urban/rural), educational status, social status (caste and class), and age. Steps need to be taken to **improve the health status of women**, reduce maternal mortality, especially in the areas which do not have good medical facilities. A programme for checking the spread of sexually transmitted diseases like HIV/AIDS and infections/communicable diseases, like T.B., need to be launched specifically for women. They face high risk of malnutrition; hence focused attention would have to be given to meet the nutritional needs of women at all stages of their life-cycle. Similarly, education initiatives cannot rely solely on building educational infrastructure, but also need to address some of the root causes of discrimination against women and girls which affect the decisions made by parents and these needs to be addressed. Women need to be encouraged to gain higher education, which can have a multiplier effect on the educational outcomes of the next generation.

Salary for women for household work:

Data from 2019, gathered by the National Sample Survey Organisation (NSSO) revealed that only about a quarter of men and boys above six years engaged in unpaid household chores, compared to over four-fifths of women. Every day, an average Indian male spent 1.5 hours per day in unpaid domestic work, compared to about five hours by a female.

Women mainly from the middle class are increasingly entering the workforce. Urban centers like Delhi and Bengaluru have seen an influx of young women from semi-urban and rural parts of the country, living alone and redefining themselves. However, the story of economic empowerment for women is not a singular narrative; rather it is located in a complex set of caste, class, religious, and ethnic identities. The Global Gender Gap Report by the World Economic Forum in 2018 ranked India 108th out of 144 countries for inequality between men and women in economy, politics, health, and education. According to the UN Food and Agriculture Organization, if women had the same access to productive resources as men, they could increase yields on their farms by 20-30% which could raise total agricultural output in developing countries by 2.5-4%. Increased labour force participation, especially in specific sectors like teaching, nursing, handicrafts, service sector, etc. can definitely help in empowering them further.

Women empowerment in right sense has been made possible through **SHG movement in India**. Self-help groups (SHGs) are a widely practiced model for social and economic mobility by NGOs and the government. They are small **economical homogenous affinity groups**, voluntarily formed to save and mutually contribute a common fund to be lent to its members as per group decision. Among the real and potential clients of microfinance, women are seen as the most **reliable in terms of repayment and utilization of loans**. SHGs provide women with the opportunity to manage loans and savings that can be used by members for varying needs. The major benefits of SHGs are social empowerment and mobilization through better organization and improved skills to enhance the abilities of the target communities to undertake productive investment and increases earning opportunities. They ensure greater access to productive assets, infrastructure, and social services; and social protection to those who are vulnerable to natural and health related risks. The extent of participation in SHG can be gauged by the fact that at present more than 100 Scheduled Banks, 349 DCCBs, 27 State Rural Livelihood Missions and over 5000 NGOs are engaged in it.

'If Panchayats are institutions of representation, women's self-help groups are institutions of participation'.
Comment.

Social Media has also empowered women in raising their voice against exploitation and discrimination meted out to them. For instance, the **#MeToo movement** that started as a hashtag on Twitter in United States in 2017, enabled women to speak out against injustice. It soon became a global phenomenon with women across countries and even in India, sharing their stories of sexual harassment and abuse on social media. The movement helped shift the narrative from sexual harassment being a law and order problem to it being a deeply rooted cultural problem prevalent in society. Social media too helped in amplifying the stories and showed that existing legal measures are inadequate in solving this menace. It also provided a platform to women to seek closure from their ordeal and embrace solidarity. However, it remained an urban phenomenon and stories of women from poor and rural families- who are actually devoid of any support system, stayed buried.

Legislative steps for women empowerment:

Some of the important Acts of government are discussed below:

1. The Special Marriage Act, 1954: This act permits inter-caste and inter-religion marriage.
2. The Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act, 1956: It is the premier legislation for prevention of trafficking of women and children forced into sex work and exploitation.
3. The Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961
4. The Medical termination of Pregnancy Act, 1971.
5. The Equal Remuneration Act, 1976: Provides for payment of equal wages to both men and women workers for the same or similar and also prohibits discrimination against women in the matter of recruitment.
6. The Commission of Sati (Prevention) Act, 1987.
7. National Commission for Women: The National Commission for Women (NCW) was constituted in 1992 as an apex statutory body at the National level under the National Commission for Women Act, 1990 to safeguard and promote the rights and interests of women.
8. The Pre-Conception & Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (Regulation and Prevention of Misuse) Act, 1994.
9. The Protection of Women from Domestic aspects of women's development. The Violence Act, 2005.
10. The Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006.
11. The Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Protection and) Act, 2013.
12. The Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act, 2017: The Maternity Benefit Amendment Act has increased the duration of paid maternity leave available for women employees from the existing 12 weeks to 26 weeks.

13. The Muslim Women (Protection of Rights on Marriage) Act, 2019 makes instant triple talaq as unconstitutional and void.

Some important legislations are being discussed as below:

Maternity Benefit Act:

In *Mini vs LIC* case, Kerala High Court had ruled that a mother cannot be compelled to choose between her motherhood and employment and emphasized that the government should come up with a legislation to protect employees from discrimination at workplace due to their family responsibilities. This underscores the need for an ecosystem that makes it easy for women to return to work after a break as maternity and child-care shouldn't be a deterrent for a woman keen on pursuing a career. With this idea in mind, the Maternity Benefits Act was passed by the Parliament in 1961 and recently amended in 2017. The amendment increased the **paid maternity leave** from 12 weeks to 26 weeks for all women employees in establishments with ten or more people as this would encourage them to join the workforce. It makes it mandatory for enterprises with 30 or more women or 50 or more employees to provide for a crèche facility within a 500m radius. The Act also extends maternity leave benefits for 12 weeks to adopting or commissioning mothers.

However, surveys and studies have found that the amendments might have unintended and unwanted consequences. Small firms would be reluctant in hiring women as it would be hard for them to bear the costs of an extended maternity leave. Moreover, the Act does not have any provisions for monitoring of the firms and grievance redressal, nor does it apply to the informal sector. To encourage employers to implement the extended 26 weeks leave, the Labour Ministry is considering a proposal to refund them for 7 weeks' worth of wages for women workers with a wage ceiling upto Rs. 15,000 per month.

The Medical Termination of Pregnancy Act:

Abortion refers to an act when a woman, out of her own free will, wants to terminate her pregnancy. This was a crime in post-independent India. As a result, a committee was constituted under Shanti Lal Shah to recommend an Act to ensure reproductive rights to women. After the passing of The Medical termination of Pregnancy Act, abortions were made legal for foetus less than 20 weeks of age, subject to doctor's opinion. The criteria for 20 weeks was chosen based on the fact that scientifically, the gender of the foetus could be determined after 20 weeks by getting a sonography. For foetus of more than 20 weeks, abortions are not allowed unless there is threat to the life of the mother. However, the Bombay High Court ruled in 2019 that women could approach the judiciary if they wanted to terminate their pregnancy after 20 weeks. This provision became a lifeline for rape victims and for women who wanted to terminate their pregnancy owing to foetal abnormalities.

Gender Budgeting:

Gender Budgeting is an exercise to translate stated gender commitments of the government into budgetary commitments. This is a strategy for ensuring gender sensitive resource allocation and enables tracking and allocating resources for women empowerment. It is used as a means of mainstreaming women's concerns in all activities and improving their access to public resources. The Ministry of Women and Child Development (MoWCD) as the Nodal agency has adopted the mission strategy of 'Budgeting for Gender Equity' to ensure that government budgets are planned according to the differential needs of women and men and accordingly prioritized. It is undertaken through several institutional mechanisms such as Gender Budget Statement, Gender Budget Cells, as well as various schemes/programmes for women and girls. India started releasing a Gender Budget along with the Union Budget in 2005-06. The Gender Budget has two parts: Part A includes schemes with 100% allocation for women (for example-the girl's hostel scheme); and Part B with schemes allocating at least 30% of funds for women (for example-Mudra Yojana). However, in the last 13 years, the allocations as a proportion to the total budget have stayed constant between 4 to 6 per cent. In order to achieve women development and empowerment, the budgetary allocations for women specific schemes, especially Part A schemes would need to be increased.

Welfare schemes for women in India:

Some of the important welfare scheme for women empowerment in India are discussed below:

1. **Beti Bachao Beti Padhao:** It was launched by the Prime Minister in 2015 at Panipat in Haryana, to bring behavioural change in the society towards birth and rights of a girl child. The Scheme has two major components such as mass communication campaign and multi-sectoral action covering all States and UTs and is being implemented by a coordinated effort by the Ministry of WCD, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare and Ministry of HRD. Its aim is to prevent gender biased sex selective elimination, ensuring survival & protection of the girl child, ensuring her education and participation in development processes.
2. **Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana and Poshan Abhiyan.** (*to be discussed in Chapter 9- Health and related issues)
3. **Swadhar and Short Stay Homes** to provide relief and rehabilitation to destitute women and women in distress.
4. **Working Women Hostels** for ensuring safe accommodation for working women away from their place of residence.
5. **Support to Training and Employment Program for Women (STEP)** to ensure sustainable employment and income generation for marginalised and asset-less rural and urban poor women across the country.
6. **Rashtriya Mahila Kosh (RMK)** to provide microfinance services to bring about the socio- economic upliftment of poor women.
7. **National Mission for Empowerment of Women (NMEW)** to strengthen the overall processes that promote all-round development of women.
8. **Rajiv Gandhi National Creche Scheme for Children of Working Mothers** (including single mother) to provide day care facilities for running a crèche of 25 children in the age group 0-6 years from families having monthly income of less than Rs 12,000.
9. Scheme for **Universalization of Women Helpline** intended to provide 24 hours immediate and emergency response to women affected by violence.
10. **Sabla Scheme** for holistic development of adolescent girls in the age group of 11-18 years.
11. Mahila Samridhi Yojana (MSY): NSFDC had introduced the Scheme titled 'Mahila Samridhi Yojana (MSY)' – an exclusive micro-credit scheme for women beneficiaries.
12. **Nari Arthik Sashaktikaran Yojana (NASY):** This scheme was launched to provide loans at 4% per annum under any NSFDC scheme to single women/widows/ women who are head of their families to take up income generating activities and improve their socio-economic status.
13. **The National Plan of Action for the Girl Child (1991-2000):** The plan of Action is to ensure survival, protection and development of the girl child with the ultimate objective of building up a better future for the girl child.
14. **National Policy for the Empowerment of Women (2001):** The Department of Women & Child Development in the Ministry of Human Resource Development prepared a 'National Policy for the Empowerment of Women' in the year 2001. The goal of this policy is to bring about the advancement, development and empowerment of women in India.

Draft National Policy for Women 2016:

The draft National Policy for Women aims at **creating a conducive socio-cultural, economic & political environment for women** to enable them to **enjoy rights** entitled to them. It also talks of **eliminating all forms of violence against women** through appropriate policies, legislations & community engagement.

In the field of health, it recommends focus on reducing maternal & pre-natal mortality, to address cases of acute anaemia, low BMI, etc. by augmenting capacity of Anganwadi & ASHA workers. It recognizes

other possible health care problems related to **adolescent & reproductive health, old age, mental health** & diseases like AIDS, Cancer, etc. & suggests intervention through prioritizing women in health care & insurance schemes. It also recommends to address problem of malnutrition among women by intervening appropriately at different stages of life cycle (childhood, adolescent, reproductive & old age) and that there is a need to end intra-house discrimination in nutritional matters.

The policy underlines importance of pre-school education by **strengthening anganwadis**. It recommends proper implementation of RTE & provision of gender friendly facilities like separate toilets to increase enrolment & reduce dropouts in case of adolescent girls. Also help of ICT & distance education programs can be taken to address issues of accessibility. It suggests setting up of **innovative educational institutions** to ensure education of children of migrant families. It recommends **gender sensitization of school faculty & curriculum** to inculcate better understanding of concept of masculinity & femininity in students through education system. Also it suggests setting up of **responsive complaint mechanism** in schools to address discriminatory attitudes & cases of sexual harassment.

The policy recommends effective implementation of relevant legal provisions to **ensure women's right to immovable property**. To **ensure resource rights of women**, policy recommends to give priority to women during government land distribution schemes & to provide relevant concessions in stamp duty to **promote joint registration of land** among spouses. It proposes a system of **registration of tribal migrants** and domestic workers to **protect their rights**. It also addresses **gender pay gap & growing informalisation of women workers** mainly due to burden of maternity leave & child care provisions. It recommends a mechanism for **monitoring compliance of regulatory laws** which **ensure equal treatment to women at workplace**. For example, Maternity Benefits Act, Sexual Harassment of Women at workplace Act, etc. It moots passing of women reservation bill for increasing their participation in state legislative assemblies & parliament. It also emphasises on increasing their participation in trade unions, political parties, interest groups, etc. so that they become active part of decision making.

Policy recognizes all incidents faced by a female since birth like sex selective abortion, denial or education, child abuse, domestic abuse & abuse faced in public like or workplace as cases of violence against women. It recommends effective implementation of PCPNDT act and awareness programs to improve sex ratio. It suggests strengthening of existing legislations & policies regarding prevention of trafficking & rehabilitation of victims. It also recommends strict monitoring of response of enforcement agencies in cases of violence against women, ensure time bound justice, strengthening of alternative dispute mechanisms like family courts and gender sensitivity training to police & judicial personnel to effectively investigate & prosecute cases of gender based violence. Urban & rural planning projects must include gender sensitive infrastructure and public utilities like innovative transportation models for school children, improving accessibility of public transport for ensuring safe commute to workplace.

Though the **policy comprehensively addresses** issue of women empowerment but a lot more needs to be done for effective implementation. In order to ensure equal rights & opportunities for women, **suggested legislative & policy changes must be incorporated** & in addition to that, **community awareness programs** must also be run to **enable mind-set change** so that the issue of crime & violence against women, which are more of social menace than a policy issue, can be effectively dealt with.

In past few years, paradoxical trends have been observed as acknowledgement of gender rights and equality is juxtaposed against increase in reporting of violence against women (Hathras, Unnao cases). In light of the above statement examine how the National Policy for Women 2016, will be able to ensure equal rights and opportunities for women.

International cooperation on women empowerment:

India is a party to various international conventions and treaties which are committed to secure equal rights of women. For example, **Convention on Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW)**, ratified by India in 1993, **Mexico Plan of Action** (1975), the **Nairobi Forward Looking Strategies** (1985), the **Beijing Declaration as well as the Platform for Action** (1995). Also, **SDG 5** aims to achieve gender equality and empower all women and girls and India is committed to the sustainable development goals.

Justice Verma Committee Report:

Justice Verma Committee was constituted to recommend **amendments to the criminal law** so as to provide for quicker trial and enhanced punishment for **criminals accused of committing sexual assault** against women. Committee made recommendations such as make voyeurism, stalking and intentional touching an offense. It emphasized an urgent need to amend rape laws, **review security laws in conflict zones**, due to the number of reports of alleged sexual offences committed by the armed forces in India's conflict areas such as Kashmir and the North East, because of the Armed Forces Special Powers Act (AFSPA). It also stressed on the need for monitoring illegal, patriarchal village councils and the need for **gender sensitization** through education.

India can be truly called as a democratic country only if its women are empowered. However, we are still far behind in achieving the equality and justice which the Preamble of our Constitution talks about. The real problem lies in the patriarchal and male-dominated system of our society which considers women as subordinate to men and creates different types of methods to subjugate them. The need of the hour is to educate and sensitize male members of the society regarding women issues and try to inculcate a feeling of togetherness and equality among them. For this to happen, apart from the government, efforts are needed from various NGOs and even from enlightened citizens of the country. Such efforts should first begin from our homes where we must empower female members of our family by providing them equal opportunities of education, health, nutrition and decision making without any discrimination.

4.1.1. Role of Women and Women Organizations

The status of the women in India has been changing through history. But different stages of history show differential treatment of their own kind towards women. In India, it is an evident dichotomy that at one side we are able to see the divine in feminine form through the goddesses Lakshmi, Saraswati and Durga but on the other hand we also commit the most heinous offences towards women such as rapes, sexual exploitation, female foeticide, social suppression, domestic violence etc. Example of gender inequality exist from ancient times, for example, Draupadi, wife of **five Pandavas** was, used by them in a game of **dice like goods**. Today as well, women don't enjoy an equal freedom to participate in economic, social, political and personal activities.

Historical studies and the scriptures indicate that Indian woman enjoyed a comparatively high status during the early Vedic period. They were trained in combat, and combat equipment was specially designed for women warriors as is evident in recently excavated burials from Sinauli. In Vedic society participation of wives was required in many rituals. Woman could select their husband in an assembly called 'Swayamvara'. Women also enjoyed religious status like that of men, especially in Vedic initiation and studies. Panini mentioned of female students studying Vedas. King Ashoka got his daughter, Sanghamitra, inducted into preaching Buddhism. From the Jain texts, we learn about the Kaushambi princess, Jayanti, who remained a spinster to study religion and philosophy. Woman wrote Sanskrit plays and verses, excelled in music, painting and other fine arts. The story of Gargi engaging in a philosophical debated with king Yajnavalkya showed they had access to education and intellectual freedom. Other sages like Maitreyi were well known. They composed Hymns in Rig Veda. They were allowed to perform sacrifices. This is depicted in the works of Patanjali and Katyayana. Condition started deteriorating. Kautilya referred to women and wine as vice. From Greeks 'Troy' to 'Mahabharat' she was depicted as cause of feuds and wars. Gupta period saw women being denied education. Medieval period saw

practice of Purdah and Sati emerging. It was the Bhakti movements and later Indian renaissance followed by INM which led the transformation of women's status in India.

During medieval period as well, there are examples of active participation of women in social, political educational and religious fields like Raziya Sultan and Rudramadevi as woman monarchs. Bhakti movement too had important women participation such as by Mira or Andal, a legendary Tamil Bhakti poet. But largely, the position of women became worse in medieval period, as system of purdah and Jauhar (woman with their own consent immolate themselves so as to save their self from exploitation by enemy), came into vogue. The position and status of women in the Mughal period was not quite high either. Purdah and child marriage were commonly practiced. Women did not move out of their houses. The Muslim women observed purdah much more strictly than the Hindus. The birth of a daughter was considered inauspicious, while that of a son was an occasion for celebration, a social trait that has continued to modern times. Women did not remarry in general, but polygamy was common. Divorce was not common among the Hindus, while it was permitted both for Muslim men and woman.

During the period of British rule in India, many social reformers such as Raja Ram Mohan Roy, Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar and Jyotiba Phule struggled for improvement in status of women in Indian society. Peary Charan Sarkar started girl's school in India in 1847 at Calcutta. But social support for reforms was lacking. Only with the help of Governor Bentick, could Raja Ram Mohan Roy succeed in abolishing the sati system by law. Widow remarriage was given a push. Women social reformers such as Pandita Ramabai Ranade also came to fore. Rani Lakshmi Bai was another inspiring figure, who died leading a battle against the Britishers during the first war of independence in 1857. Woman too played very crucial role in national movement against British rule in India for example Kasturba Gandhi, Annie Besant, Aruna Asaf Ali, Sarojini Naidu, etc. Many women movement played a critical role in boycotting of foreign cloth and picketing of liquor shops during the civil disobedience movement. In the event of men's arrest, the women's organization took on the task of carrying on civil disobedience and organizing meetings. In spite of all these examples, status of woman in the society was unprivileged. They did not have any right to succession in the property of their own family members.

In ancient and medieval period, status of women is practically lower than males even though the scriptures, theoretically, have given higher status to woman. Women are also worshipped as Goddess, yet they are ill-treated in everyday life. However, the position and status of women is considerably changing in modern Indian society. Progressive laws are being made, keeping in mind that women act as important stakeholders in the development process. Woman today occupy high ranking posts like I.A.S., I.P.S. and also in our Defence services. Role of women in modern India can be observed in various fields such as education, politics, sports etc.

Education plays a critical role in the development of a nation whether it is social or economic growth. As per a UN report, education for women is the single most effective way to improve lives and health of a family and a society at large. There is a huge gap between male (82.14%, in 2011) and female (65.46%, in 2011) literacy rates in India. Though slow, in the last decade (2001-2011) the gender gap is seen to be narrowing rapidly – women literacy rate has been growing at 11.8% and men at 6.9%. The enrolment of girls in higher education increased from 39% to 46% from 2007 to 2014. The educational performance of girl students particularly at high school and college level is proving to be better than that of boys especially after 1980. We have today some universities exclusively meant for women. The contribution of women for developing various languages cannot be ignored. Mahadevi Verma and Subhadra Kumari Chauhan are well known for Hindi writings, Amrita Pritam has enriched Punjabi language with her works. Kuntala Kumari Sabat has enriched Oriya literature and many women writers have been awarded by the Sahitya Academy and other organizations. There are hundreds of women editors, journalists and columnists in the country who are performing meritorious services.

In both villages and cities, there has been a remarkable increase in the number of women going out of the four walls of the household and doing full-time work. In some fields the number of **women employees** is steadily increasing. For example, women working as teachers, doctors, nurses, advocates, bank employees, clerks, typists, telephone operators, receptionist, personal assistants and so on. Since 1991, though in a smaller number, women are getting recruited into armed force, air force and naval force also.

Female participation in **sports** rose dramatically in the twentieth century, especially in the last quarter, reflecting changes in modern societies that emphasized gender parity. Karnam Malleswari, Saina Nehwal, Sania Mirza, P V Sindhu, Sakshi Malik, Mary Kom, Mirabai Chanu, Lovelina Borgohain, the Phogat sisters, etc. are the names of a few individuals who have made India proud at various sporting events. More and more parents are encouraging their children especially females, to play and seek a career in sports. They have faith that sports can provide the platform for a healthy and decent future.

Women's organizations:

As women become more aware of the structural problems they faced in society and their rights, they began raising their voice against such infractions and injustice. Emergence of women's organizations in India has been due to the combined effects of spread of education and the various reform movements being carried out for women's rights.

Pre-Independence women's organizations- Social reform movements were started by Raja Ram Mohan Roy, and Swami Dayanand Saraswati in 19th century. They challenged conventional subservience of women, supported widow remarriage, female education and gender equality in matters of religion, among other issues. As a consequence, many women's organizations were formed, some of which are listed below:

1. **Pandita Ramabai**, and **Justice Ranade** established the **Arya Mahila Samaj** in 1882 to improve the condition of women, especially child widows. In 1889, Ramabai also established the Mukti Mission, in Pune, a refuge for young widows who had been deserted and abused by their families. She then founded the Ladies Social Conference (**Bharat Mahila Parishad**), under the parent organization National Social Conference, in 1904 in Bombay.
2. In 1910, Sarala Devi Chaudhrani established the **Bharat Stree Mandal** (Great circle of India Women) with the objective of bringing together women of all castes, creeds and classes together. Branches were begun in different cities all over India like Lahore, Amritsar, Allahabad, Hyderabad, Delhi, Karachi etc. Sarala Devi considered 'Purdah' to be the main obstacle for women's education.
3. The **Women's Indian Association** (WIA) was founded at Adyar, Madras, in 1917 by Annie Besant, Margaret Cousins, Jeena Raja Dasa, and others to liberate women from the deplorable conditions in social, economic and political matters during the 19th and the early 20th century. The Association developed into a potent force in fight against illiteracy, child marriage, the Devadasi system and other social ills.
4. Women in Mumbai, Chennai and Kolkata through networks developed during World War I work, allied their associations together and created the **National Council of Women in India (NCWI)** in 1925.
5. A non-governmental organization 'the **All-India Women's Conference** (AIWC)' was founded in 1927 by Margaret Cousins to mobilize educational efforts for women and children. It later expanded its scope to also tackle other women's rights issues. The organization is one of the oldest women's groups in India that continue to be active. It has branches throughout the country.

These movements were Hindu dominated and were criticized for being elitist. They were also called 'a club of upper class women.'

The women's questions arose in modern India as a part of the 19th century social reform movement. What are the major issues and debates concerning women in that period? (UPSC 2017)

Post-Independence women's organizations– The Constitution of India drafted in 1950 granted equal rights to men and women. A slew of rights such as the right to vote, right to education, right to entry into public service and political offices, however brought in complacency among women's groups. During this time rights for women were limited. The organization building efforts continued as the **National Federation of Indian Women (1954)**, and **Samajwadi Mahila Sabha (1959)** were formed to provide basics rights to women. **Self Employed Women's Association (SEWA)** was established by initiative of Ela Bhat in 1972.

Between 1970-1980, women organizations took up the issue of dowry deaths, bride burning, rape, and sati and focused on violence against women. These organizations questioned the orthodox patriarchal system which undermined women's role in the family and society.

Progressive Organization of Women (POW, Hyderabad) later reorganized as Forum Against Oppression of Women, **Stree Sangharsh** and **Samata (Delhi)** were some of the groups which started struggle against rape in 1980s. The **National Commission for Women (NCW)**, a statutory body of the Government of India, was established in January 1992. It is generally concerned with advising the government on all policy matters affecting women. The objective of the NCW is to represent the rights of women in India and to provide a voice for their issues and concerns. The subjects of their campaigns have included dowry, political equality, religion, equal representation for women in jobs, and the exploitation of women for labour. They have also raised their voice against police excesses against women. Some organizations such as the **Banga Mahila Samaj**, and the **Ladies Theosophical Society** work at the grassroots level in order to share contemporary ideas with women of rural regions. These organizations deal with issues like **women's education, abolition of social evils like purdah and Child marriage, Hindu law reform, moral** and material progress of women, equality of rights and opportunities. The basic aim of these women organizations is upliftment of women and equality of rights between men and women.

Friends of Women's World Banking was established as a non-profit organization to promote direct participation of poor women in the economy through access to financial services. The main aim to create this was to expand informal credit supports and networks within India to link them to a global movement. **Bharatiya Mahila Bank (BMB)** was an Indian financial services banking company based in Mumbai, India. Although initially it was reported that bank was exclusively for women, later the bank allowed deposits from everyone, but lending was still predominantly for women. It was subsumed by the State Bank of India in 2017 as part of banking consolidation.

Aapan Samachar is an Indian news program produced entirely by women. It is based in Muzaffarpur, Bihar, India. **Durga Vahini** (Carrier of Durga) is the women's wing of the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP). The purpose of the Durga Vahini is to encourage more women to participate in prayer meetings and in cultural activities. **Association of Theologically Trained Women of India (ATTWI)** is an association of Indian women theologians which was constituted in 1979 in Chennai. The whole aim of this association is to help the theologically trained women to explore ways and extend responsible participation in the total life and mission of the Church. **All India Federation of Women Lawyers** is an association of Indian women lawyers. Its main aim is to promote the rights and welfare of women and children particularly through legislation and help them in the exercise of their rights.

Bharatiya Grameen Mahila Sangh (BGMS) has the goal of welfare, upliftment and empowerment of women, children, the aged and partially impaired. It is the world's largest organization for rural women, and is in-turn a consultative body for UNO, UNESCO, WHO, and ILO. **Confederation of Women Entrepreneurs (COWE)** is an NGO/social organization engaged in the social and economic "upliftment of women through entrepreneurship". **Swadhina** (Self-ruled women), established in 1986, is primarily a civil society organization focused on empowerment of women & child development based on sustainable development principles and the right to livelihood. Swadhina has a goal to bring positive social change as it has a direct effect on the lives of

women through their equal and spontaneous participation. The **All-India Democratic Women's Association** is an independent left oriented women's organization committed to achieve democracy, equality and women's emancipation. Membership is sought from all strata of society, regardless of class, caste and community. Apart from these organizations, all major Indian political parties also have their own women's organizations

The women organizations have promoted equality, literacy, and social awareness among the marginalized women. They have encouraged income generating activities and economic capacity building among women. These organizations have also helped in breaking the **gender stereotypes**. They have even contributed to **strengthening women's participation in agriculture & provided support in achieving food security**. These organizations are helping in making the society and world a better place to live in. They are helping us march towards an inclusive future for (wo)mankind as they break through the stereotype of patriarchal mindsets in families, society and individuals.

1. 'Women's movement in India has not addressed the issues of women of lower social strata.' Substantiate your view. (UPSC 2018)
2. Male membership needs to be encouraged in order to make women's organization free from gender bias. Comment. (UPSC 2013)

Changing nature of women's movements:

Women's movements in India have been organised to address various socio-economic and political disadvantages faced by women as a category. These movements have witnessed a change along with the changing position of women in India today.

1. **Leadership:** While the earlier movements were led by male intelligentsia such as the socio-religious reform movements of the early 19th centuries, the women's movements today are led by female leaders such as Ela Bhatt(SEWA), Indira Jaising (DVA, 2005), Meenakshi Arora (Vishakha Guidelines), Menaka Gandhi, etc.
2. **Ideology:** The women's movements till even the last decade were more concerned with alleviating specific issues related to women's rights such as Domestic Violence Act agitation, anti-liquor movements, anti-dowry movements, etc. However recently, the movements aim towards a deeper change in social mind-set of patriarchy. For example, recently India witnessed an extension of global movement 'Slut walk'.
3. **Methods:** While the earlier movements relied on petitions, protests and public opinion formulation, the newer movements have complemented these with an extensive use of social media. Emotionally appealing videos and messages are used to impact the mind-set with the use of new media and fast pace of communication.
4. **Concept:** The concept of women's movements has undergone a shift from viewing women merely as a deprived section of society, to viewing them as equal participants in the developmental process of the nation. For example, the recent movements for RTI in Rajasthan, the anti-Corruption movement, etc. saw large women participation.
5. **Basis:** While the earlier movements were majorly concerned with improving the social position of women like Sati, Infanticide, the new ones are oriented to better economic standing like the SHG Movement.

As India continues to perform low in Gender Equality Indices (Gender Inequality rank- 125 out of 159), the women's movements must continue to evolve and strengthen, to achieve the ideal of an equitable society.

Feminism

Feminism is an ideology that believes in equal rights for both men and women in all walks of life. It fights against patriarchy and promotes an egalitarian society with no gender roles. The essence of Feminism has a

strong fundamental case that woman suffer from systematic social injustice because of their sex. Although, centrally it is about women- their experiences and condition, however, feminism is also fundamentally about men- their perceptions and about social change. Feminism must be given a positive overtone through social/electronic media, political groups and by male counterparts themselves, in order to tackle the conservative backlash against the rising power of womanhood.

Two methods feminists use to facilitate a sense of women empowerment are consciousness-raising and building relationships with the women participants. When raising consciousness, women not only become knowledgeable about their personal struggles but how it is related to political and economic issues. Raising consciousness allows marginalized individuals to see where they are placed in the larger social structure and pinpoint the root of their oppression. Awareness of their problems will initiate self-mobilization which precisely creates empowerment. In addition, feminists focus on building relationships as a medium for creating women empowerment. Scholars claim that building relationships results in empowerment because the increasing presence of power gaps in society are due to the lack of relationships that are needed to bridge them. Fostering a space for collaboration as well as deliberation of conflicting ideas is important because sorting out disagreements allows for the formation of trust between the parties. In addition, conflict individually benefits the women participants because it fosters problem-solving skills and opens them to a new pool of knowledge and perspectives on society.

4.2. Empowerment of children

The United Nations Convention on the Rights of a Child, an international treaty that recognizes the human rights of children, defines children as persons up to the age of 18 years. According to it, State parties must ensure children are not discriminated in any form and are provided special assistance and protection, given their vulnerability. India has one of the largest proportions of population in the younger age groups in the world. 35.3% of the population of the country has been in the age group 0-14 years as per Census 2001 and 41% of the population accounts for less than 18 years of age.

Children are considered to be at a risk of experiencing exploitation, violence and neglect. Children in especially poor households or difficult circumstances, are comparatively more vulnerable. They include orphans and street children, refugee or displaced children, child workers, children trapped in prostitution or sexual abuse, disabled children and delinquent children. Some of them are exploited as child labourers and are more vulnerable to malnutrition, bad health, poor educational facilities, poor recreational and sports facilities, thus restricting their freedoms and opportunities. **Diarrhoea and malnutrition** are two biggest killers of children under the age of 5. India has one of the **highest Infant Mortality Rate (IMR)** i.e. 34 per 1000 live births. In 2005, around 2.1 million children were out of school in urban areas out of a total of 13.4 million children out of school in the country.

Girl babies are at an even greater disadvantage due to prevailing social norms that tend to value males much more than females. This leads to son 'preference'. Despite continuing PCPNDT Act the sex selective abortion technology is still used by the members of the family to know the gender of the child. Family members coerce the pregnant women to abort in case a female child is expected. Child sex ratio (0 - 6 year) in India has shown a disturbing trend since 1961 and was at its historical low in 2011. Child Sex ratio imbalances are most evident when the first born is a girl.

Year	1961	1971	1981	1991	2001	2011
CSR (0-6)	976	964	962	945	927	919

A girl child further faces different forms of violence like infanticide, neglect of nutrition needs, lack of education and healthcare facilities, early marriage, gender discrimination, gender based exploitation and violence, etc. In 2013, India was among the top 5 countries with the highest rate of **child sexual abuse**.

Child labour is another conspicuous problem in India. Its prevalence is evident in the child work participation rate, which is more than that of other developing countries. The position of India in terms of child labour is not an appreciable one; with credible **estimates ranging from 60 to 115 million. India has the largest number of working children in the world.** According to International Labour Organisation, the term '**child labour**' is defined as the 'work that deprives children of their childhood, their potential and their dignity, and that is harmful to physical and mental development.' ILO's World Report on Child Labour 2015 says that **one in every eleven** children in India is working. Numerous **causes** can be attributed to this such as poverty, illiteracy, lack of access to education, increasing demand for child labour etc.

Child Labour:

In India, **Article 24 of Fundamental Rights** prohibits the employment of children below the age of 14 years in hazardous environment and **Article 39(e) of DPSP** directs the state to ensure that children are not exploited. However, the Constitution did not provide for a blanket ban on child labour for children under 14 years, it did not discuss about children from 14-18 years of age and violations were also not dealt with. Thus, Parliament enacted **Child Labour Act of 1986** and thereafter, came up with the new **Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2016**.

Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act, 2016 provisions for plugging the loopholes:

The Act completely bans employment of children below 14 in all occupations and enterprises, with a few exceptions (for example- family or family enterprises, audio-visual entertainment industry), provided that education is not hampered. The Act has provided for a new category of persons called "adolescent", i.e., between 14 to 18 years and bars their employment in hazardous occupations. The Act makes child labour a cognizable offence and specifies punishment. Employing children below 14 years will attract a jail term between 6 months to two years (earlier 3 months to 1 year) or a penalty. The Act has provided for creating a Rehabilitation Fund for the rehabilitation of children. It also empowers the government to make **periodic inspection** of places at which employment of children and adolescents are prohibited. Therefore, it can be said the Child Labour Act 2016 takes up from where the constitutional obligation under Article 24 ends but some **shortfalls** remain.

It has reduced the list of hazardous occupations for children (from 83 to 3- mining, explosives and occupations mentioned in the Factory Act) allowing children to be employed in hazardous chemical mixing units, battery recycling units, among others. According to the UNICEF India, permitting children to work in their family enterprises would lead to more children working in unregulated conditions. It may restrict the children especially the poor children belonging to low caste to traditional caste-based occupations for generations. Also, it may be difficult to determine whether an enterprise is owned by a family or some person has employed the whole family to run the enterprise. The girl and child are particularly prone to more exploitation. The bill has also expanded the definition of family to include not only parents and siblings but also the siblings of either parent. The Act also does not define the hours of work; it simply states that children may work after school hours or during vacations which ignores the necessary time for recreation for children.

The Act makes a significant distinction between '**adolescents**' and '**children**' and therefore does not follow the provision of **UNCRC**, which states that 'a child means every human being below the age of 18 years. This redefining of hazardous occupations and processes has turned the occupations of domestic

labour, handling chemical insecticides in agriculture, work in slaughterhouses, brick kilns, carpet weaving, stone breaking and crushing, cotton ginning etc., as non-hazardous. The government need to focus on elimination of poverty, free and compulsory education, proper and strict implementation of the labour laws, abolishment of child trafficking, pro-active work of social organisations like the Kailash Satyarthi Children's Foundation, international cooperation etc. to solve the problem of child labour.

International mechanisms for eliminating child labour:

1. **International Labour Organisation** has helped set international law, which most countries have signed on and ratified.
 - a. According to **ILO Minimum Age Convention (C138)** of 1973, child labour refers to any work performed by children under the age of 12, non-light work done by children aged 12–14, and hazardous work done by children aged 15–17. Light work was defined, under this Convention, as any work that does not harm a child's health and development, and that does not interfere with his or her attendance at school. This convention has been ratified by 135 countries, including India.
 - b. In 1999, ILO helped lead the **Worst Forms Convention 182 (C182)**, which has so far been signed upon and domestically ratified by 151 countries including the United States. This international law prohibits worst forms of child labour, defined as all forms of slavery and slavery-like practices, such as child trafficking, debt bondage, and forced labour, including forced recruitment of children into armed conflict. The law also prohibits the use of a child for prostitution or the production of pornography, child labour in illicit activities such as drug production and trafficking; and in hazardous work. India ratified this convention in 2019.
 - c. The **ILO's International Programme on the Elimination of Child Labour (IPEC)** was created in 1992 with the overall goal of the progressive elimination of child labour, which was to be achieved through strengthening the capacity of countries to deal with the problem and promoting a worldwide movement to combat child labour.
2. The **United Nations** adopted the **Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC)** in 1990, which was subsequently ratified by 193 countries under Article 1 of the 1990 Convention, a child is defined as "... every human being below the age of eighteen years unless, under the law applicable to the child, a majority is attained earlier." Article 28 of this Convention requires States to, "make primary education compulsory and available free to all."

Children's safety, health, holistic development, and even their very futures are at risk due to the COVID-19 pandemic. For instance, many children are in danger of being trafficked or forced into child labour, teenage girls are at risk of being pushed into child marriage, many suffer exclusion, marginalization, abuse, and even violence owing to poverty. Large numbers of children are being cut off from formal education due to lack of accessibility to digital modes of education. Many children have also been orphaned due to loss of their parents.

Constitutional provisions:

Following are some Constitutional Articles that provide for protection and empowerment of children:

1. **Article 15(3)**: State can make special provisions for betterment of children.
2. **Article 21 A**: State to provide free and compulsory education of all children in the age group of six to fourteen years.
3. **Article 23**: Right of children to be protected from being trafficked and forced into bonded labour.

4. **Article 24:** prohibits the employment of children below the age of 14 years in any factory, mine or other hazardous activities like construction work or railway.
5. **Article 39(e)** of Directive Principles of State Policy direct state to ensure that the children are not exploited.
6. **Article 45:** The state to provide early childhood care and education for all children until they complete the age of six years.

Government bodies/commissions:

Following bodies have been set-up by the government for protection of children's rights and their development:

1. **National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR)**- examines and reviews the legal safeguards provided for the protection of child rights and recommends measures for their effective implementation; enquires into violation of child rights; inspects institutions meant for juvenile/children, etc. The Commission also has the powers of a civil court and all criminal cases brought to the same have to be forwarded to a concerned Magistrate.
2. **National Authority for Elimination of Child Labour** (Ministry of Labour and Employment)
3. **National Human Rights Commission (NHRC)**
4. **Ministry of Women and Child Development (MWCD)**
5. **Central Adoption Resource Authority (CARA)** functions as the nodal body for adoption of Indian children and is mandated to monitor and regulate in-country and inter-country adoptions of orphans and abandoned children. It also issues adoption guidelines laying down procedures and processes to be followed during the adoption programme.

Legislative provisions:

The government has passed below legislations for child empowerment:

1. **The Pre-conception & Pre-natal Diagnostic Techniques (Regulation and Prevention of Misuse) Act, 1994 (PCPNDT)** was enacted for prohibition of sex selection before or after conception and for prevention of misuse of pre-conception and pre-natal diagnostic techniques for sex determination.
2. **The Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006** was enacted to outlaw child marriage. The Act defines child marriage as a marriage in which either the girl or boy is underage, i.e., the girl is under 18 years of age or the boy is younger than 21 years.
3. **Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act (RTE)** was enacted to provide free and compulsory primary education to children between 6-14 years. It enforces Right to education as a Fundamental Right.
4. **Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act (2012)** provides protection to children from the offences of sexual assault, sexual harassment and pornography. It also provides for establishment of special courts for trial of such offences.
5. **Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act, 2016** bans employment of children below 14 years in all occupations and enterprises, with a few exceptions, provided that education is not hampered.
6. Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act (1976), Children (Pledging of Labour) Act (1933), Factories Act (1948), Plantation Labour Act (1951), Merchant Shipping Act (1951), Mines Act (1952), Motor Transport Workers Act (1961), Apprentices Act (1961), Beedi and Cigar Workers (Conditions of Employment) Act (1966) are other acts that ban child labour.
7. **Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act (1956)** aims to stop immoral trafficking of women and children.
8. **Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015** deals with juveniles who are in conflict with law and those in need of care and protection.
9. **Commissions for Protection of Child Rights Act (2005)** provides for the establishment of a **National Commission for Protection of Child Rights**, State Commissions for Protection of Child Rights and Children's Courts for the purpose of providing speedy trial of cases of violation of child rights.

Who is a child? In India, different laws define the words 'child' differently:

1. The 1989 United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child defines a child as an individual who has not attained the age of **18 years**.
2. Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act, 1986 – a child is defined as a person who has **not completed 14 years of age**.
3. The Plantation Labour Act 1951 has separate definitions for child, adolescent and adult. According to it 'child' means a person who has not completed his **fifteenth year**. 'Adolescent' means a person who has completed his fifteenth year but has not completed his eighteenth year whereas 'adult' means a person who has completed his eighteenth year.
4. Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006, states that "child" means a person who, if a male, has not completed **twenty-one years** of age, and if a female, has not completed **eighteen years** of age.
5. A Delhi High Court ruling said that "a Muslim girl can marry without the consent of her parents when she attains the **age of puberty**", thereby adding to the confusion.
6. **Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012**, defines child as any person below the age of **18 years**.
7. **Juvenile Justice (Care And Protection Of Children) Act, 2015** differentiates between children of less than 16 years age and those between 16-18 years of age.

Government schemes:

1. **Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS) Scheme** is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme that works for early childhood care by providing supplementary nutrition, immunization and pre-school education to the children. Its beneficiaries include children in the age group of 0-6 years and pregnant and lactating women.
2. **Sarva Siksha Abhiyan (SSA)** seeks to open new schools in those habitations which do not have schooling facilities and strengthen existing school infrastructure through provision of additional class rooms, toilets, drinking water, maintenance grant and school improvement grants. SSA seeks to provide quality elementary education including life skills. SSA has a special focus on girl's education and children with special needs and also seeks to provide computer education to bridge the digital divide.
3. **Mid-Day Meal (MDM) scheme** is a freshly-cooked lunch service to children in government and government-aided schools in India. It aims to avoid classroom hunger, act as an inducement for children to attend school and increase attendance and enrolment, improve socialisation among castes, address malnutrition and also empower women through employment as cooks.
4. **Platform for Effective Enforcement for No Child Labour (PENCIL)** is an electronic platform that aims at involving governments, civil society and the general public in achieving the target of child labour free society. Its components include child tracking system, complaint corner, etc.
5. **Rajiv Gandhi Scheme for Empowerment of Adolescent Girls (SABLA)** is a comprehensive scheme having adolescent girls of 11-18 years old as its intended beneficiaries. Salient features of the scheme include nutrition provision, iron and folic acid (IFA) supplements provision, health check-up, family counselling, child care support, etc.
6. Minister of Health and Family Welfare launched **MAA (Mothers Absolute Affection)** to ensure adequate awareness among masses, especially mothers, on the benefits of **breastfeeding**.
7. Under **Rashtriya Kishor Swasthya Karyakram**, peer educators will work as a change agent, helping in responding to queries related to- nutrition, sexual reproductive health, substance misuse, non - communicable diseases, mental health, injuries and violence.

8. **National Policy on Children 2013**- The Policy calls for purposeful convergence and coordination and has identified four key priority areas: survival; health and nutrition; education and development; and protection and participation, for focused attention.
9. **POCSO e-Box** - Protection of children from sexual offences e-Box is an online complaint box for reporting child sexual abuse. It is an NCPCR initiative to help children report such crimes directly to the Commission.
10. **Childline-1098** is India's first 24-hour, free, emergency phone service for children in need of aid and assistance. It is a platform bringing together the Union Ministry for Women & Child Development, working in Partnership with State Governments, NGOs, International Organizations, the Corporate Sector, Concerned Individuals and Children.
11. **National Child Policy, 2013**- In pursuance of the constitutional objective and UN convention on Child Rights, the Government launched National Child policy, in 2013, reaffirming children as an important national asset and adopts 'right based' approach. The policy proposes to provide long term, sustainable, multi-sectoral, integrated and inclusive approach for the overall and harmonious development and protection of children. It states that the right to life, survival, health and nutrition is an inalienable right of every child and should receive the highest priority. It also recognises the needs of the differently abled, the girl child and HIV-affected children. Every child has equal right to learning, knowledge and education, with due regard for special needs, through access, provision and promotion of required environment, information, infrastructure, services and supports, towards the development of the child's fullest potential. The state should provide an enabling environment, opportunities and support to develop skills, to form aspirations and express their views in accordance with their age, level of maturity and evolving capacities. Establishment of National/State Coordination and Action Groups to ensure field level implementation of child related schemes. The policy talks about social audit and community score card being used as tools to monitor effective implementation of the policy. It also proposes Child Budgeting in order to ensure budgetary accountability on commitments made for children.
12. **National Plan of Action for Children, 2016**- NPAC was launched at a special function held to celebrate the National Girl Child. The Action Plan has four key priority areas; survival, health and nutrition; education and development; protection and participation. The plan also puts focus on new and emerging concerns for children such as online child abuse, children affected by natural and man-made disasters and climate change, etc. The plan takes into account the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and provides a roadmap towards achieving them through co-ordination and convergence with different stakeholders.

Government, civil society and parents need to ensure that children have access to services such as education and health care; can develop their personalities, abilities and talents to the fullest potential; grow up in an environment of happiness, love and understanding; and are informed about and participate in, achieving their rights in an accessible and active manner.

Examine the main provisions of the National Child Policy and throw light on the status of its implementation. (UPSC 2016)

Juvenile crimes:

A juvenile is a young person under 18 years of age. There is a debate regarding their ability to show signs of maturity and therefore if they should be made legally liable for their criminal activities. In India, the juvenile delinquents (juveniles in violation of laws) are covered under the **Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act**. This act was amended in 2015 that will replace the JJ Act 2000 and states that any person aged between 16 and 18 years and accused of a heinous offence – defined as a crime for which there is a sentence

of seven years or more under the Indian Penal Code — may be tried under the IPC and not the JJ Act if, after a preliminary inquiry, the Juvenile Justice Board feels that the crime was committed with full knowledge and understanding of the consequences.

Standing Committee observed that the Bill violates the UNCRC (United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child) as it differentiates between children below 18 years of age. The UNCRC states that signatory countries should treat every child under the age of 18 years in the same manner and not try them as adults. It also recommends that those countries that treat or propose to treat 16-18 year olds as adult criminals, should change their laws to align with the principle of non-discrimination towards children. Child rights activists have criticized the Act as it is more focused on retribution rather than reformation, rehabilitation and preventing recidivism— which is the entire purpose for making separate laws for juveniles. Moreover, the adult prisons also don't offer a reformatory environment. The bill is targeting adolescents when it should be dealing with root causes of juvenile crime, such as poverty, broken families, unregulated access to pornography, etc. Additionally, past experience shows that harsh laws have not produced desired results. For example, TADA (Terrorists and Disruptive Activities Prevention Act) and POTA (Prevention of Terrorism Act).

However, according to National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB), the percentage of **16-18 year olds**, accused of crimes as a percentage of all juveniles accused of crimes increased from 54% in 2003 to 66% in 2013. It has been found that these juveniles are involved in serious crimes and such criminal acts are done with full knowledge and maturity. It is also of the view that the 3-year-period (for which delinquent children are kept in the custody of special homes) is for correction with respect to the damage done to the personality of the child. As per JS Verma committee, children, who have been deprived of parental guidance and education, have very little chances of mainstreaming and rehabilitation. Moreover, children these days, have access to technology and the crimes committed now are also different from in the past. Several other countries such as the U.S. and the U.K., have also faced an increase in violent crimes by juveniles and have resorted to similar actions. The amended Act is believed to have the potential to ensure justice to the victims on one hand and create effective deterrence on the other. What we need to ensure while doing this, is that these children grow up to become better citizens rather than hardened criminals. It is the wider society that will really benefit from rehabilitative justice for child offenders and their transition to responsible adulthood.

5. SOCIAL EMPOWERMENT

Social empowerment is a continuous and ongoing process of developing a sense of autonomy and self-confidence, and acting individually and collectively to change social relationships and the institutions that exclude the socially disadvantaged section. It is the process of accessing opportunities and resources in order to make personal choices (e.g., choosing what to eat, whom to marry, what neighbourhood to live in, etc.) and have some control over our environment. In this sense, social empowerment is the **development** of socially, educationally and economically marginalized sections of the society that includes scheduled castes (SCs), scheduled tribes (STs), other backward classes (OBCs), minorities, disabled and other social groups in order to bring them at par with the rest of society.

Social empowerment is a commitment enshrined in the Constitution. It is to be done by adopting the approach of social justice to ensure equal rights, access to benefits and resources to enable them to develop their potential and capacities as agents of social change, through the process of planned development.

5.1. Empowerment of SC, ST and OBCs

The caste system practiced in our society since ancient times gave rise to a class of people who were considered lowest in hierarchy with respect to their caste status. Such people earlier known as 'untouchables' and later as 'Depressed classes' during British times, were further classified as Schedule Castes (SC) post-independence. Scheduled Tribes were the 'tribes or communities', for instance, de-notified tribes, criminal tribes, forest dwellers etc., who were isolated from the rest of the communities. These indigenous tribal groups were later classified as Schedule Tribes (ST). They are called so because they are governed by the Schedules 5 and 6 of the Indian Constitution. Even after 75 years of independence, weaker sections especially SCs and STs continue to face **discrimination and atrocities in society**. The age-old practices of untouchability, lack of infrastructure facilities and geographical isolation have resulted in extreme social, educational and economic backwardness.

According to the **Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC) 2011**, the **literacy rate** of SC women is about 56.5% and SC males are 75.2%. Among ST males' literacy rate is 68.5%. Around 45 percent of SC households and almost 30 percent of Adivasis are landless and derive a major part of their income from manual casual labour. 35.4 % of the SC population lives **below the poverty line** in rural areas. Only 28 % of the SC population and 22 % of the ST population were users of **electricity** as against the national average of 48 % in 2011. **Infant Mortality Rate** (child death before the age of 1) in SCs is almost 83 per 1000 live births as against 61.8 for non-SC/ST group. Over 1.3 million Dalits are involved in **manual scavenging** of which almost 90 percent are women. 1.82 lakh families have at least one member employed in manual scavenging (Human Rights Watch 2014; Tandon and Basu 2016). These factors call for an utmost need for special consideration safeguarding their interests and accelerated socio-economic development.

Tribal Panchsheel

Based on the inputs of Indian anthropologist Verrier Elwin, Prime Minister Nehru favoured the policy of integrating tribal community with the mainstream, even while maintaining their distinct identity and culture. Tribal Panchsheel is the set of five fundamental principles for tribal development in India laid down by him. The Five Principles are as follows:

1. The tribals should develop along the lines of their own genius; there should be no imposition or compulsion from outside. They should not be made to do things that are alien to them in nature.
2. Tribal rights in land and forests should be respected and no outsider should be able to take possession of tribal lands. The incursion of the market economy into tribal areas had to be strictly controlled and regulated.
3. It was necessary to encourage the tribal languages which 'must be given all possible support and the conditions in which they can flourish, must be safeguarded'.

4. For administration, reliance should be placed on the tribal people themselves, and administrators should be recruited from amongst them and trained.
5. There should be no over-administration of the tribal areas. The effort should be to administer and develop the tribals' through their own social and cultural institutions.

As a result, Article 46 was inserted in the Constitution, which says, "The State shall promote with special care, the educational and economic interests of the weaker sections of the people, and, in particular, of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes, and shall protect them from social injustice and all forms of exploitation." Even after the Constitutional safeguards, Tribal Panchsheel policy and inclusive initiatives of the government, tribal development has been slow and they continue to be poor, landless and unemployed. Reasons behind this include, lack of political will, exploitation by forest officials and bureaucracy, illegal mining activities that impact their environment, misappropriation of funds and corruption, negation of their land rights and rights to minor forest produce, etc. Another reason is that the government has adopted a one-size-fits-all policy and has made the mistake of painting every tribe with the same brush. However, every tribe has a different typology and character and has to be treated differently. For instance, the condition of indigenous people in Central India is very different from that in the Northeast or in the Andamans. In a hospital for the Onge tribe, milk powder was given to them, which they were not able to digest. Similarly, in another case, a Jarawe boy who was sent to a local school by his parents was sent back by the school authorities, saying that they could not even touch him since official policy stated that he had to be left alone. The government must address these flaws and for that scientific research and evaluations should be done for each tribe separately before proposing any policy.

Constitutional provisions for SCs and STs:

Given the social and cultural history of India, Constitution contains **special provisions and safeguards** for Scheduled Castes, minorities, backward classes and Scheduled Tribes. These safeguards provide protection from discrimination, for their educational, economic, social and political development. In the **1931 Census**, for the first time, Government had systematically categorized certain castes as **depressed classes**. Thereafter, the **Government of India Act, 1935**, for the first time, provided for notification of socially disadvantaged castes as '**Scheduled Castes**'.

Article 341 (SC) and 342 (ST)– The **President**, may **with respect to any State/Union territory**, and where it is a State, **after consultation with the Governor**, specify the caste/races/tribes or parts of or groups within castes/races/tribes which shall be deemed to be Scheduled Castes (A341) or Scheduled Tribes (A342) in relation to that State or Union territory, as the case may be. **Parliament** may **by law include in or exclude from the list** of Scheduled Castes (A341) or Scheduled Tribes (A342) any castes/race/tribe or part of or group within any caste/race/tribe.

The Constitution of India provided several special safeguards for the Scheduled Castes, so as to ensure that they are able to attain equality with the other social groups in the shortest possible time. It **abolished "untouchability"** and provided reservations in elections to the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies and reservation in government jobs. Some important Constitutional provisions are discussed as below:

1. **Article 15(5)** – State to make **special provisions for backward classes or SCs or STs** for admissions in private educational institutions, aided or unaided.
2. **Article 16(4)** – State to reserve vacancies in public service for any backward classes of the state that are not adequately represented in the public services.
3. **Article 17** – "**Untouchability**" is abolished and its practice in any form is forbidden. The enforcement of any disability arising out of "Untouchability" shall be an offence punishable in accordance with law.
4. **Art. 19(5)** – State can impose restriction on freedom of movement or of residence for the benefit of Scheduled Tribes.

5. **Article 40**– Provides for the constitutions of Panchayat and there is reservation in 1/3 seats in Panchayats to SC/ST through 73rd Constitution Amendment Act 1992.
6. **Article 46**– Enjoins the states to promote with care the educational and economic interests of the weaker sections, especially SC and STs.
7. **Article 275**– Allows special grant in aids to states for tribal welfare.
8. **Article 330 & 332**– Allows reservation of seats for SC/ST in the Parliament as well as in state legislatures.
9. **Article 335**– Allows relaxation in qualifying marks for admission in educational institutes or promotions for SCs/STs.
10. **Article 338 and 338A**– Establishment of National Commission for SCs and STs.
11. **Article 339**– Central government can direct states to implement and execute plans for the betterment of SC/STs.
12. **Article 340**– Allows the President to appoint a commission to investigate the condition of socially and economically classes and table the report in the Parliament.
13. **Schedule 5**– deals with the administration and control of Scheduled Areas as well as of Scheduled Tribes residing in 10 States namely Andhra Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Odisha, Rajasthan and Telangana. Tribal habitations in the states of Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, West Bengal, Uttar Pradesh and Jammu & Kashmir have not been brought under the Fifth or Sixth Schedule. If the President so directs, there will be established a Tribes Advisory Council to advise on matters pertaining to the welfare and the advancement of the STs in the State.
14. **Schedule 6**– deals with the provisions for the administration of tribal areas in Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura and Mizoram, as per Article 244 of the Indian Constitution. It seeks to safeguard the rights of the tribal population through the formation of Autonomous District Councils (ADC). There are 10 autonomous districts in the country– North Cachar Hills, Karbi Anglong and the Bodoland Territorial Area in Assam, Khasi Hills, Jaintia Hills and Garo Hills in Meghalaya, Tribal Areas in Tripura, Chakma, Mara and Lai districts in Mizoram.

Census of India (2011):

Scheduled Castes are notified in 31 States/UTs of India and Scheduled Tribes in 30 States. **Punjab** has the highest percentage of its population as SC (32%). Mizoram and Lakshadweep have the highest percentage of their population as ST (95%), while Punjab and Haryana do not have ST population at all. 21.53%, or 3.86 crore families living in villages belong to SC/ST categories.

Census 2011 data	SCs	STs
Population	16.6 Crore	8.43 Crore
Sex Ratio	933	957
Literacy Rate	66.1 %	59 %
Gender Gap in Literacy Rate	14.7 %	19.1 %
Work Participation Rate	40.9 %	48.7 %

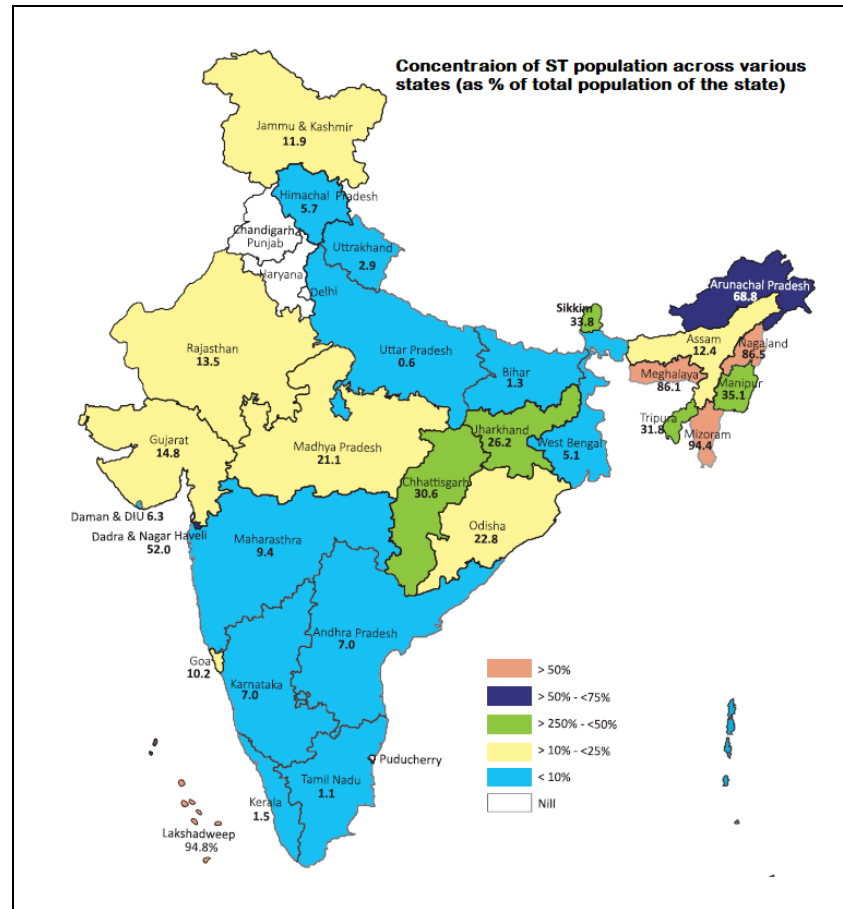


Figure : Share of ST population across various states (Vikaspedia)

Important Acts, bodies and commissions:

After independence, the government has taken several steps through acts, budget, and Five-year plans for socio-economic development of the scheduled castes and scheduled tribes which are discussed below:

1. **Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955**

This act mandates punishment for committing any form of untouchability. Assistance is provided to States/ UTs for its implementation.

2. **Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989**

It provides financial assistance to the States/ UTs for implementation of these acts, relief to atrocity victims, incentive for inter-caste marriages, awareness generation, special courts for the trial of such offences related to the SC and ST.

3. **The Prohibition of Employment as Manual Scavengers and their Rehabilitation Act, 2013**

It makes provision for eradication of manual scavenging and dry latrines. It is unlawful and an offence under this Act for any person, municipality, panchayat or agency to build an insanitary latrine, or employ a manual scavenger. It also provides for rehabilitation of manual scavengers in alternative occupation, multi-pronged legislative as well as programmatic interventions strategies.

4. **National Commission for Scheduled Caste (NCSC)**

National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC) was established as a **Constitutional body under Article 338** with a view to provide safeguards against the exploitation of Scheduled Castes to promote and protect their social, educational, economic and cultural interests; to investigate and monitor all matters relating to the safeguards provided for the Scheduled Castes under the Constitution or under

any other law for the time being in force or under any order of the Government and to evaluate the working of such safeguards; and to inquire into specific complaints with respect to the deprivation of rights and safeguards of the Scheduled Castes. The Commission consists of Chairman, Vice Chairman and three other members. They are **appointed by the President of India**.

5. **National Commission for Safai Karamchari(NCSK)**

The National Commission for Safai Karamcharis (NCSK) was constituted on 12th August, 1994 as a statutory body by an Act of Parliament- National Commission for Safai Karamcharis Act, 1993. With the lapse of the act w.e.f. 29.2.2004, the Commission now acts as a non-statutory body of the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment whose tenure is extended from time to time through government resolutions.

6. **National Commission for Scheduled Tribes (NCST)**

National Commission for Scheduled Tribes (NCST) is a Constitutional body established under **Article 338A through Constitution (89th Amendment) Act, 2003** after bifurcation from the erstwhile National Commission of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes. Its major functions include- to inquire into specific complaints with respect to the deprivation of rights and safeguards of the Scheduled Tribes; to investigate and monitor all matters relating to the safeguards provided for the Scheduled Tribes under the Constitution or under any other law for the time being in force or under any order of the government; to participate and advise in the planning process of socio-economic development of the Scheduled Tribes and to evaluate the progress of their development under the Union and any State; **to present to the President**, annually and at such other times as the Commission may deem fit, reports upon the working of those safeguards; **to make in such reports, recommendations** as to the measures that should be taken by the Union or any State for effective implementation of those safeguards and other measures for the protection, welfare and socio-economic development of the Scheduled Tribes, and **to discharge such other functions** in relation to the protection, welfare and development and advancement of the Scheduled Tribes as the President may, subject to the provisions of any law made by Parliament, by rule specify. The commission consists of Chairperson, a Vice-Chairperson and three full-time members (including **one female member**). The term of all the members of the commission is **three years** from the date of assumption of charge.

Why are the tribals in India referred to as 'the Scheduled Tribes'? Indicate the major provisions enshrined in the Constitution of India for their upliftment. (UPSC 2016)

Important schemes for SCs and STs:

The government has come up with various schemes and policies to socially, educationally and economically empower the Scheduled castes and tribes. Some of them are discussed below:

1. **Post-matric scholarship for Scheduled Castes** is a **centrally sponsored scheme** and implemented through state government and UT administration. The objectives of the scheme include supporting parents of SC children for education of their wards studying in classes IX and X so that the incidence of drop-out, especially in the transition from the elementary to the secondary stage is minimized.
2. **Rajiv Gandhi national fellowship for higher education for Scheduled Tribes** is a **central sector scheme** to encourage the ST students to acquire higher education in the form of fellowships to pursue M. Phil and Ph. D. courses, with a view to create qualified professionals to hold posts of teachers/professionals and other higher stages of employment. ST students who secure admission in these institutes are awarded scholarships.
3. **National overseas fellowship** provides financial assistance to selected candidates for pursuing Masters level courses and Ph.D., abroad in accredited institutions/universities in specified fields of study viz. Engineering and Management, Pure Sciences & Applied Sciences, Agricultural Sciences and Medicine,

Commerce, Accounting & Finance and Humanities & Social Science. One hundred fellowships are awarded every year with **30% of them earmarked for women** candidates.

4. **PM Adarsh Gram yojana** was launched during 2009-10. It aims at integrated development of villages in which the population of **Scheduled Castes is above 50%**. Another objective is to capture the gaps in critical socio-economic '**monitorable indicators**' which are part of various sectors/domains including **water and sanitation**, education, health and nutrition, agricultural best practices etc. amongst others.
5. **Self-employment scheme for rehabilitation of manual scavengers** is a cash and livelihood scheme with the objective to rehabilitate the remaining manual scavengers and their dependents in alternative occupations. It aims at identifying manual scavengers, one from each family, and providing them one-time cash assistance. Beneficiaries are also provided training for skill development for a period up to two years, during which a stipend of Rs. 3,000 per month is also provided.
6. **Green business scheme** is an initiative of National Safai Karamcharis Finance and Development Corporation (NSKFDC) to provide **financial assistance** in the form of loans to **safai karamcharis, scavengers and their dependents** for activities which could tackle climate change along with income generation. Scheme applies to the procurement and utilization of battery electric vehicle (e- rickshaw), compressed air vehicle, solar energy gadgets, poly houses, etc. Any income generating activities which could mitigate the greenhouse effect or could be classified under adaptation initiatives, would be covered under the scheme.
7. **Mahila Adhikarita Yojana (MAY)** is an initiative by National Safai Karamcharis Finance & Development Corporation (NSKFDC) under the Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment (M/o SJ&E) **to provide loans to safai karamchari, scavenger women and their dependent daughters** through state channelizing agencies (SCAs) and Regional Rural Banks (RRBs). Loans shall be provided for projects with a maximum cost of Rs.1,00,000/- for small and petty trade/business and sundry income generating activities.
8. **National Scheduled Caste Finance & Development Corporation (NSFDC)**. It **finances, facilitates and mobilizes funds** for the economic empowerment of persons having annual family income up to Rs. 3 lakhs for both rural and urban areas. It provides **financial assistance for income generating schemes** for the target group through state channelizing agencies (SCAs) which are nominated by respective State/UT Government and other channel partners such as Public Sector Banks, Regional Rural Banks, NBFC-MFIs, etc. It acts as **catalyst in systematic reduction of poverty** through socio-economic development of eligible Scheduled Castes, working in an efficient, responsive and collaborative manner with channelizing agencies and other development partners.
9. **Dr. Ambedkar Foundation** was established under the aegis of the **Ministry of Welfare (now Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment)** on March 24, 1992 as a registered society under the Societies Registration Act, 1860 by the Prime Minister of India on the centenary celebration of Babasaheb Dr. B. R. Ambedkar. Its mandate is to carry out programmes and activities for **furthering of Dr Ambedkar's ideology** and to spread his message of social justice to the masses in India and abroad.
10. **National Career Service Centre for SC/ST** is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS) under Labour Ministry to give platform for job seekers from the Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe communities.
11. **Vanbandhu Kalyan Yojana** has been launched for Tribal welfare. It aims at converging several central and state schemes related to tribals and its components include providing quality infrastructure, improving quality of life in tribal areas, improving tribal human development indices, providing quality education to tribals, providing employment opportunities for tribal families and protection of tribal culture and heritage.

Important court judgements:

A series of **judgments** have ensured that the rights of the Scheduled Castes and Tribes are upheld and they are made equal partners in the process of development. For instance, in the **Maneka Gandhi v. Union of India (1978)** case, Supreme Court held that the **right to live (Article 21)** is not merely a physical right but includes

within its ambit the **right to live with human dignity** as well, thus negating the centuries of inhuman treatment meted out to disadvantaged members of the society. Similarly, in **Francis Coralie Mullin v. Union Territory of Delhi and Others (1981)**, the court held that the right to live includes the **right to live** with human dignity and all that goes along with it, viz., the **bare necessities of life** such as adequate nutrition, clothing and shelter over the head and facilities for reading writing and expressing oneself in diverse forms, freely moving about and mixing and mingling with fellow human beings and to carry on functions and activities. In **Murlidhar Dayandeo Kesekar v. Vishwanath Pande Barde (1995)**, the court held that the **right to economic empowerment** of poor, disadvantaged and oppressed Dalits was a fundamental right.

According to the court, in **Bandhua Mukti Morcha v. Union of India (1997)**, it is the fundamental right of everyone in this country **to live with human dignity free from exploitation**. This right to live with human dignity enshrined in **Article 21** derives its life breath from the **Directive Principles of State Policy** and must include- protection of the health and strength of workers, men and women, and of the tender age of children against abuse, provision of opportunities and facilities for children to develop in a healthy manner and in conditions of freedom and dignity. In **Sujit Kumar v. State of U.P (2002)**, the court observed the practice of “**honour killing**” as a blot on society. The court, therefore, directed the police to take strong measures, against those who committed an act of killing a person for wanting to get married to a person of another caste or community; since inter caste or inter community marriage was not prohibited by law. In **Dr. Subhash Kashinath Mahajan Vs the State of Maharashtra and Another (2018)** case, Supreme Court introduced a provision for anticipatory bail stating that there would be no automatic arrest and police must conduct a preliminary enquiry within seven days before taking any action.

Recommendations of NITI Aayog:

Scheduled Castes– It recommended that efforts need to be stepped up for **establishing functional residential schools** for boys and girls in blocks with a substantial Schedule Castes population. It also spoke about **mandatory funding** provision by the Finance Commission and other agencies so that the State Governments face no financial crunch for welfare schemes. It emphasized on the **need for strengthening administration** such as monitoring mechanism, periodic audits, coordination with other social welfare departments and scholarships through cash payments should move to Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT). It further recommended **creating awareness** about government schemes through print, electronic and social media channels. It suggested **Impact evaluation** of different schemes for effective implementation and target achievement. **Targeted coverage** of SCs through the provision of soft loans and financial assistance by the National Scheduled Caste Finance Development Corporation and the National Safai Karamchari Finance Development Corporation needs to be ensured. The government also needs to work on **strengthening of market linkages to market the products** developed by SC artisans and entrepreneurs e.g., National SC/ST Hub.

Scheduled Tribes– It recommended for **administrative strengthening** of agencies responsible for implementing schemes in tribal areas by developing a **comprehensive personnel policy** which covers duration of postings, incentives for rendering services in tribal areas and modules for sensitizing officials. It also suggested **online monitoring of various schemes** to assess the critical gaps between fund allocation and utilization e.g., Ministry of Tribal Affairs-UNDP project on Management Information System (MIS). **Anganwadi facilities** should be extended to tribal areas and focus on **Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT)** of scholarships to fill the loopholes.

Tracing the tribal integration efforts of India since independence, critically analyse the effectiveness of such attempts on tribal society and people. Is there a need for a revisit and a subsequent re-orientation of the tribal integration approach followed so far? Comment.

Some positive results of tribal development and integration efforts include an improving trend in human development index i.e. female literacy is showing a progressive trend. Gross enrolment ratio in schools has also increased and dropout rates are decreasing. Affirmative discrimination through reservation for STs has increased their representation in the political decision-making institutions i.e. Parliament, Legislative Assemblies and in the grass-root democratic institutions viz., Panchayats and local bodies. The allocation of funds towards STs have increased since tribal sub-plan. The role of gram sabhas and tribal advisory councils have become mandatory for decision making in tribal areas.

STs have also been given the rights over minor forest produce under the Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006, commonly called the **Forest Rights Act**. The Act recognized and vested the forest rights in forest dwelling STs and other traditional forest dwellers who have been residing in such forests for generations but whose rights could not be recorded. Recognized tribes were made entitled to responsibilities and authority for sustainable use, conservation of biodiversity and maintenance of ecological balance. However, the Act differentiates in the eligibility and criteria for verification of rights of STs and OTFDs. While STs must prove that they have 'primarily resided in the forest or forest land prior to 13-12-2005', OTFDs must prove that they have 'primarily resided in forests or on forest lands for three generations (75 years) prior to 13-12-2005'. Moreover, the petitioners sought the eviction of all forest-dwellers whose claims to land under the law had been rejected (more than 11 lakh households) alleging that they were bogus claimants. However, report of the high-level Xaxa Committee found deep procedural flaws in processing claims under the FRA. The committee observed that claims were being rejected without assigning reasons, or based on wrong interpretation of the 'OTFD' definition or lack of evidence. In several cases, the claims were rejected based on flawed methodologies in violation of FRA Rules. For example, in Gujarat, claims were rejected based only on satellite maps and not on ground surveys. The court had also directed states to ensure eviction in all rejected claims cases, but later put a stay on its previous order.

The **Panchayat Extension to Scheduled Areas (PESA) Act 1996** has also empowered the tribal population. As per the recommendations of the Bhuria Committee, the Act came into existence for ensuring tribal self-rule for people living in scheduled areas of India. It made it mandatory for states to make specific provisions for giving wide-ranging powers to tribals on matters relating to their rights over local natural resources, decision making and development of their community. It not only accepts the validity of "customary law, social and religious practices, and traditional management practices of community resources", but also directs the state government not to make any law which is inconsistent with these. It has also made environmental impact assessment (EIA) mandatory for infrastructural projects in tribal areas. However, the ground realities are very different as corruption and red-tapism are rampant at various levels, and required sanctions are marked by inordinate delays or outright refusals. There are restrictions placed on ownership of common property by any village, communities, groups, or people and the Gram Sabha's power to accord such ownership is not recognized, which is in direct violation of the PESA Act. Government officials, Panchayati Raj institutions and community members have very little information about PESA, and presently PESA is not truly implemented in schedule V areas. In many states, the forest department officials also do not adhere to the Gram Sabha resolution of collecting minor forest produce.

Salwa Judum (peace march) began in 2005 as a government-backed "people's resistance movement" against the Maoists. The local tribal youth were forced into government-controlled camps where they received arms support and training. Those who refused were punished by having their villages burnt. Hundreds of people were killed, and their deaths were not even recorded. However, in 2011, the Supreme Court declared the militia to be illegal and unconstitutional and ordered its disbanding. The displaced tribals continue to face hardships while no steps have yet been taken to prosecute government officials or security forces for their atrocities on tribals.

As a result, even after the Constitutional safeguards and inclusive initiatives of the government, tribal development has been slow. Many committees like Mungekar committee, Dutta committee, and most recently Virginius Xaxa committee report of 2014 pointed out loopholes in the working of such policies. These have led to land alienation, displacement, enforced migration, education, health, legal and constitutional issues, exploitation by forest officials and bureaucracy, illegal mining activities that impact their environment, misappropriation of funds and corruption. Cases like in Orissa's Niyamgiri hills, Dongria Kondh tribes' land was given to Vedanta for mining. There are also conflicts between tribals and government like in central India following the initiation of counter insurgency operation called Salwa Judum in Chhattisgarh, and in North east due to imposition of AFSPA.

The **AFSPA** or the **Armed Forces Special Powers Act**, gives armed forces the power to maintain public order in "disturbed areas". They have the authority to prohibit a gathering of five or more persons in an area, can use force or even open fire after giving due warning if they feel a person is in contravention of the law. It has been in force since over five decades in North-East with wide reports of abuse of power by armed forces in the area.

Thus, Nehru's Tribal Panchsheel should be followed and implemented properly so as to save the unique way of living of the tribals. In view of the above mentioned lacunas, reforms are needed in tribal integration policies. New challenges like climate change and double burden of health diseases must also effectively be incorporated in the policy of tribal integration. Also, attempts at development and conservation must be ensured to be tribal inclusive.

In November 2018, John Allen Chau – a 26-year-old evangelical missionary – was killed by the self-isolated Sentinelese tribe in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, when he attempted to convert them to Christianity. There have been other attempts too, by various religions in imposing their culture and practices on the tribals who have their unique culture, God, etc.

Who are the OBCs?

Other Backward Class (OBC) is a collective term used by the Government of India to classify castes which are **educationally or socially disadvantaged**. It constitutes such classes or citizens, other than the SCs and STs, as the **Central government may specify in "lists"** prepared from time to time for the purpose of reservation in appointments in favour of such classes of citizens which, in the opinion of that government are not adequately represented in the services under the government of India and any local or other authority. The OBCs, as per a government of India notification dated **8th September 1993**, include castes and communities which are named in both the list contained in the **Report of the Backward Classes Commission (Mandal Commission)** and in the list of individual state governments. The OBCs were estimated to be **52%** of the country's population by the Mandal Commission report of 1980 and as per the National Sample Survey Organization (NSSO) 61st round (2004-05), OBCs constitutes **41%** of India's population.

Should there be a Caste Census?

Every Census in independent India from 1951 to 2011 has published data on Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, but not on other castes. (Before that, every Census until 1931 had data on caste.) Hence, in the absence of such a census, there is no proper estimate for the population of OBCs. Many believe that Caste Census like that of SECC is a requirement and that it would be the best way to rationalize reservation based on data and make a strong case for breaching India's reservation cap. It would show the gap between economic and social capital holdings within and between the general category as well as the reserved sections. It would also help in revising the benchmark for social, economic and educational backwardness.

Further, it would help in authenticating the findings and recommendations of Union and state-level backward caste commissions, resulting in evidence-based policymaking. The current policies are based on the last caste census, which was conducted in 1931. The census would also reveal information regarding caste-based marginalization, deprivation, the kind of jobs pursued by a caste, etc. and remove ambiguities associated with the caste. Earlier, Sachar committee had been formed to examine the socio-economic and educational status of the Muslim community in India. In its report, the committee mentioned that the availability of data on religion was useful in highlighting the relative deprivation of minorities. So, similar data on caste can also help to identify vulnerable sections within castes.

Constitutional Provisions for OBCs:

1. Clause (4) of **Article 15** of Constitution of India [**“Prohibition of discrimination** on grounds of religion, race, caste, sex or place of birth”] permits the State to make special provision for the advancement of **“any socially and educationally backward classes of citizens”** including in admission to educational institutions.
2. **Article 16 (4)** [**“Equality of opportunity** in matters of public employment”] permits the State to make provision for reservation in appointments for “any backward class of citizens”.
3. Clause (1) of **Article 38** of the Constitution makes it obligatory for the State to “strive to promote the welfare of the people by securing and protecting as effectively as it may, a social order, in which justice, social, economic and political, shall inform all the institutions of the national life”.
4. **Art. 46** enjoins upon the States to “promote with special care the educational and economic interests of the weaker sections”.
5. **Article 340** of the Constitution provides “that the President may by order appoint a **Commission** to investigate the conditions of socially and educationally backward classes”. As it was not envisaged to set up an independent Commission to investigate complaints made by OBCs, the National Commission for Scheduled Castes had been entrusted to look into such complaints under **Article 338 (10)** of the Constitution.
6. Later, **National Commission for Backward Classes** was set up and given Constitutional status by the 102nd Constitutional Amendment Act 2018. **Article 338B** provides authority to NCBC to examine complaints and welfare measures regarding socially and educationally backward classes.

What are the benefits of constitutional status to NCBC?

Constitutional status implies that the OBC panel will have a **more robust grievance redressal mechanism** and will have the powers of **a civil court** trying a suit. After the constitutional status, the NCBC will get all the rights which are already available to NCST and NCSC. The step will ensure suitable power and authority to the commission to **redress the grievances of the OBC employees** in government and private sectors. It will also help the NCBC to inquire into specific complaints regarding violation of rights. It can make recommendations and oversee their implementation for the upliftment of **OBCs**.

Empowering OBCs:

Their empowerment can be done through the effective implementation of various welfare and developmental policies and programmes, in order to bring them at par with rest of the society. Education is the best instrument through which social empowerment of OBCs can take place. **Pre-matric scholarship** shall be awarded to students belonging to OBCs whose parents’/ guardian’s income from all sources does not exceed Rs. 2,50,000/- per annum. **National fellowship for OBC students** aims at providing financial assistance to the OBC students in obtaining quality higher education leading to degrees such as M. Phil and Ph. D in universities, research institutions and scientific institutions.

Economic empowerment of the weaker sections of OBCs and minorities is being carried out through promotion of employment and income generating activities with a special focus on below poverty line (BPL) families. **National Finance and Development Corporation (NFDC)** for weaker sections has been set up to provide term loans, bridge loans, margin money, micro credit, employment and income generating and skill upgradation schemes exclusively for the disadvantaged groups. The **Protection of Civil Rights (PCR) Act, 1955**, is an important legislation to address the problems of social discrimination, exploitation and atrocities against disadvantaged groups. Under this Act, financial assistance is provided for strengthening the administrative, enforcement and judicial machinery related to these legislations; and relief and rehabilitation of the affected persons. The social and economic empowerment requires emphasis to be laid on technical, vocational training especially for OBCs.

Important Acts, bodies and commissions:**1. National Commission for Backward Classes (NCBC)**

National Commission for Backward Classes (NCBC) was constituted adhering to the provisions of the National Commission for Backward Classes Act, 1993, under the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment. The Act provides that the commission consist of five members. Chairperson is an acting or retired judge of the Supreme Court or of a High Court. Members include one social scientist, two eminent persons with special knowledge in matters relating to backward classes. Member-Secretary is an acting or retired officer of the Central government in the rank of a Secretary to the Government of India, with a term of 3 years. Major functions include:

- a. It considers the inclusions and exclusions from the lists of communities notified as backward for the purpose of job.
 - b. It has the same powers as a Civil court although it has not yet been empowered to look into the grievances of persons of Other Backward Classes.
 - c. It shall investigate and monitor how the safeguards provided to the backward classes under the Constitution and other laws are being implemented.
 - d. Advising and making recommendations on socio-economic development of such classes.
 - e. It also presents annual reports to the President on working of the safeguards for backward classes.
2. **Kaka Kalelkar Commission:** Adhering to Article 340 of the Constitution of India, the First Backward Classes Commission was set up by a Presidential order under the chairmanship of Kaka Kalelkar. The commission submitted its report in March 1955, listing 2,399 backward castes or communities, with 837 of them being classified as 'most backward'. The report was never implemented.
3. **Mandal Commission:** In 1979, Janata Party government under Prime Minister Morarji Desai established the Mandal Commission in India with a mandate to "identify the socially or educationally backward." The commission was setup to consider the question of seat reservations and quotas for people to redress caste discrimination. Its recommendations included reservation for SCs and STs is in proportion to their population i.e., 22% and a reservation of 27% for OBCs. On August 7, 1990, then PM V P Singh announced in Parliament that his government had accepted the Mandal Commission with which, OBCs made their way into the lexicon of India's social justice movement.

Important judgement:

Indra Sawhney Judgement: In the famous Mandal case (Indra Sawhney v. Union of India 1992), the scope and extent of Article 16(4), which provides for reservation of jobs in favor of backward classes, was examined thoroughly by the Supreme Court and said that the advanced sections among the OBCs (**the creamy layer**) should be excluded from the list of beneficiaries of reservation. The total reserved quota should not exceed 50% except in some extraordinary situations. In **Pichhra Varg Kalyan Mahasabha Haryana v. State of Haryana 2021** case, the Supreme Court stated that economic criterion cannot be the sole basis for identifying sections of

backward communities as 'creamy layer'. The court mentioned that apart from the economic criterion, social, educational and other factors must also be taken into account.

Recommendations of NITI Aayog:

NITI Aayog has provided some recommendations for OBCs such as prioritization of government funds for construction of hostel facilities for boys and girls belonging to OBCs, setting up residential schools in every district that has a large population of OBCs on an urgent basis, revised free coaching scheme for OBC students should be implemented in a timely manner. It has also suggested increasing the number of awards under the National Fellowship for OBCs per year and expansion of National SC/ST Hub to meet the marketing needs of artisans belonging to OBCs or a similar institutional mechanism could be put in place. Provision of concessional loans for entrepreneurship development among OBCs as well as financial assistance to trained/educated youth for self-employment on a priority basis should be taken up by the government.

The great Indian reservation system:

The notion of reservation was included in the Constitution to give a chance to the underprivileged classes to come at par with the so-called privileged one. It is a facility to **support** those who are deprived of adequate opportunity and equal treatment from the rest of the society. Reservations are currently offered to SCs/STs/OBCs/PwDs/sportspersons/persons from erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir with certain criteria/Economically Weaker Sections- in government colleges and institutions. Reservations are also provided for women in institutions of local self government. Some state governments provide additional reservation to women in state administration and bureaucracy.

The argument in favour of reservation is that meritocracy is incomplete without equality. If all sections of the society are not getting equitable opportunities to excel in life, then meritocracy loses its value. Reservation has brought people of different classes to the same level, regardless of merit. It has helped in improving the **socio-economic status of SC, ST and OBC** in the society, which is evident from the increased proportion of SC, ST, and OBC in government institutes. It also shows that they now understand that education is the only way of upliftment from their repressed situation. Reservation of seats in **Lok Sabha for SC/ST** has made them a part of decision-making body and thus they can share their views and ideas on different aspects of society. Reservation of women in **Rural and Urban Local bodies**, as an important stakeholder, has helped in making development more inclusive and increasing employment and raising their standard of living. Recently **Centre increased the reservation for disabled from 3% to 4%** and reserved government jobs for persons with autism, down syndrome, intellectual disabilities, specific learning disabilities and acid attack victims. This will go a long way in their empowerment.

However, critiques have called for a **rationalization of reservation policy**. In **Nagraj case of 2006** **Supreme Court** took into consideration the existence of the three essential compelling circumstances - (i) Backwardness of the class, (ii) Inadequacy of representation in public employment; and (iii) Overall administrative efficiency, for reservation. There is also a need to bring in more objectivity so that the criterion for reservation can be made effective and more rational in nature. Whether the class of citizens was backward in social and educational terms should also be taken into consideration. Experts are of the opinion that with regard to promotions within **Class I** there shouldn't be any reservation, only concession should be allowed. There are also demands for creating a **horizontal reservation** slab for women to take care of gender-based discrimination. A **13-point reservation roster system** can be adopted as seen in India's top Universities like Delhi University. **Sub categorization of SC and ST** can be considered on the lines of sub-categorization of OBCs (creamy/non-creamy layer). The kind of scenario that India is witnessing at present includes communities belonging to upper caste coming forth for reservation (Jats, Patidar etc.) which compels us to deliberate upon the prevalent reservation policy and find ways to make it more rational & effective.

The reservations system would benefit markedly from an administrative face-lift. As recommended by the Commission for **Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes**, a comprehensive act, articulating the policy, is needed. The revision and streamlining of procedures, such as SC certification, might help curb abuse. In addition, social programs such as those directed at improving the education system, especially at the primary level and in rural areas, should be given more emphasis.

5.2. Empowerment of Differently-abled persons

'I am invisible, understand, simply because people refuse to see me. Like the bodiless heads you see sometimes in the circus sideshows, it is as though I have been surrounded by mirrors of hard distorting glass. When they approach me they see only my surroundings, themselves, figments of their imagination. Indeed, everything and anything except me.' – Ellison

'We are disabled by buildings that are not designed to admit us, and this in turn leads to a range of further disablements regarding our education, our chances of gaining employment, our social lives and so on. The disablement lies in the construction of society, not in the physical condition of the individual' – Brisenden

Prime Minister in a Mann ki Baat address in December, 2015, used the term 'Divyaang' or 'possessed with divinity' for 'differently-abled'. However, some activists criticized the usage of this word, saying its usage was a deeply uncomfortable idea for those who, because of their disability, feel excluded from several aspects of life. The decision was also criticised by those who have been battling for equal opportunity and acceptability for the disabled through a rights-based framework – as opposed to a charity/sympathy prism which 'divinity' implies.

India has **one of the largest disabled populations** in the world.

As per census 2011, In India around **2.21 %** population is affected by either one form of disability (visual, hearing, speech and locomotor disabilities, mental illness, mental retardation, multiple disabilities and other disabilities) or suffering from multiple disorders, and majority of them live in rural areas. Of them, about 1.50 crore are males and 1.18 crore females. Persons with disability are **more vulnerable to exclusion** from the socio-economic domains as they have poor access to infrastructure, education and skill development. The future of a country depends on ensuring that all citizens, including the differently-abled, have capacity to realize their full potential. In order to achieve this goal, we have to create a sensitive and harmonious society, where every person feels empowered and possesses empathy towards weaker sections.

Traditional and informal **social security system** that was provided by the institution of family in India has been impacted due to industrialization, modernization, urbanization and individualism. This necessitates the state to take steps for social security of differently-abled. India is a party to **UN Convention on 'Rights of persons with disabilities'**. This requires that the government promotes, protects, and ensures the full enjoyment of human rights by persons with disabilities and that they enjoy full equality under the law. The Convention has served as a major catalyst in the global movement by evolving the perception from viewing persons with disabilities as objects of charity, needing medical treatment and social protection towards viewing them as full and equal members of society, with human rights. Hence, Indian social security system also has specific schemes for the differently-abled.

Disability results from the interaction between persons with impairments, and attitudinal and environmental barriers that hinders their full and effective participation in society on an equal basis with others. Disability is thus, not just a health problem, it is rather a complex phenomenon. It is viewed from medical and pathological angle only, ignoring the social and institutional arrangements that prevent PwDs from leading normal lives. Social segregation and stigma attached to disability prevents 'Persons with Disabilities' (PwDs) from meaningfully participating in the society and it subjects them to psychological trauma due to the

unfriendly attitude of the society. Attitudinal barriers like lack of self-belief, low confidence etc. also prevent them from realizing their full potential.

They are subjected to **multiple deprivations and limited opportunities** in several dimensions of their lives. Their families and caregivers also go through lot of stress and challenges in having a person with disability at home which ultimately leads to grave discriminatory practices towards these children. Superstitions prevailing in the communities also play a big role in subjecting the people with disabilities to various harmful treatments. They refrain from attending any social events. Even their family members often tend to avoid such social gatherings. Moreover, as per the Indian laws, all kith and kin in the family are eligible to get their share of inherited property, but in reality, persons with disabilities are denied these rights.

Lack of institutional and infrastructural support has debilitating effects on the lives of PwDs by restricting their mobility and preventing access to government services, educational attainment and skill development. This is evident from the fact that of the total disabled persons 45% are illiterates. Inadequate transportation and communication facilities, lack of secondary and tertiary health care facilities, lack of appropriate employment opportunities etc. also aid their under-development. Poverty exacerbates the problems faced by PwDs and as a result they are unable to make use of assistive devices. Many preventable disabilities are being left untreated on account of lack of money.

The **government policies have been ineffective** as they are not made as per evidence based decision making. There used to be inconsistency in defining disability in various censuses. There is also a lack of standard reporting, as census depends on self-reporting of disability which may leave out mental disability. Lack of coordination between different sectors, ministries as well as between the government sector and NGOs has also resulted in non-availability of relevant data. Overcoming the difficulties faced by people with disabilities requires interventions to remove environmental and social barriers as well. Addressing these barriers will unlock the potential of so many people with so much to contribute to the world. By providing the PwDs with aids to overcome their disability and enabling them to earn a dignified livelihood, we can actually transform them from being disabled to being differently-abled.

People with disabilities are vulnerable because of the many barriers they face. Examine those barriers and suggest measures to address them.

Constitutional provisions:

The Constitution contains various provisions to prevent discrimination of people and provide the differently-abled opportunities for their development.

1. The Constitution of India through its **Preamble**, inter-alia seeks to secure to all its citizens– Justice– social, economic and political; Liberty of thought, expression, belief, faith and worship; Equality of status and of opportunity.
2. **Part-III** of the Constitution provides for a set of six **Fundamental Rights** to all the citizens. These include – Right to Equality; Right to Freedom; Right against Exploitation; Right to Freedom of Religion; Cultural and Educational Rights and Right to Constitutional Remedies. All these rights are also available to the persons with disabilities even though no specific mention of such persons appears in this Part of the Constitution.
3. **Article 41:** Right to work, to education and to public assistance in certain cases, is provided as “The State shall, within the limits of its economic capacity and development, make effective provision for securing the right to work, to education and to public assistance in cases of unemployment, old age, sickness and disablement and in other cases of undeserved want”.
4. **Eleventh Schedule** to Article 243-G and **Twelfth Schedule** to Article 243-W, which provides for powers and responsibilities of the panchayats and municipalities respectively with respect to implementation

of schemes for economic development and social justice, include welfare and safeguarding the interests of persons with disabilities among other weaker sections of the society.

Eleventh Schedule to Article 243-G: **“Social welfare, including welfare of the handicapped and mentally retarded”** (Entry No.26).

Twelfth Schedule to Article 243-W: **“Safeguarding the interests of weaker sections of society, including the handicapped and mentally retarded”** (Entry No. 09).

Measures taken for welfare of persons with disability:

Social protection plays a key role in realizing the rights of persons with disabilities of all ages. Efforts have been made to give social security to disabled at the global and national levels, some of the measures are given below:

Global Efforts– There have been many efforts and initiative over the past few decades at global level to include people in social and economic development. Some of the measures undertaken at the global level are as follows:

1. **United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD)**

India is one of the few first countries which ratified the Convention. This Convention places the following three important obligations on each State party: implementation of the provisions of the Convention; harmonization of the country laws with the Convention and preparation of a country report.

2. **Incheon Strategy**

It is intended to enable the Asian and Pacific region to track progress towards improving the quality of life, and the fulfilment of the rights of person with disabilities. It builds on the Convention on the rights of persons with disabilities and the **Biwako** millennium framework for action. The Incheon Strategy goals cover development areas including poverty reduction, employment generation, political participation, ensuring accessibility in comprehensive terms, social protection, early intervention, education, and disability-inclusive disaster risk reduction. Improving disability statistics, and increasing ratification of the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities are also contained in the Incheon Goals.

Government policies:

The government has come up with various policies to empower the differently-abled. They are:

1. **National Policy for Persons with Disabilities, 2006**

The Policy recognized that the persons with disabilities constitute a valuable human resource for the country and that a majority of such persons can lead a better quality of life if they have equal opportunities and effective access to rehabilitation measures. The government, with a view to create an environment that provides such persons equal opportunities for protection of their rights and full participation in society, formulated and brought out the National Policy for Persons with Disabilities.

2. In order to give focused attention to policy issues and meaningful thrust to the activities aimed at welfare and empowerment of the persons with disabilities, a separate Department of Disability Affairs was carved out of the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment in 2012. The Department was renamed as **Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities** in 2014. The Department acts as a nodal agency for matters pertaining to disability and persons with disabilities including affecting closer coordination among different stakeholders- related Central Ministries, State/UT Governments, NGOs etc. in matters pertaining to disability.

3. **The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016**

- a. The Act defines disability based on an evolving and dynamic concept. The **types of disabilities have been increased from existing 7 to 21** and the Central Government will have the power to add more types of disabilities. Speech and Language Disability and Specific Learning Disability have been added for the first time. Acid Attack Victims have also been included. Dwarfism, muscular dystrophy has been indicated as separate class of specified disability. The New

categories of disabilities also included three blood disorders, Thalassemia, Hemophilia and Sickle Cell disease. Responsibility has been cast upon the appropriate governments to take effective measures to ensure that the persons with disabilities enjoy their rights equally with others. Every child with benchmark disability between the age group of 6 and 18 years shall have the right to free education.

- b. **Reservation in vacancies** in government establishments has been increased from **3% to 4%** for certain persons or class of persons with benchmark disability. It provides for various rights and entitlements for persons with disabilities which include equality and non-discrimination, community life, protection against cruelty and inhuman treatment, access to justice, legal capacity etc.
- c. The Act also mandates the appropriate governments to frame schemes and programmes in the area of social security, health, rehabilitation, recreation, skill development etc.

Does the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 ensure effective mechanism for empowerment and inclusion of the intended beneficiaries in the society? Discuss. (UPSC 2017)

Schemes:

In order to take care of other auxiliary needs of the differently-abled, the government has come out with various schemes:

1. **Accessible India Campaign:** Accessible India Campaign (AIC) is the nationwide flagship campaign to make a barrier-free and conducive environment for **Divyangjan** all over the country. It was launched on **International Day of Persons with Disabilities on 3rd December, 2015**. The campaign is based on the principles of the social model of disability, that disability is caused by the way society is organized, and not the person's limitations and impairments. A barrier-free environment facilitates equal participation in all the activities and promotes an independent and dignified way of life. For creating universal accessibility for Persons with Disabilities, the campaign has been divided into three verticals:
 - a. **Built environment:** Measures should be undertaken to eliminate obstacles and barriers to indoor and outdoor facilities including schools, medical facilities, and workplaces.
 - b. **Transport:** The term transportation covers a number of areas including air travel, buses, taxis, and trains.
 - c. **Information & Communication Technology (ICT) ecosystem:** Access to information can range from actions such as being able to read price tags, to physically enter a hall, to participate in an event, to read a pamphlet with healthcare information, to understand a train timetable, or to view webpages.

However, the campaign has progressed at an excruciatingly slow pace. A parliamentary standing committee report tabled in 2021, pointed out that just 494 or 29.7% of the total buildings identified have been made accessible by nine states and Union territories till date.

2. **Sugamya Pustakalaya:** An online platform that makes accessible content available to print-disabled people was also launched in August, 2016.
3. **Deendayal Disabled Rehabilitation Scheme (DDRS):** Deendayal Disabled Rehabilitation Scheme to promote Voluntary Action for PwDs aims at creating an enabling environment to ensure equal opportunities, equity, social justice and their empowerment.
4. The Ministry of Human Resource Development (Department of Secondary and Higher Education) has been implementing a scheme of '**Integrated Education for the Disabled Children**' (IEDC) in **formal schools** since 1982. The main objective of the scheme is to provide educational opportunities for the disabled children in normal schools so as to facilitate their retention in the school system.
5. **Special schools:** This is a programme of the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment. Children with severe multiple disabilities who have difficulty in coping with regular schools are referred to such special schools. Most of these special schools are located in urban areas and run by voluntary organizations. A majority of them are residential schools, and boarding- lodging and other services are

provided free of cost. At present more than 3000 special schools for the disabled children are functioning across the country.

Other benefits/schemes for differently-abled by government of India:

1. **Tax:** Persons with disabilities and their legal guardians are eligible for income tax deduction and deduction is based on severity of person's disability.
2. **Comprehensive education scheme for disabled children** – The scheme provides for accessible and barrier free built-in infrastructure and transport facilities, supply of books, uniforms and stationery, specialized learning aids and scholarships for students with disabilities.
3. **Rajiv Gandhi Fellowship scheme:** This scheme provides scholarships to persons with disabilities to pursue higher education such as M Phil / Ph.D. for five years.
4. **Employment:** Government has **reserved 5% posts** in Group A, B, C and D positions in government PSUs, PSBs and services for persons with disabilities. Persons with disabilities are given age relaxation for recruitment in government positions.

Role of civil society:

NGOs and Civil Society organization has been playing an invaluable role in the protection of rights of differently-abled persons and towards their development. **Smile Foundation, Udaan, Ability Foundation** are NGOs which bring together like-minded people to work towards a common goal of improving the living conditions of people with disabilities by developing appropriate opportunities and means for them, especially for those from poor socio-economic background. They aid in creating awareness, sensitizing the masses about various aspects of disability, developing skills and capacities and enabling PwDs to realize their potential and latent talents.

Preventive and rehabilitative steps need to be taken by way of obtaining realistic estimates of the number of people who are coping with various types of disabilities. Early detection of disability, strategic interventions, counselling and medical rehabilitation will ensure that differently-abled get a favourable environment to grow and contribute to society. There is a need to improve accessibility by formulating mandatory provisions for accessibility in government and private sector buildings, public transport etc. Corporate social responsibility funds could be tapped to achieve this. Measures to strengthen education by providing scholarships/fellowships, infrastructural improvements in educational institutions, sensitization and capacity building of teachers and developing special teaching material etc. also need to be taken. Employability can be enhanced by providing skill training through dedicated ITI Centres for PwDs according to the requirements of the private sector. Authorized share capital of National Handicapped Finance and Development Corporation (NHFD) could be enhanced to Rs 1000Cr (at present Rs 400Cr) to increase loans for self-employment. Steps need to be taken to improve access to aids/assistive technologies for PwDs. Digitization of the process of issuing disability certificates through Unique Disability Identity Card (UDID) should also be fast-tracked. Also, there is a need to improve community participation program, to increase their participation in **Paralympic Games**, etc.

How technology is making life easier for differently-abled?

People with disabilities meet different kinds of barriers. However, with the help of assistive technology, they are now able to do things that would have never been possible before—from switching on a light to having a voice to express themselves. Technology has always lent a helping hand for people with visual impairment, speech impairment and motor disabilities. Mobile technology, in particular, has provided the foundation for development of a lot of applications and gadgets that can help ease the difficulties people with disabilities face on a daily basis. Some of these devices which have been used by the differently-abled people are discussed below:

1. Braille e-book reader.
2. Tactile wand electronic stick- It uses a distance sensor to detect objects in front of the user.
3. Finger Reader- This wearable tool assists in reading as well as translating text.
4. Lechal Shoes- GPS & Bluetooth enabled shoes are helping differently-abled to navigate through the streets.

It is suggested that multiple departments or agencies need to be integrated together to have a comprehensive programme design and implementation policy. There is a need to introduce a component plan for the disabled in the budget of all concerned ministries in order to ensure a regular flow of funds for schemes for the empowerment of the differently abled. Focus should be given more on preventive **social security schemes**. The Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 needs to be implemented strictly. The decision to publish government documents in the electronic publication (e-PUB) or optical character reader (OCR) based pdf format on portals is good in this regard. Recently, government also awarded **Khel Ratna** (country's greatest sporting award) to Devendra Jhaharia (javelin medallist at Japan, Athens and Rio Paralympics). This recognition will go a long way in ensuring that differently-abled athletes will henceforth be considered at par with the able-bodied. Such recognition from other fields too will go a long way in boosting the morale of differently-abled in India. Even the release of the movie 'Zero' in which both the lead actors-Shah Rukh Khan and Anushka Sharma, had disabilities of different kinds helped in bringing this issue into the mainstream. Civil society and private initiatives like **kick start cabs in Bangalore**, which have modified vehicles designed for PwDs have made mobility of PwDs easy and more inclusive.

Disability need not be an obstacle to success. We have a moral duty to remove the barriers to participation, and to invest sufficient funding and expertise to unlock the vast potential of people with disabilities. There is a need to shift from a **charity-based approach to a rights-based approach**. In an era where '**inclusive development**' is being emphasised as the right path towards sustainable development, focused initiatives for the welfare of disabled persons are essential. Therefore, challenges of social stigma, providing right to health and meaningful employment must be tackled to transform a dream of a **New India** into a reality.

For all our unity in diversity claims, India has not been able to accept people with disabilities. Critically examine.

5.3. Empowerment of Senior citizens

The Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007 defines senior citizens as the Indian citizens who have attained the age of 60 years or above. As per the Census of India 2011, there are **104 million** senior citizens, females being 53 million and males 51 million, accounting for 8.6 % of India's population. There is a significant variation across states in terms of elderly population. For example, Kerala has 12.6 % of its population above 60 years while Arunachal Pradesh has only 4.6 % elderly population. The Population Division of United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs in its 2015 report has projected the elderly population (60+age group) to be **19.4% in 2050** as per the details given below:

Year	2015	2030	2050
%	8.9	12.5	19.4

Figure: Percentage of projected elderly population aged 60 years and above

63% of the total elderly population are in the age group of 60-69 years, **26%** are in age group of 70-79 years and **11%** are in age group of 80 years and above. National figures also indicate that incidence of widowhood is much higher among females who are 60+ than amongst males in the same age group. While there

is parity in average lifespan of males and females at the age of 50 years, by the age of 80 years and above, women population is almost twice that of men. **71 %** of elderlies reside in rural India while **29 %** in urban India. **44 %** of the elderly are literate, female literacy being only 28% compared to 59% literacy in males. **22 %** of elderly people are widowed. Old age dependency ratio in India is consistently on rise reaching to **14.2%** in 2011 from 10.9% in 1961 (*Census of India 2011*). The Constitution of India under **Article 41** directs the State to provide assistance to the old-age people, which has been followed up by enacting several laws and implementing various schemes. However, despite numerous interventions by the Governments at the Centre and State, their condition remains precarious as they continue to face marginalization at the level of family, society as well as the state.

Problems faced by the elderly population:

Aging is a life-cycle stage where the human capacity to think, act, relate, and learn starts to falter and deteriorate. It breeds illnesses such as loss of memory, immobility, organ failure and poor vision. These are critical dysfunctions that could sideline a senior citizen to a lonely and miserable life. The problem gets aggravated in countries like India. Elderlies face several issues such as lack of quality healthcare facilities in the vicinity, lack of financial means to secure healthcare, neglect and ignorance by the children, slow and inefficient administrative machinery, absence of elderly-friendly facilities in hospitals, banks, courts etc. Since they are susceptible to a **variety of diseases**, especially non-communicable ones like, diabetes, heart diseases and cataract, health costs also keep on rising with age. Older people, and those with underlying medical problems like cardiovascular disease, diabetes, chronic respiratory disease, and cancer are also more likely to develop serious illness due to the 'silent tormentor' COVID-19. Almost all of them retire by this age and have no means of livelihood of their own, hence rely entirely on their children or government support for survival.

Shelter is a fundamental requirement of human beings. However, many of the homeless elderly population have been pushed out of their homes because of family problems, that is to say, being beaten, death in the family, mental or physical illness, psychological abuse or property dispute, etc. For others it is the direct result of being unable to break the vicious cycle of homelessness in urban areas and they have sadly grown old on the streets, being unable to secure a permanent abode. The State's insensitivity to the issue makes the lives of these people more and more difficult. Rather than them receiving the support and security they need, instead homeless people are criminalized by various legislations e.g. **The Bombay Prevention of Begging Act 1959**. Delhi alone has over 56000 elderlies living on streets (Delhi Human Development Report 2013). The problem is as grim in literate states like Kerala which reported over 8600 cases of forced homelessness during 2011-16.

Rapid socio-economic change, including more **nuclear families**, is also making elder care management difficult, especially for busy adult children responsible for their older parents' wellbeing. Most senior citizens who live alone suffer due to lack of companionship, sometimes exacerbated by a lack of mobility due to ill health. Isolation can result in gradual depression and other mental disorders in the elderly. If there is one thing every senior citizen, man or woman craves for, it is emotional connect. All they expect from the current generation is a little love and attention so that they would gladly and graciously ride into the sunset of their lives. However, the degrading value system in the society has resulted in physical and mental abuse by their children and other members of the family. Elderly people are merely seen as a liability to them, who can earn no returns and any expenses on them are futile given their uncertain lifespan. The 2013 HelpAge India Report, revealed that the most common form of abuse nationally experienced by elderly was disrespect (79%) followed by verbal abuse (76%) and neglect (69%), and a disturbing (39%) elderly faced beating/slapping. An elderly despised by his/her own family, is treated even worse by the society and various social disabilities are imposed on them. The report also found that nationally, in cases of elderly abuse, daughter-in-law has been reported as a primary perpetrator (39%) followed closely by the son (38%). As per NCRB data, a total of **20,532 cases** of IPC crimes against senior citizens were registered during 2015. This includes cheating, murder (or attempt to murder), homicide, grievous hurt, extortion etc.

Lack of physical infrastructure is a major deterrent in providing comfort to the senior citizens. There are very few purpose-built old-age care homes or even public ramps available for the less mobile older citizens, like those who need wheelchair access. With increasing longevity and debilitating chronic diseases, many elder citizens need better access to physical infrastructure in the current scenario, both in their own homes and in public spaces, like hospitals, Govt. offices, banks and malls. Public transport in India viz the Railways, buses, airports, are devoid of elderly-friendly stairs/ramps, elevators at stations and ample sitting facilities. Road crossing is also a nightmare for them as Indian roads are jammed with automobiles.

A financially-handicapped senior citizen, afflicted with some degenerative or serious illness, is practically on the road to an early death. A financially secure senior citizen with the same illness, however, may have a longer life to live because money can give quick and convenient access to life-giving remedies. Moreover, only **10%** of India's workforce is eligible for any kind of pension. In such cases, they are forced to work for a living. This may include working as a laborer, rickshaw pulling, vegetable seller, street vendor or even to work as a bonded farm labour. Due to lack of awareness about their rights in old age, many people are compelled to live in inhuman conditions. This can be largely attributed to politico-administrative failure to reach out to the elderly with their programs. Illiteracy, linguistic barriers (especially in tribal areas), digital divide and unfriendly officials force them to give up even the scarcely available social support.

All the above-mentioned problems equally affect a male elderly and a female elderly. However, there are several issues that the old-age females have to bear alone, either on account of their social status or physical specialties.

Issues faced by old-age women:

Among old-age females, being widowed can have serious ramifications as compared to males. This is because most of the Indian women are traditionally housewives, and their husbands are the bread-earners. Death of the husband means breakdown of the financial support and hence the old-age widows are left at the mercy of their children. This also means an end of their independent existence and subsequent termination of realizing their non- basic needs. Older women are also more prone to suffer abuse due to factors like gender discrimination, longer lifespan than older men, longer span of widowhood and no source of income. Also, societal prejudices ensure that they are denied property and inheritance rights, which they could have leveraged to influence their family behaviour towards them. These factors place old-age women at a highly disadvantageous position vis their male counterparts. Also, old-age deprives them of working in the farm. As a result, old-age women have very limited avenues to earn income of their own, unlike men.

Older women, who live in cities, are prone to social alienation/marginalization in comparison to older women of villages. Joint family system (to a certain extent) is still alive in rural areas. Older women, who live in semi urban situations/industrial townships also find it difficult to cope with old age, particularly after their children have grown up and husbands retire. Due to lack of social protection, older women are forced to lead a life full of distress. Due to negligence, lack of awareness, financial support and religious mind-set of women, older women often have to face acute health problems. Since most of the older women are living within the four walls and barely come out in open public places, most of their health problems remain unnoticed.

Government initiatives:

The government has taken the following policy initiatives to empower the elderly:

- 1. Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS)**

It forms a part of the National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) which is in operation since 1995. This scheme provides social assistance for the old age persons aged 60 years and above, belonging to

the Below Poverty Line household. The central assistance provided as pension is **Rs. 200 per month** for persons between 60 years and 79 years. For persons who are 80 years and above the pension is **Rs.500 per month**.

2. **Vayoshreshtha Samman**

Launched in 2005, it is a scheme to confer National awards to institutions involved in rendering distinguished service for the cause of elderly persons and to eminent citizens in recognition of their services/achievements. These awards are presented as part of the celebration of the International Day of Older Persons on 1st October every year.

3. **Maintenance of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007**

The Act makes it a legal obligation for children and heirs to provide maintenance to senior citizens and parents, by monthly allowance. This Act also provides simple, speedy and inexpensive mechanism for the protection of life and property of the older persons.

4. **National Programme for the Health Care for the Elderly (NPHCE)**

It was launched in 2010 for providing preventive, curative and rehabilitative services to the elderly persons at various levels of healthcare delivery system of the country. It aimed to provide dedicated health facilities in district hospitals, community health centers (CHC), primary health centers (PHC) and sub-centers levels through State Health Society. The healthcare facilities, being provided under this programme, are either free or highly subsidized.

5. **Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana**

As per Census 2011, A sizeable percentage (5.2%) of the senior citizens suffers from some sort of physical disabilities related to old age. Thus, the Government in 2017, launched this scheme to provide physical aids and assisted-living devices for senior citizens belonging to Below Poverty Line (BPL) category. The eligible elderly beneficiary will get walking sticks, elbow crutches, walkers/crutches, tripods/qadpods, hearing aids, wheelchair, artificial dentures and spectacles depending upon their physical impairment. These products will be distributed free of cost in camps across the country. It will help the senior citizens to overcome their age-related physical impairment and to lead a dignified and productive life with minimal dependence on others.

6. **Pradhan Mantri Vaya Vandana Yojana (PMVVY)**

It was launched in May, 2017 to provide a long-term income option for senior citizens in the country. Under the scheme, on payment of an initial lump sum amount ranging from Rs 1,50,000 to Rs. 15,00,000, pensioners would receive a pension of Rs 1,000 to Rs. 10,000 per month. Subscribers will get an assured pension based on a guaranteed rate of return of 8% per annum payable monthly/quarterly/half-yearly/annually.

7. **Integrated Programme for Older Persons (IPOP)**

Steps to improve the quality of life of the senior citizens by providing basic amenities like shelter, food, medical care and entertainment opportunities through capacity building of State/ UT Governments/ Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs)/Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) / local bodies and the community at large, were to be undertaken. Under the scheme, grants are given for running and maintenance old age homes, day care centres, mobile Medicare units, multi-facility care centre for older widows, etc. Funds are directly released to the implementing agencies like NGOs and not to the State Governments.

8. **National Council for Senior Citizens**

The Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment has constituted the “National Council of Senior Citizens (NCSrC)” by renaming of the erstwhile “National Council for Older Persons (NPOP)”. Its mandate is to advise the Central and State Governments on the entire gamut of issues related to the welfare of senior citizens and enhancement of their quality of life.

Concessions and facilities given to senior citizens– Various Ministries offer different types of concessions to the elderly population:

1. **Ministry of Finance** provides income tax rebates, exemption from e-filing, benefits under **Sections 80TTB & 194A** of the Income Tax Act, Income tax rebate for medical treatment & insurance premium etc.
2. **Ministry of Health & Family Welfare:** The Ministry is implementing The Senior Citizens Health Insurance Scheme (SCHIS) over existing schemes which provides enhanced coverage of upto **Rs. 30,000** per senior citizen per annum in the eligible households. The beneficiaries include BPL households and 11 other designated categories
3. **Ministry of Railways:** Railways Ministry provides fare concession in all Mail / Express including Rajdhani / Shatabdi / Jan-Shatabdi trains for senior citizens aged 58 years (females) and 60 years (males) and above. The amount of concession is **40 % for male and 50 % for female**.
4. **Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution:** Under the Antyodaya Scheme, the BPL families which also include older persons are provided food grains at the rate of 35 kgs. per family per month.

National policy on senior citizens, 2011:

The **Ministry of Social Justice** came up with the policy due to demographic explosion among the elderly, the changing economy and social milieu, advancement in medical research, science and technology and high levels of destitution among the elderly rural poor. Social deprivations and exclusion, privatization of health services and changing pattern of morbidity also called for an integrated holistic towards the elderly population.

The policy aims to mainstream senior citizens, especially older women, and bring their concerns into the national development debate with priority to implement mechanisms already set by governments and supported by civil society and senior citizens associations. It recognizes that senior citizens are a valuable resource for the country and create an environment that provides them with equal opportunities, protects their rights and enables their full participation in society. The policy stresses on the **need of preventive care** rather than cure. It also promotes the concept of “**Ageing in Place**” or ageing in own home, housing, income security and homecare services, old age pension and access to healthcare insurance schemes. It recognizes that **care of senior citizens** has to remain vested in the family which would partner with the community, government and the private sector. Long term **savings instruments** and credit activities will be promoted to reach both rural and urban areas. It encourages **employment** in income generating activities after superannuation and support and assistance to organisations that provide care to the elderly population. It calls for proper implementation of the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007 by the States and setting up Tribunals so that elderly parents unable to maintain themselves are not abandoned and neglected.

The areas of intervention recognized in the policy include income security in old age, healthcare, safety and security, housing facilities, **productive ageing**, welfare (through a welfare fund), multigenerational bonding and role of media. The policy also envisages establishment of National Council for Senior Citizens to monitor the implementation of the policy and advise the government on concerns of senior citizens.

Though successive governments have taken several steps to provide old-age citizens a life of dignity and well-being, there are several challenges hindering the efforts. The mandated use of Aadhaar card has left huge number of old-age citizens out of the ambit of the welfare schemes as their fingerprints tend to wear away with age. This has led to exclusions and errors in beneficiaries' identification. Also, lack of coordination among Centre and States and among various Departments and Ministries has caused further issues. Health being a State list subject, various states run their own schemes for the elderly people and refuse to integrate or align their schemes with that of the Centre or many times even refuse to share the financial burden.

Implementation of the Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana is another issue. Even after one year since the launch, only over 61,000 elderly people have benefitted so far. Similarly, under the PMVVY (Pradhan Mantri Vaya Vandana Yojana), just over 2 lakh people are receiving the benefits. Further, PMVVY entails a minimum purchase price of Rs 1.5 lakh to redeem monthly pension of mere Rs 1000. Even the pension amount under Widow Pension scheme is a meagre Rs 500 per month while that under IGNOAPS is as low as Rs 200 per month. By no means these amounts are sufficient to help an individual even achieve a decent standard of living.

Geriatric healthcare challenges have also started emerging. Being a relatively new branch of healthcare in India, most practicing physicians have limited knowledge of the clinical and functional implications of aging. India's old, their caregivers and healthcare providers recognize ill-health as part of old age. In fact, healthcare providers often view elderly patients in a "negative and mechanistic fashion". Condemnatory attitudes, limited awareness and knowledge with non-acceptance of geriatrics as a legitimate discipline has manifested in inaccessible or poor-quality care. The National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly (NPHCE) also seems to have overlooked the problems of caregivers of the beneficiaries. Although a number of dedicated services have been set up at various levels of healthcare delivery, these services **lack specialized equipment and trained geriatric healthcare team** to bring about target oriented management of geriatric problems.

Despite several initiatives, old-age people continue to live a life of isolation, destitution and agony, being seen as a burden by the society as well as their family. There is ample scope for improving the way schemes are implemented. Further, to ensure financial security, the pension amount under the **IGNOAPS** should be raised and the premium under schemes like **PMVVY, Atal Pension Yojana** etc. should be kept low so that most of the poor elders can afford it. There is also a need to provide dedicated sections and wards for elderly people in every hospital in the country and it should be made easily accessible. The attempt to improvise geriatric educational programmes at medical and public health institutes can be elaborated by extending the education to Ayurveda, Yoga and Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha and Homeopathy (**AYUSH**) professionals. These professionals can replenish the deficit of medical manpower and gaps in delivery of healthcare to the elderly. Home based care backed up by a predefined referral chain especially in rural and tribal areas should also be incorporated in the National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly (NPHCE).

All the Government offices and establishments must have ramps and wheelchair facilities while the private established shall be asked to do so by utilizing the **CSR funds**. The government must also make use of this second demographic dividend, which results from an increase in adult longevity, and causes individuals to save more in preparation for old age. This increase in savings can thus contribute to capital accumulation and economic growth. Also, the Centre and the State Governments should work in the spirit of **Cooperative federalism** with respect to the schemes they formulate. The public officials should be held liable for non-effective implementation of legislations like **Maintenance of Parents and Senior Citizens Act**. A dedicated senior citizens' **helpline number** should be launched nationally where they can seek guidance to avail their entitlements and register complain. Also, a mass awareness campaign to make all citizens aware of elderly human rights and entitlements under various schemes should be launched.

Today, the old-age people remain the least empowered group in the country, physically, psychologically, and financially. However, empowering them shall not be seen as a sole prerogative of the State. The degrading moral values in the society and rapid transition from joint family to nuclear family system have also contributed to the agony of the old-age people. It must be ensured that the kith and kin who owe their very existence to them are enlightened and encouraged to take care of their parents in the final years of their life. It is time to see the elderly population not as a liability but as an asset of the society. All schemes and statutes shall be implemented in letter and spirit to ensure them their human rights. India being a signatory to the **Madrid Plan of Action on Ageing** must ensure that ageing remains a healthy and blissful process. Unless we secure a better future for our senior citizens, the idea of **Swaraj** as envisaged by Mahatma Gandhi will remain a distant dream.

In order to enhance the prospects of social development, sound and adequate health care policies are needed particularly in the fields of geriatric and maternal health care. Discuss. (UPSC 2020)

5.4. Empowerment of minorities

The Constitution of India uses the word 'minority' (in Article 29, 30, 350 A and 350 B) but does not define the word 'minority'. The minorities in India include:

1. Religious minority- As per National Commission for Minorities Act, 1992, it includes Muslims, Sikhs, Christians, Buddhists, Zoroastrians (Parsis) and Jains. Sects within a religion are not considered a religious minority.
2. Linguistic minority -They belong mainly to a State and not at the national level. The linguistic minorities must have a separate spoken language but it is not necessary that they have a distinct script.

India is **home to thousands of distinct and unique cultures**, formed by mixing of multiple religious and linguistic minorities. However, with rapid socio-economic changes and urbanization in recent years, the valuable cultures and traditions of the minorities in India are under severe threat and in some cases face extinction. Today minorities who were known for metal works, elegant textile such as Banarasi, kantha (West Bengal), Kashida (J&K) are leaving these art forms. Even Parsi population has reduced to half.

Globalization has led to change in preferences and demands of consumers. They are preferring western, machine made, cheaper products over local, hand-made, exquisite so expensive products. **Increased competition** with such cheap machine made products and scarce and rising cost of basic resources has caused decline of traditional art and artifacts. Moreover, increased poverty levels, illiteracy, lack of adequate income has forced traditional artisans to either migrate to other regions or shift to some other occupation. As a result, **art forms** have not been able to pass on to successive generations. Homogenization is also impacting individual fine arts, music, festivals. The changed lifestyle is giving way to **migration, homogenization, blind race behind western traditions and neglect of indigenous culture, stressful life, time and resource scarcity**, intergenerational gaps which makes people to lose sight of their prized heritage.

Even for linguistic minorities, discriminatory practices or policies against them in different states, can, in the long term, threaten national integration. We have already witnessed linguistic reorganization of states, immediately after independence, to help citizens stay connected with their linguistic identity and protect them from any discrimination. However, continued prejudiced treatment against linguistic minorities, can perpetuate 'separatism'. For example, Bengali speaking people in Assam; Kannada and Malayalam speaking people in Andhra Pradesh, Nepali speaking people (Gorkhas) in upper districts of West Bengal, are being discriminated against based on their languages and often efforts are taken to impose the state language on them. This suppressing of cultural diversity can be very costly in terms of the alienation of the minorities.

Constitutional provisions:

There are various Constitutional provisions, to safeguard the interests of 'linguistic, religious and other minorities', as given below:

1. **Article 15:** Prohibition of discrimination on grounds of religion, race, caste, sex or place of birth.
2. **Article 16:** Equality of opportunity in matters of public employment and no citizens shall be ineligible for employment on grounds only of religion, race, caste, sex, descent, place of birth.
3. **Article 25:** Guarantees freedom of conscience and free profession, practice and propagation of religion.
4. **Article 26:** Every religious denomination has the freedom to manage its religious affairs.
5. **Article 27:** Freedom from payment of taxes for promotion of any particular religion.

6. **Article 28:** Freedom as to attendance at religious instruction or religious worship in certain educational institutions.
7. **Article 29:** Protection of distinct language, script or culture of minorities.
8. **Article 30:** Rights of all minorities, whether based on religion or language, to establish and administer educational institutions of their choice.
9. **Article 347:** The President may, if he is satisfied that a substantial proportion of the population of a state desires the use of any language spoken by them to be recognised by that State, direct that such language shall also be officially recognised throughout that State or any part thereof for such purpose as he may specify.
10. **Article 350B:** Article 350B provides for a **special officer for linguistic minorities** to be appointed by the President, to investigate all matters relating to the safeguards provided for linguistic minorities under the constitution.

Ministry of Minority affairs was carved out of Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment and created on 29th January 2006 to ensure a more focused approach towards issues relating to the notified minority communities namely Muslim, Christian, Buddhist, Sikhs, Parsis and Jain. The ministry is also involved with linguistic minorities and the office of Commissioner for Linguistic Minorities, representation of the Anglo-Indian community, protection and preservation of non-Muslim shrines in Pakistan and Muslim shrines in India in terms of the Pant-Mirza Agreement of 1955. The Minister in charge is also Chairperson of the Central Wakf Council, India, which manages the running of the State Wakf Boards.

Court judgements:

1. In **St. Stephen's College vs University of Delhi** (1992), the court held that autonomy of a minority institution cannot be taken away as it will defeat the purpose of right to establish and administer educational institutions by minorities.
2. Supreme Court in **TMA Pai Foundation case** considered the question of definition of 'minority' within the meaning of Article 30(1). It held that 'a minority either linguistic or religious is determinable only by reference to demography of the State and not by taking into consideration the population of the country as a whole'. Thus, religious and linguistic minorities, have to be considered state-wise for the application of central and state laws.

Legislative provisions:

The government has passed various laws for the protection and upliftment of minorities in India. They are:

1. Different personal laws govern marriage, divorce and succession rights of persons belonging to different religions. For example, **Indian Christian Marriage Act, 1872** and **Parsi Marriage and Divorce Act 1936**.
2. **National Commission for Minorities Act, 1992**– It set up the National Commission for Minorities to protect minority rights in the country. It consists of one chairperson and six members representing the six minor communities – Muslims, Sikhs, Buddhists, Christians, Parsis and Jains. The Commission performs various functions including evaluating the development of minority communities under Union and States, ensuring the safeguard of minority rights as per the Constitution and other laws, conducting studies on matters related to minorities and suggesting measures to the government. The commission also acts as a grievance redressal forum for persons belonging to minority communities. It functions as a civil court in matters concerning summoning of witnesses, discovery and production of documents, requisitioning of public records and copies, etc.
3. **National Commission for Minority Educational Institutions Act, 2004** -- This act allows direct affiliation of minority educational institutes to central universities in order to provide quality

education in minority institutes. It can also look into any complaints relating to violation and deprivation of rights of minorities to establish and administer educational institutions of their choice.

4. **Central Waqf Council** was set up as a statutory body, whose administration is the responsibility of the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment. A Wakf is a permanent dedication of movable or immovable properties for purposes recognised by the Muslim law as religious, pious or charitable. The Wakfs are also instruments of social and economic upliftment. The Council implements schemes for development of urban Wakf properties and educational programmes.

Government policies and schemes:

Government of India has adopted a comprehensive approach to preserve minority heritage and culture. Various components of the strategy are:

1. **Educational empowerment:** Ministry of minority affairs provides pre-matric, post-matric and merit cum means scholarships to students of poor families. **“Maulana Azad National Fellowship”** for higher studies and interest subsidy scheme like **“Padho Pardesh”**. The educated minority youth are well placed to recognize the significance of historic resources, to preserve them for future generations, and to integrate them into everyday life through redevelopment, community efforts in conservation.
2. **Livelihood security:** Ministry’s **“Nai Roshni”** scheme is empowering women by providing knowledge, tools, technique, while scheme **“Nai Manzil”** is bridging the skill gaps in madrasa students. **“Seekho Aur Kamao (Learn and Earn)”** scheme imparts minority youth with skill and 75% assured placement guarantee. National Minorities Development & Finance Corporation (NMDFC) fulfills microfinance needs of entrepreneurs. An empowered artisan can prudently manage inventory, access government schemes, can gather market trends, can tailor the product design as consumer need.
3. **Jiyo Parsi scheme:** Parsi population has seen 50% decline since independence; reasons are low fertility, migration, a large number of Parsis who remain unmarried, late marriages etc. It is threatening their 2000 year old cultural practices such as Navjote, Zoroastrian weddings, funeral, their temples, dakhma (Tower of silence) etc. Government through this scheme has made unique structural intervention to **stabilize Parsi population**. It provides for counselling, medical assistance which will indirectly help to preserve the rich heritage.
4. **USTAAD scheme: Upgrading the Skills and Training in Traditional Arts/Crafts for Development** scheme, is direct intervention to preserve rich heritage of traditional arts/crafts of minorities and build capacity of traditional artisans/craftsmen through **recognition, preserving talent, exhibitions, stipend and awards**. With such a unique provisions this scheme is preserving traditional textile, wood, carpet, handicraft, embroidery art forms of minority society.
5. **Hamari Dharohar scheme** has been announced to preserve the rich heritage of minorities, their literature/ documents, calligraphy etc. under the overall concept of Indian culture through documentation of oral traditions, art forms, exhibitions and fellowships. It works in partnership with National museum, National gallery of modern arts, ASI, UNESCO and world monument foundation. Three iconic exhibitions of Parsi culture have been arranged and a project for **translation of 240 invaluable documents** has also been announced. These documents, belonging to the medieval period, on the subjects of medicines, mathematics, literature, etc., will be translated from the Arabic language to English; digitized, and re-printed.
6. **Nalanda Scheme:** Union Ministry of Minority Affairs has launched the Nalanda Project for higher educational institutions belonging to minorities. It is an innovative faculty development program and is taken up at Aligarh Muslim University.
7. **Waqf management:** Government provides **interest free loans** for construction and reconstruction of financially viable assets such as hospitals, marriage halls, cold storage on waqf lands.
8. **Prime Minister’s New 15 Point Programme for the Welfare of Minorities:** It is an overarching programme which covers various schemes under concerned ministries by **earmarking 15% of physical targets/financial outlay** for minorities. For **enhancing opportunities for education**, it focuses on (1)

equitable availability of Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS), (2) improving access to school education, (3) mobilizing greater resources for teaching Urdu, (4) modernizing Madarsa education, (5) provision of scholarships for meritorious students from minority communities and (6) improving educational infrastructure through the Maulana Azad Education Foundation. In order to **generate equitable share in economic activities and employment**, the programme focuses on (7) self-employment and wage employment for the poor, (8) upgradation of skills through technical training, (9) enhanced credit support for economic activities and (10) recruitment to State and Central Services. To **improve the conditions of living of minorities**, it calls for (11) equitable share in rural housing scheme and (12) improvement in condition of slums inhabited by minority communities. To **prevent and control communal riots**, it suggests (13) posting of efficient, impartial public servants in communally sensitive and riot prone areas, (14) prosecution for communal offences and (15) rehabilitation of victims of communal riots.

9. **Minority Cyber Gram (MCG):** It seeks to introduce digital literacy skills in identified minority clusters in India through designated digital fellows for knowledge empowerment and entitlement gains of minority groups and beneficiaries.

In order to protect minorities, they should be given special consideration especially in a context where the normal working of the political and democratic system, places them at a disadvantage with respect to the majority. Special rights for minorities were designed to help them preserve their institutions and to guarantee autonomy in the matter of administration of these institutions. Ensuring these rights does not imply that they are to be treated as a privileged section of the society, but the idea is to provide them with a sense of security. Government's efforts are also incomplete **without citizen's participation**. Our cultural heritage teaches us about tolerance and respect for diverse traditions. Therefore, minority or no minority, it is the civic duty of every citizen to protect our heritage.

5.5. Empowerment of youth

UNESCO defines 'Youth' as "the period of transition from the dependence to independence and awareness of our independence as members of a community." India is a very young nation with around 65% population under the age of 35, thereby compelling even political parties to cater to its needs – 2014 elections was a significant event in this particular regard when its role was aptly considered. The inherent nature of youth is its potential which has to be tapped by substantial policy orientation and support. In recent times, youth have defined the public discourse on matters as diverse as LGBT movement to women emancipation to environmental sanctity to human rights. Hence youth is acting as an emerging pressure group beyond the confines of traditional political mores. The fact that it acts as bridge between two generations and filters knowledge amply on the two sides, therefore creating new social thinking and political activity. The importance of the youth and their indomitable spirit has been exemplified by Swami Vivekananda's words – "Arise! Awake! And stop not until the goal is reached".

Challenges faced by the youth:

Indian demographic transition is uniquely placed and therefore offers a unique opportunity for India to become skill capital of the world. It will in turn open avenues for the ageing economies as well to meet the skilled manpower requirements. However, it needs to be appreciated that demographic advantage of India is not uniformly distributed. Mobilisation of youth for vocational education or skill development beyond the confines of caste occupations is difficult. Also there is lack of willingness to migrate, inability to pay for training, low literacy or lack of awareness etc. which hinders the desired aim.

Indian youth can be harbinger of economic growth of India if they are efficiently absorbed in the labour market. India is already experiencing a youth bulge which needs to be tapped. It needs to be noted that

this is much more pronounced in the northern and eastern states which are incidentally backward. But the prospects for the youth in the job market are not bright as the jobs which are being created are not sufficient to absorb the huge chunk of the youth. Since the attracting factor of the agriculture is diminishing for various reasons, not to mention the economic dwindling returns, they are more slated to join sectors such as construction, manufacturing and trade relating service activities. The shift from agriculture is albeit a good sign, but the jobs outside remains cruel to the expectations of the youth.

Moreover, unemployment is a harsh reality and it is higher in urban areas than in rural areas where people still become disguisedly unemployed through agriculture. Females are largely unemployed post 1991 as per ILO because definite gender roles assigned became prominent when incomes increased in middle class, leading to women being dropped off from the labor force.. The discrimination against women also persists when it comes to hiring them, as they are considered less productive or are presumed to be simultaneously engaged in reproductive and household works. The recent amendments in Maternity Act which mandates employees to provide crèche facilities may also create some hindrance, as suggested by some. It is also generally accepted that the lack of suitable infrastructure facilities such as transport, crèche facilities, etc. which facilitate women's access to jobs is a major reason in limiting the women to job market.

There has been a decline in labour force participation rate for all age groups irrespective of gender and spatial distinction. Still this decline is steep for the rural females which could be attributed to the absence of jobs in rural areas. The challenge is to address the problem of working poor, insecurity at the workplace, lack of market linked skills, information asymmetry, poor perception about skill development. Hence there is a need to match supply to current demand for skills. Help workers and enterprises adjust to change and build and sustain competencies for future labour market needs. Excessive competition as a result of rising materialism is leading to case of depression and anxiety amongst the youth. Further, generation gap is on a rise, alienating the youth from their families.

Increasing use of Social media is leading to erosion of traditional values. Peer pressure, pop culture etc. are leading the youth towards self destructive tendencies. For example, blue whale challenge, extreme diets etc.

Twin challenge of lack of skills and insufficient quality jobs is reading to rising unemployability. The eight edition of the India Skills Report (ISR) highlights that only **45.9 per cent** of graduates are employable.

Naxalism's Red Corridor has also spread geographically over the years with continuing violence perpetrated by angry Naxal youth. The youth in such areas are particularly vulnerable due to the environment they grow up in. Similarly, the youth in Kashmir is estranged with the Indian goal of democracy and has to be rescued. Youth today is also prone to ill effects of urban culture and therefore often resorts to illegal activities to make a living. The disparity between availability and accessibility is the major reason behind the alienation of the youth, which needs to be fulfilled, as only digital empowerment cannot be complete.

COVID-19 has worsened the situation for youth. School and college closures has had a serious impact on their lives and their mental well-being. In India, more than 32 crore students have been affected by the nationwide lockdown due to COVID-19. Of these, about 15.8 crores are female. Many of those who have dropped out are unlikely to go back to school or college. 17% of young people are likely to be suffering from anxiety and depression. Moreover, increased poverty levels during the pandemic may result in early marriages of girls in India and gender violence. Adolescent girls are at high risk, given their vulnerability to abuse and trafficking, especially if primary caregivers fall ill or die.

** We will discuss more on Mental Health in Chapter on Health and related issues.*

Drug abuse is a **self-destructive pattern** of **harmful** or **hazardous use of psychoactive substances**. Drug abuse reduces **physical and mental agency of the users** as well as destroys not only current but also future generation of **families both financially and emotionally**. Further, it **denies the nation of its productive youth and best of talents**. According to NCRB report, substance abuse caused 9000 deaths by suicide in 2020 i.e. **one death every hour**.

It generally starts with **voluntary experimentation** but gradually translates into involuntary dependency and **addiction**. Drugs can be broadly classified into three different categories with different user base and underlying factors:

Categories	User base	Reasons
Party/Designer/synthetic drugs Cocaine, ecstasy, etc.	Affluent section	1. Curiosity to experiment and experience something different, perceived as thrilling or daring. 2. Peer pressure and desire to fit in their social grouping. 3. To heighten enjoyment and sustain energy for effective participation in the social gatherings. 4. Entertainment and creative industries: Success at young age, excessive competitive pressure, blinding glamour, party culture can push artists into drug abuse. E.g. Honey Singh, Sushant Singh Rajput, Aryan Khan.
Pharmaceuticals drugs Morphine, codeine syrup	Broad user base from affluent to poor.	1. Long and continued use of psychoactive medications used to treat underlying diseases. 2. Easy access to over the counter medication. 3. To increase efficiency in athletics, academics and stage performance.
Inhalants : Household and industrial chemicals Whitener solution, glue, iodex, etc.	Poorer section of society	1. Cheap and easy availability. 2. An attempt to escape reality and sufferings caused by socio-economic deprivations. 3. Lower level of education leads to drug use without knowing its ill effects.

Some common factors also include: (i) **reduce attention of parents** on their kids, (ii) influence of **social media**, imitation of west and easy **access to age-inappropriate content** on internet, (iii) cut throat **competition** in carrier, (iv) trouble in **personal/love life**, (v) easy access to **drugs** (location of India between **golden triangle and golden crescent**) and (vi) certain degree of **acceptance** for some drugs like marijuana.

A multi-stakeholder approach involving a **3-pronged strategy of enforcement, de-addiction and prevention** is required to tackle this menace.

1. Role of Government

- a. **Effective enforcement of Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act**, to bust drug cartel and stringent action against bigwigs to prevent easy access to drugs. Prevention of over-the-counter sale of non-prescription drugs and counter new and emerging routes of drug trade. E.g. Chabahar-Mumbai route.
- b. Bridge treatment gap, building **rehabilitation centers** and promoting physical activity through Khelo India.
- c. **Differentiate Users** from **peddlers** and treat users as **victims** (suggestion by Ministry of SJ&E). Also, **decriminalizing small quantity usage**.

2. Role of Civil Society

- a. Rope in **NGOs** and **faith-based Institutes** for **raising awareness** and reduce stigmatization of and discrimination against, drug abusers for their reintegration into the society.

- b. Community based services for the identification, motivation, counselling, de-addiction, after care and rehabilitation for **Whole Person Recovery (WPR)** of addicts

3. Role of Family

- a. **Child-Parent Communication** and **regular parent monitoring** can help in early interventions into drug usage.
- b. **Family therapy** has gained increased acceptance, with involvement of family members in treatment as they collectively influence **psycho-social development of addicts**.

The drug menace is **eating into our social fabric** and the **economy** by destroying physical and mental health of users. It is a **multidimensional problem** and needs a similar **combative strategy** to eradicate it.

Government initiatives:

1. **National Youth Policy**- “The National Youth Policy 2014” reiterates the commitment of the entire nation to the all-round development of youth of India so that they can realise their full potential and contribute productively to the nation building process.
2. **Nehru Yuva Kendra Sangathan** – It is an autonomous organization of the Department of Youth Affairs and Sports, under the Government of India. It was established in 1987-88 to provide rural youth, avenues for nation building, as well as opportunities to develop their personality and skills.
3. **National Service Scheme (NSS)** – National Service Scheme(NSS) is an Indian government-sponsored public service program conducted by the Department of Youth Affairs and Sports of the Government of India. Popularly known as NSS, the scheme was launched in Gandhiji’s centenary year, 1969. It is aimed at developing student’s personality through community service, NSS is a voluntary association of young people in Colleges, Universities and at +2 level working for a campus-community linkage.
4. **Skill Upgradation Training Programme** –Aims to develop vocational training to help generate extra income and boost self confidence
5. Promotion of Folk Art, Culture and **Yuva Kriti** – Opportunity for rural youth to showcase their talent and culture.
6. **Mahatma Gandhi Yuva Swachta Abhiyanand Shramdaan Karyakaram** – To engage youth in contributing to the cleanliness drive and water conservation.
7. **Life Skill Training for Adolescents** – Training youth to enable them to cope with pressure and make healthy life choices. To sensitise the adolescents about reproductive sexual health and issues involved which concerns their health.
8. **Tribal Yuva Exchange Programme** – It aims to sensitize the tribal youth to rich cultural heritage of the country and to enable them to appreciate the concept of unity in diversity, to expose them to development activities and technological/ industrial advancement in other parts of the country, to enable them to develop emotional linkage with the people in other parts of the country and to develop their personality by enhancing their understanding of the core life skills, identifying their skill development needs and providing them necessary career counselling. Youth are generally selected from left wing extremism affected areas and taken on tour to different parts of the country, in order to nationalise their mind-set.
9. **Start-up India:** It is based on an action plan aimed at promoting bank financing, tax incentives etc. for start-up ventures to boost entrepreneurship and encourage start-ups with jobs creation, particularly for the youth. It is focused on to restrict role of States in policy domain and to get rid of “license raj” and hindrances like in land permissions, foreign investment proposal, environmental clearances. The government has already launched iMADE, an app development platform aimed at producing 1,000,000 apps and PMMY, the MUDRA Bank, a new institution set up for development and refinancing activities relating to micro units with a refinance Fund of ₹200 billion. Rural India’s version of Start-up India was named the Deen Dayal Upadhyay Swaniyojan Yojana.

10. **Stand Up India:** It aims at promoting entrepreneurship among SCs/STs, women communities and to make them job-creators rather than job-seekers.
11. **Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojna:** It is under the Micro Units Development and Refinance Agency (MUDRA) Bank, which is a new institution set up by Government of India for development and refinancing activities relating to micro units. It was announced by the Finance Minister while presenting the Union Budget for FY 2016. The purpose of MUDRA is to provide funding to the non-corporate small business sectors and create more jobs.
12. **Startup Village Entrepreneurship Programme:** It intends to encourage entrepreneurship amongst the rural youth.
13. **National Skill Development Mission** together with new National Policy for Skill Development and Entrepreneurship was launched in 2015. It focuses upon creating a pipeline of skilled people, upskilling and reskilling to align supply for demand. Further there is a renewed focus on reorienting the school education by vocalising it from class 9th. It seeks to create both capacity and quality improvement.
14. **New Integrated Action Plan:** It aims to bring Adivasis in LWE areas, in the mainstream while dealing with the security aspect simultaneously. Government has also launched initiatives relating to education and skill development for the youth of these areas.
15. **Residential Schooling Facility:** It is provided to all children under Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan in left wing violence affected regions.
16. **Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalayas:** It aims to provide affordable and elementary education for the girl children.
17. **Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan:** It is being implemented vigorously to provide secondary education to growing children who are most vulnerable to be attracted by ideological violence.
18. **Prayas:** It is an institute established by the government where children are being prepared for competitive exams.
19. **UDAAN:** It is a special industry initiative for J&K funded by Ministry of Home Affairs and implemented by National Skill Development Corporation. It aims to provide corporate exposure to the youth as well as provide corporate India the talent available in the state.
20. **Sadbhavna:** Under Sadbhavna, Army runs several important programmes for the youth of J&K. Army Goodwill Schools which is an education initiative works to provide middle and high school level education to over one lakh students. Army runs National Integration Tour where students get to visit other states and get a first-hand view of the culture of their fellow citizens. Army also runs vocational training centres and women empowerment centres spread across the state to provide practical skills to interested and deserving candidates.
21. **Himayat:** Run under the Ministry of Rural Development, Government of India's Deen Dayal Upadhyay Grameen Kaushal Yojana the scheme endeavours to train 1.24 lakh local youth of J&K in job intensive vocational courses.

Digital Empowerment of the Youth:

The emergence of alternate platforms through digital transformation of media has empowered the youth with new information and ideas while also enhancing their learning capabilities as a whole. The faster communication has also created avenues in connecting geographically alienated regions and people, thereby facilitating mutual exchange of values, norms and understanding. It has functionally enabled equal opportunities in matters of accessibility of knowledge resources. The vantage point is this that the youth has been particularly well co-opted to this new technology, which in turn has also strengthened the spirit of entrepreneurship and start-ups.

Open and Distance Learning System in India has emerged as a convenient, flexible and viable alternative for making education accessible to diverse population who do not have access to formal education. Information and communication technology has blurred classroom boundaries both spatially and temporally.

Virtual learning environments have the enormous potential to reach the masses. They provide them with access to quality contents. Entrepreneurship education has received special attention from the central government. The role of young entrepreneurs in a globalised economy such as ours has been aptly recognised by the government and the educational institutes. Empowering youth is an imperative for national development. However, personal development is also an important facet of youth development. It can be pursued by promoting youth rights, youth activism and their participatory and deliberative role in community decision making. But to realise this, the key is to educate them and make them employable. Significantly, sustainable development of any nation cannot be achieved without the activity of youth.

National Youth Policy 2014 acknowledges that the young persons in the age group of 15-29 is very diverse with varying requirements, needs and aspirations and has to be dealt accordingly. It is high time to empower youth to achieve their fullest potential and enable India to become leader in supply of skilled labour. India is going through a phase of demographic transition due to which the proportion of youth in the total population is increasing. An increasing number of youth require good education and a steady creation of suitable jobs. Employment creation needs to be a part of macro and other economic policies. There is a need to accelerate the process of job creation and therefore different ministries can include job creation in all their programmes and policies. Regional inequality needs to be corrected so that local youth are able to get employment in the regions itself as demanded by regional behemoths in Maharashtra. There is a need for suitable policies and programmes so that more and more women get employment. The country needs to move fast so that it realizes the demographic dividend. If it fails, the demographic dividend will turn into demographic disaster. The transforming youth shall be the torch bearers of a much sensitized, conscious and harmonious world.

5.6. Empowerment of transgenders

According to World Health Organization, Transgender is an umbrella term for people whose gender identity and expression does not conform to the norms and expectations traditionally associated with the sex assigned to them at birth. They are referred to as transsexuals if they desire medical assistance in order to make the transition from one biological sex to another.

As per the Census of 2011, the total population of Transgender in India is 4.9lakh. The highest proportion of the trans-gender population, about 28%, has been identified in Uttar Pradesh followed by Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh and West Bengal. There are various types of transgender communities in India- Hijras, Kothis, Aravanis, Jogappas, and Shiv-Shakthis etc.

Traditional transgender communities in India

1. Hijras: They are a member of an ancient transgender community in India, popularly referred to as eunuchs.
2. Kothis: The term is used in reference to those that adopt feminine roles in the same- sex relationships, but do not live in communes like the Aravanis.
3. Aravanis: Aravanis refer to the earlier male but now female transgenders, who have undergone genital modification through Sex Reassignment Surgery or performed Nirwaan, which is the traditional mode of castration.
4. Jogappas: They are the male turned female transgenders, who devote to the services of a particular God.
5. Shiv-Shaktis: They are the males that are considered married to Gods, and in particular, Lord Shiva, and are found in Andhra Pradesh

Problems faced by Transgender communities in India

Transgender population remains one of the most marginalized groups. Sexuality or gender identity often makes transgender a victim of stigmatization and exclusion by the society. They are often ousted by their own biological family or run away at an early age due to harassment. Transgender people are unable to access equal educational opportunities because of harassment, discrimination and even violence. Most transgender children are forced to drop out of schools as Indian schools remain unequipped to handle children with alternative sexual identities. As a result, they are economically marginalised and forced into professions like prostitution and begging for livelihood or resorting to exploitative entertainment industry.

Transgenders frequently experience discrimination when accessing health care, from disrespect and harassment to violence and outright denial of service. The community remains highly vulnerable to sexually transmitted diseases like HIV AIDS. According to a recent UNAIDS report, the HIV prevalence among transgenders in India is 3.1% (2017). They are often subjected to sexual abuse, rape and exploitation. Mental health issues including depression and suicidal tendencies, and violence-related stress also hamper their well-being. They face direct discrimination and denial while accessing houses or apartments. Further, they also face problems due to lack of provision of gender neutral/separate transgender toilets and discrimination in accessing public toilets. Moreover, possessing accurate and consistent identification documents has always been challenging for the transgender community.

Constitutional Safeguards

The Constitution guarantees Fundamental rights to all communities including transgenders. They are:

1. **Article 14.** The State shall not deny to any person equality before the law or the equal protection of the laws within the territory of India.
2. **Article 15.** The State shall not discriminate against any citizen on grounds only of religion, race, caste, sex, and place of birth or any of them
3. **Article 19:** Right to freedom of speech and expression
4. **Article 21:** No person shall be deprived of his life or personal liberty except according to procedure established by law.
5. **Article 23:** Traffic in human beings and beggar and other similar forms of forced labour are prohibited and any contravention of this provision shall be an offence punishable in accordance with law

The Constitution provides for the fundamental right to equality, and tolerates no discrimination on the grounds of sex, caste, creed or religion. But the transgender community continues to be ostracized.

Court judgements:

Courts have led the way in recognizing the rights of the transgenders and accepting years of discrimination that the community has been subjected to. Some important court judgements include:

1. **NALSA Judgement, 2014:** The Supreme Court in National Legal Services Authority v. Union of India & Ors recognized the third gender along with the male and female. The Court upheld that transgenders should be treated as third gender for the purpose of safeguarding their fundamental rights. It acknowledged that Article 21 of the Constitution guarantees right to choose one's gender identity. The Court directed the state to provide reservations in public education and employment as socially and educationally backward class of citizens and to make special provisions regarding HIV sero-surveillance for transgender persons and provide appropriate health facilities. It also directed the state to frame social welfare schemes for their all-round development
2. **Section 377 Judgement, 2018:** Supreme Court decriminalised homosexuality by partially striking down the colonial era provisions of Section 377 of the Indian Penal Code (IPC).
3. In April 2019, **Madras High Court** upheld that the marriage solemnised between a man and a trans woman was valid under the Hindu Marriage Act, 1955 and ordered its registration. This is the first time in India where marriage between a man and Trans woman has been legally recognised.

4. The **Kerala High Court** allowed a petition by a transwoman seeking admission into the National Cadet Corps based on her self-claimed gender identity. The court noted that the NCC Act cannot prevent the operation of the Transgender Persons Act.

Legal Provisions:

Legislative steps for the empowerment of transgenders include:

1. In 2014, The Rights of Transgender Persons Bill, 2014, was introduced as a Private Member's Bill in the Rajya Sabha by Tiruchi Siva, a Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) MP. It was unanimously passed in the Upper House but was never debated in the Lok Sabha. Later in 2015, the Union government drafted The Rights of Transgender Persons Bill, 2015.
2. **Right of Transgender Persons Bill, 2016:** The bill aimed at defining the transgender people and prohibiting discrimination against them. Through this Bill the Government evolved a mechanism for their social, economic and educational empowerment. The Bill was originally introduced in 2016 and was passed with 27 amendments (after the recommendations of Parliamentary Standing Committee) by Lok Sabha in 2018, but didn't saw light of the day.
3. **Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019:** The Act aims to mitigating the social stigma against transgenders and ensure fundamental and basic human rights for them. It also aims at preventing discrimination and abuse against their population and bringing them into the mainstream of society. It defines transgenders as, 'Those whose gender does not match the gender assigned to that person at birth.' The Act prohibits the discrimination against a transgender person, including denial of service or unfair treatment in relation to education, employment, healthcare, access to, or enjoyment of goods, facilities, opportunities available to the public, right to movement, right to reside, rent, or otherwise occupy property, opportunity to hold public or private office and access to a government or private establishment in whose care or custody a transgender person is.

The Act mentions that every transgender person shall have a right to reside and be included in his household. If the immediate family is unable to care for the transgender person, the person may be placed in a rehabilitation centre, on the orders of a competent court. It also states that no government or private entity can discriminate against a transgender person in employment matters, including recruitment, and promotion. Every establishment is required to designate a person to be a complaint officer to deal with complaints in relation to the Act. Educational institutions funded or recognised by the relevant government shall provide inclusive education, sports and recreational facilities for transgender persons, without discrimination. The government must take steps to provide health facilities to transgender persons including separate HIV surveillance centres, and sex reassignment surgeries. The government shall review medical curriculum to address health issues of transgender persons, and provide comprehensive medical insurance schemes for them.

A transgender person may make an application to the District Magistrate for a certificate of identity, indicating the gender as 'transgender'. A revised certificate may be obtained only if the individual undergoes surgery to change their gender either as a male or a female. The Act states that the relevant government will take measures to ensure the full inclusion and participation of transgender persons in society. It must also take steps for their rescue and rehabilitation, vocational training and self-employment, create schemes that are transgender sensitive, and promote their participation in cultural activities. The Act mentions the following offences against transgender persons– forced or bonded labour (excluding compulsory government service for public purposes), denial of use of public places, removal from household, and village, and physical, sexual, verbal, emotional or economic abuse.

The National Council for Transgender persons (NCT) will advise the central government as well as monitor the impact of policies, legislation and projects with respect to transgender persons. It will also redress the grievances of transgender persons. Thus transgender Act, 2019 seeks to provide

justice to the community. It ensures various fundamental rights to transgender community under Article 14, 15, 19, 21 and article 23 of the constitution. It seek to instil social reform through legislation which is important for the rights of transgenders.

However, critics argue that the definition in the Act emphasises the biological dimension of transgender identity and conflates “sex” with “gender”. Further, the definition erroneously includes all intersex persons under the transgender category. They also argue that transgenders need assistance with housing, not ‘rehabilitation.’ Further there are concerns as state-run rehabilitation centres are known to have deplorable living conditions and frequent instances of sexual violence. The provision to make an application to the DM for a certificate of identity, amounts to denial of self-determination. The Act fundamentally misunderstands the specific circumstances in which transgender persons are forced to beg or take up prostitution as a profession. In such circumstances, to criminalise whoever “compels or entices a transgender person to indulge in the act of begging” can criminalize transgenders. Also, the Act fails to prescribe a punishment for the violation of prohibited acts like sexual crimes. The Act also overlooks everyday acts of bullying, intimidation and abuse carried out by police officials and further grants them complete immunity from prosecution.

State Level Initiatives:

1. Odisha: Draft Odisha Transgender Policy 2017: It seeks to protect rights of the gender non-conforming child.
2. Kerala: Kerala is the first state to formulate a transgender policy in 2015 which is aimed at ending the discrimination and bringing the third sex to the mainstream. The state has also set up a transgender justice board to deal with their complaints
3. Maharashtra: Maharashtra is the second state in India to set up a welfare board and the first, to set up a cultural institute dedicated to the transgender community.
4. Tamil Nadu: Tamil Nadu has established Tamil Nadu Transgender Welfare Board (TGWB) and has also been providing welfare schemes for socio-economic upliftment of the community. The Tamil Nadu police also welcomed a few transgender constables.
5. Chhattisgarh: Post the 2014 Supreme Court judgment, the Chhattisgarh government created the Third Gender Welfare Board. It takes various welfare measures in favour of trans people. Firstly, all departments were asked to include the third gender as an option in official documents that need mention of gender or sex of a person. Secondly, district-level committees were established to recognize members of the transgender community to help in the implementation of welfare schemes for their benefit. Thirdly, sensitisation workshops were held at State and district levels by the police department and police officers. Fourthly, training capsules were prepared for police training institutes with the help of transgender members of the Welfare Board. Fifthly, the police permitted the use of their sports ground for practice and also helped the trans-genders in preparing for the written examination. It was the hard work of the transgender people which ensured their success and marked their presence in the department. 13 members of the transgender community were selected as constables under the Chhattisgarh police. This move is truly historic and exciting for this community. Their entry into the law and order system would ensure the empowerment of the transgender community.

It is important to evolve an effective system to sensitize schools and universities as regards to the needs and the nature of the transgender community. Further, the issues pertaining to the transgender community within the education sector must be dealt with a holistic approach by addressing the core issues of equity, environment and employment. Schemes and measures should be directed towards skill development among transgender communities. Further, bank credit, micro loans, subsidized loans should be provided to support self-employment or entrepreneurial initiatives. Anti-discrimination Policies must be effectively followed in processes of hiring, retention and promotion. Workplace anti-sexual harassment policies should be transgender inclusive.

Separate policies related to health care must be framed and communicated in all private and public hospitals and clinics. The focus should not only be on HIV prevention but also on mental health issues and measures to address alcohol and drug abuse. Legal and the law enforcement systems need to be empowered and sensitized on the issues of Transgender community. Stringent criminal and disciplinary action must be taken against the people who commits violence against Transgender. Amendments should be made in several other laws like IPC to include transgender. For example, definition of rape under Section 376 IPC deals with crime committed against a female. Provision of free legal aid must be ensured for the Transgender community. A multi-prolonged approach with focus on public awareness campaigns is needed to eliminate the social stigma associated with the transgender community. Large scale sensitization needs to happen starting from the school level to accept the transgender community integral component of societal life.

6. POPULATION AND ASSOCIATED ISSUES

As per population projections provided by the technical group constituted under the **National Commission on Population** (NCP), India's population is expected to grow by **25%** from 1.21 billion in **2011** to 1.52 billion in **2036**. However, the decadal population growth rate is expected to decline to 12.5% in the 2011-2021 decade, its lowest since independence. As per the report, it will decline further to 8.4% in the 2021-2031 decade. Further according to these projections, India will overtake China as the world's most populous country around 2031. A large population is invariably seen as a liability and a major hindrance to the quality of services that the government can provide to its citizens. In this background, it becomes necessary to understand and study the factors leading to population growth and how they will impact the development policies of the country, given that the resources shall remain limited while the number of people they support are constantly rising.

The scientific and systematic study of population is known as **demography**. The term is of Greek origin and is composed of two words: demos (people) and graphein (describe), i.e. the description of people. Demography studies the trends and processes associated with population including – changes in population size, pattern of births, deaths, and migration, and the structure and composition of the population such as the relative proportions of women, men and different age groups etc. There are different varieties of demography, including formal demography which is a largely quantitative field, and social demography which focuses on the social, economic or political aspects of populations. All demographic studies are based on processes of counting or enumeration – such as the **census** or the **survey** – which involve the systematic collection of data on the people residing within a specified territory. The responsibility of conducting the decennial Census rests with the Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner under Ministry of Home Affairs. In September 2019, Union Home Minister stated that the **2021 census would be conducted digitally** replacing the traditional pen and paper. This will be the first Census of India that will be conducted digitally, by approximately 33 lakh teachers who would take on the responsibility of enumerators.

Global population milestones:

It is estimated that the world population reached one billion for the first time in 1803. It took another 124 years for the global population to reach two billion in 1927, but it took only 33 years to increase by another billion to total three billion people in 1960. Thereafter, the global population reached four billion in 1975, five billion in 1987, six billion in 1999 and 7 billion in 2011. According to current projections, the global population will reach eight billion by 2024, and is likely to reach around nine billion by 2042.

Arithmetic increase in food supply:

Food supply grows in arithmetic progression due to the operation of the law of diminishing returns based on the supposition that supply of land is constant. Thus, the food supply in successive years, will be 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7...

Geometric increase in population: Due to the natural sexual instinct in human beings, population increases at a faster rate (in geometrical progression). If left unchecked, it doubles itself every 25 years. Thus, starting from 1, population in successive periods of 25 years will be 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64...

6.1. Population theories and concepts

Malthusian theory of population:

Thomas Robert Malthus, an English cleric, and scholar, published the theory of population in his 1798 writings '**An Essay on the Principle of Population**.' According to him, population is rising at a higher rate as compared to rate of increase in food production. Malthus thus suggested **preventive checks** and **positive checks**, to control this over-population, resulting from the imbalance between population and food supply. The preventive checks are applied by a man to control the birth rate. They include abstaining from marriage or going for delayed

marriage, enforced celibacy, adopting moral restraint, etc. If people failed to check growth of population by the adoption of preventive checks, positive checks in the form of steps that tend to shorten human life, should be adopted. These include exposing people to severe labour, providing people unhealthy and insufficient food, prevalence of epidemics, wars, etc. These would reduce population and thereby bring a balance with food supply.

However, experts argue that historical data suggests that population growth has never been geometric, i.e. it has never doubled in 25 years. Moreover, Malthus overemphasized the 'positive' checks and did not visualize the role of other 'preventive' checks like contraceptives and family planning. Neo-Malthusians advocated for the adoption of birth control within marriage. Human inventions in the fields of birth control, health and nutrition, and agriculture have helped to a great extent to strike a balance between human reproduction and food supply.

Karl Marx's critic of Malthusian theory of population:

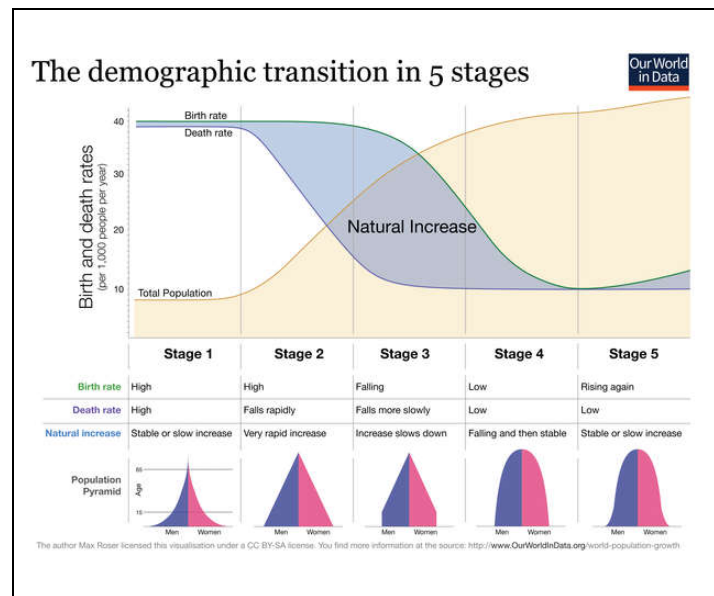
Karl Marx was the father of communism and a great theoretician. He argued that starvation was caused by the unequal distribution of wealth and its accumulation by capitalists. It had nothing to do with population. The problems of overpopulation and limits to resources are inevitable results associated with the capitalist system of production. He suggested that the capitalist class has lower population growth because they tend to save the wealth for personal consumption. Meanwhile **labour class has higher population growth rate because they consider 'greater the no. of hands, more the wages earned'**. Also, the survival rates among poor are very low, due to lack of nutrition, healthcare, ante-natal and post-natal services, etc. As a result, fertility rate among the lower sections of the society is large, in the hope that a few children will be able to survive and reach adulthood. Thus, children are a source of wealth.

Since the population increases rapidly among the labour class, the supply of labour also increases. This in turn reduces the wage rate and the income levels fall and as a reaction to it a new explosion takes place due to increased reproduction rate found among the labour class. Whereas the capitalist class continues to increase the concentration of wealth and the class differentiation grows further. Marx suggested that for population control, fall of capitalism is the only means of distributive justice and that only state control over resources could mitigate the food crisis. Thus, his theory is the socio-economic model of population control. However, critics argue that the problem of population explosion is not limited to capitalist countries. For instance, India and China, both are facing over-population.

Theory of Demographic Transitions:

The Demographic transition theory postulates a particular pattern of demographic change from a **high fertility and high mortality** to a **low fertility and low mortality stage** as a society progresses from a largely rural, agrarian and illiterate society to an urban, industrial, literate and modern society. Based on a study of 34 industrialist nations, demographic transition happens in five stages:

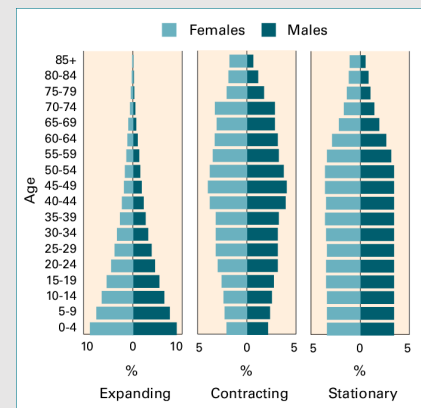
1. **Stage 1: High stationary phase** (Very high death and birth rates). For example- Congo, Sierra Leone
2. **Stage 2: Early expansionary phase** (Low death rate, very high birth rate). For example- Iran, Saudi Arabia
3. **Stage 3: Late expansionary phase** (Low death rate, high but falling birth rate). For example- India
4. **Stage 4: Low stationary phase** (Very low death rate and birth rate). For example- China
5. **Stage 5: Declining phase or negative population.** (Low death rate, very low birth rate but rising). For example- Japan, Germany.



The **age-sex structure** of a population refers to the number of females and males in different age groups. A population pyramid is used to show the age-sex structure of the population. The shape of the population pyramid reflects the characteristics of the population.

Types of Population Pyramids:

1. **Expanding populations:** This type of graph has a triangular shape, with a very wide base and pointed apex. The large base shows a **high birth rate**, which is probably due to factors like a developing economy, poverty, low levels of female education, and less awareness of birth control measures. The tapering top of the graph indicates a **high death rate**, meaning that the life expectancy in such a country is less. Factors like poor living conditions and the lack of proper medical facilities may be responsible for the high mortality among the elderly. Such countries have a higher population of children as compared to people of working age or older people. This results in a strain on the working-age population to support the large younger population, making them work in stressful conditions. Examples: Such a population pyramid is a characteristic of newly developing countries such as **Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Kenya**, and some countries of Latin America.
2. **Stable/stationary populations:** This shows birth and death rates are almost equal leading to a near constant population. Highly-developed countries such as USA, Sweden, and Netherlands, which have well-established economies, come under this type. They also have a stable birth rate, as there is more awareness and incentives to use birth control measures, along with the empowerment of women.
3. **Contracting populations:** There is a high life expectancy and good living conditions in such a country, leading to a higher number of older people. Despite this, there is a lesser number of births taking place, which is outnumbered by the number of deaths. This indicates a greying as well as decreasing population. There is a higher proportion of older people than the youth in the country, which places a burden upon the working-age population to support the large number of elderly dependents. Developed European countries like Italy and Germany, along with countries like Japan come under this category.



6.2. Determinants of Indian population

1. **Birth Rate:** The birth rate is the number of babies born for every 1000 people during a particular period of time. Increase in population is directly related to birth rate. As per population projection survey 2019, the crude birth rate will decline from 19.6 during 2011-15 to 13.0 during 2031-35 because of falling level of total fertility.

Factors affecting birth rate of a country include:

- a. the marriage age i.e. greater the number of people starting married life earlier, higher the birth rate;
 - b. availability and awareness of family planning methods; religious beliefs such as beliefs about contraception, family size, etc.;
 - c. female employment i.e. career commitments may reduce the number of children women might want to have;
 - d. economic prosperity i.e. even though richer families can afford to have more children, their way of life might prefer fewer children. On the other hand, poor may opt to have more children to have working hands for the family in a few years' time, even though bringing up children could cost more.
 - e. Infant mortality rate (IMR), also dictates birth rate in a fundamental way. If IMR is high, birth rate will likely be high as families expect that some children might die young.
2. **Death rate:** Death rate is the number of people who die every year compared to 1000 people in the population. As per population projection survey 2019, the crude death rate is expected to increase marginally from 6.9 during 2011-15 to 7.3 during 2031-35.
Factors affecting death rate of a country include:
 - a. medical facilities and health care – better the medical facilities and health care, lower the death rate;
 - b. nutrition level, living standards, access to clean drinking water, hygiene level, level of infectious diseases;
 - c. social factors such as conflicts and levels of violent crime, and exposure to natural calamities.
 3. **Total Fertility Rate**
Fertility rate of a population is the average number of children born to a woman in her lifetime. If fertility is high, population will increase. The Total Fertility Rate (TFR) is expected to decline from 2.34 during 2011-2015 to 1.72 during 2031- 35. **Replacement rate** is the total fertility rate at which a population exactly replaces itself from one generation to the next, without migration. This rate is roughly 2.1 children per woman for most countries.
 4. **Net Migration**
Migration is the movement of people in to and out of the country. Net migration is the difference between **immigration** (people moving in to the country) and **emigration** (people moving out of the country). A positive net immigration will increase the population, while the opposite decreases the population.

Natural growth of population is the population increased adjusted for deaths in a particular region between two points of time, i.e.,

$$\text{Natural growth} = \text{Births} - \text{Deaths}.$$

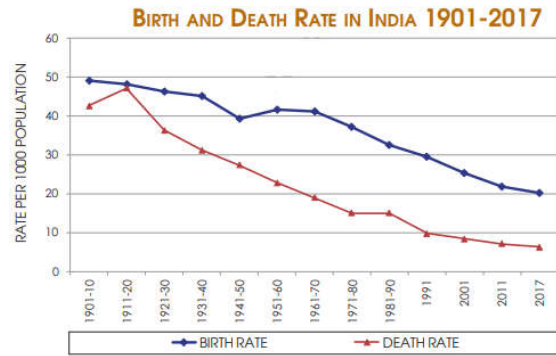
Actual growth of population = Births - Deaths + In Migration - Out Migration.

Population composition:
 Population composition is the description of a population according to characteristics such as age and sex. It provides a framework against which we can interpret the health status, economic and social behavior of the population.

Population growth trends in India:

The saga of growth of population in India is almost in tune with the popular theory of demographic transition. The distinct phases of the demographic history of India during the twentieth century is described below:

1. **Period of stagnant population (1901-1921):** The first two decades of the 20th century (1901-1921) were the period of stagnant population. During this period, both birth rate and death rate were high. Population growth was slow and fluctuating. There was high infant mortality; there was shortage of workers in agriculture; there was an epidemic, lack of clean water, war and no family planning. The population growth rate in 1921 over 1901 was only 5.42 percent. In fact, the census year 1921 registered negative growth rate of 0.31 percent which happened only once across all census periods since 1872. It is because of this decline in place of rise in population that the year 1921 is called the 'year of **demographic divide**' in the demographic history of India.
2. **Period of steady growth (1921-1951):** This duration of 30 years registered a population growth of 47.3 percent. During this stage, birth rate remained high, death rate decreased, and population grew steadily. There was improvement in health care (e.g., smallpox, plague, and vaccines), hygiene, sanitation, food supply, and decrease in infant mortality rates. Since crude death rate declined considerably and crude birth rate remained very high, the population growth during this period is called '**mortality induced growth**'.
3. **Period of rapid high growth (1951-1981):** This period experienced fall in the mortality rate but the fertility remained stubbornly high. Therefore, this period experienced very high rate of population growth and is often referred to as '**the period of population explosion**'. The unprecedented growth rate was due to the accelerated development activities and further improvement in health facilities. The living condition of people improved enormously. Death rates declined much faster than the birth.
4. **Period of high growth with definite signs of slowing down (1981-11):** This period has experienced high population growth but at a declining rate. The highest ever population growth rate of 2.48 percent was recorded in 1971 which remained at a high 2.46 in 1981 also. It declined to 2.38 percent in 1991, 2.15 percent in 2001 and further to 1.76 in 2011. During this period 1981-2011, the northern zone and the southern zone had the highest and lowest growth rates respectively.



Delimitation freeze of 1971:

Article 81 of the Constitution provided that each State shall be allotted seats in the Lok Sabha, in such manner that the ratio between that number and the population of the State is, so far as practicable, the same for all States. Further, population as per the last preceding Census was to be taken into account. The Northern Indian states were experiencing high population growth rates during that time, but the Southern States were able to control their population due to good policies. However, these states taking a lead in population control faced the prospect of their number of seats getting reduced, whereas States having higher population figures stood to gain by increase in the number of seats in Lok Sabha. To relieve this anxiety, Constitution (Forty-second Amendment) Act, 1976 effected a freeze on the population figure with reference to the 1971 Census for delimitation, until the year 2000. Constitution (Eighty-fourth Amendment), Act 2001 extended the deadline from 2000 to 2026.

Density and distribution of population in India:

The population of various states are generally compared in terms of density of population. Some parts of the country are densely populated, some parts moderately populated and some parts are sparsely populated. Density is defined as the number of persons per square kilometer. On the basis of varying density Indian states can be divided in following category:

1. **Areas of extremely low density:** Areas having **less than or up to 100 persons per sq. km** are included in this class. They include Arunachal Pradesh (17), Mizoram (52), Andaman and Nicobar Islands (46) and Sikkim (86).
2. **Areas of low density:** Areas having population density of **101 to 250 persons per sq. km** are included in this class. These states are Meghalaya (132), Manipur (122), Himachal Pradesh (123), Nagaland (119), Chhattisgarh (189), Uttarakhand (189), Rajasthan (201), and Madhya Pradesh (236). Meghalaya, Manipur, and Nagaland are hilly, forested areas while Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand are parts of the north-western Himalayan region and have very little level land to support high population density. Most of Rajasthan is a sandy desert lacking in water resources and does not support high population density. Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh have rugged topography, are thickly forested and largely inhabited by the tribal people.
3. **Areas of moderate density:** This class includes those areas which are having **251 to 500 persons per sq. km**. The average for whole of India (382 persons per sq. km) also falls in this class. Gujarat (308), Karnataka (319), Andhra Pradesh (308), Tripura (350), Maharashtra (365), Jharkhand (414), Assam (397) and Goa (394), are included in this category. There are different reasons for moderate density of population in different areas. For example, Assam has tea whereas Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka are highly urbanized and industrialized states. Jharkhand has agricultural and mineral resources. The state of Gujarat also has urban and industrial growth, although at a scale smaller than that of Maharashtra. Among the north eastern states, Tripura has sufficient levelled land which supports moderate population density.
4. **Areas of high density:** These are areas having population density of **501 to 1000 persons per sq. km**. Uttar Pradesh (828), Kerala (859), Tamil Nadu (555), Punjab (550), Haryana (573) and Dadra and Nagar Haveli (698) are included in this category. Punjab and Haryana have highly developed agriculture based on heavy inputs in the form of high yielding varieties of seeds, chemical fertilizers and canal and tube-well irrigation. Similarly, Tamil Nadu's population is based on agriculture and industries.
5. **Areas of very high density:** Areas **having more than 1000 persons per sq. km** are termed as areas of very high population density. Union Territories of Daman and Diu (1102), Lakshadweep (1204), Pondicherry (2598), Chandigarh (9252), Delhi (11297) and states of Bihar (1102) and West Bengal are areas of very high population. Delhi has experienced one of the fastest population growths as a result of which its population density has increased considerably. This growth is primarily due to large scale migration of people from the surrounding areas in search of livelihood, and better amenities of life. On an average, Delhi's population grows at an annual rate of 4 lakhs out of which 2.5 lakhs is on account of migration. It may be seen that the Eastern region i.e. West Bengal, Bihar etc. has by far the highest density and the North Eastern region the lowest. West Bengal is located in the Ganges delta which is one of the most fertile areas of the world, producing 3-4 crops of rice in a year. In addition, India's biggest industrial cluster is located in the Hugli basin. Eastern region has recorded the highest increase in density from 431 in 1991 to 525 in 2001 followed by Central region and Western region respectively.

Factors influencing distribution and density of population in India:

Population of India is not uniformly distributed. Various factors affect its distribution. They are:

1. **Landforms:** Landforms influence the distribution pattern of population, the most important attributes being- altitude and slope. The evidence of the influence of altitude and slope on population density and distribution has been observed between mountains and plains. For example, Indo-Gangetic plains are one of the most densely populated, while the highly mountainous state of Arunachal Pradesh is among the least densely populated ones. Other than this, factors like drainage, and water table also affect population distribution.
2. **Climate:** Climate, in the form of temperature conditions and the amount of precipitation, is one of the essential elements which influences the spatial distribution of population. Both hot and dry deserts of

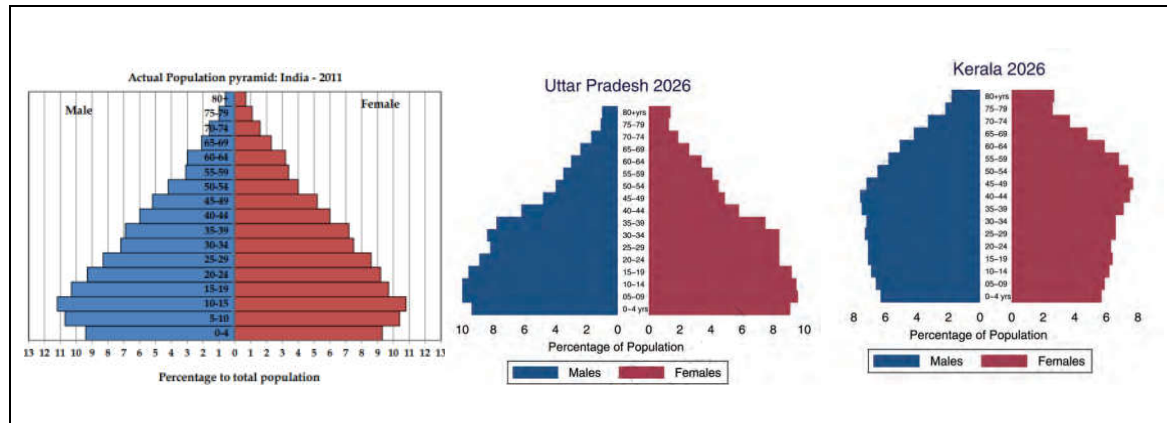
Rajasthan and the cold and wet Eastern Himalayan region are areas having extreme temperatures and hence uneven distribution and low density of population. Almost even distribution and high density of population is found in plains of Kerala and West Bengal where rainfall is high.

3. **Soil:** Soil is another factor which affects the density and distribution of population. Even today about 60-70 percent of the Indian population lives in villages. They earn their livelihood from agriculture and allied activities, which depend upon the quality of soil. This is why alluvial region of northern plains and coastal and deltaic regions of India continue to support high densities of population. Consequently, vast tracts of land in desert areas like Rajasthan, Rann of Kutch in Gujarat, Terai region in Uttarakhand continue to remain sparsely populated due to problems like soil erosion and soil efflorescence (salty depositions in soils) among others.
4. **Mineral resources:** Minerals act as a great source of attraction for people from different areas, due to their economic potential. This results in higher density of population which is evident from the Chhota Nagpur Plateau of Jharkhand and in the adjoining areas of Orissa, due to presence of mining industries.
5. **Industries:** Industrial growth offers massive employment opportunities and acts as a great magnet to attract people, particularly from the neighbouring areas. This results in higher population density. One hectare of industrial land is capable of supporting several thousand persons, while the most fertile area devoted to agriculture may not support more than a few hundred persons per hectare. One of the major causes of high population density in West Bengal, Bihar, Jharkhand, Orissa, Maharashtra and Gujarat is the phenomenal growth of industries in these states.
6. **Transport:** Growth of population is directly proportional to the development of transport facilities. The northern plain of India has a dense network of transport routes and therefore, is a densely populated region. The peninsular plateau has moderate network of transport route and is moderately populated. The Himalayan region badly lacks transport facilities and is sparsely populated.
7. **Urbanization:** Urbanization and population concentration go hand-in-hand and are closely related to each other. All the urban centres are marked by high density of population. The highly urbanized districts of Kolkata, Chennai, Greater Mumbai, Hyderabad, Delhi and Chandigarh have population densities of over 6,000 persons per sq. km.

Age Structure of Population

Age structure represents the **number of people of different age groups in the population**. This is an important indicator of population composition. For example, a large size of population in the age group of 15- 59 indicates a large working population; a greater proportion of population above 60 years represents an ageing population which requires more expenditure on health care facilities. Similarly, high proportion of young population would mean that the region has a high birth rate and the population is youthful. Planning for various social and physical amenities in a region also requires data on age distribution. The interrelations between age structure and a wide range of social, demographic, economic and political phenomena make the classification of a population by age groups especially important.

Figure shows the estimated population pyramids for Uttar Pradesh and Kerala in the year 2026. It is important to note the difference in the location of the widest parts of the pyramid for Kerala and Uttar Pradesh. While a state like Kerala is beginning to acquire an age structure like that of the developed countries, Uttar Pradesh presents a very different picture with high proportions in the younger age groups and relatively low proportions among the aged. India as a whole is somewhere in the middle, because it includes states like Uttar Pradesh as well as states that are more like Kerala.



6.3. Demographic dividend

The demographic dividend, as defined by the United Nations Population Fund (**UNFPA**) means, "the economic growth potential that can result from shifts in a population's age structure, mainly when the share of the working-age population (15 to 64) is larger than the non-working-age share of the population (14 and younger, and 65 and older). In other words, it is "a boost in economic productivity that occurs when there are growing numbers of people in the workforce relative to the number of dependents. This phenomenon occurs with a falling birth rate and the consequent shift in the age structure of the population towards the adult working age. Demographic dividend is also known as **demographic bonus or demographic window**.

It is clear from the above population pyramid that more than 60% of Indian population are in 15-59 age group which is working age group. A significant factor pointing to the demographic dividend is the declining dependency ratio. **Dependency is defined as the percentage of the dependent population (0 -14 and 60 and above age groups.) divided by the working age population (15-59 age groups).** The dependency ratio was more than 0.9 in 1971. It fell to 0.8 in 1991, 0.73 in 2001 and was expected to further decline sharply to 0.59 in 2011 as per the technical group on population projections. This decline sharply contrasts with the demographic trend in the industrialized countries, where dependency ratio is rising. The age structure of the population presents an unprecedented opportunity to India and this has been called India's **demographic dividend**.

Higher percentage of population in working age group and lower dependency ratio has a **positive impact on economic growth**. The demographic dividend that accrues to a country will automatically **generate capital resources** that the country needs for investment purpose. This is due to the reason that the size of surplus available for investment after current consumption depends on the ratio of actual workforce to those who are outside the workforce. With the decline in fertility, more women are likely to enter into the labour market resulting in increased economic activity. One of the major hurdles for women entering the labour market had been high fertility rates and time spent on child care. A decline in fertility allows women to spend more time on economic activities. This is expected to give a spurt to economic growth. People also invest more on their own health when children are fewer in number, leading to better productivity and economic benefits to the household.

The demographic dividend is often cited as one of the reasons for high growth in East Asia. According to the UN's data, China's dependency ratio declined from 68% in 1980 to 36% by 2010, a drop of 32 percentage points. In contrast, the decline in India's dependency ratio over the same period was a much lower 20.8 percentage points. Japan's dependency ratio fell from 67.6% in 1950 to 45.3% in 1970—this was a period of very rapid growth in Japan. Similarly, South Korea's dependency ratio fell from 83.3% in 1970 to 40.6% in 1995, a period in which the country notched up very high growth rates.

China's shift from one-child to three-child policy:

China has announced that it will allow couples to have up to three children after census data showed a steep decline in birth rates. China's One-Child Policy was announced in 1980 by then-leader Deng Xiaoping. The policy was adopted out of fear that unchecked population growth would lead to economic and environmental catastrophe. It was also a response to concerns about food shortages. The policy was implemented through several means. Such as, incentivizing families financially to have one child, making contraceptives widely available and imposing sanctions against those who violated the policy. However, the policy was also a source of discontent as the state used brutal tactics such as forced abortions and sterilizations. It was a controversial policy as it violated human rights. It was also unfair to poorer Chinese since the richer ones could afford to pay economic sanctions if they violated the policy.

The policy has been blamed for making China's population aged faster than other countries, impacting the country's growth potential. It is also suggested that because of the one-child policy, China would be unable to reap the full benefits of its economic growth and will need other ways to support it. As a result, in 2016,



China relaxed its One Child Policy. It allowed two children per couple. However, the policy change did little to change the rapid fall in population growth. According to Census 2020, around 12 million babies were born in 2020. This is a significant decrease from the 18 million in 2016 and also the lowest number of births recorded since the 1960s. Hence, this was the reason why China has now relaxed its two-child policy and has allowed couples to have up to three children. The experts have said that relaxing limits on reproductive rights alone cannot go a long way in averting an unwanted demographic shift. Rising costs of living, education and supporting ageing parents, country's pervasive

culture of long working hours and a culture shift with many couples believing that one child is enough and some expressing no interest in having children are some of the other reasons for fewer children being born in China.

Challenge for India in reaping the demographic dividend:

Demographic dividend is a one-time window of opportunity for any country. This window of opportunity, though presently available to India, can be rendered irrelevant because almost half of the working age population is not empowered enough to make a difference. Not directing this huge resource base into productive tasks can lead to unemployment and social unrest. For instance, unemployment was a major reason for protests, rebellions and civil war that led to Arab Spring in early 2010s. The population report asserts that the lack of education and women empowerment is like a vicious cycle that needs to be broken if the country wants to use the window and avoid a demographic disaster. India faces huge challenges in reaping the benefit of demographic dividend, some of which are mentioned in the following section.

Poor human capital, as reflected in the recently released World Bank report on **Global Human Capital Index rankings** (2018), where India currently ranks 115th out of 157 nations (China being 46th, Malaysia 55th) is one of the most important concerns. According to the report, a child born in India is likely to be only 44% productive when (s)he grows up and if (s)he receives education and adequate healthcare. India, in comparison to other developing economies, does poorly in its ability to expand overall productivity with a rise in GDP per capita. According to UNDP's **Human Development Index** of 2017, India also ranks low at 130 out of the 189 countries in overall human development. In 2015, India added the **fewest** organized-sector jobs - in large companies and factories - in seven years across eight important industries. The proportion of jobs in the

unorganized sector (without formal monthly payment or social security benefits) has risen to 93 percent in 2017. Rural wages are at a decadal low, as agriculture - which accounts for 47 percent of jobs - contracted 0.2 percent in 2014-15 and grew at just 1-2% in subsequent years.

As many as 60 percent of those with jobs remain unemployed for most of the year, indicating widespread 'under-employment' and temporary jobs. Even the setting up of new companies has slowed to 2009 levels, and existing companies are growing at 2 per cent, the lowest in five years. With large corporations and public-sector banks financially stressed, the average size of companies in India is reducing, at a time when well-organized large companies are central to creating jobs." According to data from International Labour Organization and World Bank, India's female labour force participation rates have fallen from 30% in 1990 to 27 % in 2013. This has further declined to 23.7 % in 2016, as per the data from the Labour Ministry. Sociocultural factors, improving school enrollments for girls and rising family incomes have been identified as the main reasons for this decline.

The condition of education sector at all level paints a very grim picture. According to ASER report a large proportion of students in both government and private schools continue to be below the 'Grade level'. Grade level means that a student can deal with what is expected of her in that grade. Moreover, No Indian University find its place in TOP 100 World University Ranking, reflecting the poor condition of quality education and learning gap among the students. Amidst the tens of thousands of management graduates churned out by the 5,500 B-schools in the country, only 7 per cent turn out to be employable, says a study conducted by ASSOCHAM.

Discuss the changes in the trends of labour migration within and outside India in the last four decades. (UPSC 2015)

What needs to be done?

A critical requirement for reaping demographic dividend is ensuring that all people have the rights and freedoms to define their lives, can pursue an education of their choice, join the productive workforce, and accrue wealth. These rights and freedoms respond to the potential in all persons, including those suffering from discrimination, stigma, and exclusion. Enriching opportunities for all persons at the individual level contributes to the economic growth of households, communities and the nation. India currently spends a little over 1 % of GDP on Health. Government **expenditure on health needs to be increased** so that health and efficiency of labor force can be improved. To be able to harness the potential of this large working population, which is growing leaps and bounds, **generation of new jobs** is a necessity. The nation needs to create ten million jobs per year to absorb the addition of young people into the workforce.

The current situation requires for the overhauling of overall education sector and create avenues for augmenting social and human capital. This can be done through investment in infrastructure and correcting the teacher-student ratio. The government must also ensure better quality of jobs with a focus on matching skill-sets and job opportunities. At present around 65% of population are below 35 years of age and only 2 percent of them are skilled. India needs a comprehensive plan to skill her workforce and make the best of her demographic potential.

Recent measures taken by the government:

The government has formulated a number of policies to realize the growth potential of India, such as:

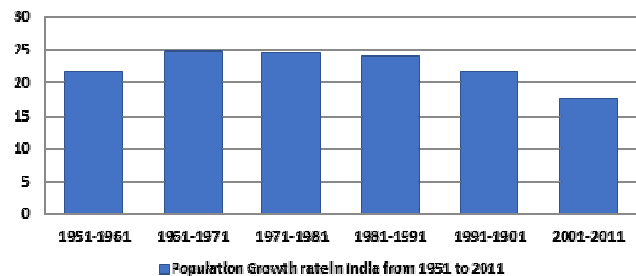
1. **Increasing labour productivity:** providing vocational training under '**Kaushal Bharat Kusal Bharat Yojana**'; improving expertise of people from minority communities in their traditional arts under USTAAD scheme; enhancing the skills under Skill India Mission; and accreditation of acquired skills.

2. **Improving employability:** Initiatives such as **SETU (Self-employment and talent utilization)** and **Atal Innovation Mission** help in fostering innovation; Schemes as Start-up India, Stand-up India strive towards developing entrepreneurship potential in people.
3. **Improving educational performance:** Initiatives as **SWAYAM** (Massive Open Online Courses) provide quality education to large number of students by improving availability, accessibility and affordability of quality content.
4. **Focus on low-income population:** Initiatives as **Grameen kaushal vikas yojana** focus on skilling rural people in agro-allied industry; Schemes as **Nai Manzil** provide integrated input of formal education and skill training along with certification.
5. **Women's employment:** As demographic transition results in greater women coming into the workforce, relaxed age limit for higher education, **Nai Roshni scheme** focusing on improving leadership qualities of women, **increase in maternity leave** etc. have been taken by the government.
6. **National Health Policy 2017** has been enacted, which aims at increasing government expenditure on health from the existing 1.1% of GDP to 2.5% by 2025. Other objectives of aforesaid Health Policy which will help in reaping the demographic dividend are:
 - a. Increase Life Expectancy at birth from 67.5 to 70 by 2025.
 - b. Reduction of TFR to 2.1 at national and sub-national level by 2025.
 - c. Reduce under five mortality to 23 by 2025 and MMR from current levels to 100 by 2025.

6.4. Rapid population growth and its after-effects in India

Rapid population growth often leads to overpopulation in countries like India. It refers to an undesirable condition where human population exceeds the available natural resources for feeding and sustenance. India is one of the most populous countries of the world. But our country covers only **2.4 percent of the land area of the world**, while it is home to more than **17 percent of the world's population**. Our population is almost equal to the combined population of the USA, Indonesia, Brazil, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Japan put together. If we look at the area of the major countries of the world, Russian federation is more than five times, Canada is over three times, the USA is 2.8 times, Brazil is 2.6 times and Australia is 2.3 times as large as India. But their combined population is only 63 percent of the total population of India. This huge population of India with limited land area puts pressure on the natural resources of the country which gets manifested in the form of poverty, malnutrition, environmental hazard and social inequalities.

Population Growth rate in India from 1951 to 2011



Rapid population growth is the bane for the economies of underdeveloped, poor and developing countries. It leads to **over-exploitation of natural resources, unequal distribution of wealth and income, and creates a vicious cycle of illiteracy, unemployment and poverty**. Many feel forced to migrate to distant lands for economic, social and ecological needs. Other similar problems generated by overpopulation include food and nutrition problems, housing problems, starvation and famine, infectious diseases and epidemics, population pressure on cities and expansion of slums, decrease in agricultural productivity, continuous destruction of forests, threat to environment and wildlife, political instability, war, social evils and corruption, etc.

Critically examine whether growing population is the cause of poverty OR poverty is the main cause of population increase in India. (UPSC 2015)

The Economic Survey 2017-18 has taken note of a peculiar behavioral pattern among Indian parents who prefer to have children “until the desired number of sons are born.” Calling this the “**son meta-preference**,” the Survey found that while an average Indian family prefers to have two children, there are instances where families have more than five children if the last child is not a male. This meta preference leads naturally to the notional category of unwanted girls which is estimated at over 21 million, while keeping population growth high.

6.5. Population control

Among the various reasons for most of the problems associated with providing healthcare and employment, social security etc., population growth is one of the factors. It is imperative for the government to take affirmative action to curb population growth. Government has taken various initiatives to control population. The details of the schemes to restrict the ever-increasing population in India are given below:

1. **Mission Parivar Vikas** has been launched to increase access to contraceptives and Family Planning services in 146 high fertility districts.
2. **Introduction of New Contraceptive Choices:** The current basket of choice has been expanded to include the new contraceptives viz. Injectable contraceptive, Centchroman and Progesterone Only Pills (POP).
3. **Redesigned Contraceptive Packaging:** The packaging for Condoms, Oral Contraceptive Pills (OCPs) and Emergency Contraceptive Pills (ECPs) has now been improved and redesigned.
4. **New Family Planning Media Campaign** has been launched to generate demand for contraceptives.
5. **Family Planning logistics management information system** has been developed to track Family Planning commodities.
6. **Enhanced Compensation Scheme for Sterilization:** The sterilization compensation scheme has been enhanced in 11 high focus states which includes Assam, Gujarat, Haryana apart from 8 Empowered Action Group (EAG).

Empowered Action Group (EAG)

EAG refers to eight socioeconomically backward states of Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Orissa, Rajasthan, Uttarakhand and Uttar Pradesh that lag behind in the demographic transition and have the highest infant mortality rates in the country.

7. **Clinical Outreach Team Scheme** - The scheme has been launched in 146 Mission Parivar Vikas districts for providing Family planning services through mobile teams from accredited organizations in far-flung, underserved and geographically difficult areas.
8. **A Scheme for Home delivery of contraceptives by ASHAs** to provide contraceptives at the doorstep of beneficiaries is in operation.
9. **World Population Day (11 July)** & fortnight as well as Vasectomy Fortnight is observed every year to boost Family Planning efforts all over the country.
10. **Strategies Adopted by Jansankhya Sthirata Kosh/National Population Stabilization Fund for Population Control:** The Government of India had set up a National Population Stabilization Fund (NPSF) in the year 2004-05 with a one-time grant of Rs.100 crore in the form of a corpus fund. This is now known as Jansankhya Sthirata Kosh (JSK). To empower the NPSF, Government of India has set up Jansankhya Sthirata Kosh (JSK). This is an autonomous body registered under the Societies Registration Act, 1860. JSK can take all the policy related decisions. It can raise contributions from organisations and individuals that support population stabilisation. JSK implements two schemes, namely, Santushti and Prerna.
11. **Prerna Strategy:** J&K has launched this strategy for helping to push up the age of marriage of girls and

delay in first child and spacing in second child birth in the interest of health of young mothers and infants. The couple who adopts this strategy awarded suitably. This helps to change the mindsets of the community.

12. **Santushti Strategy:** Under this strategy, Jansankhya Sthirata Kosh, invites private sector gynaecologists and vasectomy surgeons to conduct sterilization operations in Public Private

India being the first country to introduce family planning programme in 1952 and subsequently the National population policy has seen high strides in the realm of family planning. Because of government initiatives, the **decadal growth rate has declined** significantly from **21.15% in census 2001 to 17.64% in census 2011**. Moreover, the Crude Birth Rate (CBR) has reduced from 23.1 to 19, Total Fertility Rate (TFR) has reduced from 2.6 to 2.2 and Total Unmet Need has reduced from 13.9 to 12.9 from NFHS 3 (2005-06) to NFHS 4 (2015-16). The recent National Family health survey also points out improvement in the family planning services and reproductive rights. The institutional deliveries have improved to 79%. However, despite these demographic strides family planning in India has raised several issues as it lacks voluntariness, equality and choices.

The family planning strategy is largely based on persuasion and is target driven. For instance, mass sterilization campaigns are held where targets are set and involve mainly the poor women. Widespread illiteracy and knowledge about family planning services prevents informed and voluntary decision making. Gender discrimination in family planning is reflected from the fact that female sterilization remains the most prevalent method of population control. For example, in case of sterilisation, as per 2014 figures from the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, 1.48 lakh women were sterilised as opposed to 5,004 men in India. Besides the patriarchal bias towards women, there are also misconceptions related to male sterilization. There are very limited choices available for family planning, in the form of very few contraceptive options, compounded by lack of access to them. As per the National Family Health Survey 2015-16 (NFHS-4), 12.9% women do not have access to contraceptives that they need. The government is also taking several initiatives to make family planning informed and voluntary.

1. **Vision family planning 2020**, has been launched as India is a signatory to the London summit on family planning. Its aim is to provide improved access to contraceptive services to an additional 48 million users, aversion of 23.9 million births, 1 million infants deaths and over 42000 maternal deaths by 2020. The initiative is based on promoting informed choices and voluntary decision as a central theme of family planning policy.
2. Initiatives like **Antara** an injectable contraceptive programme has been launched to broaden the choices.

The National health policy 2017 and the Sustainable development goals to which India is committed to advocates equality and rights-based approach to health and family services. Besides the above measure there is need to involve NGO, SHGs and other community level organisations to improve knowledge, provide counselling and create demand for family planning services. As stable population is a basic need for the all-round development of a country, family planning strategy has to be based on the principles of equality, freedom, voluntariness and access to family planning services has to be seen as a matter of right than privilege.

A new population policy released by the Uttar Pradesh government aims to bring fertility levels down. It also aims to create a population balance among various communities. Also, a draft of the Uttar Pradesh Population (Control, Stabilisation, and Welfare) Bill, 2021 has been released, which states that any citizen who “violates” a two-child policy would be barred from contesting local bodies polls, applying for, or getting promotion in, government jobs, and receiving government subsidies. The State’s new population policy and draft law try to use punishment as a tool to control fertility levels, which disproportionately targets the poor vis-à-vis the rich population. However, evidence shows that focusing on education and empowerment of

women can yield better results, as seen in southern states. Also, the aim of establishing a population balance among communities might breed polarisation and communal disharmony in the state. Moreover, the National Family Health Survey (NFHS) and Census data show that in most states, and many urban areas, the total fertility rate (TFR) has already reached replacement levels (2.1). On a national level, TFR has declined from 3.4 in 1994 to 2.2 in 2015. Decadal growth rates have declined across all religious communities, with the fertility rate falling faster among Muslims than in Hindus. The success of India's southern states in containing population growth indicates that economic growth, as well as attention to education, health, and empowerment of women, work far better to dis-incentivize larger families than punitive measures.

Population control vs Population development:

Emphasis on population control diverts the conversation from the need to focus on improving the quality of life. Issues like poverty, social and health services cannot be combated with a one-stop excuse of population control. It deflects attention from the emerging need to invest resources in education, health and skill development of young people. It also undermines the reality of population trends with several states having or approaching replacement level or lower fertility rates. Coercive methods of family planning undermine the rights of women on bodily autonomy. Such an approach also contributes to other social problems such as gender-biased sex selection and a skewed sex ratio.

Instead of coercive methods of population control, family planning programmes should emphasize on sex education, usage of contraceptives and ensuring quality sexual and reproductive health services. Governments must work on the education and empowerment of women and respect their choices and **reproductive rights**. Quality of education, life skills, healthcare and vocational training must be upgraded in order to address the issue of employment and livelihood concerns. There is a need to understand the dynamics of migration flows to address the issues of housing and infrastructure, health care and utilities, education and skills. Coordination and cooperation between central, state and local agencies is equally essential important for targeted and effective implementation of various social schemes. The two-pronged approach of health system strengthening and population control may be justified on balance of interests.

“Empowering women is the key to control population growth.” Discuss. (UPSC 2019)

6.6. National Population Policy

National population policy was launched in 2000 to stabilize population size in order to promote sustainable development with more equitable distribution. It is based on voluntary and informed choice, and consent of citizens while availing of reproductive healthcare services. It simultaneously also addresses the issue of child survival and maternal health. India was the first country in the world to launch a national programme in 1952 emphasizing on population control and family planning. Population policy since 1952 has followed **different approaches** ranging from **Gandhian persuasion-based approach** to **camp approach** where **sterilization** programs were introduced.

National Population Policy, 2000 has following salient features:

1. Focus on **both aspects** of population control -**limiting the family size** as well as **ensuring proper spacing** between children.
2. **Timeline** based objectives –
 - a. **Immediate objective** is to **address the unmet needs** for **contraception**, health care **infrastructure**, and health **personnel**, and to provide **integrated service delivery** for basic reproductive and child health care.

- b. **Mid-term objective** is to bring the **TFR to replacement levels (2.1)** by 2010, through vigorous implementation of inter-sectoral operational strategies.
- c. **Long-term objective** is to achieve a **stable population** by 2045, at a level consistent with the requirements of sustainable economic growth, social development, and environmental protection.
- 3. **Targeting youth** (targets to be achieved by 2010)-
 - a. Making school **education** up to age 14 free and compulsory.
 - b. Promote **delayed marriage** for girls, not earlier than age 18 and preferably after 20 years of age.
 - c. Achieve universal access to **information/counselling**, and services for fertility regulation and contraception with a **wide basket of choices**.
- 4. Focus on **child and mother health** (targets to be achieved by 2010):
 - a. Reduce **IMR** to below 30 per thousand, achieve universal **immunization**.
 - b. Reduce **MMR** to below 100 per lakh, achieve 80% **institutional deliveries** and 100% deliveries by trained persons.

However, National population policy has not been successful in checking population growth as was envisaged by the planners. For a diverse country like India, **top down approach** is **not suitable** as social mobilization and social consciousness is shaped by people's religion, regional values etc. **Family planning** in India is **not gender neutral** and there is "**son-meta preference**" among families leading to continuous birth of girl child until a boy is born. In order to change these behavioural patterns, policy needs a bottom up approach. Moreover, the issues of lack of infrastructure, shortage of doctors and medical staff and affordability of preventive procedures like tubectomy, vasectomy, etc. continue to ail Indian healthcare system. The coercive programs adopted earlier, like sterilization camps led to politicization of the issue and also alienated the people. There was backlash against the policy, instead of support from the public.

The intended targets of the policy have been the poor, marginalized caste groups and females who have been coerced to undergo sterilization and thus presents the prejudice against such groups. Policy also failed to address root causes of population rise in terms of poverty alleviation, improvement in standard of living, better education and focused on monetary incentives approach for population control. Monetary tools for success of policies are not the game changers as they do not change the religious values as well as the social behaviour of people easily. Role of other stakeholders like panchayats and research institutes have also **not been specified** in the policy which has prevented decentralization of policy implementation to grass-root levels.

Nevertheless, National population policy has **partially achieved its target** as **rate of decadal growth** of population has **declined** significantly from 21.5% for the period 1991-2001 to 17.7% during 2001-2011 and **TFR** has **declined** from 3.2 in 2000 to 2.3 in 2013. It has to be kept in mind that population control is as much a function of making **reproductive health care accessible and affordable** for all, as of increasing the provision and outreach of primary and secondary **education**, extending **basic amenities** including **sanitation**, safe **drinking water** and **housing**, besides **empowering women** and enhancing their **employment opportunities**.

It is noteworthy that the National Population Policy document indicates that India's population and that of every state in India would be stabilized by 2040, that is, the TFR would become 2.1. There is no doubt that India will be the most populous country of the world by 2030. But India will also have the largest young population in the world. To unleash the full potential of the young population, policies must focus on the population development approach (i.e., better education, better health services, skill development and better standard of living), in order to reap the benefits of demographic dividend. After all, development is the best contraceptive.

7. REGIONALISM, COMMUNALISM, SECULARISM

7.1. Regionalism

Regionalism is defined as a **strong feeling of love and patriotism** towards a particular region or state within a country, to an extent that it is far different from and sometimes exceeds the love for and interest of the nation. It is the ideology of focusing on social, political and economic interest of a particular region and is encouraged when a particular identity marker is concentrated in a geographical region. It has a tendency to **militate against nationalism** and **impede the process of national integration**. A preference of a region over nation produces a sense of sub-nationalism and threatens balkanization or political division of one Nation into many.

However, regionalism also has a positive side. It is a political attribute associated with people's love and loyalty for their region, culture, language, etc. with a view to maintain their independent identity. People cherish and celebrate their cultural diversity including language, food, festivals etc. For example, people of Punjab celebrate Baisakhi while people of Kerala celebrate Onam. Such feelings for one's region can very well be in line with the feeling of patriotism for the larger nation. For example, a feeling among people of being proud of their identities as a **Tamil, a Punjabi, a Bengali or a Gujarati is not contrary to patriotism**, until and unless they are less proud of being Indian or are hostile to people from other regions, thus keeping regional love above the love for the nation. Further, looking after a region's benefits like dealing with poverty and increasing industrialization or providing lucrative offers to industries to attract them there, does not qualify as regionalism unless it is being done to harm other states. India is a country with wide diversity and plurality. Regionalism is a common phenomenon resulting from this diversity. Some experts argue that regionalism manifested in coalition politics has made Indian democracy stronger and more representative.

Regionalism is a phenomenon that **precedes the independence** of the nation. During the independence struggle, regionalism was not seen as a disruptive force to the idea of India as a nation, even though the Indian National Congress wanted to develop a sense of national unity among people, irrespective of the province of an individual. This is evident from the fact that the provinces in British India were drawn out of administrative convenience, yet the national movement rejected these divisions as artificial and promised linguistic principle as the basis of formation of states. In fact, in the Nagpur session, Provincial Congress Committees were formed on the basis of linguistic zones and did not coincide with the administrative divisions of the time. **The bitter experience of partition** created a general feeling of aversion towards regionalism in the minds of founding fathers of India. They felt carving out of states based on regional factors like language might act as a barrier in the process of nation building and might lead to disintegration. The prevalent idea among the political commentators at the time that a diverse nation like India would not survive added to the pressure. Since then **regionalism has manifested in the following ways:**

1. **Drawing of state boundaries:** The Dhar Commission and JVP Committee rejected the linguistic province and this triggered the Vishal Andhra movement. After the death of Sriramulu the Centre was forced to carve out a separate Andhra state on the basis of language. Fazl Ali Commission broadly accepted the language as the basis of reorganization of states and eventually more reorganization followed.
2. **Regional Disparities:** Regionalism was effective in mobilizing people to protest against disparities among the regions of India and states like Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Telangana were drawn. States like Andhra Pradesh have also been demanding of Special Category status to fulfill the regional aspirations of the people. Also, there is an apparent identity divide between the North and South Indian states owing to their distinct cultures, languages, development status, etc.

3. **Secession from Indian Union:** Secession from Indian Union typically refers to state secession, which is the withdrawal of one or more states from the Republic of India. Examples include the Khalistan movement, post-independence efforts of Nawab of Junagadh and Nizam of Hyderabad to secede from India, Dravida Nadu Movement, etc. The 1980s saw a rise of regional aspiration outside the framework of the state as seen in Punjab, Jammu and Kashmir and North- East. In fact, on the issue of Citizenship amendment bill, people in Mizoram protested via threatening to accede to China.
4. **Inter-state river water disputes:** The inter-state river water disputes are one of the most contentious issues of the Indian federalism today. For example, Cauvery water dispute between Tamil Nadu and Karnataka, Mandovi river dispute between Karnataka and Maharashtra and Godavari river water dispute between Telangana and Andhra Pradesh. In extreme cases, they hamper the relationship between the disputing states. For instance, riots had erupted after Supreme Court ordered Karnataka to release water from the Cauvery river to Tamil Nadu.
5. **Inter-state boundary disputes:** Boundary disputes have arisen out of the formation of linguistic states as in the case of Belgaum (between Maharashtra and Karnataka) and Chandigarh (between Punjab and Haryana), or due to ethnic and tribal fault lines as between Assam and Mizoram. In August 2021, clashes between Assam and Mizoram police led to firing on the inter-state boundary, which left at least 6 Assam police personnel dead and over 50 injured.
6. **Sons of the soil doctrine:** This doctrine ties people to their place of birth, calling them 'sons of the soil' and treats all others who live in that region as later settlers, occupiers and outsiders. There is fear among locals that outsiders will outnumber them threatening their demography, cultural and social life. For example, in Nagaland, the Nagas feel threatened by the arrival of Kukis and Meiteis. Even during COVID crisis, Chief Minister of Delhi raised concern that treatment to citizens living in Delhi was getting delayed at the city's hospitals due to 'outsiders' coming for cheaper treatment. The 'sons of the soil' movements have been more virulent in regions when there is actual or potential competition for industrial and middle-class jobs, between the migrants and the local youth, or due to a general scarcity of well-paying jobs. For example, the slogan of 'Maharashtra for the Maharashtrians' that was used to target migrants around 2008. Marathi natives staged massive demonstrations and protests against the migrants of UP and Bihar who would provide cheap labor and were perceived to be taking away the job of natives.

Other factors giving rise to regionalism:

Regionalism is a strong attachment to one's own region. In addition to the regionalist manifestations mentioned above, it is a complex amalgamation of geographical, historical, cultural, economic, politico-administrative and psychological factors. For example, some states and regions are better in terms of development like infrastructure, healthcare, job opportunities, standards of living, etc. Such **economic inequality** can give birth to sub-regional movements. In fact, many people argue that the problem of Naxalism has its roots in economic deprivation of people belonging to regions that have remained beyond the pale of development. Even the formation of states like Jharkhand and Telangana was based on lack of development and unequal distribution of financial resources. Development deficit between economically prosperous Western Maharashtra and drought prone area in Vidarbha region of Eastern Maharashtra has given rise to demands for Vidarbha state.

Indian politics and **political parties** are also very much responsible for regionalism in India. Regional parties and local leaders use the regional sentiments in order to capture power and this helps in preparing the ground for regionalism. They often project an imaginary threat from outsiders and promise their vote bank about securing their land, jobs and culture from outsiders. For example, regional parties like ADMK and AIDMK in Tamil Nadu secured power by **promoting regional sentiments**. While some political movements arise from a demand of greater autonomy within a state. For instance, the demand for Gorkhaland in North Bengal districts, is to gain political autonomy from the State government, thus giving rise to regionalism.

In a diverse country like India **regionalism** finds its essence in multiple languages, cultures, tribes and religions. Languages can help in integrating people and in providing emotional attachment to one's culture. Sometimes this emotional attachment translates into the demand for linguistic states. Language related riots have also taken place in past such as the anti-Hindi agitations in Tamil Nadu during 1950s and 60s. Moreover, culture of Indian population varies with respect to region. When a citizen from other cultural group offends these traditions or shows cultural insensitivity, there arises the seeds of conflict. **Caste system** also acts as an axis of consolidation for people. Caste attributes differing social status to different sections of the population which can create regional grievances. For Example, **the Vanniyars of North Tamil Nadu have been demanding a separate state based on caste identity**. India has a lot of ethnic diversity in different regions. **These ethnic differences** have at times formed the basis for **demanding political autonomy and sometimes secession**. For example, the **Nagas of Nagaland** are demanding a state based on their ethnic identity. Such demands often take the form of violent armed struggle with established parallel governments.

Heading to sub-regional demands leads to domino effect and unnecessary fragmentation and administrative challenges. Moreover, violence, politicization and disturbance to law and order deters investors, undercuts potential for industrial development and hampers supply and demand. For example, North Bengal's economy which is based on tea and tourism industries, slumped during Gorkhaland demands in 2017. Modern industry requires a large market of goods and factors of production, which only a united India, with freedom of mobility, employment and residence can provide. Such demands also lead to acrimonious relationship between different sections of society based on ethnicity, language etc. threatening the unity and integrity of India. For example, there was severe competition between Haryana and Punjab after creation of Haryana in 1966.

However, regionalism has helped in **deepening** federalism in India. It can be seen from the fact that even during the era of one party system of Congress, the regional aspirations forced the Centre to form a new state. It has also helped in ushering in the era of **coalition** politics where regional political parties held power in the Parliament as seen during the NDA and UPA alliances. It has led to democratic **decentralization** within the state as well, for example Ladakh was given the divisional status in Jammu and Kashmir and finally was created as a separate Union Territory. Democracy allows regional aspirations and does not look at them as anti-national, given that the aspirations are within the framework of Constitution. Thus in course of democratic politics regional aspirations get strengthened. But, regional demands should not manifest in narrow sense as seen during the separatist movements and any disagreement must be ironed out with democratic dialogue and negotiations. Regionalism can in fact play a uniting force, like linguistic reorganization of states gave a uniform basis of drawing state boundaries and underlined the acceptance of principle of diversity.

Single time-zone across India:

For over a century, India has observed a single time zone. Due to the sheer size of the country, this has significant impacts on some of India's states, particularly in the Northeast. Leaders from the region argue that a separate time zone would increase daylight savings and efficiency. In the Northeast, the sun rises as early as four in the morning and in winter it sets by four in the evening. By the time government offices or educational institutions open, many daylight hours are already lost. In winter this problem gets even more accentuated and the ecological costs are a disaster with much more electricity having to be consumed. National Institute of Advanced Studies claim that advancing IST by half an hour would result in saving 2.7 billion units of electricity every year. None of the other proposals such as the introduction of daylight saving time in India has met with any approval and it is felt that having two time zones would be unsuitable.

Experts are of the opinion that two time zones are not advisable for India as it would cause '**unimaginable chaos**', given the country's demographic size. People would have to adjust to multiple time zones & administrative integration would be difficult. Also, India's lifeline, **the railways is not yet automated**

enough to handle time shifts mid-journey and this could induce major accidents due to human error. There is also a strong **political dimension** to granting a separate time zone in the Northeast given the region's long history of self-determination movements. The unstated assumption is that the grant of a different time zone is only the **first temporal step towards conceding spatial autonomy**.

Day light saving in north eastern states can be allowed to advance their clocks by some time (0.5-1 hour) to save more daylight hours. The move will not mean that time will slow down. But, the perception will change, and it would imply a delayed sunset. This will allow the citizens to make use of added daylight hours. For instance, **Chai Bagaan time** or tea time is an informal practice followed in tea gardens in Assam which is an hour ahead of IST.

1. Do you agree that regionalism in India appears to be a consequence of rising cultural assertiveness? Argue. (UPSC 2020)
2. Ever rising demand for new states reinforces the fact that the state's reorganization is still an unfinished job. In the light of this statement states how demand for new states threatens the economic development, unity and integrity of India?
3. Regionalism on one hand promotes cultural diversity and political autonomy while on the other hand it creates barriers to movement of people across different states defying the constitutional norms. Discuss.
4. What is the basis of regionalism? Is it that unequal distribution of benefits of development on regional basis eventually promotes regionalism? Substantiate your answer. (UPSC 2016)
5. Growing feeling of regionalism is an important factor in the generation of demand for a separate state. Discuss. (UPSC 2013)

Overcoming Regionalism:

The road to overcoming radical regionalism begins with overcoming regional inequalities. **Freight Equalization Policy** was introduced by the government right after independence with an apparently good intention of ensuring equal industrial growth in all the regions of the country by subsidizing the movement of naturally occurring ores and minerals from one state/region to another. But this had the unintended dampening effect on the growth of industrialisation in the Eastern states like Bihar, West Bengal and Odisha since it weakened the incentives for private sector to establish production facilities in these areas. The **1956 Industrial Policy resolution** also highlighted that securing a balanced and coordinated development of the industrial and agricultural economy in each region can reduce regional inequality. Government incentives were therefore provided to the private sector to invest in backward areas through subsidies, tax concessions, licenses, permits and institutional loans at subsidized rates. Nationalization of Banks in 1969 and 1980 was done to promote financial inclusion in backward regions. Various Finance Commissions have tried to reduce disparity among states by preferential treatment to the poorer states and recommending them more grant allocation. Planning was used as an important tool to remove regional inequality and different five-year plans were adopted to overcome inequality.

Migration of unskilled labour from the backward regions also contributes to regional disparity, but creates its own social, cultural and psychological cost for the migrants and their families. This can be mitigated by increasing ecosystem support for education, social and cultural security for such families and individuals. Schemes such as MGNREGA have been proved to have moderated inter-state migration at least partially by making economic opportunities available in close vicinity. Finance Commission can play an important role in bridging the gap of inequality. The focus should be given on Special Area Development Programme and expanding access to basic services. Aspirational District Programme is a step in the right direction, but

eventually there is no alternative to industrial investments in under-served regions if the question of regional inequality has to be addressed substantially.

Apart from government steps to reduce inequalities, even political parties should try to avoid partisanship. The appeals made to the electorate based on regional identity must be stopped. They should aim at bringing a national unity instead of pandering to factional interests. Some of the campaigns of government can also help in overcoming the regional factor such as **Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat; Swadesh Darshan etc.** The role of **National Integration council** must be revamped to address the problems of regionalism in India. Creating strong **interdependence among states** would help as each state would see another state as a partner in development.

We have seen how regionalism could be good or bad for a nation as well for a group of nations. Constitution of India under **Article-19** gives every citizen a fundamental right to move around and settle down peacefully in any part of the country. And, as a citizen of India, everyone should respect this fundamental right of every person and avoid stoking xenophobic passions, as a narrow regional outlook will doom our people to poverty. On the other hand, an integrative approach will enable social and economic development, the spread of education and further deepening of democracy to solve the issues underlying regional sentiments. The need of the hour is to develop each region of India, through devolution of power to local governments and empowering people for their participation in decision-making.

7.2. Communalism

Communalism - in a broad sense - means 'related to' or 'shared by' a community. However, it has a different context in India. It is a strong attachment to one's own community, and feeling of **antagonism, hatred and hostility** towards other communities or any specific community. The community could be based on region, religion, language or any other identity, but often religion is the fundamental distinction that overrides all other communal identities. Communalism is based on a belief that people following different religions have **irreconcilable social, political and economic interests**. It has the following characteristics:

1. Communalism views one's **own group** as the only **legitimate and worthy group**, while other groups are held as inferior and illegitimate. This drives one towards promoting orthodox tenets, intolerance and prejudices against a community, and results in discriminatory treatment of individuals from that community.
2. Communalism has a **political** angle as well. A communal person may or may not be religious but he/she bases their political identity on religion. Communalism perverts religion and converts it into a political constituency.
3. Communalism claims that **religious identity overrides** every other identity (class, caste, gender, economic, linguistic, ethnic or national identity etc.)
4. Communalists are **unwilling to accept the belief pattern and faiths of other communities** and **promote unity of community against other communities**. It is in direct conflict with the concept of pluralism and integration.
5. Communalism is also pro-violence. The emotional baggage carried over by communalism turns a crowd into a mob. Lynching, riots etc. happen as a result.

Communal tensions appear in different societies depending upon their cultural history. Ancient India was a multi-religious society, but there was no hatred against anyone's religion. It had a pluralistic culture and **religious tolerance**. Kings patronized religions and religious institutions other than their own, for example Kumaragupta - a proclaimed Vaishnava - established the Nalanda Mahavihara, a center of Buddhist learnings. However, few incidents of religious intolerance were also seen such as persecution of Vaishnavas by Kulothunga Chola, a Shaivite king. But it is hard to find any parallels of such incidents in ancient India. With the arrival of

Islam in medieval India, the native religions were often suppressed. Temples were converted into mosques as a mark of conquest. There was religious as well as racial discrimination. However, despite the intolerant regime, the relations among people continued to be harmonious with absence of communal feelings among them. There were exceptions among the ruling class as well such as the Mughal Emperor Akbar, who was an epitome of secular outlook and believed in propagating interreligious understanding. He abolished the **Jajiya tax which discriminated against Hindus**.

Further, the colonial period saw increasing mobilization of people. The Britishers also saw the 1857 revolt as a Hindu-Muslim conspiracy against them. Because of Mughal rule and the revolt under the assumed leadership of Bahadur Shah Zafar, colonial government began to be **suspicious towards Muslims** and started patronizing Hindus. In fact, after the suppression of revolt British officials took a **vindictive attitude** towards the Muslims. For example, they hanged 27,000 Muslims in Delhi alone. But this attitude changed in 1870s when they started following the policy of **divide and rule** as a tool to keep their political stranglehold over the country. Moreover, amongst the common masses, religion was also usually the first method to mobilize public opinion against the British, such as through large scale celebrations of Ganesh Chaturthi and Shivaji Jayanti by Bal Gangadhar Tilak. But it also meant that clashing communal interests now degenerated into riots, which enlarged the gulf of distrust between communities. Eventually, communalism emerged as a new and modern political system based on **people's participation and mobilization**. This was evident from the transformation of religious consciousness to communal consciousness among some sections of people.

The **economic policies followed by British** resulted in deprivation among masses and competition for the resources. The British acted in a biased and prejudiced manner in matters of government services and promotions. For example- the Hindu community improved their social and economic status by modern education and subsequent employment in British services while Muslims remained aloof and suffered from backwardness and degradation. From the very beginning, **upper caste Hindus** dominated colonial services as they adapted early to colonial structure. Thus, huge imbalance was created between two communities. This resulted in resentment among Muslims in late 19th century and they then formed a **pressure group** under **Sir Syed Ahmed Khan** to bargain as a separate community. The first visible signs of British divide and rule policy can be traced from the partition of Bengal in **1905 where they promoted provincialism** by talking of **Bengali domination**. They also provided support in the formation of **Muslim League** with religious agenda to counter Indian National Congress. Further, British strategy of providing **separate electorate to Muslims** under **Morley Minto Reforms of 1909** too resulted in Hindu-Muslim conflict.

In several parts, **religious distinction** coincided with social and class distinction, causing communal distortion. For example, in western Punjab at that time, Muslim landlords opposed Hindu moneylenders while in eastern Bengal, Muslim *jotedars* opposed Hindu *zamindars*. The Britishers also started **accepting** communal organizations and leaders as the real spokesperson of communities and adopted a policy of **non-action** against communalism. Gradually **religiosity** became major contributory factor and it started **intruding** the non-religious and non-spiritual areas of life and also beyond the individual's private life. **Religious revivalism** movement in India like **Shuddhi movement** among Hindus and **Tabligh** and **Tanzim** among Muslims also contributed to polarization. The period between 1923 to 1930 witnessed multiple communal riots in India. Also, political positions such as seats in legislative councils, municipal bodies etc., were provided based on the communal considerations. This communal policy was continued by the British through Communal award in 1932, and to the partition in 1947. **Manipulation of religious sentiments** became prominent during **British rule** which accentuated religious and cultural differences between the Hindus and Muslims and led to the consolidation of separate communal identities.

The British historians also provided a communal and distorted view of Indian history. For example - British historian, James Mill **designated** the **ancient period** of Indian history as the **Hindu period** (based on

Hindu rulers) and the **medieval** period (1200 AD – 1757AD) **as the Muslim period** (based on Muslims rulers). It was also described that in the medieval period, there was **subjugation and oppression of Hindus**.

After independence, several incidents have accentuated communalism in India. For example- subsequent Hindu- Muslim riots after partition, Anti-Sikh riots 1984, demolition of Babri Masjid in 1992, Godhra Riots 2002, Muzaffarnagar riots in Uttar Pradesh in 2013, Delhi riots 2020, etc. **Vote bank politics and politics of appeasement** followed by political parties made communal divisions even more stark. For example, Rath yatra, Shah Bano judgement by court which was overturned by central government through Muslim Women's Act in early 1986. In the **contemporary times**, issues like conversion and re-conversion (**Ghar wapsi**), emergence of inter-religious marriages (**Love-Jihad controversy**), religious sentiments related to **cow-slaughter** (Dadri lynching), misrepresentation of historical evidence, **sensationalization of news** by media etc. have polarized the society and has resulted in communalism in Indian society.

The roots of Communalism in India are a remnant of colonial socio-economic political structure. Examine.

Communalism is especially, a **significant issue** in India because it has been a recurrent source of **tension and violence**. Though the remnants of communalism belong to colonial times and they can be traced out in contemporary times as well, but such incidents could not disturb the harmony of India. This is due to the **values of morality and tolerance** which are inbuilt in the character of India.

Contemporary communalism:

Communalism which started as a religious conflict between two religions, continued even after partition and exists in society after decades since independence. Political opportunism can be cited as a major reason for this. With continuing absence of a uniform civil code, there is deepening perception that different religious communities having divergent and contradictory interests. Consequently, community-based pressure groups bargain for their own community. At the political level, these communities compete for power and resources. This competition, in turn, escalates into a major social divide. Politicians try to turn communities into vote banks and different communities become watertight compartments. External elements (including non-state actors) also have a role in worsening the problem of communalism as such elements try to stoke internal unrest and social instability in India. Politics and connivance of international elements combined with socio-economic conditions has turned contemporary communalism into a serious domestic issue. In fact, it is no more a religious conflict but now it encompasses **other spheres of Indian life**.

“Contemporary communalism is more than a conflict between religious communities.”

Uniform Civil Code:

Article 44 of the Indian Constitution refers to the creation of a uniform civil code for the citizens of the country. To give effect to this provision, in the initial years of independence, Prime Minister Nehru had introduced the Hindu Code bill into the Parliament but was met with a huge opposition. Hindu Code bill had meant to provide a civil code in place of the Hindu personal law that governed systems like marriage, adoption, re-marriage, hereditary rights, etc. However, it was perceived as an attack on the Hindu religion. Nehru was also criticized for being soft on the Muslim minority and not including them under the purview of the civil code, as was originally envisaged in the Constitution. The Prime Minister, on the other hand, had wanted to reassure the Muslims who had chosen India and decided to stay back. He believed that the majority had a duty towards the minority and it would be wise to offer concessions to make them feel at ease. The controversy, finally was resolved when the Hindu Code Bill was broken down into three subsidiary bills- The Hindu Marriage Bill (outlawed polygamy and gave provisions for inter-caste marriages and

divorces), The Hindu Adoption and Maintenance Bill; and The Hindu Succession Bill. Members of Buddhist, Jain, Christian and Sikh community also fall under the purview of these laws. There are still demands for the passing of a Uniform Civil Code in order to bring all religions under the same civil laws and also to empower women who are sometimes at a disadvantage due to personal laws of religions.

Causes of communalism:

Communalism has diverse underlying causes. **Social and cultural differences**, for example between the Hindus and the Muslims, result in one treating the cow as sacred while the other treating it as food and sacrificial animal. Conversion is another social factor in communalism. Constitution has provided the citizens, the freedom to profess, practice and propagate any religion but when this freedom is used to aggressively increase the influence of one religion over others through conversion, it creates an unhealthy tension between religious communities. **Economic inequality** is another significant ground which projects the interests of two communities as not only distinct, but conflicting as well. A majority of Muslims in India lack scientific and technological education. Due to their educational backwardness, they have not been represented sufficiently in public service, industry, and trade etc. This creates a sense of **relative deprivation and inequality** which prepares the ground for communal feelings through a justification of the community having been side-lined by the state.

Vote bank politics is another way through which the interests of the communities are projected to be distinct. Use of religious appeals to mobilize people electorally creates a slippery slope for communalization of politics. It can lead to dehumanization of a section of society through political indoctrination. Also the government's **policy of appeasement** of minorities to give them confidence has backfired. There has been an increase in communal feelings amongst the majority population for being sidelined and ignored as equal partners in the development process. There are psychological reasons as well, behind growth of communal sentiments. A feeling of insecurity might arise among minorities simply due to not belonging to a majority community, or a feeling of exclusion might arise because of lack of easy bonding and friendship between the two communities in society, or due to constant bickering between them. Moreover, lockdown imposed isolation during the pandemic, also reduced social interactions between people belonging to various communities, which earlier acted as mediums to bridge the divide. As a result, few adverse incidents were extrapolated to stereotype the entire community. For example, the ghettoization of Tablighi Jamaat and Sikhs in Nanded (Maharashtra) as corona spreaders.

1. 'Communalism arises either due to power struggle or relative deprivation.' Argue by giving suitable illustrations. (UPSC 2018)
2. Distinguish between religiousness/religiosity and communalism giving one example of how the former has got transformed into the latter in independent India. (UPSC 2017)

Communalism has manifestations even in international context. There are increasing cases of intolerance and victimization of minorities all over the world. Attacks on Asian origin minorities in mosques in Christchurch, New Zealand shows white supremacy and racism. Even western countries that take pride in calling themselves as secular and democratic, have experienced cases of communalism and cultural intolerance. For example, attacks on Sikhs in USA etc. There are also incidences where excesses are committed against religious minorities by majority population. For example, forced conversion of Hindu and Sikh girls in Pakistan, destruction of Hindu temples, etc. State sponsored atrocities against Rohingyas by the Myanmar authorities, further provide institutional support to communalism. Some states promote one particular religion defeating the very objective of secularism. For example- Sunnis led Saudi Arabia. Communalism is both the cause for and the effect of the spread of terrorism. Terrorists opt for literal interpretation of religious scriptures, which were written with a different context and during a different setting. Some of these religious

teachings, even though not applicable to the current society, are used as a motive to wage jihad against the non-believers. For instance, Islamic State as a fundamentalist group seeks to establish a political state based on Islamic laws in Iraq and Syria. Same is the goal of Taliban in Afghanistan. This leads to loss of humanity, peace, stability, life and property world over. India is also a victim of Pakistan's state sponsored terrorism with the sole aim of getting control over Kashmir.

Communalism is not only manifested in the rise of terrorism but also in the rising intolerance to cultural diversity world over. Elucidate with recent examples.

How to overcome communalism?

It has been observed that there is a substantive **decline in religious conflicts with rise in per capita income, literacy rate, employment rate and gender equality**. Also, reducing educational and economic backwardness can uplift socio-economic status and reduce deprivation. Poverty alleviation measures are therefore, important for promoting communal harmony. Raising the employment level of the people, by providing more jobs through different government schemes like MGNREGA can economically empower people and help dissuade them away from communal appeals. Creating awareness in the society about the ill effects of communalism through mass media will also help. Religious tolerance needs to be promoted in society to combat communal violence and to counter communal indoctrination. Politicization of religion should be actively discouraged. News media should also take due care when publishing communally sensitive news that has the potential to incite violence. Identification, mapping and monitoring of riot-prone areas on religiously important day or festivals can help to manage any untoward incident with communal potential. Use of modern tools such as drones, innovative messaging through social media, busting fake news and rumors can help in such situations.

2nd ARC's recommendations to curb religious conflicts:

1. **Community policing** should be encouraged.
2. **District Peace Committees/Integration Councils** should be made effective instruments for addressing issues likely to cause communal disharmony.
3. Mohalla Committees should also be organized on the same lines to identify local problems with the potential to degenerate into communal conflicts and suggest means to deal with them at the earliest.
4. In **conflict-prone areas**, the police should formulate a programme in which the members of the target population get an opportunity of interacting with the police as a confidence-building mechanism.
5. A separate law to deal with communal violence is not required. The existing provisions of the Indian Penal Code and the Criminal Procedure Code need to be strengthened. This may be achieved by incorporating the following provisions:
 - a. Enhanced punishments for communal offenses.
 - b. Setting up of special courts for expeditious trial of cases related to communal violence.
 - c. Giving powers of remand to Executive Magistrates in cases of communal offenses.
 - d. Prescription of norms of relief and rehabilitation.

Policization, relative deprivation and misinformation results in covert/suppressed frictions turning into overt conflicts and confrontations. The resultant communal violence threatens the secular fabric, peaceful co-existence, harmony, unity, integrity and internal security of India and poses a problem of rehabilitation of victims of such violence. We need to preserve, protect and strengthen our unity in diversity. Emphasis should be on value-oriented education, unbiased policing, strict adherence to laws and speedy trials. Schemes such as Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat is an important step to foster unity in diversity. To eradicate the menace of

communalism in India, there is a need to initiate the process of de-communalization of the people at all levels, say, by exposing communal assumptions, by explaining to people the socio-economic and political roots of communalism, and by letting them know that what the communalists project as problems are not the real problems and what they suggest as remedies are not the real remedies.

7.3. Secularism

"I do not want my house to be walled in on all sides and my windows to be stuffed. I want the culture of all lands to be blown about my house as freely as possible. But I refuse to be blown off my feet by any" Mahatma Gandhi

Secularism is understood as separation of state from religion, or more broadly as zero interference of the state in the matters of religion, and vice-versa. What this implies is that the state treats all citizens equally, without any special consideration for anyone's religion.

Secularism, as a concept, originated in Europe during the period of renaissance. Its origin is traced to reaction against the oppression by the church in the name of religion. Secularism, therefore, sought to separate state from religion. But **secularism, as understood in India, has implied giving equal respect to all religions**, in line with the practices of the land since time immemorial. India is a birthplace for major religions like Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism. And Indian society also welcomed faiths and beliefs originating in other lands like Islam and Christianity which, over time, have become a feature of Indian society itself. It originated in the ancient Vedic period **based on religious pluralism** and later evolved by Ashoka's dhamma, Akbar's sulh-e-kul etc. Even then, the priests and religious heads largely had religious and moral functions and were rarely involved in administrative affairs of the State. The modern background of secularism in India has a colonial context though. During British colonial rule in India, the government made different laws for different religions and followed the **policy of divide and rule**. They brought civil codes that were not the same across all religions. Introduction of **separate electorates for Muslims** in the Government of India Act 1909 was another major attack on the secular fabric of the Indian society. Demand for the separate state of Pakistan followed after years of similar pandering policies by the colonial government. The partition riots, which killed thousands of innocent people, shocked leaders of the freedom movement. Secularism, therefore, was seen as a prerequisite for unity and integrity of India.

In this light, the Constitution of India included far-sighted provisions like **the rights to equality, freedom of religion** for all its citizens and also safeguarded the rights of minority communities. But the word secularism was not mentioned in the Constitution drafted by the Constituent Assembly. It was added by the **42nd Constitutional Amendment Act of 1976, although the concrete provisions such as the constitutional rights and protections for freedom of religion and minorities implied secular credentials implicitly**. Supreme Court has also held that **Secularism is the basic feature** of the Constitution. In line with this vision, India has continued as a secular society and polity on the principle of '*sarva dharma sambhava*' which is a positive notion unlike the western notion of secularism which seeks complete separation of state from religion.

Why is it important to separate religion from the State?

Secularism prevents the majority population belonging to one religion from oppressing the minority and allows minorities to practice their religion. If the majority religious group has access to State power, then it could quite easily use this power and financial resources to discriminate against and prosecute persons of other religions. This tyranny of the majority could result in discrimination, coercion and at times even genocide. For instance, state persecution of Rohingyas in Myanmar, who belong to a different religion than Buddhism—the majority religion. Any form of domination based on religion is in violation of the rights that a democratic society guarantees to each and every citizen irrespective of their religion. In addition, we also need to protect the freedom of individuals to exit from their religion, embrace another religion or have the freedom to interpret

religious teachings differently. A state which maintains a safe distance from religion becomes a protector for such individuals. Also, contemporary world history has shown us that how wars have been fought by the State in the name of religion. This is also evident from the current precarious situations in West Asia which is bearing the brunt of religious jihad.

The western model of secularism:

The western model of secularism ensures the separation between political institutions and religion and this separation means complete separation where the state does not interfere in religious affairs at all and religion also does not intervene in the affairs of the state. **It originated** in response to rampant **corruption in the Church** as well as its **unwarranted interference** in state affairs during the Dark Ages. The philosophy of western secularism solely focuses on the rights of a citizen to follow the religion of their choice. The **religion and states have a separate sphere** of its own. In the western model of secularism, no public policy will be drafted on the basis of religion. The state cannot aid any religious institution nor it can give any financial support to educational institutions run by religious communities. The **State doesn't intervene in the affairs of religion** till the time religion is working within the limits of the law. The State does not give community-based rights or minority rights. This is because; most of the western societies are religiously homogeneous except for the presence of Jews. So, they focus on individual freedom and equality and inter-religious issues were neglected.

Indian model of secularism:

India is a country comprising of various religions such as Hinduism, Islam, Buddhism, Sikhism, Jainism etc. Secularism in practice is one of the most important achievements of independent India as it has ensured equal treatment of people in all aspects regardless of their caste, religion, beliefs, etc. Indian secularism is attributed to the **fair and equal treatment of all religions** and treat them all as one under the law. For example, Delhi government scheme - Mukhyamantri Tirth Yatra Yojana which provides state funded visit to pilgrimage sites for elderly people. Keeping its deep-rooted diversity in mind, Indian secularism focused on equality. It opposed the **oppression of women and Dalits** within Hinduism or Indian Islam or Christianity. It deals not only with the religious freedom of individuals but also with the religious freedom of minority communities. Within it, the individual has the **right to profess the religion** of his/her choice. Religious communities have a right to exist and establish their own culture and educational institutions. We have state-supported religious reforms. Recently Supreme Court judgement allowed the entry of women in **Sabarimala** Temple, Kerala. Bombay High Court judgment opened **Haji Ali Dargah** to women. Indian model of secularism constructively intervenes in regressive religious practices. It allows the state to strike down regressive practices of religion and also upholds other fundamental rights.. For example, triple talaq has been banned by law. Similarly, our Constitution has banned **untouchability**, it has also enacted several laws like **abolishing child marriage** and also **allowing inter-caste marriage** within Hinduism.

India has adopted a very sophisticated policy of religious equality. It has chosen a positive mode of engagement. State **does not owe loyalty** to any particular religion **nor does it itself uphold** any religion as state religion. It is **not irreligious** or **anti-religious** but gives **equal freedom and protection to all religions**. It grants all religious minorities the right to establish and maintain their own educational institutions which may receive assistance from the state. The 7th schedule of Indian Constitution places religious institutions, charities and trusts into Concurrent List, which means that both the central government of India, and various state governments in India can make their own laws about religious institutions, charities and trusts. These strategies are adopted by the state to promote values of peace, freedom, and equality. Indian Constitution allows for principled state intervention. It means that the state will intervene when its principles of freedom, equality, and peace will be hindered.

Thus, the conception of Indian and Western models is vastly **different due to differences in time and space of evolution**. Each developed largely indigenously so the respective models are suited to their own socio-

political needs. As per **Ashis Nandy**, a better term to explain Indian secularism is using the term **religious tolerance** rather than redefining it through the prism of Western model of secularism. However, with greater migration of refugees and immigrants to the West, West is beginning to resemble India. Hence, the current **Western conception** of secularism is proving to be **myopic** as it is overlooking **multiculturalism**. The Indian model of religious pluralism could hold a lesson for the west that has mired itself in religious stereotyping leading to discrimination and a divided society. Islamophobia for example has been seen to have become a recognised cause of proliferation of terrorist organisations like ISIS. Also, with increasing globalisation religiously varied societies have come closer making it necessary to respect different religions along with providing space for their expression. This, Indian System of secularism could be a guiding light for the overly radicalised form of secularism of the west. It could curb the growing xenophobia in the locals, and the threat perception in the migrants. Only because of this system has India managed to keep together its cultural diversity for over thousand of years. The idea of 'Sarv Dharma Sambhav' thus, needs to become a global maxim to sustain social ties in an increasingly global world.

The Indian Constitution and secularism:

As per the Indian Constitution, the State itself does not have any religion. It gives equal importance and extends equal opportunities to all religions, allowing all of them equal opportunities to co-exist and flourish. The **preamble** of the Indian Constitution reflects the **philosophy** of the constitution as it secures to all citizens of India liberty of belief, faith and worship. Other provisions include:

1. The State shall not deny to any person equality before the law or equal protection of the laws (Article 14).
2. The State shall not discriminate against any citizen on the ground of religion (Article 15).
3. Equality of opportunity for all citizens in matters of public employment (Article 16).
4. All persons are equally entitled to freedom of conscience and the right to freely profess, practice and propagate any religion (Article 25).
5. Every religious denomination or any of its section shall have the right to manage its religious affairs (Article 26).
6. No person shall be compelled to pay any taxes for the promotion of a particular religion (Article 27).
7. No religious instruction shall be provided in any educational institution maintained by the State (Article 28).
8. Any section of the citizens shall have the right to conserve its distinct language, script or culture (Article 29).
9. All minorities shall have the right to establish and administer educational institutions of their choice (Article 30).
10. The State shall endeavour to secure for all the citizens a Uniform Civil Code (Article 44).

1. "India's approach to secularism could hold a lesson for the west." Comment.
2. How the Indian concept of secularism differ from the western model of secularism? Discuss. (UPSC 2018, 2014)

Critical view Indian secularism:

1. **Western Import:** A major criticism is that secularism in India is borrowed from the west and doesn't suite Indian culture. But given that we successfully adopted parliamentary democracy from the west and molded it in Indian way to suit our interest, this criticism is not well rounded. In the west, it was the Church-state separation which was central and in countries such as India, the idea of peaceful coexistence of different religious communities has been important.
2. **Minoritism:** Another criticism is that Indian secularism favours minorities for no historical reasons

unlike Europe where many minority nationalities got boxed into territorial nation-states. However, in the Indian constitutional scheme, the special arrangement by the states intend to treat minorities with the same respect and dignity with which all others are being treated. Here the rights of minority need not be nor should be viewed as special privileges.

3. **Interventionist:** The Indian secularism is said to be coercive with excessive interference with the religious freedom of communities. But the Indian secularism is not based on the traditional notion of total separation between religion and state. Indian secularism justifies interference on the grounds such as a personal law treating women unequally and unjustly, being against morality or public health such as human sacrifice or animal cruelty. The state here acts as a facilitator of reforms by supporting liberal and democratic voices within every religion.
4. **Anti-religious:** Some experts argue that the Indian secularism is anti-religious. But the Indian secularism is against the institutionalized religious domination and this can't be dubbed as being anti-religious. It is also said that Indian secularism threatens religious identity. But the intention of Indian secularism is to promote religious freedom and equality. Dogmatic, violent, fanatical, exclusivist and hatred-fostering beliefs and practices are intended to be suppressed. The real question is not whether something is undermined but whether what is undermined is intrinsically worthy or unworthy of being preserved/supported.

There are several factors acting as **hindrance to secular fabric of India**. The polarization of people on religious lines, **appeal to religion** and caste based identities even for secular interests by political leaders and parties is a big cause for concern. For example, riots such as in Muzaffarnagar, Kandhamal, and Gujarat, etc. Moreover, rationalism, science are opposed by **clergy, vested interests and feudal elements** so as to perpetuate their monopoly. **Religious revivalism and fundamentalism**, missions of conversions and re conversions also drive people to narrow mind-sets. **Failure of government in creating just economic order** leading to poverty, ignorance, illiteracy, population explosion, environmental pollution, jobs has led to a **sense of injustice**. Not only this, attempts to subvert history, distorting textbooks affect young minds negatively. **Neighbouring countries** are many times instrumental in fanning communalism, terrorism in country. eg state sponsored terrorism by Pakistan, ISIS, etc. India today has more than 200 million users on social media, which has also become a handy tool to disseminate **hate speeches, fake news** and hence the communal propaganda.

1. What are the challenges to our cultural practices in the name of secularism? (UPSC 2019)
2. Customs and traditions suppress reason leading to obscurantism. Do you agree? (UPSC 2020)

**Note: A good answer to this question will include points from all the previous chapters.*

Strengthening peace and harmony in Indian society:

States should tackle riots with promptness, grit and determination. Adequate manpower deployment, detailed standard operating procedures (SOPs), contingency plans should be kept ready in **sensitive/hypersensitive areas**. Economic disparities should be reduced by dedicated efforts in **job creation** for youth. Legislature should strengthen hands of **Election Commission** to bar parties and individuals making religious appeals to voters even during non-election period. **Inter-religious education at school** level with emphasis on sacrifices and hardships of all religious communities and their contribution towards freedom and development of the country need to be focused in the books of the history. **Community festivals like Durga Puja in West Bengal** (wherein different communities participate in idol making etc.) could be utilized to enhance cooperation among people. We should abide by **Article 51A** of our Constitution which states it is a fundamental duty of every citizen to promote harmony among people transcending religious diversities. We should not pay heed to hate speeches online and people should be sensitized to differentiate between **free speech and hate speech**.

UN has declared 1st week of February as “**World Interfaith Harmony Week**”. It should be celebrated at all social gatherings and issues such as processions, use of loudspeakers, interfaith marriages should be dealt

with mature mind-set under guidance of laws. Revival of the **National Integration Council (NIC 1960)** and **National Foundation for communal harmony (NFCH 1992)** and their regular meetings is the need of the hour. **Justice delayed is justice denied**, therefore, judicial remedies should be prompt and effective so as to instil confidence among people. The criminal justice system in the country should be made free from **politicization and graft**. **Media is one of main stakeholders** in ensuring peace. Curbs on dissemination of hateful material on social media such as Facebook, WhatsApp and mainstream media should be put into place. **Editors' guild** should make self-regulations in this regard both for unbiased coverage and for a ban on provocative headlines and non-factual reporting. India is a nursery of many blended cultures, it is hope of all exploited races on Earth, therefore it is high time to bring **Communal Violence (Prevention, Control and Rehabilitation of Victims) Bill, 2011**, back to table so that responsibility could be fixed for any untoward incident and communal harmony could be secured.

Given the issues of communalism and the diversity and plurality of India, adoption of secularism has been a blessing as people can express their opinions freely. Being part of their identity, people can openly profess or practice the religion of their choice or choose not to practice any religion at all. But it needs to be understood that any state cannot be truly secular with secularism just written in its books. The ideology has to be accepted with grace by society and implemented with equal application for all sections of the people, and all communities. Keeping a check on the governmental bodies for any unfair use of religious influence to gain power is also needed. The young generation can more fully embrace the importance of the concept of secularism if is taught about the struggles and sacrifices of our countrymen in establishing and sustaining a pluralistic, modern Republic of India. As a popular song from yesteryears goes: **'hum laaye hain toofan se kashti nikaal ke, tum desh ko rakhna mere bachchon sambhaal ke'**.

8. POVERTY AND DEVELOPMENTAL ISSUES

Poverty is a multidimensional phenomenon in which a person or community lacks the financial and other resources to enjoy a minimum standard of life and well-being that is considered acceptable in society. According to World Bank, poverty is a pronounced deprivation in well-being, and comprises many dimensions. It includes low incomes and the inability to acquire the basic goods and services necessary for survival with dignity. Poverty also encompasses low levels of health and education, poor access to clean water and sanitation, inadequate physical security, lack of voice, and insufficient capacity and opportunity to better one's life. Each nation may have its own threshold that determines how many of its people are living in poverty. In India, 21.9% of the population lived below the national poverty line in 2011. In 2018, almost 8% of the world's workers and their families lived on less than US\$1.90 per person per day (international poverty line).

Poverty refers to socially perceived deprivation in terms of basic human needs. It has both material and nonmaterial dimensions. The **material dimension** relates to deprivation in consumption including items such as food, clothing, durables, shelter, health, education and connectivity. **Nonmaterial dimension** relates to deprivation associated with such phenomena as discrimination based on gender, religion, race or caste.

Social structure is conceived as the pattern of inter-related rights and obligations of persons and groups found in a society, constituting a relatively stable set of social relations, for example- family, marriage, kinship, caste, class etc. Poverty although, is usually perceived from economic perspective (income, calorie intake etc), however, there is growing consensus among social scientists that poverty should also be understood based on multiple deprivations such as social exclusion, individual mental, physical social well being, etc. Gunnar Myrdal in his book - Asian Drama: An Inquiry into the Poverty of Nations - in 1968, pursued an institutional approach in which poverty issues were not to be studied in isolation but in their mutual relationships such as social structure of society. In India, poverty is also impacted by social structure which dictates status and roles and provides for allocation of resources.

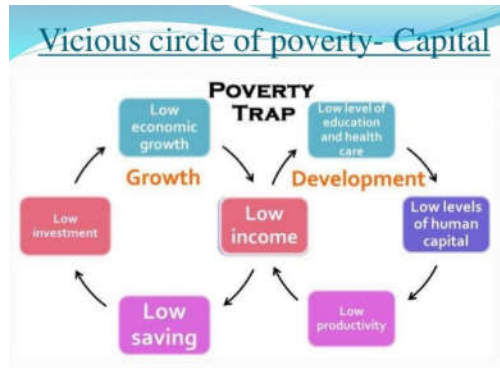
As discussed earlier, the patriarchal value system embedded in the society provides for lower status of women. Women are discriminated, harassed and humiliated at each and every stage of their life. This attitude is seen at the work place, where there is gender segregation of work and women are provided low status, low paid informal jobs. It has resulted in feminisation of poverty. Caste system has also perpetuated poverty as it is often seen that upper castes in an area are the dominant caste which tries to appropriate economic benefits. The caste system has resulted in economic discrimination against lower castes (untouchables, Shudras, SCs/STs etc) in markets and nonmarket institutions, such as in education, health services, and food from the schools, primary health centres and fair price shops. They also suffer from social exclusion and multiple deprivations which has resulted in persistence of poverty among the lower castes in India.

In India, the class position of people influences the opportunities open to them. A person who starts out life in poverty has a greater risk of poverty in later life also. For example, when a poor lower caste individual migrates to urban setting for better opportunities, he often faces marginalisation and exclusion and is provided only menial jobs. Thus, class and power relations embedded in society are also responsible for persistence of poverty in India. The fruits of economic development have been appropriated by the elites in India (mostly upper caste and upper class people). For example- success of land reforms and green revolution has been cornered by big landlords while poor, landless labourers, tenants etc still face hardship of bonded labour in various forms. Even the service sector employs people with high skills. The vulnerable sections of society such as women, SCs/STs etc who are discriminated in education and thus lack adequate skills, are naturally marginalised in jobs. They continue to work in sectors which are less rewarding. Their low status in social structure in society is reflected in their economic status also. Poverty therefore, can be eliminated not through

economic measures alone but through the participation of the community in a way where historical wrongs are corrected and opportunities are extended to help the poor join the mainstream of development and contribute their worth to nation building.

There is a close relationship between poverty and the structure of society. Explain with reference to Indian society.

8.1. Poverty as a vicious cycle



With the official statistics of people falling below the poverty limit around 22%, poverty becomes one of great concern for policy makers. The major determinants of poverty are lack of income and below par purchasing power which can be attributed to lack of productive employment and considerable underemployment. Further, inadequate social infrastructure, affects the employability and quality of life of the people. Poverty has therefore been rightly called a 'trap' by many economists. Illiteracy (25.96% of the Indian population is illiterate) and lack of adequate skill (only 4.69% of the population

is adequately skilled) lead to lower levels of income and compensation. This leads to poverty which further perpetuates into lack of accessibility to quality education and avenues to garner adequate skills. Moreover, poor health status – reduced nutrition, diseases, etc. reduce productivity and inhibit ability to perform to the best of one's potential. This further results in lower wages and subsequent lower ability to afford healthy food, quality healthcare and therefore, poor health.

Higher degree of unemployment in the society also corresponds to lesser spending by individuals and consumers implying lack of demand. As a consequence, reduced industrial production further leads to slowing economic growth and unemployment. The causes and effects of poverty mutually reinforce each other, creating a grinding wheel of mind numbing poverty in India. Addressing poverty thus, requires an integrated approach- alleviating both the causes and effects at the same time, to ultimately get rid of absolute levels of poverty in India.

8.2. Types of poverty

Absolute poverty: It refers to a condition where a person does not have the minimum amount of income needed to meet the minimum requirements for one or more basic living needs over an extended period of time. It may be calculated in monetary terms, nutrition attainment or in terms of calorie intake. For example: Homeless people living on the streets, families that cannot afford to buy food to feed themselves and their children are examples of absolute poverty. Absolute poverty is usually based upon the idea of subsistence, i.e., people are said to be in absolute poverty if they do not have the resources to maintain basic human life.

Relative poverty: It occurs when people do not enjoy a certain minimum level of living standards in comparison with specific sections of society, as determined by the government (and enjoyed by the bulk of population). These vary from country to country. For example, in the UK relative poverty is defined as income 50% less than average incomes.

8.3. Estimation of poverty

A credible measure of poverty can be a powerful instrument for focusing the attention of policy makers on the living conditions of the poor." In another words, it is easy to ignore the poor if they are statistically invisible.

The measurement of poverty is thus necessary if it is to appear on the political and economic agenda. The objective for measuring poverty is in order to target interventions as one cannot help the poor without at least knowing who they are. This is the purpose of a poverty profile, which sets out the major facts on poverty (and, typically, inequality), and then examines the pattern of poverty, to see how it varies by geography (by region, urban/rural, mountain/plain, etc.), by community characteristics (e.g. in communities with and without a school, etc.), and by household characteristics (e.g. by education of household head, by size of household). Another objective for measuring poverty is to be able to predict the effects of, and then evaluate, policies and programs designed to help the poor. Policies that look good on paper may present challenges in their proper implementation. For example agriculture subsidies meant for the benefit of small farmers is seen to be distorting the agriculture pattern and benefiting the large farmers.

In India, identification of poor is done by the government based on information from **Below Poverty Line (BPL)** censuses, latest being the Socio-Economic Caste Census 2011 (SECC 2011). **Poverty line** is set at a level that enables an individual to purchase goods and services in quantities adequate to satisfy basic needs as per prevailing social norms. The basket itself may be referred to as the poverty line basket (PLB). A **brief history of estimation of poverty line** is as follows:

1. **Dadabhai Naoroji** in his book- Poverty and Un-British rule in India- was the first to estimate poverty in the second-half of 19th century. He concluded the base line in 1867-68 price which was based on the cost of a subsistence diet consisting of 'rice or flour, daal, mutton, vegetables, ghee, vegetable oil and salt' as the minimum wages one would need for survival.
2. In 1938 Indian National Congress session at Haripura, Subhash Chandra Bose set up the **National Planning Committee (NPC)** with Jawaharlal Nehru as the Chairman. The Committee decided that the irreducible minimum income should be between Rs. 15 and Rs. 25 per capita per month at pre-war prices.
3. The **1944 Bombay Plan** proponents had suggested a poverty line of Rs.75 per capita per year. (The Bombay Plan was a set of proposals of a small group of influential business leaders in Bombay for the development of the post-independence economy of India.)
4. In 1962, **Planning Commission Expert Group**, formulated separate poverty lines for rural and urban areas- Rs.20 and Rs.25 per capita per year respectively.
5. **Y.K.Alagh committee in 1979**, decided that poverty should be measured precisely based on starvation. It recommended that people consuming less than 2,100 calories in urban areas or less than 2,400 calories in rural areas should be considered as poor.
6. In **1993, Lakdawala committee**, constituted to review methodology for poverty estimation, suggested the continuation of calorie consumption as the basis of consumption expenditure. The committee also recommended the establishment of state specific poverty lines, which should be updated using the Consumer Price Index of Industrial Workers (CPI-IW) in urban areas and Consumer Price Index of Agricultural Labour (CPI-AL) in rural areas.
7. In **2005, Suresh Tendulkar Committee** was constituted by the Planning Commission. This committee recommended to shift away from the calorie-based model and made the poverty line broad based by considering monthly spending on education, health, electricity and transport. The official indicators of poverty in India are based on the **Tendulkar Poverty Line**. According to it, all India poverty line was INR 816 per capita per month in rural areas and INR 1000 per capita per month in urban areas in 2011-12. India witnessed an astonishing poverty decline between **2011-12 and 2016-17** (as per the Tendulkar poverty line of Rs 44 per person per day in 2017-18 prices, just 4.5 per cent of the population is below the poverty line).
8. **The Rangarajan Committee (2014)** recommended separate consumption baskets for rural and urban areas which include food items that ensure recommended calorie, protein & fat intake and non-food items like clothing, education, health, housing and transport. The Committee once again de-links the rural and urban poverty lines. The recommended methodology of Rangarajan committee has raised the

Tendulkar national rural poverty line from INR 816 per-capita per month at 2011-12 prices to INR 972 and the Tendulkar national urban poverty line from INR 1000 per capita per month at 2011-12 prices to INR 1407. These revisions lead to the total national poverty estimate in 2011-12 to rise from 21.9% under the Tendulkar line to 29.5%.

9. The **Arvind Panagariya task force** suggested setting up of committee to identify people “Below Poverty Line (BPL)”. The paper talks of considering either of the four approaches for calculation of poverty. First is continuation of the Tendulkar poverty line. Second, switch to Rangarajan or other higher rural and urban poverty lines. Third, track bottom 30% of the population over time. And fourth, tracking the bottom 30% on specific components, such as housing, sanitation, electricity, nutritional intake, etc.

Global Multi-dimensional Poverty Index(MPI):

The index is released by Oxford Poverty and Human Development Initiative (OPHI) in collaboration with the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) to provide a comprehensive picture of global trends in multidimensional poverty. The index identifies how people are left behind across three key dimensions: health, education and standard of living, based on 10 indicators. A person is multidimensional poor if she/he is deprived in one third or more (means 33% or more) of the weighted indicators. The 2020 Global Multidimensional Poverty Index(MPI) has recently been released with the theme- “Charting pathways out of multidimensional poverty: Achieving the SDGs.” According to it, around 1.3 billion people are still living in multi-dimensional poverty, half of which are children under age 18. About 84 % of multi-dimensionally poor people live in Sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia. During 2005-06 and 2015-16, India was successful in lifting around 273 million people out of multidimensional poverty.

8.4. Poverty alleviation schemes since independence

The government’s approach to poverty reduction was of three dimensions. The **first one** was a **growth-oriented approach**. It was based on the expectation that the effects of economic growth – rapid increase in gross domestic product and per capita income – would spread to all sections of society and will trickle down to the poor sections also. The **second approach** was initiated from the **Third Five Year Plan (1961-66)** and it has progressively enlarged since then. To specifically address the poor, policymakers started thinking that income and employment for the poor could be raised through the creation of additional assets and by means of work generation. This could be achieved through specific poverty alleviation programs. The **third approach** to address poverty was to provide minimum basic amenities to the people. India was among the pioneers in the world to envisage that through public expenditure on social consumption needs – provision of food grains at subsidized rates, education, health, water supply, and sanitation—people’s living standards could be improved.

Integrated Rural Development Program (IRDP) initiated in the early 1980s was one of the earliest poverty alleviation programmes. Various others have been launched since, like employment generation program, income support, employment guarantee (like MGNREGA), etc. to eradicate poverty. Schemes for providing utilities like housing, electricity etc. have also been launched to ease the financial expenditure of the poor households. Some important poverty alleviation and employment generation programs include:

1. **Integrated Rural Development Programme (IRDP) and allied programmes**

The Integrated Rural Development Programme (IRDP) aimed at providing self-employment to the rural poor through acquisition of productive assets or appropriate skills which would generate additional income on a sustained basis to enable them to cross the poverty line.

2. **Training of Rural Youth for Self-Employment (TRYSEM)**

Aimed at providing basic technical and entrepreneurial skills to the rural poor in the age group of 18 to 35 years to enable them to take up income generating activities.

3. **National Rural Employment Programme (NREP)**

This program was launched in 1980 to create employment opportunities by building and maintaining community assets like village roads, ponds, and wells, etc. The scheme was expected to generate additional gainful employment to the extent of 30 to 40 crore man-days per annum and to develop community assets.

4. **Rural Landless Employment Guarantee Programme (RLEGP)**

Launched on 15th August 1983, during the Sixth Five-Year Plan, RLEGP was to be limited only to the landless, with guaranteed employment of 100 days. The entire expenditure of this programme was financed by the Central Government.

5. **Jawahar Rozgar Yojana (JRY)**

The main objective of the programme is the generation of additional gainful employment for unemployed and underemployed persons, both men and women, in the rural areas through the creation of rural economic infrastructure, community and social assets with the aim of improving the quality of life of the rural poor.

6. **Rural Housing – Indira Awaas Yojana**

Indira Awas Yojana was started in 1985-86 to provide residential units free of cost to SC and ST and freed bonded labour. It aimed at creating 20 lakh housing units out of which 13 lakhs were in rural areas. This scheme also gave out loans to people at subsidized rates to make houses.

7. **National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP)**

It is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme with 100 per cent Central assistance provided to States/UTs. The three components of the programme are (i) National Old Age Pension Scheme (NOAPS) in which old age pension of Rs.75 per month is provided to persons of 65 years and above who are destitutes. (ii) National Family Benefit Scheme (NFBS) and (iii) National Maternity Benefit Scheme (NMBS) in which there is a provision for payment of Rs.500 per pregnancy to women belonging to poor households for pre-natal and post-natal maternity care upto the first two live births. This benefit is provided to eligible women of 19 years and above.

8. **Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana** and Housing for All by 2022 Scheme to provide housing to rural and urban poor.

9. Indian government's latest schemes like **Start-Up India** and **Stand Up India** are about empowering people i.e. making them self-sufficient, to earn their livelihood.

10. **Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA)**: It guarantees 100 days of work a year to every rural household with an aim to enhance the livelihood security of people. It has generated more than 31 billion person-days of employment in the last 15 years, with the government spending over Rs 6.4 lakh crore in this period, on this demand-driven program. The programme mandates that at least 60 percent of the works undertaken must be related to land and water conservation. The creation of these productive assets boost rural incomes as the majority of villages are agrarian. Since 2006, more than 30 million water conservation-related assets have been created in the country's rural areas under MGNREGA. According to the government data, over 11 crore people worked under MGNREGS during the financial year 2020-21 alone (pandemic year). As part of the economic package during the Covid-19 pandemic, the government announced additional funding of Rs 40,000 crore for the MGNREGS over and above the budgetary allocation of 2020-21. The scheme has provided support in times of distress and individuals are not forced to migrate into cities. For instance, distress migration has stopped in Bandlapalli village in Andhra Pradesh's Ananthapuramu district and the village is drought-proof today.

11. **National Rural Livelihood Mission** and **Deen Dayal Antyodaya Yojana**- The schemes aim at creating effective and efficient institutional platforms to enable the rural poor to increase their household income by means of sustainable livelihood enhancements and better access to financial services.

The earlier poverty alleviation programmes did not result in any radical changes in the ownership of assets, production processes and improvement of basic amenities to the needy. The incidence of poverty declined from 54.9 percent in 1973-74 to 36 percent in 1993-94. But the absolute number of poor did not decline much over this period of 20 years. There were 321 million poor in 1973-74 and 320 million in 1993-94. The IRDP has been successful in providing incremental income to the poor families, but in most cases, the incremental income has not been adequate to enable the beneficiaries to cross the poverty line on a sustained basis, mainly because of a low per family investment. In 1992-93, a review of the Jawahar Rozgar Yojana (JRY) revealed that the per person employment generated was inadequate in terms of the requirement and did not provide enough income to the poor. Moreover, compared to the magnitude of poverty, the amount of resources allocated for these programs was not sufficient. Also, several groups of the poor that were formed under various poverty alleviation schemes have become defunct over time. The reasons for these include- improper selection of groups; lack of homogeneity among the group members; and selection of non-viable economic activities which are mostly traditional and yield low income. Lack of institutional financial support, inadequate training, a non-professional approach and poor access to upgraded technological inputs have deprived beneficiaries from diversifying into high value addition activities.

Earlier, the poor were seen as passive beneficiaries of government development schemes and not as a partner, but later focus was on capacity building and making the poor as an active participant in the developmental process as it was realized that without their active participation, successful implementation of any program would not be possible. Even former Finance Minister, Pranab Mukherjee, had called for a re-thinking on the development policy, saying that the trickle-down theory would not work in eliminating poverty in India. He had said that for our development to be real, the poorest of our land must feel that they are a part of the narrative of rising India. In short, the earlier premise of 'rising tide will raise all boats' would not work as the poor do not even have a boat i.e., they do not even have the basic human capital to participate in the development process, let alone benefit from it.

Possible reforms in various poverty alleviation schemes:

As per various scholars, **agricultural growth** is thrice more effective than any other means of poverty alleviation. The new approach towards poverty alleviation should involve **targeted income transfers**. Under the targeted basic income programme, the government transfers the poverty gap (the difference between per capita consumption of the household and the poverty line faced by the household) into the bank account of the poor. Though India's pace of poverty reduction has improved over the last five years, it can be augmented through a targeted **basic income policy** (Universal Basic Income) which could free up resources for other sectors of the economy. It is necessary to recast the special employment programmes with a view to make them more effective in meeting not only the short-term objective of providing temporary work, but also in building up the productive capacity of individuals/areas which, in turn, would make for greater employment on a more sustainable basis.

Panchayats should be given the power to raise their own revenue as per the recommendations of the State Finance Commissions. Voluntary organizations would also play an enhanced role especially as facilitators and social animators in bringing about greater awareness through advocacy e.g. through formation of SHGs. The Indian economy requires adequate investments in critical areas such as roads, railways and water. Therefore, the government needs to rationalize its expenditure and tax rates to ensure reallocation of resources. The various lacunas identified in the policies related to poverty alleviation needs to be addressed. Better targeting, generating a variety of employment options, DBT etc. may be included in the poverty alleviation programmes to make India poverty free country sooner or later.

For plugging leakages-Jan Dhan Yojana, Aadhaar, Mobile (**JAM**) trinity could play a vital role in widening the reach of government to the vulnerable sections. With the Aadhar account permitting aggregation

of the information, this would give the government an excellent database to assess the total volume of benefits accruing to each household. In turn, this information can eventually pave the way for replacing myriad schemes with consolidated cash transfers. There is also a need for reorientation of the subsidy. As per SECC (Rural), 40% of the rural households satisfy one or more exclusion criteria. This greatly weakens the case for subsidy to more than 60% of the rural households under the NFSA. **Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA)** can be made more effective by allowing it to impart skills. Workers could be given a chance to choose between unskilled employment and skill formation that would allow them to exit the program. During peak season, farmers may be permitted to hire MGNREGA workers by paying 75% of the wages with the balance paid by MGNREGA wage funds. This would lead to more productive use of labour while also spreading MGNREGA wages over more workdays. Similar schemes of employment guarantee can be started in the urban areas as well.

Some economists also believe that there is a strong co-relation between a growing and thriving **middle class** and a growing and thriving economy. A stable but evolving middle class is required to spur consumption and therefore investments and growth, as the wealthy in unequal societies, do not consume enough to drive a modern economy. Therefore, government policies should focus more on expanding this middle class, from both the sides. The poverty alleviation programmes must help in increasing the disposable incomes of the poor so that they can slide upwards, into the lower middle class category. Additionally, private investment and consumption should drive more expenditure from the rich, so that they come into the upper middle class category. This will also help in reducing economic inequality in the country. An integral part of a well-rounded and holistic anti-poverty strategy must be to sustain growth. Sustained growth creates well-paid jobs and raises real wages, thereby directly denting poverty. Eventually, these efforts will lead in battling out poverty and achieving the SDG goal 1- of eradicating poverty.

'Despite implementation of various programmes for eradication of poverty by the government in India, poverty is still existing'. Explain by giving reasons. (UPSC 2018)

Feminization of poverty in India:

The United Nations Development Programme defines 'feminization of poverty' as a condition wherein the change in poverty levels is biased against women or female-headed households. It refers to the process which leads the widening of gap between women and men caught in the cycle of poverty. India presents a staring example to this ongoing global process. Some indicators of feminization of poverty in India include:

1. India is ranked very low at 125 in the Gender Inequality Index 2015.
2. As per the Global Gender Gap report by World Economic Forum, India slipped 21 places on the index to 108.
3. Female labour force participation rate in India is a meagre 27%.
4. Current contribution of Indian women to the GDP is 17%, which is not only far below the global average 37%, but also less than that of China 41% and Sub Saharan Africa 39%.
5. Poor health statistics like MMR at 174 per 1 lakh live births.

All the above statistics point to the fact that women in India encounter discriminatory practices throughout their lifecycle. An unfavourable child sex ratio, high school dropout rates, low asset ownership, high levels of anaemia during adolescence and increasing incidence of violent crimes are reflective of this fact.

Impact of COVID-19 on poverty:

COVID-19 pandemic has brought economies to a standstill due to lockdowns and movement restrictions. Impact of this contracting economic activity is immense on the lives of those who are below the poverty line (BPL) as well as on the vulnerables, who can fall below BPL level. Reduced incomes and resultant poverty have pushed people into a humanitarian crisis with deprivation of food and healthcare. Urban jobs in informal sector have been lost due to lack of job security. Casual wage workers, weavers, artisans, rickshaw pullers, self-employed persons have all faced loss of livelihoods. Migrants had returned to their villages in fear of the

pandemic and also because employment opportunities in urban areas had reduced. This led to reduction of incomes of both urban households and rural households and therefore, rise in poverty levels. Rural households which were dependent on remittances from migrant workers now faced distress due to return of migrant workers. People and households have been pushed to BPL level of incomes. These include MSME employees, gig economy employees, domestic workers, sex workers, lower middle class households like that of teachers in private schools. Nutritional items of diet like milk, eggs, dal, vegetables, fruit, meat were forgone and only cereal based diet (rice and roti) began to be consumed in lesser quantities. Further, it led to rise in child labour, to meet income and food needs of households. As pandemic spread to states with weak public health systems like Bihar, the poor also faced a health crisis due to lack of quality public health care and unaffordability of private health care. This further pushed them into poverty and exacerbated the hunger crisis.

The UN estimates that 40 crore people will fall into extreme poverty (less than \$1.9 per day) especially in South, South East and East Asia. Further due to lack of efficient public food distribution support, 25 crore people will face acute hunger globally. Ending of universal food support after lockdowns reduced food availability for new poor who lost their livelihoods. Only those with ration cards were able to access the rations. Preferring credit expansion over cash transfers did not aid economic recovery as demand had fallen drastically. In addition, it did not address the distress of households which lost income and livelihoods. Dilution of labour laws led to reduced protection to workers. Increased working hours (upto 12 hours), suspension of safeguards also weakened the bargaining power of workers and posed health risks.

Moreover, the economic impacts of COVID pandemic are not the same for the rich and poor. The following facts of the Oxfam report provide a glimpse of the sharp difference:

1. 1000 richest people in the world would regain their COVID-19 losses within just nine months. But it could take more than a decade for the world's poorest to recover from the economic impacts of the pandemic.
2. The increase in income of the top 100 billionaires since the March 2020 lockdown is enough to give each of the 138 million poorest Indians a cheque of Rs.94045.
3. It will take up to 3 years for unskilled labor in India to earn what the richest earned in one second last year.

Policymakers have accepted this inequality as one of the impacts of economic growth. While they were happy with the reduction in absolute poverty (pre-COVID era), inequality kept on rising. Now, economists have agreed that the economic divide of new wealth between capital and labour is one-sided. While the wealthy are getting wealthier, workers are continually being forced into poverty.

Poverty is no longer about food, hence there is a need for the government to strive to free up our food producers rather than keeping them as prisoners of policy. Policymaking should concentrate on what causes growth, not what causes poverty to decline. Policymakers consider food consumption as the ultimate criterion of poverty, however they should also focus on climate change mitigation, efficient use of water and energy. Eradication of poverty should aim at raising the living standards of people living BPL by providing them sanitation, housing, piped water, electricity, education, health, and jobs. Since poverty is a dynamic concept, it is not fair to define poverty in absolute terms, rather it must be defined in relative terms. Most European nations have a relative definition of poverty — that is, a fixed proportion of the median income. India should move towards that by the end of 2024, as India will likely be a \$5 trillion economy by that time. Our poverty line should also be constantly updated and made consistent with our income status today as a lower-middle income country. We need to grow from the traditional approach of 'roti, kapda and makan' to 'rozgar, swasthya and shiksha' in order to bring people out of poverty.

1. COVID-19 pandemic accelerated class inequalities and poverty in India. Comment. (UPSC 2020)
2. "An essential condition to eradicate poverty is to liberate the poor from the process of deprivation." Substantiate this statement with suitable examples. (UPSC 2016)

9. HEALTH AND NUTRITION ISSUES

9.1. What are Public health services?

Public health services are conceptually different from medical services. Their key goal is to reduce the population's exposure to diseases – for example through assuring food safety and other health regulations; disease vectors control; monitoring waste disposal and water systems; health awareness and education to improve personal health behaviours and build citizen demand for improved public health outcomes.

The Constitution of India provides for public health and sanitation; hospitals and dispensaries under Entry 6 of the **State List** in Seventh Schedule. Based on this, public health is the core domain of the state government. However, the Union government has also provided guiding policies and schemes for public health. Health is considered as a public good and the current framework of public health is as below:

9.2. Constitutional framework of health

Right to health is not explicitly mentioned in the Fundamental Rights (Part III) of Constitution of India, however various other Articles regard health services as an important factor in achieving rights based approach to development. Most of the provisions related to health are mentioned in Part IV - Directive Principle of State Policy (DPSP) of Constitution-

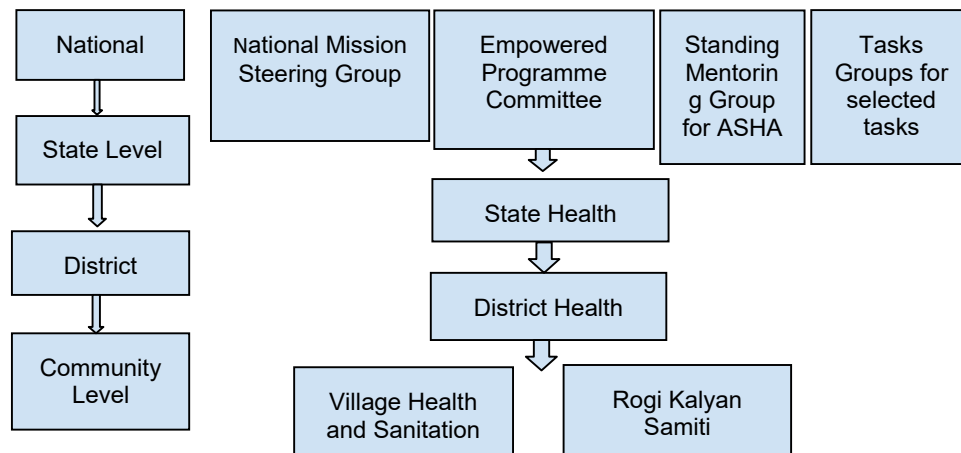
1. Article **21** of the Constitution guarantees protection of life. The Supreme Court has expanded the reach of this right to include the **right to health** as an integral component of the right to live with dignity. The government therefore, has a constitutional obligation to provide health facilities.
2. Article **38** of Indian Constitution imposes liability on the State to secure a social order for the promotion of welfare of the people. Providing affordable healthcare forms the basis for securing people's welfare.
3. Article **39(e)** calls the state to make sure that health and strength of workers, men and women, and the tender age of children are not abused.
4. Article **41** imposes duty on state to provide public assistance in cases of unemployment, old age, sickness and disablement, etc.
5. Article **42** makes provision to protect the health of infant and mother by maternity benefits.
6. Article **47** of the Constitution of India's Directive Principles, recognizes the duty of the state to raise the levels of nutrition and the standard of living and to improve public health as among its primary duties.
7. Article **48A** ensures that the State shall endeavour to protect and improve the environment so as to maintain pollution free environment for good health.

9.3. Healthcare systems and infrastructure in India

The Healthcare system is intended to deliver healthcare services. It constitutes the management sector and involves organizational matters. It operates in the context of the socio economic and political framework of the country. In India, it is represented by five major sectors which differ from each other by the health technology applied and by the sources of funds for operation. These are-

1. **Public health sector**
 - a. Primary Health Care includes Primary Health Centres and Sub Centres
 - b. Hospitals / Health Centres include Community Health Centres, Rural Hospitals, District Hospitals / Health Centre and Specialist Hospitals
 - c. Health Insurance Schemes include Employees State Insurance and Central Government Health Scheme

- d. Other agencies like Defence services and Railways also provide health services to their employees.
- e. At **village** level –Village Health & Sanitation Samiti (at village level consisting of Panchayat Representative/s, ANM/MPW, Anganwadi worker, teacher, ASHA, community health volunteers).
- f. At **district** level –District Health Mission, under the leadership of Zila Parishad with District Health Head as Convener and all relevant departments, NGOs, private professionals etc. represented on it
- g. At **State** level –State Health Mission, chaired by Chief Minister and co-chaired by Health Minister and with the State Health Secretary as Convener- representation of related departments, NGOs, private professionals etc.
- h. Integration of Departments of Health and Family Welfare, at **National** and **State** level



2. **Private sector**
 - a. Private Hospitals, Polyclinics, Nursing Homes and Dispensaries
 - b. General Practitioners and Clinics
3. **Traditional systems of medicine**
 - a. Ayurveda and Siddha
 - b. Unani and Tibbi
 - c. Homeopathy
 - d. Unregistered practitioners
4. **Voluntary health agencies** e.g. Indian Red cross society, Tuberculosis Association of India, Bharat Sevak Samaj etc.
5. **National health programmes** - e.g National Vector Borne disease control programme, National Aids control programme Universal immunization programme etc.

9.4. Policy framework

The government policies propose an achievable target of raising public health expenditure to 2.5% of the GDP in a time bound manner. Programmes like Swachh Bharat Abhiyan aim to help in improving the hygiene conditions for better health outcomes. Other like Yatri Suraksha help in preventing deaths due to rail and road traffic accidents. Government policies are also aimed at reducing stress at workplace; promoting balanced, healthy diets and regular exercises; addressing tobacco, alcohol and substance abuse; and reducing indoor and outdoor air pollution.

9.4.1. National Health Mission, 2013:

The National Health Mission (NHM) envisions achievement of universal access to equitable, affordable & quality health care services that are accountable and responsive to people's needs. It encompasses two sub-Missions–National Rural Health Mission (NRHM) and National Urban Health Mission (NUHM). The main components include strengthening of health systems in rural and urban areas, Reproductive-Maternal-Neonatal Child and Adolescent Health (RMNCH+A) and communicable and non-communicable diseases.

National Rural Health Mission (NRHM) seeks to provide accessible, affordable and quality health care to the rural population especially the vulnerable ones. The North Eastern states, Empowered Action Group (EAG) States, Jammu & Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh have been given special attention under NRHM. The focus of the mission is on establishing a community owned fully functional decentralized health delivery system with inter-sectoral convergence at all levels. This would help in ensuring simultaneous actions on a wide range of health indicators such as water, sanitation, social and gender equality, education and nutrition.

National Urban Health Mission (NUHM) seeks to facilitate access to primary health care for the urban populations, particularly urban poor and other vulnerable sections in order to improve their health status. NUHM covers all State capitals, district headquarters and other cities/towns with a population of **50,000** and above (as per Census 2011) in a phased manner. Cities and towns with population below 50,000 will continue to be covered under NRHM.

9.4.2. National Health Policy 2017:

The National Health Policy, 2017, seeks to promote wellness as an important theme in a comprehensive and integrated manner. It aims for universal health coverage with both quality and affordability of health care services, without anyone having to face any financial hardship as a consequence. The attainment of the highest possible level of health and well-being for all at all ages, through a preventive and promotive health care orientation in all developmental programmes, is the motive of the policy. This would be achieved through increasing access, improving quality and lowering the cost of healthcare delivery. Quantitative goals and objectives include:

1. Life expectancy and healthy life
 - a. Increase the **life expectancy at birth from 67.5 to 70 by 2025.**
 - b. Establish regular tracking of **Disability Adjusted Life Years (DALY) Index** as a measure of burden of disease and its trends by major categories by 2022.
 - c. Reduce **TFR to 2.1 (Replacement Level) at national and sub-national level by 2025.**
2. Mortality by age and/ or cause
 - a. Reduce **Under Five Mortality to 23 by 2025** and **MMR** from current levels to 100 by **2020.**
 - b. Reduce **infant mortality rate to 28 by 2019.**
 - c. Reduce neonatal mortality to 16 and stillbirth rate to “single digit” by 2025.
3. Reduction of disease prevalence/ incidence
 - a. To achieve the target of 90:90:90 (global target of 2020) for HIV/AIDS i.e., 90% of all people living with HIV should know their HIV status, 90% of all people diagnosed with HIV infection should receive sustained antiretroviral therapy and 90% of all people receiving antiretroviral therapy effectively have viral suppression.
 - b. To achieve and maintain elimination status for Leprosy by 2018, Lymphatic Filariasis in endemic pockets by 2017 and Kala-Azar by 2017.
 - c. To achieve and maintain a cure rate of >85% in new sputum positive patients for TB and reduce incidence of new cases, to reach elimination status by 2025.
 - d. To reduce the prevalence of blindness to 0.25/ 1000 by 2025 and disease burden by one third from current levels.

- e. To reduce premature mortality from cardiovascular diseases, cancer, diabetes or chronic respiratory diseases by 25% by 2025.
4. Coverage of health services
 - a. To increase utilization of public health facilities by 50% from current levels by 2025.
 - b. Antenatal care coverage to be sustained above 90% and skilled attendance at birth above 90% by 2025.
 - c. More than 90% of the new-born are fully immunized by one year of age by 2025.
 - d. Meet need of family planning above 90% at national and sub national level by 2025.
 - e. 80% of known hypertensive and diabetic individuals at household level maintain "controlled disease status" by 2025.
5. Cross sectoral goals related to health
 - a. Relative reduction in prevalence of current tobacco use by 15% by 2020 and 30% by 2025.
 - b. Reduction of 40% in prevalence of stunting of under-five children by 2025.
 - c. Access to safe water and sanitation to all by 2020 (Swachh Bharat Mission).
 - d. Reduction of occupational injury by half from current levels of 334 per lakh agricultural workers by 2020.
 - e. National/ State level tracking of selected health behaviour.
6. Health finance
 - a. Increase health expenditure by Government as a percentage of **GDP** from the existing 1.15 % **to 2.5 % by 2025.**
 - b. Increase State sector health spending to > 8% of their budget by 2020.
 - c. Decrease in proportion of households facing catastrophic health expenditure from the current levels by 25% by 2025.
7. Health Infrastructure and Human Resource
 - a. Ensure availability of paramedics and doctors as per Indian Public Health Standard (IPHS) norm in high priority districts by 2020.
 - b. Increase community health volunteers to population ratio as per IPHS norm, in high priority districts by 2025.
 - c. Establish primary and secondary care facility as per norms in high priority districts (population as well as time to reach norms) by 2025.
8. Health Management Information
 - a. Ensure district - level electronic database of information on health system components by 2020.
 - b. Strengthen the health surveillance system and establish registries for diseases of public health importance by 2020.
 - c. Establish federated integrated health information architecture, Health Information Exchanges and National Health Information Network by 2025.

However, health is still not a justiciable right. A National Health Rights Act on the lines of the Right to Education Act 2005 would ensure that Right to Health gets the same status as Right to Education. A health cess was also introduced in the draft policy by the Health Ministry to scale up public investments in healthcare but it has now been dropped off from the final policy. The health sector expenditure of the government has not exceeded 2 percent of the GDP, even once, in the past 15 years, even though different political parties have formed the National government since then and inspite of government stating it as a goal in 2002 policy. The 2002 National Health Policy had set the target of eliminating leprosy by 2005, lymphatic filariasis by 2015 and kala azar by 2010, none of which could be achieved yet. Therefore, the issues of **old targets and new deadlines** remain as it is.

To what extent, do you think, the Health Policy 2017 addresses the concerns of the healthcare sector in India?

9.4.3. National Mental Healthcare Act 2017:

The National Mental Healthcare Act provides for mental healthcare and services for persons with psychological illnesses and to protect, promote and fulfil the rights of such persons during delivery of such health services. According to the policy, every person should have the right to access mental healthcare services, which should be convenient, affordable, accessible and of good quality. The Act further seeks to protect such persons from inhuman treatment, by helping them gain access to free legal services and their medical records, and providing them the right to complain in the event of deficiencies in provisions. The Act also provides for “Advance Directive”- according to which, a mentally ill person has the right to make an advance declaration to choose his/her nominative representative and also list down the way he/she wants to be treated for the illness. This directive has to be vetted by a medical practitioner. The government also has to set up the Central Mental Health Authority at National level and State Mental Health Authority in every state.

The Act outlines the procedure and process for admission, treatment, and subsequent discharge of mentally ill persons. It decriminalizes any suicide attempt by a mentally ill person but other suicides are still dealt as criminal cases under IPC. It also mandates the government to rehabilitate such persons and monitor them so that there is no recurrence of a suicide attempt. According to the Act, a person with mental illness should not be subjected to electroconvulsive therapy (ECT) therapy without the use of muscle relaxants and anaesthesia. Further, ECT therapy should not be performed on minors. Moreover, a police officer in charge of a police station is duty bound to report to the Magistrate, if, he feels that a mentally ill person is being ill-treated or neglected in their premises. The Act also imposes a duty on the police officers to take any wandering person under protection; subject them to examination by a medical officer and based on such examination, either admit them to a mental health establishment or take them to their residence or to an establishment for homeless persons. Further, the punishment for violation of provisions under this Act would be imprisonment up to 6 months or Rs. 10,000 or both. Repeat offenders could face up to 2 years in jail or a fine of Rs. 50,000–5 lakhs or both.

Status of mental health in India:

Mental illnesses include anxiety related, psychotic related, mood related, substance use related, personality related or eating related disorders. Majority of suicides in the world are related to psychiatric problems or to the illnesses listed above. In 2016, globally, the suicide rate was 10.6 per 1,00,000 population whereas in India, it was 16.3 per 1,00,000. The suicide rate was also higher among males as compared to females. Moreover, these challenges need to be considered more seriously in the wake of COVID-19 as mental health issues have widely been prevalent among the Indian population due to lockdowns and related issues. A Lancet report revealed that one in seven people in India had a mental disorder ranging from mild to severe in 2017. Mental disorders like depression, anxiety, schizophrenia, bipolar disorder have been found to be generally worse in the southern States as compared to the northern States. Depressive disorders have also been found to be more prevalent among females than males which could be due to gender discrimination, sexual abuse, stress due to antenatal and postnatal issues, etc.

As per National Family Health Survey, government expenditure on hospitals dealing with mental health issues as a percentage of total mental healthcare government expenditure is 1.3% in India; in developed countries, it ranges from 3% to 15%. According to the WHO, in India, the share of mental hospitals per 1,00,000 people is as low as 0.01 (in line with developing countries). This may possibly be due to the lack of focused attention given to mental health compared to other major diseases in India. Nurses, social workers, psychiatrists/psychologists working in the mental health sector in India are 0.796, 0.065, and 0.069, respectively, per 1,00,000 population. The leading countries in each of these three areas have 150.3,

145.4, and 222.6 per 1,00,000 people. India's ranking in this context among the WHO member countries is also poor- 97th, 79th and 104th, respectively.

9.4.4. Ayushman Bharat (PMJAY) – National Health Protection Mission (AB-NHPM):

The announcement of Ayushman Bharat - National Health Protection Mission (AB-NHPM) is one of the major policy initiatives of the government, for the vulnerable section of the Indian population. If implemented effectively, it would help the nation move closer to the Sustainable Development Goal of 'Universal Health Coverage'. AB-NHPM is expected to have a far-reaching impact on the entire Indian healthcare and insurance landscape. The initiatives under it are as follows:

1. **Health and Wellness Centre:** 1.5 lakh centres have been planned to set-up to bring health care system closer to people's homes. These centres would provide comprehensive health care, including for non-communicable diseases, maternal and child health services, etc. These centres would also provide free essential drugs and diagnostic services. Even the National Health Policy, 2017 had envisioned Health and Wellness Centres as the foundation of India's health system. The Budget-2019 had allocated Rs.1200 crore for this flagship scheme. Private Sector participation in the form of CSR- Corporate Social Responsibility and philanthropic institutions in adopting these centres has also been envisaged.
2. **National Health Protection Scheme:** The second flagship programme under Ayushman Bharat is National Health Protection Scheme, which aims to cover over 10 crore poor and vulnerable families (approximately 50 crore beneficiaries) and providing them coverage upto 5 lakh rupees per family per year for secondary and tertiary care hospitalization. If implemented effectively, it would be the world's largest government funded health care programme. As a result, adequate funds would be needed for smooth implementation of this programme.

The **Alma-Ata Declaration** of 1978 is a major milestone in the field of public health, as it identified primary health care as the key to the attainment of the goal of **Health for All**. According to it, primary health care should include awareness concerning prevailing health problems; promotion of adequate food and water supply, proper nutrition and basic sanitation; maternal and child health care, including family planning; immunization against major infectious diseases; promotion of mental health and provision of essential drugs.

9.4.5. National Digital Health Mission, 2020:

National Digital Health Mission (NDHM) is a voluntary healthcare programme that aims to reduce the gap among stakeholders such as doctors, hospitals and other healthcare providers by bringing them together and connecting them in an integrated digital health infrastructure. The mission comprises six key building blocks or digital systems namely HealthID, DigiDoctor, Health Facility Registry, Personal Health Records, e-Pharmacy & telemedicine. Health ID is a 14-digit serial number which will be generated for each individual. The ID will be a repository of all health-related information of a person such as medical tests, previous prescriptions, diagnosis, treatments and all historical health records. The National Health Authority(NHA) would design, build, roll-out and implement the mission.

The NDHM will help in developing the diagnostics and management of health services. Apart from that, the NDHM will also help in achieving broader public health monitoring, research, socio-economic studies, prioritizing resource allocation and policy interventions, etc. Digitization can make healthcare more organized, effective, and efficient. But we must know that digitization can't substitute the fundamentals like an investment in nutrition and welfare, primary healthcare services and healthcare professionals, etc. India needs to carefully develop various ways to fulfil the "health needs of the public". India needs to carefully examine the following things and their improvement with digitization. Such as, ways of facilitating better diagnosis and management,

understanding of the data structures for effective health services, and alleviate health problems with digitization such as malnutrition and child stunting, etc.

It may also create tensions between a collection of digital health data and individual rights to privacy. For example, many countries like UK, Sweden, the US, etc. attempted to build digital health infrastructures they were not successful due to serious privacy-related controversies. This data may be linked to other sectors such as banking and services with adequate access to data, which further creates two types of challenges. One, not linking the digital health data with other sectors will make the potential uses of digital health data very limited, and two, complete interlinking of digital health data will create various problems such as privacy violation, the vulnerability of data to profit-motivated pharma companies, etc. Access to digital data requires identifying and understanding the complexity in various data sources such as immunization records, data in government and private hospitals, diagnostic centres, etc. The design should also include an understanding of data generation frequency, error models, sharing and other operational requirements, etc. Building an effective system that can generate people's trust requires building a transparent process. That process should have openness and public consultations in all spheres of development. So, developing a comprehensive digital health infrastructure not only depends on the health sector alone, rather, it also depends on e-governance and the administration of digitization in India.

e-Health:

To take up the Digital India initiative ahead, MoHFW has started various e-Government initiatives in health care sectors in India, under the e-Health division. e-Health is broadly defined as the use of Information and Communication Technology (ICT) in health. It has a huge potential to improve healthcare services in India, where mobile technologies have been penetrating at rapid rate. The e-Health initiatives aim to deliver better health outcomes in terms of access, affordability, quality, lowering of disease burden and efficient monitoring of health entitlements of citizens. Benefits can be described in the form of 10 e's in 'e-Health' namely- efficiency, enhancing quality, evidence based, empowerment of consumers and patients, encourage, education, enabling information exchange, extending scope of health care, ethics and equity in provision of health services.

9.5. Other government initiatives

Rogi Kalyan Samiti (Patient Welfare Committees) / Hospital Management Committees are simple yet effective health management institutions. These committees, are a registered society, and act as a group of trustees for the hospitals to manage the affairs of the hospital. They consist of members from local NGOs, Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs), local elected representatives and officials from government sector. They ensure compliance to minimal standards for facilities and hospital care and protocols of treatment, as issued by the Government.

Accredited Social Health Activists (ASHA) are the first port of call in the communities, especially for marginalized sections of the society, with a major focus on women and children. More than 9 lakh ASHAs are in place across the country and serve as facilitators, mobilizers and providers of community level care. The ASHA scheme is presently in place in 33 states and UTs (except Goa, Chandigarh & Puducherry). After the launch of National Urban Health Mission in 2013, ASHA workers are being employed in urban areas as well.

National Quality Assurance Programme for improving Quality of care at public health facilities, Operational Guidelines for Quality Assurance in Public Health Facilities and Quality Standards for DHs, CHCs, PHCs and Urban PHCs (UPHCs) were released. These Standards have also received international accreditation by International Society for Quality in Healthcare (ISQua). **Kayakalp - an initiative for recognizing good Public Health Facilities** was launched to promote cleanliness, hygiene and infection control practices in public health facilities wherein under public healthcare, such facilities are appraised and those facilities that show exemplary

performance, meeting standards of protocols of cleanliness, hygiene and infection control, receive awards and commendation. For this, Swachhta Guidelines for public health facilities have also been released.

e-Rakt Kosh is a centralized blood bank management system to assist revamping of the existing systems and processes through process re-engineering and automating data entry, search and availability of blood and related components. **National Ambulance Services (NAS)**: At the time of launch of NRHM, such ambulances networks were non-existent. About 32 States/ UTs have the facility where people can dial 108 or 102 telephone number for calling an ambulance. **National Mobile Medical Units (NMMUs)** have been established with universal colour and design to increase visibility, awareness and accountability.

Janani Suraksha Yojana is a centrally sponsored scheme which is being implemented to reduce maternal and infant mortality by promotion of institutional delivery among pregnant women. Under the JSY, eligible pregnant women are entitled for cash assistance irrespective of the age of mother and number of children, if they give birth in a government or government accredited private health facility. **Janani Shishu Suraksha Karyakaram (JSSK)** scheme's objective is also to benefit pregnant women who access government health facilities for their delivery. They are provided free and cashless health service, including pre-natal and ante-natal delivery services. This helps in motivating those women who still choose to deliver at their homes and rather encourages them to opt for institutional deliveries. All the States and UTs have initiated implementation of the scheme.

Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY), previously known as the Indira Gandhi Matritva Sahyog Yojana, is a maternity benefit program run by the government of India. It is a conditional cash transfer scheme for pregnant and lactating women of 19 years of age or above for the first live birth. It provides a partial wage compensation to women for wage-loss during childbirth and childcare and to provide conditions for safe delivery and good nutrition and feeding practices. In 2013, the scheme was brought under the National Food Security Act, 2013 to implement the provision of cash maternity benefit of ₹ 6,000 stated in the Act.

The **Mission Indradhanush** aims to cover all unvaccinated, or partially vaccinated children by 2020 against vaccine preventable diseases. India's Universal Immunisation Programme (UIP) provides free vaccines against 12 life threatening diseases, to 26 million children annually. The vaccination under UIP protects children against **Diphtheria, Pertussis, Tuberculosis, Tetanus, Hepatitis B, Polio, Pneumonia and Meningitis due to Haemophilus Influenzae type b (Hib), Rubella, Measles, Rotavirus diarrhoea and Japanese Encephalitis (JE)**. (Rubella, JE and Rotavirus vaccine in select states and districts).

National Ayush Mission –The basic objective of NAM is to promote AYUSH medical systems through cost effective AYUSH services, strengthening of educational systems, facilitate the enforcement of quality control of Ayurveda, Siddha and Unani & Homoeopathy (ASU&H) drugs and sustainable availability of ASU&H raw-materials.

The **National Nutrition Mission or POSHAN Abhiyan** was launched in 2018 with the goal of attaining "Kuposhan Mukta Bharat" or malnutrition-free India, by 2022. It aims to improve nutritional status of children from 0-6 years, adolescent girls, pregnant women and lactating mothers in a time bound manner. 50% of the total budget will come from World Bank or such other multilateral institutions and the rest would be financed through Centre's budgetary support. The scheme includes mapping of other schemes which address malnutrition, creating a robust ICT based real time monitoring system. It also incentivizes States/UTs for meeting their targets and Anganwadi Workers (AWWs) for using IT based tools. The scheme ensures convergence with various programmes and Ministries i.e., Anganwadi Services, Scheme for Adolescent Girls (SAG) of MWCD, Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY), Janani Suraksha Yojana (JSY), Public Distribution System (PDS), Department Food & Public Distribution, National Health Mission (NHM), Swachh-

Bharat Mission, Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS) and Ministry of Drinking Water & Sanitation.

Labour Room Quality Improvement Initiative or 'LaQshya' programme aims at improving quality of care in labour room and maternity Operation Theatre (OT). It aims to reduce maternal and new-born mortality & morbidity, improve the quality of care during delivery and immediate postpartum care. Its objectives also include enabling an effective two-way follow-up system to enhance satisfaction of beneficiaries visiting the health facilities and stabilizing complications and ensuring timely referrals. Provision of Respectful Maternity Care (RMC) to all pregnant women attending the public health facility is a foundation principle of this scheme.

National Health Fund (Rashtriya Arogya Nidhi) Scheme provides financial assistance to poor people suffering from major life threatening diseases, receive medical treatment at any super specialty govt. hospitals/institutes or govt. hospitals. Financial assistance upto 10 Lakhs will be funded for critical disease including cancer treatment of poor patients (Below poverty Line) at government hospitals.

Rashtriya Swasthya Bima Yojana (RSBY) is a centrally sponsored scheme, implemented by Ministry of Labour & Employment (MoLE) since 2008 under the Unorganized Workers' Social Security Act 2008. Initially it aimed to provide health insurance coverage to Below Poverty Line (BPL) families only, but later on 11 other categories of Unorganized Workers (UOWs) MGNREGA workers, construction workers, etc. were included. The scheme has now been transferred to the Ministry of Health & Family Welfare on an "as is where is" basis in 2015. The beneficiary family has to pay Rs. 30 per annum per family as registration/renewal fee and this amount is used by the state government to take care of the administrative cost for the scheme. The maximum premium payable is Rs. 750 per family. The scheme covers all pre-existing diseases and even hospitalization expenses. However, only secondary care hospitalization procedures are included in the scheme. Both public and private hospitals are empanelled under the scheme.

Ministry of Health and Family Welfare also issued a notification for the enforcement of **HIV/AIDS Act, 2017**, to provide legal recourse to protect the rights and interests of people suffering from HIV/AIDS. The act prohibits discrimination against person living with HIV in matters of employment, education, shelter, healthcare and insurance. HIV testing as a pre-requisite for employment or education or healthcare is prohibited. The Act also makes anti-retroviral treatment a legal right and adopts test and treat policy. It also states that no HIV positive person can be subjected to medical intervention without prior consent, including pregnant women.

The **National TB Control Programme** was started in 1962 with the aim to detect and treat tuberculosis cases at the earliest. With the declared objective of universal access to early quality diagnosis and quality TB care for all TB patients, the Revised National Tuberculosis Control Programme (RNTCP), based on the Directly Observed Treatment, Short Course (DOTS) strategy, began as a pilot project in 1993 and was launched as a national programme in 1997. RNTCP is being implemented through 13,000+ designated microscopy centres and free treatment across the nation through 4 lakh DOT centres. The major focus was early and complete detection of all TB cases, including drug resistant TB and HIV-associated TB in the community, with greater engagement of private sector for improving care to all TB patients. The National Strategic Plan for 2017- 25 for TB elimination in India builds on the success and learnings of the previous programmes and encapsulates the innovative and bold steps required to eliminate Tuberculosis in India by 2030. It is designed in line with other health sector strategies and global efforts, such as the National Health Policy, World Health Organization's End TB Strategy, and the Sustainable Development Goals of the United Nations (UN).

National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority, is an independent body set up in 1997 under the Department of Pharmaceuticals, Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers. Its mandate is to fix/revise controlled

bulk drug prices and formulations, enforce prices and availability of medicines under Drug Price (Control) Order, 2013. It collects/maintains data on production, exports and imports, profitability of companies etc. for bulk drugs and formulations. The **National list of essential medicines** is one of the major instruments in a balanced healthcare delivery system of a country which includes accessible and affordable quality medicines at all the primary, secondary, tertiary levels of healthcare. It is prepared by Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, and contains a list of medicines considered essential for India's health needs. The first National List of Essential Medicines of India was prepared and released in 1996 (Eighth plan). The purpose is to ensure that the medicines listed under NELM are available at a reasonable price to the general public.

Over the years, there have been several issues with the functioning of the **Medical Council of India** with respect to its regulatory role, composition, allegations of corruption, and lack of accountability. The **National Medical Commission Act, 2019**, therefore sought to remove such issues ensuring transparency and better medical standards. The Act aims at regulating medical education and ensuring better medical research and policies by medical professionals. It also ensures accountability of medical institutions through their periodic assessment. It provides for an effective grievance redressal mechanism and aims to help in addressing the issue of corruption as was seen in Medical Council of India. It also plans to reduce shortage of medical professionals by giving license to community health providers and ensure ethical standards in the medical practice through Ethics board.

However, the NMC composition lacks diverse stakeholders such as public health experts, social scientists, health economists, and health related non-government organizations, leading to a monopoly of doctors. Also, disputes related to ethics and misconduct in medical practice require judicial expertise and should not be handled by Ethics board alone. Moreover, with the proposed cap on fees, the costs for the remaining seats are likely to escalate, thereby putting medical education out of the reach of vast, especially underprivileged sections of the society. Meritorious students would then have to enrol themselves in institutions where the quality of education is low. Additionally, due to no provision of election for all the chief posts of these multiple bodies, corruption and favouritism is bound to increase. Also, States have been reduced to mere advisory roles from being in governance mode, leading to centralization of power. With the Advisory council comprising of more than 100 members, it would be difficult to reach a consensus on any issue in such an overwhelmingly large body. This will hit the decision making at the top.

The Act mentions that National Exit Test, which is to gain a licence to practice after MBBS, can also serve as an entrance examination to post-graduate level. It has left a lot of room for confusion. It seems that those who don't clear the exam will not be allowed to practise at all. This will lead to acute shortage of doctors in our country. Also, a strong evaluation framework with a strong regulatory governance is extremely important to prevent corruption in medical field and related governing bodies. However, the Act entrusts the inspection process upon Medical Assessment and Rating Board who can inspect on their own, but can even hire and authorize any other third party agency or persons for carrying out inspections. This will only increase corruption and crony capitalism. The Act also does not specify the validity period of the licence to practice. This can promote gross incompetence. Moreover, according to the Act, a community health service provider may prescribe specified medicine independently, which legalizes quackery and a six-month course will not be enough to train such personnel.

The **National Family Health Survey** (NFHS) is a large-scale, multi-round survey conducted based on the representative samples collected from households throughout India. It provides state and national information for India on various health parameters such as fertility, infant and child mortality, the practice of family planning, maternal and child health, reproductive health, nutrition, anaemia, utilization and quality of health and family planning services. Every National Family Health Survey (NFHS) has two specific goals to fulfill. They include- to provide essential data needed by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare and other agencies

for informed decision making and policy and programme intervention purposes; and to provide insight regarding important emerging health and family welfare issues.

The MOHFW in December 2020, released Phase – I of NFHS-5 comprising data for 22 states/UTs. NFHS-5 also included some new topics such as preschool education, disability, access to a toilet facility, death registration, bathing practices during menstruation (menstrual hygiene), methods and reasons for abortion, components of micro-nutrients to children, frequency of alcohol and tobacco use, additional components of non-communicable diseases (NCDs), expanded age ranges for measuring hypertension and diabetes among all aged 15 years and above etc.

Of the 22 States and UTs, there is an increase in the prevalence of severe acute malnutrition in 16 States/UTs (compared to NFHS-4). Anaemia levels among children as well as adult women have increased in most of the States with a decline in anaemia among children being seen only in four States/UTs. The percentage of children under five who are underweight has also increased in 16 out of the 22 States/UTs. The data reports an increase in childhood stunting in 13 of the 22 States/UTs compared to the data of NFHS-4. Most States/UTs also see an increase in overweight/obesity prevalence among children and adults, once again drawing attention to the inadequacy of diets in India both in terms of quality and quantity. In the Hunger Watch survey carried out in 11 States, two-thirds of the respondents reported that the nutritional quality and quantity of their diets worsened in September-October compared to before the lockdown. The survey has found considerable improvement in vaccination coverage among children aged 12-23 months across all States/UTs. However, volunteers of the Right to Food campaign have listed over 100 starvation deaths based on media and/or verified fact-finding reports since 2015.

National Family Health Survey:

NFHS is released by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MOHFW), but it has designated, the International Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS), Mumbai, as the nodal agency. The IIPS is responsible for providing coordination and technical guidance for the survey. Many international agencies provide funds to carry out the NFHS. They are, United States Agency for International Development (USAID), The Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, Department for International Development (DFID), United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF), United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), etc. There are 5 rounds of National Family Health Surveys (NFHS) conducted so far in India. They are, NFHS-1 in 1992-93, NFHS-2 in 1998-99, NFHS-3 in 2005-06, NFHS-4 in 2015-16 and NFHS-5 in 2019-20. Since NFHS-4, the survey introduced district-level estimates for many important indicators and also included other UTs to provide holistic information.

9.6. Issues with the health sector

Despite significant progress in India's health sector, especially since the launch of National Health Mission, challenges remain. The availability of health care services provided by both the public and private sectors taken together, is inadequate. Moreover, their quality of healthcare services vary considerably as regulatory standards for public and private hospitals are not adequately defined and, are ineffectively enforced. As a result, the affordability of healthcare is a serious problem for the vast majority of the population, especially at the tertiary level.

Despite so many health programmes and policies and rapid economic growth, India has witnessed a surge in diseases capable of adversely affecting the health of its population. Rising prosperity, where the proportion of people living in poverty fell by half in the 25 years leading to 2016, has been marked by a “**dual-disease burden**”. It is a continuing pressure of communicable diseases and a spurt in non-communicable or “lifestyle” diseases such as diabetes, cardiovascular diseases and hypertension, etc. which accounted for more

than 60% of all deaths in 2015, from 42% in 2001-03. Increasing industrialization, urbanization and environmental degradation have **polluted both water and air**. There is also an increased risk of road traffic accidents, injury and violence, mental health disorder and substance abuse. The **infectious and parasitic diseases** are on the rise. Known avoidable environmental risk factors cause at least 13 million deaths every year and about one quarter of the global burden of disease. There is also an increased risk of road traffic accidents, injury and violence, mental health disorder and substance abuse. According to World Bank estimates India is ranked 2nd in the number of children suffering from **malnutrition**. **Undernutrition** is found mostly in rural areas. Major form of nutrition deficiency is reflected in protein energy malnutrition (marasmus and kwashiorkor). 80 percent children have mild to moderate Protein Energy Malnutrition (PEM). India has highest number of nutritional anaemia among women and children.

Around 62% of health expenditure incurred by Indians is met using personal savings (called “**out-of-pocket expenses**”), compared with 10% in the UK, 13.4% in the U.S. and 54% in China. There is also a prevalence of **urban vs. rural divide** in access to healthcare. According to a report by KPMG, the majority of Indian healthcare professionals are concentrated in and around urban areas, leaving rural areas as under-served. This can be attributed to the higher spending power of consumers in towns and cities. Nearly **80% of all doctors, 75% of all dispensaries and 60% of all hospitals are located in urban areas**, even though a majority of the Indian population lives in rural areas. Doctors in India are catering to atleast a third of the urban population (more than 442 million people).

There is one state-run hospital for every 90,343 citizens, one government doctor for every 14,56 people and one government hospital bed for every 2,046 individuals respectively, indicating **lack of adequate health infrastructure**. In comparison to these grim numbers, the US has one hospital bed for every 345 citizens and 24.5 doctors for every 10,000 people. According to the government health and family welfare statistics, India also faces a **shortage of specialist doctors** at rural community health centres. Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority (IRDA) has stated that India's **per capita healthcare expenditure is one of the lowest** in the world. What makes this fact more dismal is that the government's contribution to insurance stands at around 32%, as compared with 83.5% in the UK. 76% of Indians do not possess health insurance, which results in the high out-of-pocket expenditure incurred by the citizens of this country.

Even though the fiscal capacity of the country to raise revenues increased substantially from 5% of GDP in 1950-51 to 17% in 2016-17, India has not sufficiently invested in health. The government's **public spending on health** continues to hover around 1% of GDP since many decades, accounting for less than 30% of the total health expenditure. Besides low public spending, neither the Central nor the State governments have undertaken any significant policy intervention, except the National Health Mission, to redress the issue of widening socio-economic inequalities in health. Also the NHM, with a budget of less than 0.2% of GDP, is far too less to make any major impact. And worryingly, the budgetary provision for the NHM had been decreased by 2% in 2018-19 from the previous year. Moreover, the public expenditure on health in India which is only 1.2% of the total health expenditure is extremely low when compared to what WHO recommends at 5%.

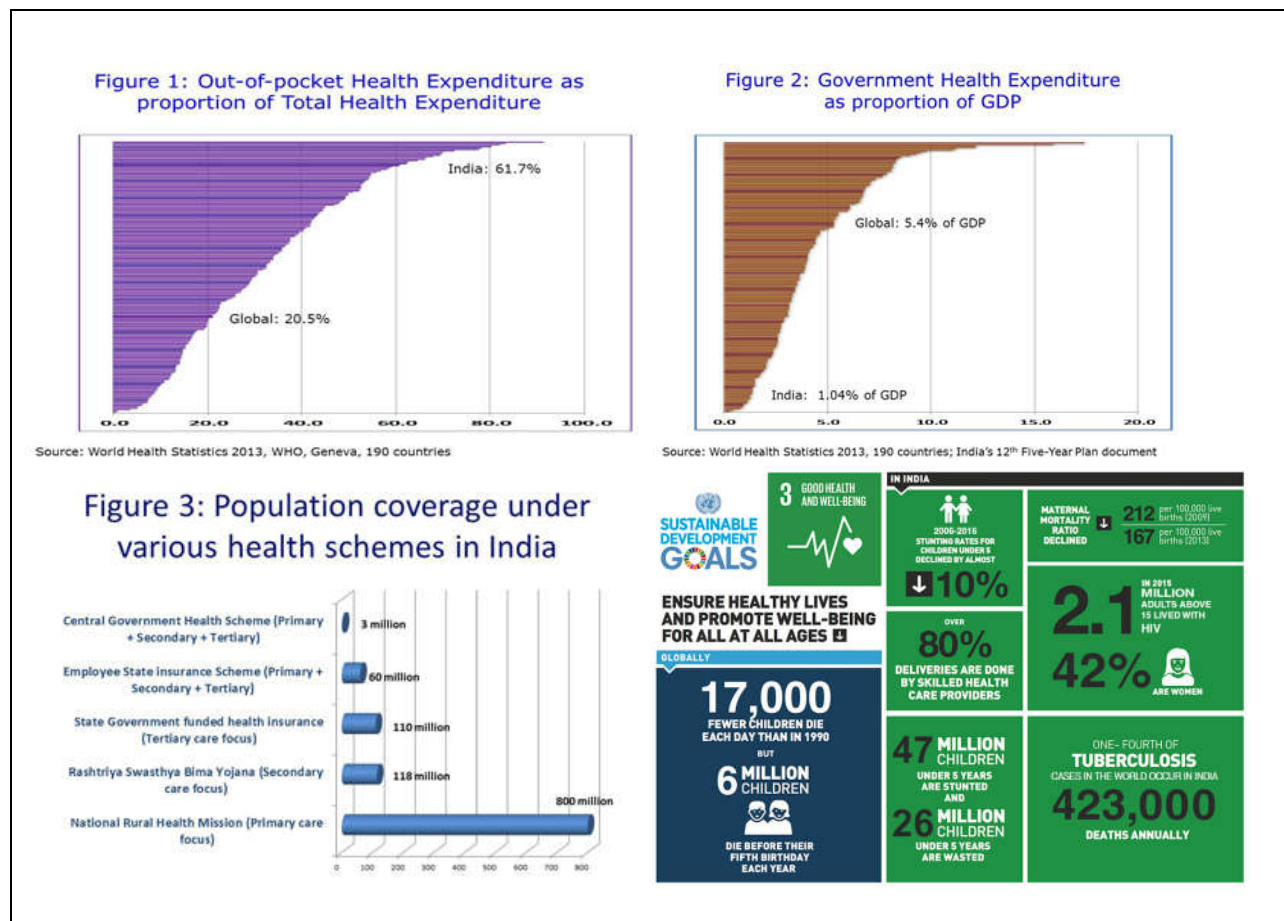
A major infrastructural challenge which India faces is shoring up or augmenting its production at home, whether pertaining to health system, medicines or vaccines. **COVID** has laid bare the lacunae in the Indian healthcare sector and has shown that India has been lacking in its own dispersal of healthcare amongst its own people. Glaring examples of lack of adequate medical care, bed, ventilators, medicines and oxygen were witnessed during the second wave. It has also impacted the health of individuals who have contracted the virus. In India, by August 2021, we have already lost more than 4.5 lakh people to COVID. Moreover, mutations and new variants are happening frequently and causing agonizing health problems and complications. The neglect of other non-communicable diseases would increase their burden in the long run. The elective surgeries getting postponement can lead to detrimental brunt on the quality of life among such patients. Further, a study

commissioned by the Stop TB Partnership reported that with this lockdown and protracted time to refurbish all the services, the efforts gained during the last 5–8 years to combat TB will get lost. The rise in cases of anxiety, depression, and suicide among people during lockdown because of forced isolation, domestic violence, and unemployment is quite detrimental. As per a survey conducted by the Indian Psychiatry Society, mental health illnesses have increased 20% during the lockdowns, with at least one in every fifth individual getting affected. Experts have warned that mental health disorders can be India's next crises and it will be difficult to deal with it in the long run.

Also, with the **COVID-19 pandemic** around the corner, there has been a diversion of resources for controlling corona cases leading to undermining availability and accessibility of health services. Diverging the 1.4 million Anganwadi workers and 1.3 million ASHAs in managing COVID-19 has strongly disrupted the maternal and child healthcare schemes. Routine vaccinations like MMR vaccinations have gone down by 69%. Almost 100,000 children could not receive BCG vaccine and around 200,000 children also missed their pentavalent vaccine doses. Estimates reveal that there will be an increase in maternal mortality, infant mortality, and anaemia due to the lack of antenatal check-ups. Also restricted maternal and child healthcare would lead to rise in unmet need for contraception and unsafe abortions.

Current status

Following graphs represent the current status of universal health coverage in India.



9.7. Universal health coverage

All nations of the world had assembled at the United Nations in 2015, to adopt the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), among which a key target of the health-related goals is to achieve Universal Health Coverage for all by 2030. "Universal coverage" refers to a scenario wherein every person is covered for basic healthcare services. Under UHC, all Indian citizens, regardless of their social, economic or cultural backgrounds will have the right to access affordable, appropriate and accountable health services of assured quality, defined in a published package of benefits and services. It is also a supplementary system of financing to protect people from rising medical costs. The National Health Package shall have a choice of facilities that are guaranteed by the government and will cover all primary, secondary and some tertiary care services, free-of-charge.



9.8. Patient Rights Charter

A patient rights charter is an official government document that lists down the rights and entitlements of patients, which should be honoured by all healthcare establishments in the country. One of the big health debates is the protection of patients in our poorly regulated medical sector, and the adoption and implementation of the Charter for Patient's Rights can help strengthen such protections. News reports confirm about several cases of violations of patients' rights by hospitals and doctors. While "Right to non-discrimination" i.e. every patient having the right to receive treatment without any discrimination based on his or her illness or condition, including HIV status or any other health condition, caste, religion, ethnicity, or sexual orientation; is an important right, it is often violated when patients are denied treatments. As per the Supreme Court rulings, all hospitals, both government and the private sector, are duty-bound to provide basic emergency medical care to injured persons. Such care should be initiated without demanding any payment or advance, and it must be provided irrespective of the patient's paying capability. However, this right is violated most of the time by hospitals, specially seen during the COVID-19 pandemic.

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) has even formulated a comprehensive Patients' Rights Charter, delineating 17 rights which pertain to the rights of the patients over information about their illness, treatment and costs; their right to seek second opinion; the right to access records and reports; the right to transparency in rates; the right to emergency medical care irrespective of paying capacity; the right to discharge a patient or receive a dead body, without detention by the hospital; right to choose a pharmacy or pathology laboratory; and the right to grievance redressal. Also, the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, had issued a letter to all state governments outlining a smaller set of rights and some additional responsibilities for patients. This set of do's and don'ts must be publicized and implemented by all state governments. All public hospitals, charitable hospitals with public obligations, and private hospitals involved in health insurance

schemes (like Ayushman Bharat-PMJAY) must display the charter in their premises. This will set the stage for all private hospitals to also implement this charter.

One Health:

One Health is an approach that recognizes that the health of people is closely connected to the health of animals and our shared environment. According to WHO, 'One Health' is an approach of designing and implementing programmes, policies, legislation and research in which multiple sectors communicate and work together to achieve better public health outcomes. One Health is not new, but it has become more important in recent years. Need and significance of One Health in context of rising zoonotic infections is as follows:

1. **Risk of disease:** Human populations are growing and expanding into new geographic areas. As a result, more people live in close contact with wild and domestic animals, both livestock and pets. Animals play an important role in our lives. Close contact with animals and their environments provides more opportunities for diseases to pass between animals and people.
2. **Climate change:** The earth has experienced changes in climate and land use, such as deforestation and intensive farming practices. Disruptions in environmental conditions and habitats can provide new opportunities for diseases to pass to animals.
3. **Global movement:** The movement of people, animals, and animal products has increased from international travel and trade. As a result, diseases can spread quickly across borders and around the globe.
4. **Collaborative effort:** Many of the same microbes infect animals and humans, as they share the ecosystems they live in. Efforts by just one sector cannot prevent or eliminate the problem. For instance, rabies in humans is effectively prevented only by targeting the animal source of the virus (for example, by vaccinating dogs).
5. **Combating disease threat:** The areas of work in which a One Health approach is particularly relevant include food safety, the control of zoonosis (diseases that can spread between animals and humans, such as flu, rabies and Rift Valley Fever) and combating antibiotic resistance.
6. **Information on viral agents:** Information on viruses circulating in animals is crucial to the selection of viruses for human vaccines for potential influenza pandemics.
7. **Well-coordinated approach:** Drug-resistant microbes can be transmitted between animals and humans through direct contact between animals and humans or through contaminated food, so to effectively contain it, a well-coordinated approach in humans and in animals is required.

Successful public health interventions require the cooperation of human, animal, and environmental health partners. Professionals in human health (doctors, nurses, public health practitioners, epidemiologists), animal health (veterinarians, paraprofessionals, agricultural workers), environment (ecologists, wildlife experts), and other areas of expertise need to communicate, collaborate on, and coordinate activities. By promoting collaboration across all sectors, a One Health approach can achieve the best health outcomes for people, animals, and plants in a shared environment.

To sum up the discussion, while challenges are bound to be there, the Indian healthcare industry has innumerable opportunities to flourish in the coming years. Big data analytics can be taken up for tracking patient data, treatment, prescription, etc. Focus should be on primary care by investing in the development and growth of the PHCs and making rural service mandatory for a medical student. Increase in the public health expenditure on health (2.5% recommended) under the National Health Policy 2017. An effective implementation of schemes such as Rashtriya Swasthya Suraksha Yojana can increase the insurance penetration. Start-ups are increasingly investing in the diversified sectors of healthcare from process automation to low-cost innovations.

There is a need for a proactive and dynamic approach to meet the rising demand for quality healthcare in India. The active collaboration of health care experts, stakeholders, and key participants can improve the quality, efficacy, and accountability of the Indian healthcare industry.

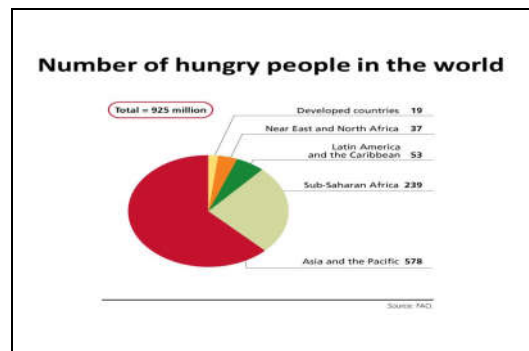
The international community, through **Sustainable Development Goal 3**, has committed itself to a global effort to eradicate disease, strengthen treatment and healthcare, and address new and emerging health issues. It calls for innovation, and research in these areas to further enhance public policy efforts. A holistic approach to better health will require ensuring universal access to healthcare and to making medicine and vaccines affordable. It also calls for a renewed focus on mental health issues. Proper allocation of fund for the health sector is prerequisite for improving the health of the health sector in India.

9.9. Hunger and malnutrition

Food security exists when all people, at all times have physical and economic access to sufficient, safe and nutritious food that meets their dietary needs and food preferences for an active healthy life.

- 1996 World Food Summit

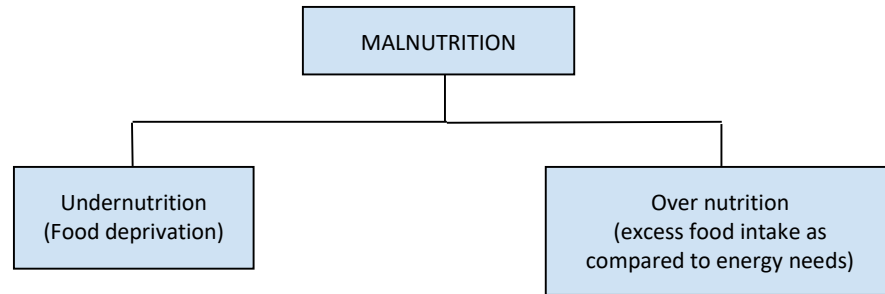
The **Global Hunger Index 2020** ranked **India** at **94th position** out of 107 countries. For a country that is the largest producer of a number of food grains in the world, it is indeed an alarming situation. The chapter aims to cover different dimensions of hunger- its causes, challenges in addressing situations of hunger and what is the way forward to deal with it. The **Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO)** defines hunger as, “an uncomfortable and painful sensation caused by insufficient food energy consumption.” The average minimum energy requirement per person is about 1800 kilocalorie per day. The exact requirement is determined by a person's age, body size, physiological conditions and activity levels. **Scientifically, hunger is referred to as food deprivation.**



Healthy living not only needs access to food but also access to nutritional food. Any deviation from the required nutritional needs falls under malnutrition.

9.9.1. What is Malnutrition?

FAO defines malnutrition as “a broad term for a range of conditions that hinder good health, caused by inadequate or unbalanced food intake or from poor absorption of food consumed.”



Both the above mentioned aspects of malnutrition result in varying health conditions. The outcomes of malnutrition process can be summed up as:

Under-nutrition	Over-nutrition
1. Stunting - low height for age 2. Wasting - low weight for height 3. Underweight - low weight for age 4. Micronutrient deficiency - absence of vital vitamins and minerals	1. Obesity - excess weight 2. Cardiovascular diseases - due to excess oil and fat consumption 3. Diabetes - due to excess carbohydrates/sugar intake 4. Other non-communicable diseases

The State of Food Insecurity Report (SOFI) by FAO highlights the interconnected nature of both forms of malnutrition. Following figure shows how we move from a stage of food insecurity to over nutrition as economy progresses:

The Global Hunger Index

The Global Hunger Index (GHI) is a tool that measures and tracks hunger globally as well as by region and by country, prepared by European NGOs of Concern Worldwide and Welthungerhilfe. The GHI is calculated annually, and its results appear in a report issued in October each year.

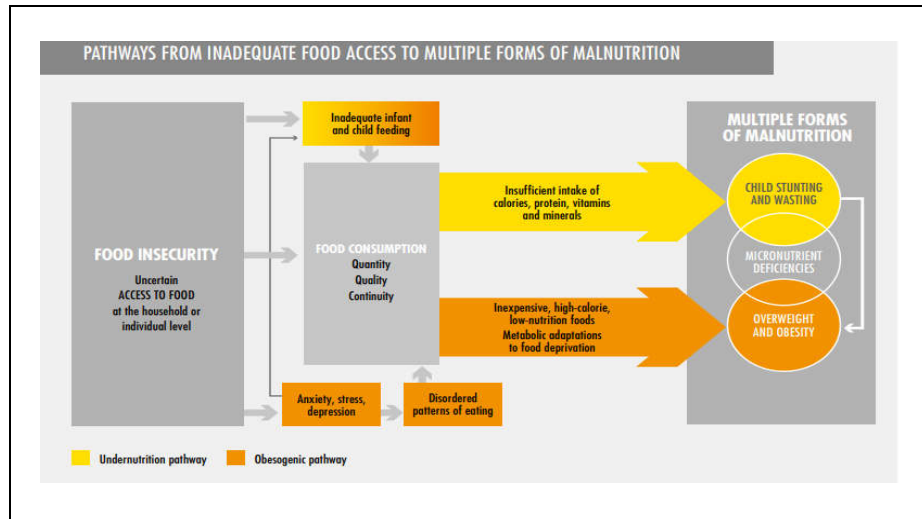
The GHI combines 4 component indicators:

1. the proportion of the undernourished as a percentage of the population
2. the proportion of children under five suffering from wasting, a sign of acute undernutrition
3. the proportion of children under five suffering from stunted growth, a sign of chronic undernutrition
4. child mortality under the age of five

In 2020, India was ranked 94th out of 107 countries. Now, in 2021 with 116 countries in the fray, it has dropped to 101st rank.

India's GHI score has also decelerated -- from 38.8 in 2000 to the range of 28.8 - 27.5 between 2012 and 2021. The share of wasting among children in India rose from 17.1 per cent between 1998-2002 to 17.3 per cent between 2016-2020, according to the report.

However, India has shown improvement in other indicators such as the under-5 mortality rate, prevalence of stunting among children and prevalence of undernourishment owing to inadequate food, the report said.

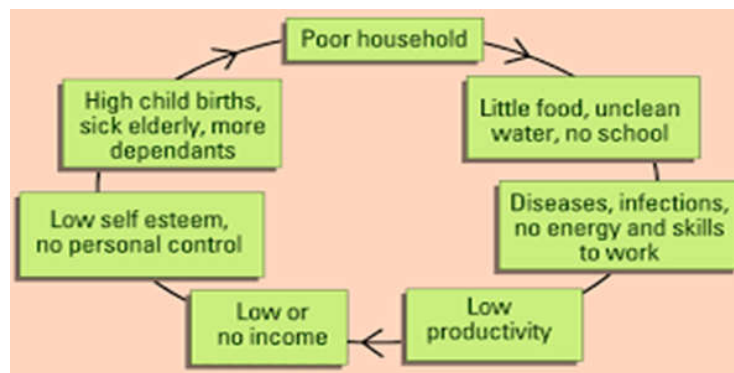


9.9.2. Measurement of hunger and malnutrition

FAO measures hunger as a form of undernourishment. It involves the proportion of population whose energy consumption is below a dietary threshold. However, both hunger and malnutrition are subjective conditions which depend on physiology, age as well as terrain of living. There have been indirect methods to ascertain the levels of hunger and malnutrition. Most common among them are:

1. **Household income and expenditure surveys** - **World Bank** estimates that for every 10% increase in per capita income, stunting reduces by 3% and wasting reduces by 7%.
2. **Food intake surveys** - involves estimates of dietary intakes and relates it to energy needs e.g. the nutrition requirements to assess poverty in India have been placed at 2400 Kilocalorie for rural and 2100 for urban areas respectively

Assessment of poverty levels have often been extrapolated to ascertain instances of hunger and malnutrition. However, poverty, hunger and malnutrition are mutually reinforcing factors. Prevalence of one facilitates the existence of the other two:



Hunger and malnutrition - an Indian perspective

The **Human Development Index 2020** released by **UNDP** saw **India** placed at **131st** out of 189 countries in the list. With an HDI value of 0.64 India is placed in the **middle human development** category - a tag that does not mirror with the fastest growing emerging economy in the world. Between 1950 and 2017, India's HDI value increased from 0.42 to 0.64 - a 50% increase. This shows the efforts undertaken to lift millions out of hunger and malnutrition by the Indian state. However, the **National Family Health Survey (NFHS) - IV** data present a dismal picture. According to NFHS data:

1. Over 1/3rd of all under 5 children in India are stunted
2. Every 5th child in India suffers from wasting
3. More than 50% children are anaemic (iron deficiency) - 53% for women between 15 to 49 years of age.
4. More than 1/5th of adults suffer from over-nutrition

The **India State Level Disease Burden Report** (released by Indian Council of Medical Research, Public Health Foundation and Institute for Health Metrics and Evaluation) states that **for the first time in 2018, the number of non-communicable diseases in India surpassed the communicable diseases list** - a finding that does not augur well for a developing country such as India. The prime mover behind this has been instances of over-nutrition - leading to various forms of cardiovascular diseases even among adults.

9.9.3. Causes of hunger and malnutrition in India

Hunger and malnutrition result from deficiencies, excesses or imbalances in food intake as well as micro/macro nutrient consumption. It involves both **food insecurity** (Pre-access causes) as well as other **non-food factors** (Post-access causes)

Pre-access causes	Post-access causes
Ecological access - declining land productivity - groundwater depletion - soil salinization - desertification - droughts in rainfed areas - excessive fertilizer use imbalancing the nutrients in soil - climate change induced extreme events leads to crop losses Physical access - corruption and pilferage in PDS network - rapid urbanization encroaching into fertile lands - unprecedented population growth leading to very low per capita food production Economic access - inadequate purchasing power for farmers/landless labourers etc. - increasing input costs for farm production - lack of warehouses and cold storage leads to wastage of food - inadequate supply chains to preserve the perishables till delivery as well as provide them market linkages Failure of multilateral institutions - no solutions over Doha Development Agenda of WTO - lack of consensus over permanent solution for food subsidy programs - absence of Special Safeguard Mechanism	- Prevalence of Carbohydrates in diet - food gets consumed to alleviate hunger and not gather required nutrients (Angus Deaton - Nobel Prize winner in Economics) - Improper access to food at per capita level due to large family sizes Bias against girl child leading to undernourishment in girls - Practice of women eating at last leaves the residual food for her consumption. Moreover, iodine and iron deficiency is prevalent in pregnant women. Unhygienic conditions act as source of diseases that leads to loss of energy Open defecation as a source of many communicable diseases - mostly among children Unavailability of toilets - women tend to eat less in order to avoid relieving themselves in the open (Economic Survey - 2018) - Sub-standard quality of food grains provided through PDS due to lack of storage facilities as well as corruption by Fair Price Shop owners - Lack of proteins in the Mid-Day Meal diets - problems over egg as protein supplements - also issues over packaged fortified foods. Lack of both protein and calorie intake leads to protein energy malnutrition (PEM).

The situations mentioned above present a grim picture of the state of hunger and malnutrition. However, there are efforts going on both at the international and national levels to alleviate this menace. UN has recognized elimination of hunger as one of its **Sustainable Development Goals**.

9.10. International efforts to end hunger

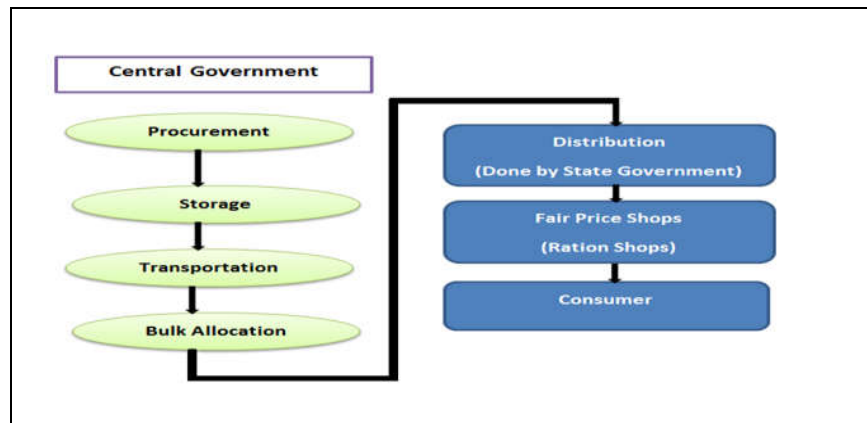
In a world of plenty, where enough food is produced to feed everyone on the planet, hunger should be a thing of the past. However, conflict, climate change, disasters, inequality and – most recently – the COVID-19 pandemic have resulted in one in nine people, globally, still going to bed hungry. The **World Food Programme** – is the food assistance branch of the United Nations and the world's largest humanitarian organization addressing hunger and promoting food security. It works in over 80 countries to bring life-saving food to people displaced by conflict and made destitute by disasters, and helps individuals and communities find life-changing solutions to the multiple challenges they face in building better futures. **Zero hunger** – is a top priority under the World Food Program that aims to end hunger, improve nutrition and promote sustainable agriculture. The second goal of the **Sustainable Development Goals** is also to end hunger by 2030.

9.11. Indian government initiatives to end hunger and malnutrition

The government remains committed to alleviating hunger and its effects upon the population. It is also important for India to remain a healthy nation in order to reap the **demographic dividend**.

9.11.1. Public Distribution System (PDS):

The objective of Public Distribution System is to ensure food security and poverty alleviation via provisions for essential commodities. It functions as:



Over the years, PDS has evolved from a general entitlement for all the citizens in the 1950s to a revamped PDS with focus towards poor/economically weaker families in 1992. Along with distribution of fixed amount of food grains, sugar and oils through government shops at prices lower than the market price, it also aimed at stopping pilferage and diversion to local markets. In 1997, it was transformed into a 'Targeted PDS'. It involved segregation of all ration card holders into Above Poverty Line (APL) and Below Poverty Line (BPL) families, which were identified by the respective states. BPL families are provided essential commodities at half the prices for APL families. As per **Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY)** – bottom most 2.5 crore BPL families get 35 kg of rice at Rs. 3/kg and wheat at Rs. 2/kg through the same Fair Price Shops. Senior citizens of 65 years of age and above if not covered under **National Old Age Pension Scheme** are provided 10 kg of food grains at free of cost.

However, there are certain limitations with Targeted PDS. The criteria for inclusion in the BPL list are solely economic – this is often underestimated/underreported because lack of availability of national income data. Persons having political patronage often find their names in BPL lists leading to inclusion errors. Due to poor identity verification mechanism – there are issues with Aadhaar authentication services as a result of which, the genuine poor are sometimes left out of the list. Families once admitted to BPL list perpetually

remain there even after moving out of BPL due to lack of periodic revision of the BPL list, implying the presence of only entry and no exit mechanism. Cases of **black marketing of food grains** by the FCI staff as well as Fair Price Shop owners are widely seen, for instance in Gujarat, where stones and soil were found in PDS stocks. Moreover, poor storage conditions at FCI godowns also leads to wastage.

In order to remove the deficiencies of PDS, the system needs to be reformed. Inclusion criteria could be shifted to exclusion criteria to leave out non-beneficiaries - respective states can decide on who needs to be excluded. Digitizing the entire system from procurement to distribution stage - FCI to Fair Price Shops to Consumer delivery would reduce **pilferage and black marketing**. We have already discussed Food Corporation of India in detail in the Post-Independence booklet. Aadhaar can be used for ascertaining identity and the verification procedures for senior citizens and differently abled can be eased out. PPP model can be adopted for godowns construction as well as transport - some states like Uttar Pradesh, have already started following this. Smart cards in the name of the eldest lady, can be used to procure commodities through Fair Price Shops. Also, in order to improve **nutritional security**, provisions of fortified food via PDS can be made to alleviate malnutrition.

9.11.2. National Food Security Act, 2013 (NFSA):

The National Food Security Act, 2013 gives right to subsidized food grains to 67% of the population and provides for penalty for non-compliance by public servants. Provisions of NFSA, 2013, include coverage of upto **75% of rural population** and upto **50% of the urban population** for receiving subsidized food grains under TPDS. Poorest households would continue to receive food grains under Antyodaya Anna Yojana. **Pregnant women** and **lactating mothers** would receive a **maternity benefit** of Rs. 6000. **Children aged 6 months to 14 years** would get **take home rations or hot cooked food**. Central government would also provide money to states and Union Territories if it has shortage/low stock of grains. Central government would provide assistance for cost of **intra-state transportation and handling of goods** and **oldest adult woman** in each house is to be considered as the **head of the household for issue of ration card**.

However, some issues and challenges with NFSA remain. Without addressing the inefficiencies in the delivery system, relative ability of state governments, can well defeat the very purpose of the scheme e.g. Bihar being a populous state also falls lowest on economic ability as compared to Gujarat. Procurement of huge quantity of food grains also needs proper storage and transport networks. The **fiscal burden** of such subsidized food grain distribution will also create a perpetual burden on government finances. Usage of Aadhaar for authentication of identity is problematic especially for elderly and differently abled.

For proper **identification of beneficiary**, an alternative mechanism is needed as BPL cards are proof of them being beneficiaries, but not a conclusive proof of being below poverty line. **Aadhaar would also need to be modified** to include comprehensive income data for genuine identification of beneficiaries. It currently only provides a unique identity but no proof of them being eligible beneficiaries. Broad consensus is required on the categories to be excluded and for uniformity purposes which can be provided by the central government.

The delivery of services to the beneficiaries is as follows:		
Services	Target Group	Service provided by
(i) Supplementary Nutrition	Children below 6 years, Pregnant & Lactating Mothers (P&LM)	Anganwadi Worker and Anganwadi Helper [MWCD]
(ii) Immunization*	Children below 6 years, Pregnant & Lactating Mothers (P&LM)	ANM/MO [Health system, MHFW]
(iii) Health Check-up*	Children below 6 years, Pregnant & Lactating Mothers (P&LM)	ANM/MO/AWW [Health system, MHFW]
(iv) Referral Services	Children below 6 years, Pregnant & Lactating Mothers (P&LM)	AWW/ANM/MO [Health system, MHFW]
(v) Pre-School Education	Children 3-6 years	AWW [MWCD]
(vi) Nutrition & Health Education	Women (15-45 years)	AWW/ANM/MO [Health system, MHFW & MWCD]

* AWW assists ANM in identifying the target group.

Objective of the scheme should not only be to 'feed' but also have a 'fit' population for demographic dividend and hence there should be focus on nutritional security as well. **Food management system** using digital tools to track the entire process from procurement to delivery, can also include public officials' data to identify the non-compliance. There is also a need to **augment storage capacity** for reducing spoilage of procured grains. The government should also lay emphasis on **improving agricultural productivity** to have food for the needy in a sustainable manner. Contract farming law is a welcome step with compulsory provisions of procurement which will ensure incomes for the producer.

9.11.3. Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS) Scheme:

It is the foremost symbol of India's commitment to its children and nursing mothers, as a response to the challenge of providing pre-school non-formal education on one-hand and breaking the vicious cycle of malnutrition, morbidity, reduced learning capacity and mortality on the other. The beneficiaries under the scheme are **children aged 0-6 years, pregnant women and lactating mothers**. The objective of the scheme is to lay the foundation of proper psychological, physical and social development of the child and reduce the incidence of mortality, morbidity, malnutrition and school dropouts. It also focuses on enhancing the capability of the mother to look after her normal health and nutritional needs of the child through proper nutrition and health education.

ICDS primarily focuses on delivery of pre-school education and hot cooked meals as well as monitoring of the services through Anganwadi centres for children between 3-6 years. However, over 80% of brain growth of the child takes place in first 1000 days where the focus is lacking. **NFHS IV** - the survey points that only 10% of children between 6 and 13 months received an adequate diet in 2015-16. Shortage of staff and field workers, poor monitoring, instances of food pilferage, poor quality of services are some persistent problems plaguing the efficient implementation of ICDS. Moreover, multidimensional determinants of undernutrition are inadequately reflected in policymaking.

9.11.4. Mid-Day Meal Scheme (MDM):

Mid-day meals in schools have had a long history in India. In 1925, a Mid-Day Meal programme was introduced for disadvantaged children by Madras Municipal Corporation. With a view to enhancing enrolment, retention and attendance and simultaneously improving nutritional levels among children, the National Program of Nutrition Support to Primary Education (NP-NSPE) was launched as a Centrally Sponsored Scheme on 15th August 1995. In September 2004, the scheme was revised to provide cooked mid-day meal with 300 calories and 8-12 grams of proteins to all children between class 1 and 5 in Government aided schools/EGS/AIE centres. The scheme also provides cooking cost and transport subsidy of food grains for the children. In 2007 the scheme was further revised to cover children in upper primary classes (6 to 8) in Educationally Backward Blocks. Cost of kitchen construction etc. have been determined on terrain and geographical cost basis. Also there has been decentralization of payment of cost of food grains to FCI at the district level. In September 2021, the scheme was renamed to PM Poshan, with addition of 24 lakh beneficiaries in the age group of 5-6 years, who will now be a part of the formal education system through Balvatika pre-schools.

The objective of the scheme is to address hunger in schools by providing cooked meals, to improve nutritional status of children and to encourage poor children, belonging to disadvantaged sections, to attend schools more regularly and help them concentrate on classroom activities, thereby increasing the enrolment, retention and attendance rates. However, the Programme Evaluation Organization of the erstwhile Planning Commission in its evaluation of the MDM programme, found the certain issues and challenges. It observed poor involvement of Gram Panchayats in MDM implementation in a number of states like Bihar, Jharkhand, Meghalaya, Andhra Pradesh. There was also absence of established linkage with the Health Department except in Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka and irregular meetings of Steering cum Monitoring Committees for evaluation purposes. One third of the schools were found to have no toilet facilities and poor access to pure

drinking water in many states. Most of the states do not follow the guidelines of Government of India to deliver the food grains at the school point by PDS dealer implying leakages in the system. There was also serious shortage of cooks. Teachers were found to spend 3-4 hours on an average on MDM activities - reducing teaching time considerably leading to no significant impact on fresh enrolments in schools.

Regular invitations to all the involved ministries to School Management Committee meetings are required for a review of infrastructure development provisions. There should be convergence with MGNREGA for construction of kitchen sheds; for drinking water/toilet through Swachh Bharat Mission; and health check-up through NRHM. The Government of India guidelines for PDS supplies should be implemented and copy of release orders of food grains should be provided to the Headmaster for cross checking while delivery. Electronic fund transfers should be made to implementing authority to avoid mid-level leakages. Regular involvement of PTA members for community monitoring of the scheme would ensure accountability. Additionally, funds could be allocated for transportation from Fair Price Shops to schools - as presently, the cooking cost is consumed for payments. Under the revamped PM Poshan scheme, the Central government has also made plans to ensure Direct Benefit Transfer from states to schools so that the problems of delayed fund transfers and shortages can be taken care of.

The concept of Mid-Day Meal (MDM) scheme is almost a century old in India with early beginnings in Madras Presidency in pre-independent India. The scheme has again been given impetus in most states in the last two decades. Critically examine its twin objectives, latest mandates and success. (UPSC 2013)

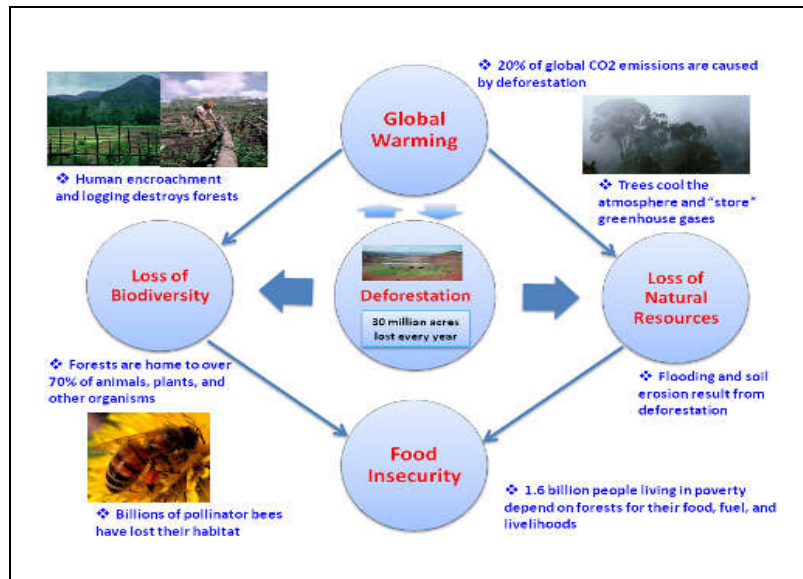
9.11.5. National Nutrition Mission (NNM) (Poshan Abhiyan):

There are a number of schemes directly/indirectly affecting the nutritional needs of children (0-6 years), pregnant women and lactating mothers. In spite of this the levels of malnutrition and hunger in the country are high. Therefore, in order to link various schemes to provide a synergy to achieve this common goal the National Nutrition Mission was launched. It will monitor, supervise, fix targets and guide the nutrition related interventions across different ministries and map various schemes contributing towards malnutrition. It shall introduce a robust convergence mechanism for all beneficiaries, ICT based real time monitoring and incentivize states/UTs for meeting targets. It shall also incentivize Anganwadi workers for using ICT based tools and eliminate registers used by them earlier. Children's height shall be measured and monitored at Anganwadi centres. It also involves conducting of social audits and setting up of National Resource Centres involving masses through Jan Aandolan for their participation for nutrition. The scheme aims to achieve the following by 2022, compared to baseline NFHS IV:

1. Reduce the prevalence of stunting among children to 25% or less;
2. Reduce the prevalence of underweight in children (0-6 years) to 25% or less;
3. Reduce the prevalence of anaemia among young children (6-59 months) to 43% or less;
4. Reduce the prevalence of anaemia among adolescent girls and women (15-49 years) to 38% or less.

9.12. Impact of climate change on food security and nutrition

The State of Food Security and Nutrition (SOFI), 2018 in the world says that extreme climate events will have a severe impact on food security. With the number of extreme climatic events almost doubled since 1990s (**average of 213 events occurring between 1996-2016**), there is a need to address food security considering such events.



Extreme events pose a direct threat to crop losses – mostly in tropical regions. Erratic rainfall is a serious threat to India as we are heavily dependent on monsoons for irrigation. Droughts due to climatic events such as El Nino etc. have a serious impact on food production capability of the nation. A shortfall in production will impact food prices – affordability and accessibility issues for poor. Moreover, low productivity will also impact food programmes of developing countries. Droughts will also impact the livestock productivity – leading to diseases due to deaths.

Sustainable alternatives to farming – **organic farming, Zero Budget Natural Farming, etc.** can be undertaken for reducing cost of inputs as well as to ensure high productivity. **Climate Smart Agriculture and precision agriculture** hold the key to increasing productivity, reducing emissions and adapting to climate change through development of drought and flood resistant crop species. **Food processing sector** could increase incomes for farmers and enhance capability during disasters. For instance, **SAMPADA yojana by government** aims at increasing the capabilities of the food processing sector. **Contract Farming**, involving a pre-harvest agreement between producers and buyers, can prove beneficial in case of post-harvest losses as and also provide income support.

9.13. NITI Aayog strategy for New India @ 75 to improve nutrition

The New India @75 strategy addresses policy and governance issues. It suggests to provide greater flexibility to states under the National Nutrition Mission to adapt programmes for context-specific implementation. Additionally, an institutional mechanism outside the government should be set-up to conduct independent annual audits of the programme. In order to ensure convergent action at all levels, the strategy document recommends development of an Annual Integrated Health, Nutrition and Swachh Bharat Mission action plan for all districts under NNM. It also recommends taking up steps to ensure accountability of local administration and for active engagement of PRI and PDS mechanisms and public health engineering departments for delivery of action plans. It focuses on refining of programme interventions, for instance- focus on first 1000 days of child care under ICDS, home based contacts for women and children under NNM, home visits by ASHA, ANM or young child feeding counsellors, etc. The strategy calls out for replacing the food centric approach with more broad based actions to include healthcare measures, child spacing, exclusive breastfeeding for 6 months etc.

The Rotavirus and Pneumococcal Vaccines immunization programmes would also need to be targeted towards high focus districts.

NITI Aayog suggests mandatory fortification of staple food products produced in the organized sector and provision of incentives to the industry to do so. These fortified food grains and double fortified salts should be included within government programmes such as ICDS/MDM and PDS. Research should also be done to eradicate micronutrient deficiency via Bio-fortification of grains. A **National Nutrition Surveillance system** should also be created to track food quality and consumption patterns and nutritional deficiency profiles for all age groups across all regions. The effectiveness of conditional cash transfers/vouchers in improving child nutrition should be assessed and programmes for adolescent girls to link it with pregnancy interventions should be redesigned. Long term studies on changes in body composition and early biomarkers of metabolic disorders should be conducted, for instance, tracking changes in birth weights and prematurity rates at the population levels. Test approaches to prevent obesity at adult and childhood levels. Establish an IT based real time monitoring mechanism by rolling out **Common Application Software(CAS)** developed by the Ministry of Women and Child Development and undertake joint health and nutrition reviews. Establish accountability with defined responsibility at all levels - District, State and Centre.

9.14. Impact of COVID on hunger

The political and social handling of the COVID-19 pandemic have added to the persisting issues of food insecurity faced by millions in India. Even prior to the novel coronavirus pandemic, India consistently has ranked poorly in all international rankings on hunger (**ranking 94th among 107 countries in the Global Hunger Index 2020**). With the second, more vigorous wave of COVID-19, the inability of those already on the brink of subsistence to absorb a second economic shock should not be overlooked. Rural distress specifically needs closer examination and urgent policy attention.

Till July 2021, the Rapid Rural Community Response, or RCRC to COVID-19, a collective of over 60 non-governmental organisations has collected three rounds of data since the lockdown in March 2020. Data suggests a persistence of cutting down on food even nine months after the first lockdown, during the seeming “revival” period. While 40% of the sample cut down on food during the first lockdown, an alarming 25% reportedly continued to cut down on food during the survey conducted between December and January 2021. Households reported cutting down on nutritious food- 80% cut down on milk, vegetables, pulses and oil (around 50% reported cutting down on pulses alone). Disaggregating the figure, we find that the poorer, socially marginalised Dalits, and those with lesser access to food security schemes (such as migrants) faced more severe food in- security.

Comparing similar households, households in Uttar Pradesh and Jharkhand were among the worst performing states. These reductions will undoubtedly further accelerate the impending effects on children's nutrition, as highlighted in the National Family Health Survey or NFHS-V (2019-20) and the Global Food Policy Report, 2021. The loss in nutrition may have come as a consequence of people losing their jobs and/or being pushed into lower income brackets over time due to the nature and handling of the pandemic. The second wave of the pandemic comes on the back of an uneven recovery and persistence of crippling food and financial insecurity among the poorest households, especially migrants. Migrants who had travelled to cities only months ago were again seen travelling back to their villages.

The government had promised to restart the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana (PMGKAY) with 5 kg of rice/wheat per person per month for limited time. The government needs to provide similar support for stabler longer periods; expand the current offering to include nutritious foods like pulses; address issues faced

in existing schemes such as MGNREGA (like delays in wages and rationing); and new schemes such as a potential urban employment scheme should be explored. Food security schemes such as ration provided to children through Anganwadis, Public Distribution System and mid-day meal scheme in primary schools need to be ramped up systematically and urgently. For migrants stuck in cities without work, community kitchens (such as Amma canteens) are required. The most vulnerable will need more predictable and stable support than ever before.

To conclude, with 65% of our population below 35 years of age, India is going to be the workforce provider to the world. It is indeed necessary that this work force remains healthy and disease free for us to reap the ongoing demographic dividend. As we move towards a knowledge economy, the age old dictum, “a healthy mind resides only in a healthy body” seems true like never before and the government must take active efforts to help achieve this state.

10. EDUCATION

“Education is the most powerful weapon you can use to change the world”- Nelson Mandela

According to UNESCO, education is the process of facilitating learning, or the acquisition of knowledge, skills, values, beliefs, and habits. It is a discipline concerned with methods of teaching and learning in schools or school-like environments. The most important role of education is to facilitate social and economic progress. Education, in its broadest sense, is the most crucial input for empowering people, especially youth, with knowledge and skills which will help them in gaining access to productive employment in the future.

All individuals are entitled to an education. Education leads to individual freedom and empowerment, which in turn yields significant social development gains and makes an individual self-reliant. Education is seen as the foundation of a society, enabling social prosperity, political stability and economic wealth. Education is therefore increasingly being viewed as the most basic right across the globe which is also essential for exercising other human rights.

10.1. Constitutional provisions

In order to understand the importance of education and also in order to implement education in a more prudent manner, some provisions have been adopted in our Constitution and are discussed below:

Fundamental Rights

1. **Article 21A:** Right to elementary education.
2. **Article 28:** Freedom from attending religious instruction or worship in certain educational institutions.
3. **Article 29:** This article provides equality of opportunity in educational institutions.
4. **Article 30:** Right of minorities to establish and administer educational institutions of their own.

Directive Principles

1. **Article 41:** Right to work, to education and to public assistance in certain cases.
2. **Article 45:** Provision for free and compulsory education for children and provision for early childhood care and education to children below the age of six years.
3. **Article 46:** It provides for special care to the promotion of education and economic interests of the scheduled caste, scheduled tribes and the weaker sections of society.

Fundamental Duties

1. **Article 51 A(k):** A parent or guardian to provide opportunities for education to his child or, as the case may be, ward between the age of six and fourteen years.

Other Articles

1. **Article 337:** This provides for special provision with respect to educational grants for the benefit of Anglo-Indian community.
2. **Article 350A:** This article relates to facilities for instruction in mother tongue at primary stage.
3. **Article 350B:** It provides for a special offer for linguistic minorities.

Amendments:

1. **42nd Amendment Act 1976:** Education was shifted from State List to Concurrent List
2. **86th Amendment Act 2002:** Right to Education (inserted 21A and amendend article 51(A)(K))
3. **93rd Amendment Act 2006:** Amended Article 15, which provides reservation for SC, ST and OBC in private institutions. (including self-financed but excluding minority educational institutions and it also nullified Supreme court's judgment in Inamdar case that State cannot impose reservation on private unaided institutions.

10.2. Right to Education Act

Education sharpens our innate abilities and converts them into responsible citizens. It is, therefore, necessary that the parents and society should protect the child with the utmost care and provide them education. A very conducive environment, free from hunger, disease, and oppression needs to be ensured for children in which they can have the full opportunity to grow in full bloom. The enactment of the **Right of children to free and Compulsory Education (RTE) Act, 2009** in India was an important step and defining event in that direction.

Article 21-A and the **Right to Education Act came into effect on 1st April 2010**. The title of the RTE Act includes the words '**free and compulsory**'. 'Free education' implies that no child, other than a child who has been admitted by his or her parents to a school which is not administratively or financially supported by the government, will be liable to pay any kind of fee or expenses or charges which may prevent him or her from pursuing and completing elementary education. 'Compulsory education' makes it obligatory for the appropriate governments and local authorities to provide and ensure admission, attendance and completion of elementary education for all children in the 6-14 age group. With this Act, India has progressed towards a rights-based framework that makes a legal obligation on the State and Central governments to implement this fundamental right of a child, as enshrined in Article 21A of the Constitution, in accordance with the provisions of the Right to Education Act. Some of the important provisions of the Act are:

1. Free and compulsory education to all children of India in the age group of 6 to 14 years.
2. No child shall be held back, expelled or required to pass a board examination until the completion of his/her elementary education.
3. If a child above 6 years of age has not yet been admitted in any school or could not complete his or her elementary education, then he or she should be admitted in a class appropriate to his or her age. However, if a case may be wherein a child is directly admitted in the class appropriate to his or her age, then, in order to be at par with others, he or she should have a right to receive special training within such time limits as may be prescribed. It is provided further, that a child so admitted to elementary education will be entitled to free education till the completion of elementary education even after 14 years.
4. Proof of age for admission: For the purpose of admission to elementary education, the age of a child shall be determined on the basis of his/her birth certificate issued in accordance with the provisions of birth. However, no child will be denied admission in a school for lack of age proof.
5. A child who completes his/her elementary education shall be awarded a certificate.
6. A fixed student-teacher ratio needs to be decided.
7. Twenty-five per cent reservation for economically disadvantaged communities, for admission to Class I in all private schools, should be undertaken.
8. School teachers should possess adequate professional degrees within five years or else they would be suspended.
9. School infrastructure (wherever there are issues) should be improved every 3 years, else recognition will be cancelled.
10. Financial burden shall be shared between the state and the central government
11. It prohibits (a) physical punishment and mental harassment; (b) screening procedures for admission of children; (c) capitation fee; (d) private tuition by teachers and (e) running of schools without recognition.
12. It provides for the development of curriculum in consonance with the Constitutional values, in order to ensure the all-round development of the child, with a focus on building on the child's knowledge, potentiality, and talent and making the child free of fear, trauma, and anxiety through a system of child-friendly and child-centered learning.

Issues associated with RTE:

Over the years many basic issues and implementation challenges have emerged in the Right to Education Act, 2009. Some of the important issues are discussed below:

1. **Why only 6 – 14; why not 0 – 18 years:** The Act allows only children between the ages 6-14 to get the right to education. It leaves out younger kids (0-6) and the older ones (14-18) despite the fact that India is a signatory to the U.N. Charter that states clearly that free education should be made compulsory for all children up to the age of 18 years. Education up to the age 14 is not at all sufficient for a person to lead a minimally decent life.
2. **Out of school children – gender bias:** In the RTE age group, the traditional gender norms force girls into helping with household chores and taking care of younger siblings. This leads to irregular attendance and eventual dropouts. The culture of early marriage, lack of security in schools and low aspirations of educating girls also pushes them out of school. Of those who manage to stay in school till 14, about 1/3 do not enroll further. One probable cause for them seems to be the fact that only 14% elementary schools (classes I to VIII) in rural India offer secondary grades (IX and X) and only 6% offer higher secondary grades (classes XI and XII).
3. **Children with special needs (CWSN) left out of RTE:** The Right to Education Act, 2009 has no provision to provide education to children with disabilities – more correctly, children with special needs (CWSN).
4. **Status of poor kids in private schools:** The RTE Act, 2009 opens the doors of private schools for children from weaker backgrounds. But the main **challenge comes from the attitude of private school administrators**. Moreover, there are no provisions to bear the overhead expenses such as uniform, books, stationery, etc. of children attending a private school.
5. **The RTE Act appears mostly input oriented with little focus on quality of learning:** The Right to Education Act is perceived to be excessively input-focused rather than oriented towards outcomes. Although it guarantees for universal admission of children, but it does not promise quality delivery of education.
6. Even though the Act stipulates that children missing out on education years should be admitted to classes based on their age, but it does not lay out the details for the creation of a **bridging course** to ensure that students are taught the subjects they missed and are able to adapt to the new classes.
7. The Act requires every government and aided school to form a **School Management Committee (SMC)** which shall mostly be comprised of parents and will be responsible for planning to manage the operations of the school. However, this can be a burden for the poor parents who would not be able to volunteer their time and effort as is expected from SMC members.

Major amendments to RTE Act:

In order to focus on quality education, the Central government has amended the RTE Rules to include the reference on learning outcomes based on classes and subjects. These would serve as a guideline for States and UTs to ensure that all children acquire appropriate learning levels. The RTE Act, 2009 was also amended in 2017 to ensure that all teachers acquire the minimum qualifications prescribed under the Act by 31st March 2019. This amendment **scrapped the “no detention” policy**, which ensured that no student could be held back (or failed) in a class until the end of elementary education (that is Standard 8th). The government is placing a lot of emphasis on the **development and provision of e-content** for students and also training of teachers, headmasters, and Principals.

10.3. National Education Policy

The first National Policy on Education was framed in 1968 and then in 1986, which was later modified in 1992. Since then several socio-economic-cultural changes have taken place which call for a revision of the policy. The Government of India has therefore, brought out the National Education Policy, 2020, to meet the changing

dynamics of the people's requirement with regards to quality education, research and innovation, aiming to make India a knowledge superpower. The policy also aims to eliminate the shortage of manpower in science, technology, academics, and industry and to equip all students with the necessary skills and knowledge.

The **need for the new educational policy** was to address some of the key challenges in the education sector. Research from around the world has highlighted the importance of early childhood education. Yet, participation in pre-school education in India has remained low. Unsatisfactory learning outcomes due to poor quality of education are also a matter of great concern. India is one of the youngest nations in the world with more than 54 percent of its total population below 25 years of age. This makes it necessary for the youth in the country to be equipped with the skills and knowledge to enter the workforce through adequate education and training. Still, the institutional arrangements to support technical and vocational education programmes remain quite insufficient. There is also a growing realization about the existence of a serious disconnect between the prevailing school and higher education syllabus and the curricular thrusts that are actually needed for promoting the acquisition of relevant skills by students, to get decent work and live a better life in a rapidly changing world.

Also, the use of **Information and Communication Technology (ICT)** in education remains limited and there is a need to accelerate efforts to use ICT for fostering quality education. The current teacher education and training programmes are also inappropriate in terms of equipping the teachers with the competencies required to carry out their duties in diverse social, economic, cultural and technological environments. Though there have been substantial gains in pre-school enrolment, children from disadvantaged population groups still lack access to pre-school education. Further, children from economically disadvantaged groups are more likely to receive less opportunity to enrol for pre-primary education. Several studies have reported that the challenges in education governance are exemplified by teacher absenteeism, delayed flow of funds to schools and administrative incapacities. Capacity constraints relating to effective programme planning and implementation continue to be a key issue.

The draft National Education Policy (NEP), 2016 was based on T.S.R.Subramanian report. However, **NEP 2020** is based on recommendations of both Kasturirangan and T.S.R.Subramanian committees. It lays emphasis on reforms in education at all levels from pre-primary to higher education. It aims to bring transformation in the education system of India in line with contemporary needs. NEP, national education policy 2020 will replace existing education policy which was formulated in 1986. Considering vast changes in technology, demography and aspirations of people, this reform is the need of the day. It also aims to address current challenges Indian education system faces like lack of resources, capacity, mismatch between education and skills needed for jobs. Major provisions of NEP, national education policy 2020:

School education:

1. Universalization of education by 2030 through 100% GER (Gross Enrollment Ratio) from pre-primary to secondary.
2. Open schooling system (no admission requirements, NIOS is example) for out of school children.
3. 5+3+3+4 curriculum system replacing existing 10+2 system.
 - a. 3-8 years of age: 3 years pre-school education + Classes 1 and 2
 - b. 8-11 years of age: classes 3 to 5
 - c. 11-14 years of age: classes 6 to 8
 - d. 14-18 years of age: Classes 9-12
4. Focus on foundational Literacy and Numeracy; extra-curriculars; vocational education and multidisciplinary approach to arts, science and commerce in high school
 - a. Vocational education to start from class 6 with internships
 - b. Curriculum will include 21st century skills like coding.
5. Teaching in mother tongue upto class 5 with no imposition of any language.

6. 360-degree holistic progress card for tracking learning outcomes.
7. Teacher education:
 - a. 4 year B.Ed. qualification to be mandatory from 2030 for teachers
 - b. National Curriculum Framework for Teacher Education, NCFTE 2021 to be formulated

Higher education:

1. GER to be raised to 50% by 2035.
2. Broad based, multi-disciplinary, holistic UG (Undergraduate) education: Provisions of flexible curriculum; integration of vocational education; multiple entry and exit points with respective degrees; UG education period between 3-4 years
3. Academic bank of credits to enable transfers of credits between institutions
4. Multidisciplinary Education and Research Universities (MERUs) for global quality multidisciplinary education
5. National Research Foundation (NRF) as an apex body for research capacity building.
6. HECI (Higher education commission of India) as umbrella regulator except for legal and medical education. It will have four verticals of:
 - a. National Higher Education Regulatory Council (NHERC) for regulation
 - b. General Education Council (GEC) for standard setting
 - c. Higher Education Grants Council (HEGC) for funding
 - d. National Accreditation Council (NAC) for accreditation
7. Phasing out affiliation system in 15 years
8. Graded autonomy to colleges will be provided as per a stage wise mechanism.

Other:

1. Increasing public expenditure on education (Centre and states) to 6% of GDP at the earliest.
2. National Educational Technology Forum (NETF) to promote use of tech in education – learning, assessment, planning and administration
3. Gender Inclusion Fund for advancing gender equality in education.
4. Special education zones for disadvantaged regions and groups. Financial incentives will be given to SC, ST, OBC and other disadvantaged groups.
5. Promotion of multilingualism in schools and colleges.
6. National institutes for Pali, Prakrit and Persian to be set up along with institutes for translation and interpretation, for knowledge creation in Indic systems and languages.

It recognizes the importance of preschool education in the future of a child through 5+3+3+4 structure. It also recognizes the importance of mother tongue upto class 5, which has an impact on learning outcomes for the child. In the context of increasing demand for English as a medium of instruction, this brings balance by not neglecting the mother tongue. It promotes multilingualism which is proven to have a positive impact on brain development. It also emphasizes that vocational education since class 6 is needed. With only 30% GER in higher education, the rest of the students need employable skills. Vocational education aids this. Hurdle of blue collarization of vocations in India must be overcome for this to succeed. Its provisions for reforming teacher education are timely as multiple reports on education point to lack of quality in teacher education. It has a multidisciplinary and research approach to education which is crucial for the 21st century. Areas like Nano technology, bio technology, robotics, artificial intelligence all need this approach. Emphasis on technology can increase access to quality education. It recognizes the need for flexibility of education. This is important in the 21st century with high mobility and alternate ways of learning. Steps like Open schooling system, multiple entry and exit points in UG education, use of technological resources aid in this flexibility.

Regulatory reforms by emphasis on transparency, quality, self-assessment and voluntary declarations reduce the regulatory burden on education. A single regulatory body with 4 verticals will aid in this lean but

effective regulation. No child left behind through focus on gender equality and disadvantaged groups, is the need of the hour. Gender Inclusion Fund and Special education zones aid in this. Focus on long neglected Indian languages and knowledge systems (tribals etc.) will advance cultural and scientific knowledge. Transformational vision proposed in NEP 2020 requires huge resources in creation of infrastructure, personnel, institutions. NEP, 2020 has set a target of 6% of GDP as target at the earliest. This is a challenge in the current fiscal position of states and centre due to COVID pandemic. But political will must be shown to realize the education transformation in NEP, 2020.

National Education Policy 2020 is in conformity with the Sustainable Development Goal-4 (2030). It intends to restructure and reorient education system in India. Critically examine the statement. (UPSC 2020)

10.4. Overview of Education Scenario in India

10.4.1. Primary Education

Primary or elementary education is typically the first stage of formal education. It is imparted immediately after preschool and followed by secondary education. Pre-school or kindergarten includes Pre-Nursery, Nursery, Prep or Lower Kindergarten and Upper Kindergarten. In India, schools provide primary education from Class 1 to Class 8. The children in these classes are generally aged between 6 and 15 years. With the passage of the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act 2009, India has made significant progress in access to schooling and enrollment rates in primary education in recent years. Under the Act, education for children from 6 to 14 years of age or up to Class 8 has been made free by the government. **Kerala** has become the first Indian state to achieve 100 percent primary education.

10.4.1.2. Annual Status of Education Report (ASER):

It is a nationwide survey of rural education and learning outcomes in terms of reading and arithmetic skills in the age group of 5-16 years. It is conducted by the NGO Pratham since the last 15 years. In 2016, ASER switched to an alternate-year cycle where the “basic” ASER is conducted every other year (2016, 2018) and in alternate years ASER focuses on a different aspect of children’s schooling and learning. **In the backdrop of the pandemic, the survey was conducted via phone calls in 2020**, reaching 52,227 rural households with school-age children in 26 States and 4 Union Territories. The key findings of the 15th Report (2020) are as follows:

1. **Access to textbooks:** According to the survey conducted in September, 2020, 20% of rural children have no textbooks at home. This proportion of students having textbooks is higher among students enrolled in government schools (84.1%) than in private schools (72.2%). In Andhra Pradesh, less than 35% of children had textbooks, and only 60% had textbooks in Rajasthan. More than 98% of students had textbooks in West Bengal, Nagaland and Assam.
2. **Enrolment:** The survey found that 5.3% of rural children aged 6-10 years had not yet enrolled in school in 2020, in comparison to just 1.8% in 2018. Non-enrolment visible mostly among the youngest children (age 6 and 7), may be due to delay in admissions owing to pandemic. Among 15-16 year-olds, however, enrolment levels are actually slightly higher than in 2018. Enrolment patterns also show a slight shift toward government schools, with private schools seeing a drop in enrolment in all age groups. 55 per cent children in the 6-14 age groups are enrolled in government schools, up from 66.42 per cent in 2018. Proportion of boys enrolled in government schools rose from 62.8% in 2018 to 66.4% in 2020. Proportion of girls enrolled in government schools rose from 70% to 73%.
3. **Smartphones related:** As many as 24.3 percent of the children said they had not received any learning material from the school in the week the survey was held because they had no smartphone. 6% of students in government schools were without access to a smartphone. A surge in the use of smartphones (as compared to 2018) has not been accompanied by greater access. Smartphone ownership has almost doubled from 2018 thus it is not only about technology, a third of children with smartphone access still did not receive any learning materials. Regardless of school type, WhatsApp

was the most common medium through which activities and materials were received. However, this proportion was much higher among children in private schools (87.2%) than those in government schools (67.3%). Almost 40% of children in low education households got no materials and did no learning, compared to 17% of high education families.

4. **Learning activities:** In the week of the survey, one in three rural children had done no learning activity at all. About two in three had no learning materials or activity given by their school that week, and only one in ten had access to live online classes.
5. **Other observations:** Inherited disadvantages continue to affect the quality of learning, low education of families affecting their children's education. Students in rural areas have received very marginal assistance in the form of structured learning from teachers. They mostly had to rely on parents and siblings to study at home. Students, specifically belonging to lower classes, could use the safety of the open countryside to learn a variety of topics by doing themselves, under guidance of teachers. Observational learning like that could create a strong foundation.

10.4.1.3. National Achievement Survey:

Aimed at understanding the health of the education system in government and government aided schools, National Achievement Survey is a representative sample of schools from all districts in India. **National Achievement Surveys (NAS)** was conducted for classes III, V and VIII, for the first time in November 2017, to assess the learning outcomes of students in government and aided schools in all subjects. But NAS does not assess the individual student performance. The survey test booklets had 45 questions for Classes III and V related to language, mathematics and 60 questions for Class VIII in Mathematics, Language, Sciences and Social Sciences. The competency based test questions reflected the learning outcomes developed by the NCERT which were recently incorporated in the RTE Act by the Government of India.

In Mathematics, students were assessed on five basic operations i.e. addition (of 2- and 3- digit numbers), subtraction (of 3-digit numbers with and without borrowing), multiplication (of 2-digit numbers by a single digit), division and number placement. They were also given questions on geometry, patterns, measurement, money, and data handling. **High scores** were obtained in problems based on money, data handling, patterns, and addition while low scores were obtained in problems based on division and place value. **Overall, high scores in mathematics questions** were obtained by southern states (like Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka), UTs (like Daman & Diu, Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Puducherry), and some North-East States (Tripura and Mizoram). **Overall, low scores in mathematical questions** were obtained by Chhattisgarh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Jammu & Kashmir, Rajasthan, Haryana, and Odisha.

In Languages, students were assessed on their abilities in listening (multiple choice questions based on a passage read aloud), word recognition (matching the picture to the correct word from two given options) and reading comprehension (reading a story/advertisement to locate information, interpret and infer). **Overall, 65% of Class III students** were able to listen to a passage with understanding, 86% were able to recognize words and 59% were able to read a passage and interpret meanings from it. **For listening, the high scores (above 70%)** were achieved by Tripura, West Bengal, Daman & Diu, Mizoram, and Gujarat. The low scores (below 58%) were in Jammu & Kashmir, Chhattisgarh, Bihar, Arunachal Pradesh, and Chandigarh. **For word recognition**, the highest performance was by Mizoram, Kerala, Tripura, Goa, and Meghalaya, while the lowest was by Bihar, Jammu & Kashmir, Chhattisgarh, Odisha, and Rajasthan. **For reading comprehension**, the highest scores were obtained by Puducherry, D&N Haveli, Daman & Diu, Tamil Nadu, and Mizoram, while the lowest was obtained by Chhattisgarh, Bihar, Uttarakhand, Haryana and Rajasthan.

There are **other issues** as well. The RTE act has called for sufficient infrastructure, but less than 5% schools have all the 9 facilities mentioned in the act. A study of 188 government-run primary schools found that 59 per cent of the schools had no drinking water, 89 percent had no toilets and over 60 % had no playgrounds.

Around 25 percent of teachers remain absent every day. The quality of teachers is also important for the learning outcomes but the District Information system for education (DISE) data shows that only **69 % of all** school teachers in the country have a graduate degree or more. One of the greatest challenges today in primary school education is to make the students capable of handling modern situations while their syllabus is still designed for life a few decades back. As per **UNESCO data**, India has one of the lowest public expenditure rates on education per student, especially compared to other Asian countries like China.

10.4.1.4. Steps taken by the government:

Several **steps have been taken by government** in order to improve the primary education. So, that education as a tool can be used for the future generation, development of student as well as for India. **Sarva Shiksha Abhiyaan (SSA)** is Government of India's flagship program for achievement of Universalization of Elementary Education (UEE) in a time bound manner. The main **objectives of SSA** include that all children should either be in a school or an education guarantee centre of an alternate school, or an 'Back-to-School' camp by 2003. All children of the appropriate age would fulfil five years of primary schooling by 2007 and eight years of elementary schooling by 2010. Focus is on elementary education of satisfactory quality which will be considered to be beneficial for life. It also aims to bridge all gender and social class gaps at primary stage by 2007 and at elementary education level by 2010. SSA targets to have universal retention in schools both primary and elementary, by 2010.

However, there are a large number of teacher vacancies under SSA, which adversely affects the implementation of the scheme. There is also a shortfall in the infrastructure, for example, lack of pucca buildings, separate toilet facilities for boys & girls, etc., required for the implementation of SSA. Contrary to the recommendations of the 14th Finance Commission, the states have failed to earmark funds for priority areas in education out of the increased fund devolution to them. The enrolment is now near universal, but the learning outcomes are still far from satisfactory, i.e., only about half the children in standard V could do a two-digit subtraction problem with borrowing.

Shagun Portal: Its main aim is to capture and showcase innovations and progress in Elementary Education sector of India by continuous monitoring of the flagship scheme - Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA). It provides a platform for all stakeholders to learn from each other, and instil a positive competitive spirit among all the States and UTs. This Portal also enables the Government of India and the State and UT Departments of education to conduct real-time assessments which normal paper-based monitoring mechanisms did not allow.

Padhe Bharat Badhe Bharat can be regarded as a countrywide programme being implemented under the aegis of the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan. It has normally been seen that kids who are unable to read during their early education tend to be bad in other subjects as well. The programme looks to improve the reading and writing skills of children in classes I and II, along with their mathematics skills.

Rashtriya Avishkar Abhiyan (RAA), is launched by Ministry of Human Resource Development. It is a framework converging School Education and Higher Education, which is aimed at encouraging children towards learning and developing their interest in Science and Mathematics. One of the important interventions under Rashtriya Avishkar Abhiyan is strengthening of school Science and Mathematics laboratories, through the Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan (RMSA). Further, under RMSA, mathematics and science kits to schools shall be provided to schools, and Science Fairs/Exhibitions and Talent Search competitions shall be conducted at the district level. Interventions targeting school visits to higher institutions and learning enhancement measures for students have also been approved.

Vidyanjali is a **school volunteer programme** and an initiative of the Ministry of Human Resource Development of India to boost community and private sector participation in government schools. Under the

programme, volunteers, including NRIs, retired teachers, government officials, defence personnel, professionals will offer their services for co-scholastic activities for children from class I to VIII. It is the project launched under the aegis of the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan by the Department of School Education and Literacy.

Mid-Day Meal (MDM)– The National Programme of Nutritional Support to Primary Education (NP-NSPE) was launched as a Centrally Sponsored Scheme on 15th August 1995 in order to enhance enrolment, retention, attendance of children and also simultaneously improve their nutritional levels. In 2001 MDMS became a **cooked Mid-Day Meal Scheme** under which every child in every Government and Government-aided primary school was to be served a prepared Mid-Day Meal with a minimum content of **300 calories of energy and 8-12 gram protein per day for a minimum of 200 days**. The Scheme was further extended in 2002 to cover not only children studying in Government, Government aided and local body schools, but also children studying in Education Guarantee Scheme (EGS) and Alternative & Innovative Education (AIE) centres. In October 2007, the Scheme was extended to cover children of upper primary classes (i.e. class VI to VIII) studying in 3,479 Educationally Backwards Blocks. The nutritional norm for the upper primary stage was fixed at **700 Calories and 20 grams of protein**. The Scheme was extended to all areas across the country.

**The scheme has been discussed in detail in the section on hunger and Nutrition issues.*

10.4.1.5. Teacher training and education:

Educating teachers is essential in order to make our education system more vibrant, and helping teachers to equip with modern knowledge in the era of globalization. There are many problems and issues plaguing the system of teacher education. Teacher preparation has been a subject of discussion at all levels, from the government, ministries, schools, regulatory bodies, to teachers themselves. A very **small time period is provided for teacher's training** in India, about one year after the graduation - the effective session being of six to seven months only. Moreover, the main purpose of teacher education programme is to develop health attitude, value and broad-based interest which is not possible during the short duration. A **better selection method** would also improve the quality of training. Some suggestions include: (a) Test of General Knowledge should be applied. (b) Candidate should be interviewed. (c) Test in school subjects. (d) Test of intelligence should be administered (e) Test of language. (f) Aptitude; interest and attitude inventory should be administered. The current training programme does not provide proper opportunities to the student teachers to develop competency because the organizers of teacher's training programme are not aware of the present problems of schools. So there should be a close matching between the work schedule of the teacher in the programme and the school adopted for teacher preparation in a training college.

The teacher training programmes do not emphasize the knowledge of the basic subject. The whole teaching practice remains indifferent with regard to the subject knowledge of the student teacher. The State Education Department have no data on the basis of which they may work out the desired intake for their institutions. There is a considerable lag between the demand and supply of teachers. This has created the problem of unemployment. Research in education has been considerably neglected. The research conducted is of low quality. Before undertaking any research, the teacher programmes are not studied properly. Mostly candidates do not have the requisite motivation and academic background for a well-deserved entry in the teaching profession. The teacher education has become isolated from schools and current development in school education, which has been observed by education commission. The schools consider the teacher education department as an alien institution and not a nursery for the professional development of school teacher. These departments do not care for the pedagogy involved in the procedure but only observe the formality of finishing the prescribed number of lessons.

In India many steps have been taken to improve the quality of teacher education. Government should also increase its investment for establishing teacher education institutions (TEIs) and increase the institutional capacity of teacher preparation. Government may explore the possibility of instituting a transparent procedure

of pre-entry testing of candidate to the pre-service teacher education programme, keeping in view the variation in local conditions. Duration of Programme of Teacher Education needs to be enhanced. The first professional degree/diploma should be offered in face to face mode only. There is also a need to develop broad based norms for qualification of teacher educators. Opportunities need to be created for teaching practitioners to teach in teacher education institutions. An urgent need is to develop comprehensive programme for continuing professional development of secondary school teachers. A Teacher Education assessment and Accreditation Centre (TEAAC) needs to be set-up. Every teacher education institute can have a dedicated school attached to it as a laboratory.

Steps taken by government for teacher training include **Diksha –National Digital Infrastructure for Teachers** to empower them. It provides offline/online training for teachers, student teachers and teacher educator. It will also provide a great platform to all teachers to improve their quality of study. On this portal, teachers can make content and share with each other. **Prashikshak Education Portal** was launched with a vision to strengthen District Institutes of Education and Training (DIETs) and bring quality teachers into the Indian school education system. It was established through joint collaboration between Ministry of Human Resource Development and Central Square Foundation. **Amendment of the RTE Act for Training of In-service Untrained Teachers** specifies all school teachers to possess minimum educational qualifications which is laid down by National Council of teacher Education. Those who aren't qualified have time until 31st March, 2019 to clear out all the prescribed rules to qualifications. This amendment to RTE Act, 2009 will enable in-service untrained elementary teachers to complete their training and ensure that all teachers at the elementary level in the country have a certain minimum standard of qualifications. This would ultimately result in improvement in overall quality of teachers, teaching processes and consequently learning outcomes of children. This will reinforce the Government's emphasis on improvement of quality of elementary education.

For **improvement of schools**, government has started **Shaala Siddhi** or the National Programme on School Standards and Evaluation (NPSSE). It is a comprehensive instrument for school evaluation leading to school improvement. It aims to enable schools to evaluate their performance in a more focused and strategic manner and facilitate them to make professional judgments for improvement. The programme's objective is to establish and refer to an agreed set of standards and to provide clear pathways for each school for self-evaluation, by focussing on key performance domains and their core standards for school evaluation. The structure of the Framework is simple yet flexible and lends itself to both self and external evaluation. **Shaala Darpan** is presently under implementation through National Informatics Centre Services Inc. (NICSI). The objective of this project is to provide services based on School Management Systems to Students, Parents, and Communities.

e-Pathshala has been developed by NCERT for showcasing and disseminating all educational e-resources including textbooks, audio, video, periodicals and a variety of other print and non-print materials through the website and mobile app. All the concerned stakeholders such as students, teachers, educators, and parents can access e-books through multiple technology platforms i.e. mobile phones, tablets and on the web through laptops and desktops. All the NCERT books have been digitized and uploaded.

In September, 2021, the Prime Minister launched a series of new initiatives under the National Education Policy. **Indian Sign Language dictionary** was launched by the Indian Sign Language Research and Training centre of DPwD (Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities). It has 10,000 words in it. It was also accompanied by the launch of the Talking Books (audiobooks for the visually impaired). **School Quality Assessment and Accreditation Framework (SQAACF)** of **CBSE** was launched to help in bridging the inequality in education. It would also address the deficiency of the absence of a common scientific framework for various dimensions. These dimensions include curricula, pedagogy, assessment, inclusive practices and governance process. **NISTHA teachers' training programme for NIPUN Bharat** is aimed at training the

teachers on new systems and techniques. The **Vidyanjali Portal** will be used for facilitating education volunteers, donors and CSR (Corporate Social Responsibility) contributors for school development. It is the platform for the country to achieve 'Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas' with 'Sabka Prayas'.

To sum up, steps need to be taken to make **Primary Education more inclusive**. We need to focus more on our Indian Education system and it needs serious reforms and changes. The funding should focus on progress towards goals, such as improving learning outcomes of children in elementary schools. We need to improve public expenditure rates on education per student. We need to improve the quality of the teacher by providing proper teacher training. The policy should shift its approach from input-based expenditure to outcome-focused achievement. The pilot project of establishing Smart Classes in government schools must be initiated to make the teaching-learning process more effective through computer enabled techniques. The states must proportionately adjust the increased devolution of funds for education.

10.4.2. Secondary and Senior Secondary Education

Secondary education in India begins after eight years of elementary education and is divided into two years of secondary education (classes IX and X) and two years of senior secondary education (classes XI and XII). **National Achievement Survey (NAS) for Class X** was conducted by the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) for the year 2018. This survey is conducted in order to inspect the result of learning in the country. As per the survey, students of **class 10** have performed the worst in mathematics. In the average performance, **Andhra Pradesh** performs the best at 40.94 percent while **Sikkim** gives the lowest outcome with 27 percent. The performance of Delhi was remarkable in average score in five subjects while J&K gave poor performance in four of the five subjects.

Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan was launched in March 2009 with the objective to enhance access to secondary education and to improve its quality. It is envisaged to achieve an **enrolment rate of 75%** from 52.26% in 2005-06 at the secondary stage of implementation of the scheme by providing a secondary school within a reasonable distance of any habitation. The other objectives include improving quality of education imparted at secondary level through making all secondary schools conform to prescribed norms, removing gender, socio-economic and disability barriers, providing universal access to secondary level education by 2017 and **achieving universal retention by 2020**. Important physical facilities provided under the scheme include additional classrooms, laboratories, libraries, art and crafts room, toilet blocks, drinking water provisions and residential hostels for teachers in remote areas. Important quality interventions provided under the scheme include appointment of additional teachers to reduce PTR to 30:1, focus on Science, Math and English education, in-service training of teachers, science laboratories, ICT enabled education, curriculum reforms and teaching-learning reforms.

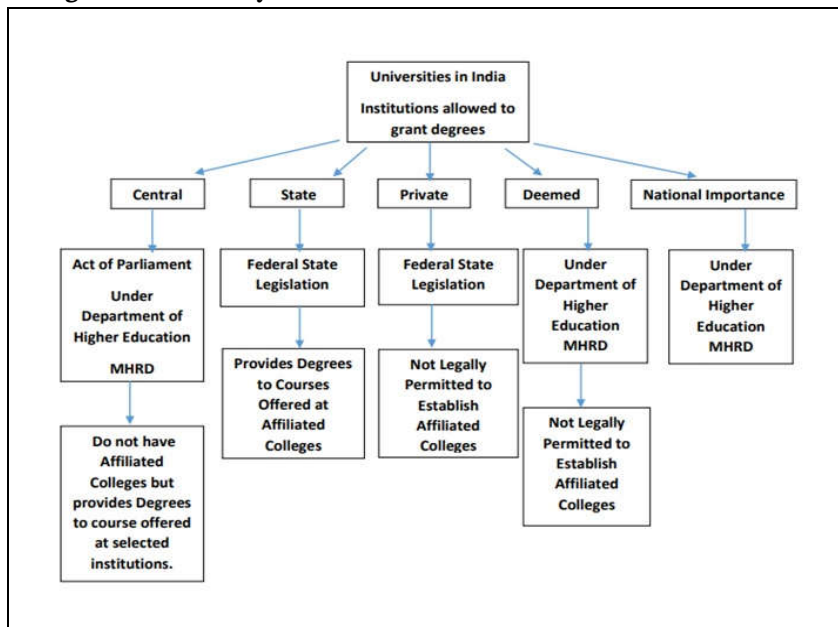
10.4.3. Higher Education

India's higher education system is the third largest in the world, next to the United States and China. The main governing body at the tertiary level is the University Grants Commission, which enforces its standards, advises the government, and helps coordinate between the Centre and the state. Accreditation for higher learning is overseen by 15 autonomous institutions established by the University Grants Commission (UGC). The status of higher education in India, as per All India Survey of Higher Education (AISHE) Report (2019-20) is as follows:

1. The percentage of students belonging to the eligible age group enrolled in Higher Education, in 2019-20 is 27.1% against 26.3% in 2018-19 and 24.3% in 2014-2015.
2. In Higher Education, Gender Parity Index (GPI) in 2019-20 is 1.01 against 1.00 in 2018-19. This indicates an improvement in the relative access to higher education for females of eligible age group compared to males.
3. In 2019-20 the pupil-teacher ratio is 26.
4. The number of students pursuing PhD in 2019-20 is 2.03 lakh against 1.17 lakh in 2014-15.

5. Nearly 3.38 crore students enrolled in programmes at under-graduate and post-graduate level. Out of these, nearly 85% of the students (2.85 crores) were enrolled in the six major disciplines. Such as Humanities, Science, Commerce, Engineering & Technology, Medical Science and IT & Computer.

10.4.3.1. Structure of higher education system in India:



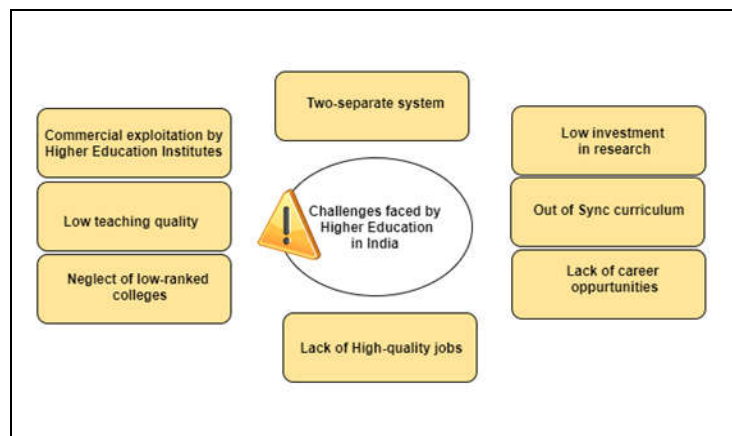
10.4.3.2. Issues associated with higher education in India:

According to UGC, the total number of sanctioned teaching posts in various Central Universities are 16,699 for professors, 4,731 for associate professors, and 9,585 for assistant professors. Out of the total sanctioned teaching posts, 5,925 (35%) professor posts, 2,183 (46%) associate professor posts and 2,459 (26%) assistant professor posts are **vacant**. Withdrawal of the public sector has left the space open for **private institutions that have turned education into a flourishing business**. Most of the **teachers in private colleges are underpaid and overworked**. There has been a rampant expansion in the number of colleges with scant regard for standards and quality. This phenomenon also shows the lapses in the regulatory structure. National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC) in its assessment report pointed out that **68% of institutions in India are of middle or poor quality**. Ad-hoc appointments and low pay scale, inadequate teacher training are all factors that have caused a deterioration in the quality of education.

The All India Survey of Higher Education (AISHE) Report 2016-17 shows that in India, the gross enrolment ratio in higher education is **25.8**. The report further exposes the scare research opportunities in the country as **students enrolled in PhD is mere 0.5%** of the total student enrollment. Also, at present, there is no mechanism for ensuring the accountability and performance of professors in universities and colleges. This is unlike foreign universities where the performance of college faculty is evaluated by their peers and students. The Department of Science and Technology mentions that **Indian R&D expenditure has remained constant at around 0.6%-0.7%** of its GDP. This is very low compare to countries like China (2%), Israel (4.3%). India has **severely under-invested in education over the last 40 years**, and today even the top institutions have very poor laboratory facilities. In India, there are **separate research institutes and universities**. This leads to most Indian universities and colleges conducting very little research. Further, most of the time, the **faculty is under pressure to publish a certain number of papers to gain promotion**. This often makes them **publish in predatory journals** as a way out.

The practical field work for technical education, more often than not are undertaken at laboratories, industrial institutions and workshops outside the centres of training. In the present state of acute financial position, it is not possible to provide large workshops in the educational institutions. Also, today we find many technicians facing unemployment. **Lack of relevant career opportunities** diminishes the appeal of academic education among students. For example, if studying hard and critical thinking doesn't lead to career improvement, students tend to lose academic ambition. This generally happens when technical schools prescribe a curriculum without keeping view the requirements of the industries. As a matter of fact, the technical education should be organized, keeping in view the needs of the industries. In India, only a few jobs exist after higher education. The Majority of jobs require lower skills and pay poorly. In such a system the Lower-ranked colleges don't find any motivation to improve themselves. Moreover, the progress in the utility and quality of the research work does not compare favourably with foreign research works. We need to redefine our technical curriculum as the supply of skilled labor force lags behind the demand of the industry. Even in terms of **pupil teacher ratio**, it is quite low as compared to the other foreign countries.

Recently, Quacquarelli Symonds (QS) released their World University Rankings for 2022. In that, no Indian institution figures in the top 100 list in that index. Further, only three educational institutes from India feature in the top 200 list. This raises the important question regarding the quality of higher education in India. Also, as per AISHE 2019-20 report, the situation of higher education in India has improved as compared to the past. But it is still far behind in comparison to countries like China, Israel, etc. Hence, urgent steps are needed to improve the quality of higher education in India, else the demographic dividend might turn into a demographic disaster.



10.4.3.3. Bodies associated with Higher Education:

Government has formed different regulatory bodies in order to make our education system more inclusive. Some of the bodies established by the government are discussed below:

1. **All India Council of Technical Education (AICTE):** It is the statutory body and a national-level council for technical education, under Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Human Resource Development.
2. **Indian Council of Historical Research (ICHR):** The Indian Council of Historical Research (ICHR) is an autonomous body of the Ministry of Human Resource Development, which had been established by an Administrative Order of the then Ministry of Education. The body, over many years, has provided financial assistance to the historians and direction to the research scholars in their multifarious topics of historical research through established historians and scholars of the country.
3. **Indian Council of Social Science Research (ICSSR):** The Indian Council of Social Science Research is an important organization of the Central Government. This council was established in August 1969 by

the Central Government. It is an autonomous organization. This council helps to provide opportunities for conducting research in the field of higher education.

4. **University Grants Commission (UGC):** The University Grants Commission (UGC) of India is a **statutory organization** set up by the Union government in 1956, charged with coordination, determination, and maintenance of standards of university education. It provides recognition to universities in India and disburses funds to such recognized universities and colleges. Its headquarters are in New Delhi, and six regional centers in Pune, Bhopal, Kolkata, Hyderabad, Guwahati and Bangalore.

UGC:

UGC provides funds to the various higher educational institutes and carries out the function of coordination, determination and maintenance of standards in institutions of higher education. However, UGC has been found to have an inadequate regulatory structure for higher education that has resulted in a visible deterioration in standards. While providing grants, widespread irregularities in approval of institutions and courses has been found. The fund-granting process of the UGC has also been plagued with allegations of corruption and inefficiency. UGC is not capable of monitoring the standards of education in higher education institutions. UGC does not have the adequate number of personnel, of requisite quality, to be an effective regulatory force in the higher education sector.

As per **Hari Gautam committee report on UGC**, UGC has deviated from its core goal of being a watchdog for ensuring excellence in education. The panel has also raised questions about selection criterion for UGC members saying that at times even businessmen have made the cut. It has mentioned working structure of UGC as extremely ad-hoc where there is no coordination between different wings which leads to wastage of man and money power.

Higher Education Commission of India (HECI):

The Higher Education Commission of India (Repeal of University Grants Commission Act) Bill 2018 seeks to repeal UGC Act and provides for setting up of Higher Education Commission of India. The HECI is supposed to replace the University Grants Commission which has been responsible for the maintenance of the standard of higher education in India. HECI shall function as a body that lays down uniform standards for the development of education in India. Higher Education Regulatory Council (NHERC) is expected to function as the common, single point regulator for the higher education sector to relook and repeal existing Acts and restructure various existing regulatory bodies. The aim of HECI is to decrease the number of regulators and to decrease the interference of the government in the management of the educational institutions. HECI claims that the regulation of higher education institutions will be more transparent. It encourages public disclosures by specifying the various parameters of the academic outcomes and the academic performance by all the higher educational institutions.

10.4.3.4. Steps taken by government to improve higher education:

Different steps have been taken by the government to improve our higher education system. **For Technical Education, IMPacting Research INnovation and Technology (IMPRINT)** is a Pan-IIT and IISc joint initiative to develop a roadmap for research to solve major engineering and technology challenges in ten technology domains relevant to India. These 10 domains are Health Care, Computer Science and ICT, Advance Materials, Water Resources and River systems, Sustainable Urban Design, Defence, Nano-technology Hardware, Environmental Science and Climate Change and Energy Security. Another scheme is **Uchchatar Avishkar Yojana**, which is under Ministry of Human Resource Development. It aims to promote industry-specific need-based research in the educational institutions to keep up the competitiveness of the Indian industry in the global market. All the IITs have been encouraged to work with the industry to identify areas where innovation is

required. The main aim of launching the UAY scheme is to make students more accustomed with the outer world and give them a market oriented mindset.

Global Initiative of Academic Network (GIAN) programme was formally launched by the Union Minister for Human Resource Development to tap the talent pool of scientists and entrepreneurs, internationally and encourage their engagement with the institutes of Higher Education in India. This would augment the country's existing academic resources, accelerate the pace of quality reform, and elevate India's scientific and technological capacity to global excellence. It enables interaction of students and faculty with the best academic and industry experts from all over the world and also share their experiences and expertise to motivate people to work on Indian problems. It is a system of Guest Lectures by internationally and nationally renowned experts targeted towards a comprehensive Faculty Development Programme not only for new IITs, IIMs, IISERs but also other institutions in the country.

Launched in December, 2002, **Technical Education Quality Improvement Programme (TEQIP)** aims to upscale and support ongoing efforts in improving quality of technical education and enhancing existing capacities of the institutions to become dynamic, demand-driven, quality conscious, efficient and forward looking, responsive to rapid economic and technological developments occurring both at national and international levels. **Higher Education Financing Agency (HEFA)** is a joint venture of **MHRD** Government of India and **Canara Bank** for financing/ creation of capital assets in premier educational institutions in India. HEFA's scope is greatly expanded to cover school education, educational institutes under Ministry of health etc. Its main work is towards developing India's top-ranked institutions like IIT's, IIIT's, NIT's, IISCs, AIIMS into Globally top ranking institutions through improvement in their academic and infrastructure quality.

For improving the **University and Higher Education**, the **National Education Policy 2020** contains certain key initiatives. They are, setting up of HECI (Higher Education Commission of India) as an umbrella regulator except for legal and medical education. It will have four verticals, namely – National Higher Education Regulatory Council (NHERC) for regulation; General Education Council (GEC) for standard-setting; Higher Education Grants Council (HEGC) for funding; and National Accreditation Council (NAC) for accreditation. It has made higher education broad-based, multi-disciplinary and holistic with the provision of the flexible curriculum; integration of vocational education; multiple entries and exit points with respective degrees and setting the Under Graduate education period between 3-4 years. It also aims to raise the Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) to 50% by 2035.

Rashtriya Uchchatar Shiksha Abhiyan (RUSA) - National Higher Education Mission is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS), launched in 2013, which aims at providing strategic funding to eligible state higher educational institutions. The **Bhuvan-RUSA Portal**, developed by the National Remote Sensing Centre (NRSC) of Indian Space Research Organization (ISRO) is a user-friendly mobile application which enables to collect and report geo-tagged information on various parameters such as new construction, up-gradation work and equipment in state higher educational institutions. This mobile app will provide a platform for controlled crowdsourcing to build spatial database on Bhuvan Geo-platform.

The **National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF)** has been launched by Ministry of Human Resource Development (MHRD), Government of India. This framework outlines a methodology to rank institutions across the country. The methodology draws from the overall recommendations broad understanding arrived at by a Core Committee set up by MHRD, to identify the broad parameters for ranking various universities and institutions. The parameters it broadly covers include– Teaching, Learning and Resources; Research and Professional Practices; Graduation Outcomes; Outreach and Inclusivity; and Perception.

10.5. Online Education

e-Education or online education is the application of information and communication technology (ICT) for delivering education at different levels in India. Through e-governance in education, education services are made available to citizens in a convenient, efficient, and transparent manner. This will be very much helpful in achieving the desired target of literacy in India.

From 'blackboard' to 'digital board', Government schools in rural India are witnessing a technological revolution. e-learning has also grown along with the development of technology. e-learning along with ICT has a greater impact on the growth of the economic educational system of the countries. The number of courses and programs offered through online have been increased in recent times in most of the higher education institutions. The emergence of e-learning has lent its supporting hand to government to overcome the shortage of teachers. It is making learning easier, comfortable and accessible, thereby helping in increasing the literacy rate in India.

10.5.1. Steps taken by government:

Different Steps have been taken by the government in order to promote Information and communication technology (ICT) for delivering education. **SWAYAM PRABHA** is a group of 32 DTH channels devoted to telecasting of high-quality educational programmes on 24X7 basis using the GSAT-15 satellite. Every day, there will be new content for at least (4) hours which would be repeated 5 more times in a day, allowing the students to choose the time of their convenience. It would involve curriculum based course contents covering diverse disciplines such as arts, science, commerce, performing arts, social sciences and humanities subjects, engineering, technology, law, medicine, agriculture etc. It also covers all level of education: School education, undergraduate, postgraduate, engineering, out of school children, vocational courses and teacher training.

SWAYAM - Massive Open Online Course(MOOCs): SWAYAM-MOOCs project is intended to address the needs of school level 9-12 to Undergraduate and Postgraduate students, covering all disciplines. The MOOC platform has been launched by the government with the objective of taking "the best teaching learning resources to all, including the most disadvantaged,". "SWAYAM will enable students to virtually attend the courses taught by the best faculty; access high quality reading resources, participate in discussion forums; take tests and earn academic grades." The **National Digital Library of India (NDLI)** is another project of the Ministry of Human Resource Development under the aegis of National Mission on Education through Information and Communication Technology (NMEICT). The objective of NDL is to make digital educational resources available to all citizens of the country to empower, inspire and encourage learning. National Digital Library of India is developed by IIT Kharagpur. The digital library anytime and anywhere absolutely free of cost and will contribute greatly to the Government's commitment towards "**Padhe Bharat Badhe Bharat**".

Digital International Standard Book Number (ISBN) portal seeks to facilitate publishers and authors to register for allotment ISBN online. It aims to automate completely the process of seeking application, their examination and allotment of ISBNs. **Vittiya Saksharta Abhiyan** aims to create awareness among people about digital economy and cashless modes of transactions. Under it, young students and faculty members will be roped to encourage and motivate people to use a digitally enabled cashless economic system for transfer of fund. The **National Academic Depository (NAD)** is an interoperable digital store house of academic awards (degrees, diplomas, certificates, mark-sheets, etc.) available on 24 X 7 online mode. It provides a system for lodging, retrieval, authentication and verification of academic awards in digital format for students, academic institutions, boards, eligibility assessment bodies and other user/verifying entities like bank, employer companies, government agencies and academic institutions. In September 2021, **N-DEAR (National digital architecture)** was launched to act as a 'super connect between various academic activities, in the same way as

UPI interface revolutionized the banking sector. It will play a major role in eradicating inequality in education and its modernization.

However, there are major challenges in improving e-education in India. There is a lack of awareness of the eLearning platforms among many students and parents. For those who have access, there are bandwidth issues and connectivity issues. There is also lack of computer literacy among a mainstream population. This is true for the rural masses as well and this also hinders introduction of eLearning and its implementation. Another concern is the lack of e-content of high quality and difficulty in engaging learners actively for online learning.

10.5.2. Pandemic and digital education:

Coronavirus-induced school closures in the country, removed a safety-net for many young students. Virtual classrooms highlighted social inequalities, be it access via mobile/tablet/laptop or lack of internet to even join the call. When governments across the world enforced “stay-at-home” orders, we saw the shutdown of schools, educational institutions and universities. Lakhs of students went from learning in a physical space at their schools/colleges to a virtual realm; and within a matter of days, educators had transformed lesson plans into content fit for learning via WhatsApp/Zoom. With public schools being completely shut for more than a year, a majority of the kids coming from low-income families, had no access to any form of education for more than 12 months. Expected issues like lack of smart devices and access to the internet, forced these kids to miss an entire year of schooling. Further, most of them might have probably forgotten what they already knew. Their families, especially in rural India, also might have gotten used to having extra hands at home and will possibly be reluctant to send their kids back to school again.

Given the social impact of education in our country, reopening schools has stayed high on priority, even for the governments. Many schools and colleges have come up with creative ideas regarding how to restart learning in their premises. For instance, some rural areas have begun using outdoor locations, or teaching in smaller groups in local community centres. The government can also think of increasing the duration of the academic year, to give the system more time to make up for the lost year and half, and facilitate widespread teacher vaccinations drives. Some states have kept mandatory vaccination for teachers as a criterion to give permissions for schools and colleges to reopen. According to Unified District Information System for Education (UDISE) survey 2019-20, only one in four teachers in India was trained to use a computer for teaching. And bridging this digital divide to enable online learning would take time. But accessing and creating free standardized content that can be easily disseminated through existing widespread mediums like television, radio and telephone can be done immediately. Many states have already undertaken this practice and such examples are mentioned in the section below. Moreover, governments and State education departments would also need to create new standardized assessments to ensure that continued learning takes place via these platforms.

Examples of digital education initiatives:

1. **‘Wise’**- It is a mobile phone app integrated with Zoom video streaming service which has been developed by two engineering graduates from IIT Bombay. It helps in imparting online teaching even on low Internet bandwidth i.e. 2G connectivity. For students coming from low income backgrounds and low connectivity areas, this app has come as a great boon. It is already being used by more than 3,000 teachers and 2,50,000 students, especially for the students and teachers in Kashmir.
2. **‘Diganta Swaraj Foundation’** has come up with an initiative called **‘Bolki Shaala’** or ‘Speaking School’, to enable students in remote villages of the tribal belt of Maharashtra to continue their learning, with the help of loudspeakers. The teachers record the study material in advance, which is then played out through loudspeakers for students. Students gather in small groups in open spaces to listen to them. A volunteer is available at hand to answer questions and clarify doubts, if any.

3. 'Bleetech Innovations' has created a **remote learning kit** for deaf children. The kit contains workbooks with visual contents and requisite stationery to enable deaf students to remain in touch with their studies, even as their schools are closed.
4. '**Support Our Students**', an initiative started in Bengaluru aimed at collecting old and unused desktop computers, laptops and tablets from willing donors. The volunteers would get the devices refurbished, and then donate them to underprivileged children who were in urgent need of such devices for their education. Nonprofits like 'Stree Shikshan Sanstha' and 'Lodge Trimurthy', also joined hands to donate used tablets for reading to girl students from the slums of Nagpur.
5. Teachers from government schools in Karnataka also helped in bringing schools to the doorsteps of students residing in hinterlands. The teachers travelled daily (5-20km) to remote villages in their *talukas* to teach students in village public areas like temples, community centres, under the shade of trees, etc. The teachers also conducted story sessions and singing competitions, and played games in between class hours, to keep them engaged. Similar concept was adopted in Tripura in the form of 'neighbourhood classes' and in Chhattisgarh in the form of 'mohalla classes'.
6. In Nagaland, '**Pen-drive schools**' became common, wherein pen-drives holding study materials was distributed among students. A similar initiative was adopted in Dadra & Nagar Haveli, wherein workbooks for students, containing study materials and solved examples, were delivered to students' homes by the administration.
7. The government of Sikkim began the '**Home-schooling for elementary education**' scheme, under which government school teachers would visit students in remote villages, at their homes or in public places like community centres, to teach them. Even in Dumarthar- a remote tribal village in Jharkhand, teachers adopted a unique way of imparting education. The mud-baked walls of some houses were painted and converted into **blackboards**, to facilitate open-air teaching.
8. In Odisha, the '**Radio Pathsala**' program imparted lessons to students via radio, parallel to the online version.

Online education world is full of information on everything. Educational videos, which have helped thousands, can advance learning even beyond the pandemic, using talented teacher-communicators. States such as Tamil Nadu and Kerala have already hosted curriculum-based video lessons on the internet, after beaming them on television. This would take out-of-the-box thinking during the pandemic to come up with interventions that are a substitute for traditional methods and prevent 2020 from becoming **a zero year**. It is important to note that 80% of families provided learning support to children. Schools opting for a hybrid solution of partial reopening and online learning should ensure expanding the availability of textbooks for all students including those who dropped out or are waiting to be formally admitted. Government must try to bridge the digital divide by providing the needy families with the necessary support in terms of equipment and access to the internet. Incorporating a **blended learning method** would bring the benefits of both traditional and e- Learning modes and help in advancing e-learning initiatives in India. There needs to be a thorough upgradation of technological infrastructure and reduction of access fees and bringing them to an affordable scale. **Incorporating mobile learning** will help overcome the issues of connectivity and accessibility to a great extent. One must also **ensure that quality e-content is developed and monitored** to ensure that standards are maintained.

How have digital initiatives in India contributed to the functioning of the education system in the country? Elaborate your answer. (UPSC 2020)

Policymakers, also need to promote **employment led-growth oriented policies** to create enough jobs for 650 million Indian youths under age 25. The funding for the R&D sector should be increased to improve infrastructure and the funding for research. It would also prevent the brain-drain of talents from the country. With the advent of a pandemic, now digital education is not an alternative option but an imperative option. So

the government and other stakeholders have to improve the ICT for post pandemic education system in India. India also needs to **collaborate with foreign institutes and industries** to foster a culture of research, upgrade pedagogy and facilitate industry student connection, etc. The government has to take **steps to improve the pay scale** offered to teachers and by **putting an end to the system of ad-hoc and temporary appointments**. Instead, the government can force the higher educational institutes in India to go for the faculty recruitment process well before a post is vacated. Further, the government can appoint a separate body for a **performance audit of teachers**. The government has to broaden the scope of Massive Open Online Course (MOOCs) and Open and Distance Learning (ODL) to provide access to quality education beyond geographical boundaries.

11. URBANIZATION

Urbanization is the societal trend where the proportion of people living in cities and towns increases while the proportion of people living in the countryside diminishes. In sociology, the term urbanization is also used to denote a distinct way of life, which emerges in cities due to their large, dense and heterogeneous population. Such a life is distinct from the life and activities of the people living in villages. 'Urban' refers to the geographic territory within or close to a city. Urbanization in India has become an important and irreversible process, and it is an important determinant of national economic growth and poverty reduction. According to Census of India, there are three conditions to qualify the **definition of 'urban'**—

1. There should be at least 5,000 inhabitants,
2. There should be density of 400 people per sq. km or more, and
3. At least 75% of male working population should be engaged in non-farming activities

As per the census definition, 31.16% (37.7 crore) of the Indian population lived in urban areas in 2011. This population is located in 7,933 towns comprising of 4,041 Statutory Towns and 3,892 Census Towns. But the share of urban population which lives in towns and cities that are governed by urban local bodies is even lower at 26%. It is estimated that by 2030, 50 per cent of India's population would reside in urban areas. United Nations estimates that India undercounts its urban population by at least 12% (based on 2011 Census).

In 1900, 10% of the world's population lived in cities. Today the figure is over 55%, and it will reach 75% by 2050 (UN Urbanization Prospects projections-2018). The UN estimates that the milestone event – when the number of people in urban areas overtook the number in rural settings – occurred in 2007.

11.1. Concept

Urbanization is an integral part of the process of economic growth. As is the case in most countries, India's towns and cities have expanded rapidly when increasing number of people migrate to towns and cities in search of economic opportunities. Major enablers of urbanization include:

1. Industrialization
2. Commercialization
3. Social benefits and better public services
4. Employment opportunities
5. Aspiration for modernization and changes in the mode of living
6. Gradual rural to urban transformation

Urbanization yields several positive effects if it happens within the appropriate limits. India's urban areas make a major contribution to the country's economy. Added to the demographic dividend India is passing through, if urbanisation is regulated properly, it can bring positive changes in different parameters as Indian cities contribute to about 2/3rd of the economic output. They are a host to the growing share of the population and the hotspots of FDI and business activities. They are the major originators of innovation and technology and result in technological and infrastructural advancements. They also have the potential to create huge **employment opportunities** for the young demography- with mean age approaching 27 years and which is one of the youngest in the world. Improved transportation and communication, quality educational and medical facilities are all enablers for a better standard of living in urban areas. The overall **quality of life** in cities is thus better than in rural areas. The culture of living in 'rented apartments' is prevalent in cities than in villages, where people generally live in their own homes. From a societal perspective, 'caste' often transforms into 'class' and there is lesser caste based discrimination in urban areas. An urban society is also more liberal and less orthodox. However, the backwardness in rural society is not because of better quality of services in urban India,

but because of lack of availability, accessibility and affordability of services in rural India. The poor have always been discriminated against and have been the neglected child in India's growth story.

**The detailed effects of urbanization on the institution of family, caste system and the status of women in society have already been discussed in earlier chapters.*

11.2. Characteristics

India is said to be in the midst of transition from a **predominantly rural to a quasi-urban society**. The process of urbanization has been characterized by an increase in the number of large cities. Today, the number of urban agglomerations/towns in India is 5161. The most urbanized states are Goa (62%), Mizoram and Tamil Nadu. Delhi (97.5%) is the most urbanized among the UTs. An important feature of urbanization in India has been that urbanization has occurred without sufficient industrialization and growth of a robust economic base. Changes in the land-use pattern have resulted in growth of many a 'cities and towns both horizontally and vertically. This urban transformation has mainly been a product of demographic explosion and poverty induced rural-urban migration. Hope for better prospects in cities attracts people to urban areas resulting in high population increase. Stagnation and volatility of agriculture and lack of sectoral diversification has also resulted in a rural to urban push.

Migration accounts for approximately 40% of the growth in urban population, converting the rural poverty into urban one. As migrants show high selectivity in choosing their destination based on known economic opportunities and due to regional division in pace of urbanization, the pressure on selective urban centres has set into motion an **urban decay**. Urban decay is a sociological concept where cities and towns have degraded to an extent beyond repairs. The 2030 development agenda of the United Nations has emphasized the role of sustainable cities through its Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) 11, i.e., Sustainable Cities and Communities for making cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient and sustainable. However, rapid and lopsided urbanisation in India has led to massive growth of slums followed by misery, poverty, unemployment, exploitation, inequalities and degradation in the quality of urban life. Today 38% of the total slum population reside in the million plus cities, which also constitute nearly 17.4% of urban households. Moreover, in spite of urban areas being economic powerhouse, they are considered as ecological blackholes, due to absence of adequate green cover.

11.3. Problems of urbanization and associated government initiatives

The patterns of urbanization in India have been marked by interstate diversities, large scale rural to urban migration, insufficient infrastructural facilities, growth of slums and other related problems. It has also aided westernization, with decline in traditional customs and processes, leading to moral degeneracy. Urbanization has increased the class divide and resulted in a more indifferent and apathetic attitude among the people. The culture of gated societies has turned them into standalone islands of elites, with discriminatory attitude against the lower working class- like plumbers, electricians, house-helps, etc. Some of the other major problems of urbanization faced in different parts of India are as follows:

1. Housing problems and slums

Due to large scale influx of migrants from rural areas, the economic base of cities becomes incapable of dealing with the problems created by the excess demand for housing. Lack of adequate housing in almost every city, results in a huge population living in slums and ghettos, thereby adding to the size of cities. The complex engagement of high cost of living, unemployment and explosive population growth results in the unregulated spread of slums and squatters. This growth is further exacerbated by clustered industrialization, lack of developed land for housing and the inflated prices of land and houses which are beyond the reach of the urban poor. Out of 4,041 Statutory Towns in Census 2011, slums were reported from 2,543 Towns (63%). People who are living in slums increased from 52 million

in 2001 to 65.5 million in 2011. There is development of unregulated slums on government properties. As slums are illegal colonies, they do not have any civic amenities like drinking water, sewage, electricity etc. This became a major problem during COVID management especially in urban slums like Dharavi, which saw a huge upsurge of cases on a daily basis. Housing provided by slums also suffers from poor structural quality and low durability. The tenancy is not secure, making people susceptible to harassment and corruption.

Remedies: Development of inclusive cities; improved urban planning; affordable housing; interstate self-registration process to monitor the scale of migration; e-governance; capacity building; population control.

Jaga Mission

The state government's initiative granting land rights to thousands of slum dwellers under the Odisha Liveable Habitat Mission (OLHM) or Jaga Mission won the bronze at World Habitat Awards. The annual award is given by World Habitat, a UK-based organisation, in partnership with UN-Habitat, in recognition of innovative, outstanding and revolutionary ideas, projects, and programmes from across the world.

Government Initiatives:

Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana - Urban: Its objective is to promote 'affordable housing' for weaker sections in urban areas through credit linked subsidy. Central government provides an interest subsidy of 6.5% on housing loans availed by the beneficiaries for a period of 15 years from the commencement of their loan tenure. It aims at rehabilitating the existing slum dwellers with private sector participation using land as a resource.

2. **Overcrowding & Poor infrastructure**

It is a situation wherein too many people live in a small space. This form of congestion in urban areas is the consequence of overpopulation. In case of India, especially its capital cities and metropolis, it is an aspect that keeps increasing day by day as more people flock to cities in search of better life and opportunities. The influx of people not only cripples the civic amenities but also puts undue pressure on established infrastructures of cities. Inadequate provisions for social infrastructure create socio-economic traps for the urban poor who can only afford to live in a hand-to-mouth existence with no social mobility, further perpetuating economic inequalities.

Remedies: Augmentation of basic urban infrastructure in water supply, solid waste management, sanitation and urban transport; local governance; Improvements in local body financing; local capacity building

Government Initiatives:

- a. **AMRUT: Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation:** It aims at providing basic civic amenities like water supply, sewerage so as to improve the quality of life for all especially the poor and the disadvantaged. It also focuses on infrastructure creation that has a direct link to provision of better services to the citizens. Its objective is to ensure that every household has access to a tap with assured supply of water and a sewerage connection.
- b. **Smart Cities Mission:** Its objective is to promote sustainable and inclusive cities that provide core infrastructure and give a decent quality of life to its citizens. Area-based development is done to transform older, disorganized parts of cities into model areas.
- c. **Swachh Bharat Mission:** Its objective is to build up capacities in urban local bodies to design, execute and operate all systems related to cleanliness, and to create public awareness about sanitation, hygiene and waste disposal. It aims to completely overhaul the scientific processing, disposal, reuse and recycling of the Municipal Solid Waste.

3. Unemployment

The problem of unemployment is highest in urban areas. The urban informal sector comprises a large part of the unorganized non-agriculture sector. Low levels of education and skill in the unorganized sector workers have resulted in their inability to access the opportunities offered by the expanding market. The commercial nature of industries in urban areas increasingly supports mechanization of infrastructure and thus there is lesser generation of employment with economic growth and growth of cities. The continuing relocation of people from rural areas or hinterland to urban areas and incapacity of urban economy to cater to unskilled migrants results in rise in unemployment. Unemployment eventually results in surge in **urban crimes**. This underscores the criticality of skills up-gradation to capitalize on better livelihoods opportunities in urban areas.

Remedies: skilling, training, labor-intensive industrialization

Government Initiatives:

- a. **Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana-National Urban Livelihood Mission (DAY-NULM):** It involves training urban poor to meet the demand from urban citizens by imparting market-oriented skills through City Livelihood Centers. Social Mobilization and Institution Development through formation of Self-Help Groups (SHG) for training members and an initial support of Rs 10,000 for each group is given. An interest subsidy of 5% - 7% is given for setting up individual micro-enterprises with a loan of up to 2 lakh and group enterprises are supported with a loan of up to Rs.10 lakhs.
 - b. **Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana:** Skill training of youth is done through the National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC) under the Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship. A monetary reward is given to trainees on assessment and certification by third party assessment bodies.
 - c. **Prime Minister's Employment Generation Programme (PMEGP):** It is a credit linked subsidy programme being implemented by Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises. It aims at generating self-employment opportunities through establishment of micro enterprises by organizing traditional artisans and unemployed youth into groups.
- ### 4. Rise in poverty & hunger

The benefits of life in the city are not evenly distributed. As noted by the International Monetary Fund "the process of urbanization has affected rural poverty more than urban poverty". Often only a small percentage of any fast-growing urban population really gets access to urban opportunities and this number tends to be shrinking further. Urban poverty in India is over 25 percent of the urban population. More than 8 crore people live in urban areas on incomes that are below the poverty line. According to FAO estimates in the report 'The State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World, 2018', 19.59 crore people are undernourished in India. By this measure 14.8% of the population is undernourished in India. As per government **criteria for poverty**, monthly expenditure of up to Rs 1000 in urban areas (**Tendulkar committee, 2009**) or earlier nutritional fulfillment of up to 2,100 calories a day for urban area (Lakdawala Committee, 1993) was considered the threshold of poverty. In urban areas, about **57 per cent** of the population does not consume the threshold calories.

Remedies: Provision of essential services; creation of more jobs; mid-day meals, public distribution system (PDS); address the issue of capability deprivation (Amartya Sen), effective poverty reduction welfare schemes (Abhijit Bannerjee's randomized control trial method)

Government Schemes:

- a. **DAY-National Urban Livelihoods Mission (DAY-NULM)-** **same as discussed in previous sections*
- b. **Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana - Urban: Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana - Urban-** **same as discussed in previous sections*
- c. **Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana:** It's a food security welfare scheme announced by the Government of India in March 2020, during the COVID-19 pandemic. The scheme aims to feed the poorest citizens by providing grains through the Public Distribution System, and is

implemented by the Department of Food and Public Distribution under the Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution.

5. **Waste disposal**

Large increase in population has led to enormous amount of solid waste generation. Huge quantities of garbage produced by our cities pose a serious health problem and pollution. In recent years, disposal of electronic waste or E-waste has become a very serious problem. Cities like Bengaluru generate around 5000 tons of solid waste on daily basis. The collection, transportation and disposal of this huge quantity of solid waste poses another serious problem overstressing the stunted capacities of the municipalities. This has resulted in rise in uncollected waste, buildup of waste at public places and dysfunctional waste management.

Remedies: Mandatory waste collection e.g manufacturers' obligation as in **E-Waste (Management) Rules, 2016**; provision of penalty for public littering; waste disposal centers, sewage treatment plants.

Government Schemes:

- a. **Swachh Bharat Mission**—*same as discussed in previous sections
- b. **The Million-plus Cities Challenge:** Proposed by the 15th Finance Commission, it allocates tied funds to 42 urban agglomerations with population of more than a million. The conditions cover factors of ambient air quality (32%) and service-level benchmark for drinking water and solid waste management (68%).

6. **Financial crunch in Urban local bodies**

The **Constitution (74th Amendment) Act, 1992** also known led to the establishment of Urban Local Bodies (ULBs). It was aimed at supplementing the inadequate Constitutional provision for Local Self Government. But according to NITI AYO, only 11 states have so far devolved municipal functions to Urban Local Bodies. Even in these states, Municipal bodies are dependent on state governments for funds and decision making. This weak and unpredictable financing framework cripples their operational autonomy in delivering adequate urban services and hence limits their capacity to manage their resources effectively. As a result, water and sanitation problems persist, and poor status of health and prevalence of diseases continues.

Remedies: Municipal bonds; Credit Risk Guarantee Funds; decentralization of taxation to local bodies; property tax to generate additional revenue at city level; budgetary support to augment existing infrastructure; greater financial and political independence for the municipalities.

Government Initiatives:

Smart Cities Mission: Its objective is to promote sustainable and inclusive cities on basis of area-based development. Special purpose vehicles have been created to implement projects and mobilize resources.

The objective of the **Smart Cities Mission** is to promote cities that provide core infrastructure, give a decent quality of life to its citizens, a clean and sustainable environment and **application of 'Smart' Solutions**. It shall focus on urban renewal, retrofitting and green field development. It envisages comprehensive development of institutional, physical, social and economic infrastructure in 100 cities by 2022.

Issues with SCM:

The mission is emerging as **too project specific**, a small area based “**smart technology enclaves**” are planned over just 5% of city areas consuming 80% of allocated money, which otherwise could have been spent over whole city. The mission will also perpetuate bias and discrimination in our national planning process. Estimates suggests India will have **40% of its population in cities by 2030**. SCM neglects the poor and marginalized populations that contributes their sweat and blood in building cities but rarely find their right to adequate housing honoured. Smart city mission is also plagued by

the **glaring absence of a rights-based approach**. There have been cases of **slum clearances for city beautification**. The implementation of the mission at the city level will be done by a **Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV)** created for the purpose thereby overpowering elected ULBs. In a nutshell, citizens and their elected grass root representatives have less power to take decisions in their city planning.

Need is to reinvent mission, from smart city to sustainable city, which requires a change from **piecemeal area based intervention to holistic urban planning paradigm**, so as to accommodate 600 million of citizens in these cities by 2030. The Mission needs a **'human rights-based implementation and monitoring framework'** to assess the achievement of targets. It must develop a special focus on the needs, concerns and human rights of the marginalized groups, individuals and communities. **Human-rights based impact assessment (HIA) and environmental impact assessment (EIA)** should be mandatory for all 'smart city' projects, before they are approved. There should be **meaningful participation and engagement of the people** in the selection and execution of smart city projects in all cities. The **free, prior and informed consent** of all persons likely to be impacted by any 'smart city' project should be obtained before the particular project is approved or selected. The **rights to adequate housing, work/livelihood**, security of the person and home, water, sanitation, health, food, privacy and information must be protected. It should especially focus on empowering women and weaker sections. These sustainable cities should be based on **intra and intergenerational equality**. It should also focus on renewable energy, natural ventilation system, green building ratings, green roofs, enhanced mobility through mass transit system, pedestrianization, cycling, car free landscapes, sustainable drainage etc. **Modest ecological footprint & reduce, reuse, recycle should be the mantra**. Plastic ban, waste segregation, solid waste management, universal sanitation, emission reduction need to be engraved in citizen behaviour.

The mission should align with India's legal commitments under the Paris Agreement and its Intended Nationally Determined Contribution (INDCs), its New Urban Agenda (2016) and **Sustainable Development Goal 11: Sustainable Cities and Communities** which strives for making cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient, and sustainable. Today, cities need to be protected and developed in a sustainable and inclusive manner, simultaneously equal attention needs to be paid on development of smart villages and other rural transformation related interventions which will not only help arrest excessive urbanization leading to its unplanned, pressurized and sudden growth but also will lead to dispersal of economic opportunities to the countryside.

7. Transport issues

Indian cities are characterized by increasing levels of **congestion, pollution, road accidents and inequality in access to mobility**. The need for better urban mobility in order to build inclusive, safer and more sustainable cities cannot be overstated. As the incomes increase, the purchasing capacity increase and the high-income individuals buy more private vehicles and use less public transport. At the same time, with the growth of cities, the distances to be travelled for work and other reasons increase and there is increasing pressure on public transport. Over the years, this paradox starts to create traffic jams, reducing the utility of private vehicles while increasing crowding in public transport.

Vehicular pollution is the biggest contributor to urban pollution. Also, of the 20 most polluted cities in the world, the top 14 are Indian cities. In 2013, 16 Chinese cities (including Beijing) were among the 20 most polluted cities in the world. However, there were only 4 Chinese cities among the top 20 in 2016. On the other hand, in 2013, only 3 Indian cities figured among the top 20 which increased to 14 cities in 2016. Vehicular pollution mainly due to trucks, tempos and other diesel run vehicles is one of

the most important causes for pollution in cities. Moreover, combustion in power plants and industries using dirty fuels, like pet coke, FO and its variants, coal and biomass also releases hazardous air pollutants. Garbage burning, road dust; dust due to construction sites etc., add further to the particulate pollution. The Annual air quality-Life Index Report by University of Chicago revealed that an average Delhiite lost 9.7 years of life on an average, due to persistent air pollution. High level of congestion has economic implications as well, in the form of reduced productivity, fuel waste, and accidents. Further, there is an acute shortage of parking spaces both on and off the streets in the urban centers. Safety in public transport is another major issue. It is the single biggest factor constraining women's mobility.

Unplanned urbanization in India has led to gentrification of city centers while lower income groups are forced to live in peripheral suburbs which have increased their cost and time for commuting. Most of the lower income groups and urban poor fail to afford private transport and even public transport is becoming expensive by each passing day.

Remedies: Regulation of number of vehicle registration for example in Singapore; odd and even scheme; rapid transits for example- Project Loop; cascading public transports.

Government Initiatives:

- a. **AMRUT Mission: Earlier Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission (JNNURM, 2005-2014)**, it attempts to improve the public transport system in large cities through funding of public transport buses, development of comprehensive city mobility plans and supporting city transport infrastructure projects.
- b. **National Urban Transport Policy, 2006:** The policy envisages safe, affordable, quick, comfortable, reliable and sustainable urban transport through establishment of quality focused multi-modal public transport systems.
- c. **Mass Rapid Transit/ Transport Systems (MRTS):** The metro rail has come up as a favoured alternative of mass transport in Indian cities. In 2017, the government introduced new Metro Policy which aims to improve collaborations, standardizing norms, financing and creating a procurement mechanism so that the projects can be implemented effectively.
- d. **National Transit Oriented Development Policy, 2017:** The policy framework aims to promote living close to mass urban transit corridors like the Metros, monorail and bus rapid transit (BRT) corridors.
- e. **Sustainable Urban Transport Project (SUTP):** The project in partnership with Ministry of Urban Development and UNDP aims to promote environmentally sustainable urban transport in India.
- f. **Promotion of Electric Vehicles:** Indian Government plans to have an all-electric fleet of vehicles by 2030. For promotion of electric vehicles FAME (Faster Adoption and Manufacturing of (hybrid &) Electric vehicles. Under FAME, the central government subsidizes the cost of electric buses and has sanctioned 390 buses in 11 cities (as of April 2018).
- g. **National Clean Air Programme:** It aims to meet prescribed annual average ambient standards at all locations in the country in a stipulated timeframe.
- h. Launch of **National Air Quality index (AQI):** The AQI classifies air quality of a day considering criteria pollutants through colour codes and air quality descriptor. Further, it also links air quality with likely human health impacts.
- i. The Indian government has decided to skip **Bharat Stage-V** and directly move to **BS-VI** from 2020. It has further agreed to advance the proposed date for Euro-VI from 2026 to 2020.
- j. **ODD& EVEN Scheme in Delhi:** Under the scheme, cars with license plates ending in an odd number and even number are allowed to ply on alternate days. The scheme aims to cut down vehicular traffic by half, thereby reducing air pollution.

8. Environmental issues and disasters

Urbanization has led to serious degradation of the environment. Increased concretization has resulted in increasing temperatures and creation of urban heat islands with extremely low groundwater. Buildings, road, footpaths radiate heat waves in the evening, making nights as hot as days, thereby decreasing the difference between maximum and minimum temperatures, resulting in urban heat island effect. Also very little emphasis is paid on rainwater harvesting, greening and landscaping initiatives, prevention of flooding, conservation of water bodies, desilting of drains, protection of green cover, etc. Excessive tiling especially around trees and on footpaths increases surface run-off and prevents seepage of water naturally into the ground, lowering the already low water tables. Even short-duration rain spells cause urban flooding, with water-logging in many areas and overflowing storm water drains. According to recent study of NITI Aayog, India is facing 'worst' water crisis in history and demand for potable water will outstrip supply by 2030. Even higher rainfall regions like Meghalaya, Shimla are facing this critical situation. Sewage and wastewater drainage into traditional water bodies is further reducing the quality of water.

Also, illegal mining for building material such as sand and quartzite both on the catchment and on the bed of the lake have extremely damaging impact on the water bodies. For example, the Jaisamand Lake in Jodhpur, once the only source of drinking water for the city, has been suffering from illegal mining. Using water bodies to attract tourists has become a threat to several urban lakes in India. Ashtamudi Lake in Kerala's Kollam city has become polluted because of spillage of oil from motor boats. The government does not have data on the total number of urban water bodies in the country. Few cities have recorded water bodies because of court rulings. Union Ministry of Environment & Climate Change had not identified wetlands and no identifications of risks to these wetlands due to pollution of river water. Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) had not identified the major aquatic species, birds, plants and animals facing risks due to pollution of rivers and lakes.

Remedies: Afforestation, use of porous tiling, avoiding concretization nearby trees, etc., avoiding use of glass on exterior of buildings, better urban drainage system, desilting of canals and drains, early warning system, rainwater harvesting, review safety limits of dams and canals and enhance their storage capacity, rejuvenating traditional water bodies, etc.

Government initiatives:

- a. Integrated approach to sustainable urban planning by empowering Urban Local Bodies in decision making and planning of flood mitigation infrastructure. ex MMRDA's Venture Capital Funding to tap finances.
 - b. Robust anti-encroachment laws.
 - c. Sustainable slum management.
 - d. Efficient Solid waste management and sewerage lines following Israel and Singapore model and in line with SWM rules 2016.
 - e. Flood water draining network, in line with JNNURM (AMRUT) vision.
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1. With a brief background of quality of urban life in India, introduce the objectives and strategy of the 'Smart City Programme.' (UPSC 2016)
 2. Discussion the various social problems which originated out of the speedy process of urbanization in India. (UPSC 2013)

Begging (also **panhandling** or **mendicancy**) is the practice of imploring others to grant a favour, often a gift of money with little or no expectation of reciprocation. **The Bombay Prevention of Begging act of 1959** defined "Begging" as soliciting or receiving alms, in public place whether or not under any pretence such as singing, dancing, fortune telling, performing or offering any article for sale. **Beggary is an age-old social evil** and so far as India is concerned it has assumed a stupendous proportion.

Economic causes include poverty, Unemployment or underemployment and loss of agricultural occupation; lack of access to education, social protection; discrimination based on caste and ethnicity; landlessness; physical and mental challenges; and isolation. Unimaginable cruelty of some guardians, destitution of the deserted wife, helplessness of the widows, willingness of many parents to use their infirm and disability, and even custom of alms, etc. can be other reasons for beggary. **Bombay Prevention of Begging Act, 1959** criminalizes begging and has prescribed that any person if found begging would be detained for not more than three years, and on conviction for the second time, for a period of ten years. However, **Delhi High Court** in a landmark judgment held the above Act as unconstitutional in 2021, on grounds that it violates Article 14 and Article 21 of the Constitution and decriminalized begging. The bench justified its ruling on the ground that the government has the mandate to provide social security to everyone, to ensure that all citizens have the basic facilities. Presence of beggars is evidence that the state has not managed to provide these to all its citizens.

With its de-criminalization, Right to freedom (**Article 19**) and Right to life (**Article 21**) including right to livelihood are ensured. As state is not able to provide them dignified opportunity, it can't criminalize begging. Also, effective checks on arbitrary detentions must be there, so that the incidents like the commonwealth games in which many beggars were put behind bars should not be repeated. Instead of dealing with them as criminals, society needs to look for ways to rehabilitate them. However, the decision could **further the activities of organized networks** as they can now deploy more beggars. It may further **encourage trafficking** in India making weaker sections of our society more vulnerable. It will **affect tourism and India's image** at a global scale which already is considered a poor state with weak capacity to take care of its people. There is also **security risk** in society as some of these beggars and vagabonds are involved in petty crimes such as snatching, theft etc. It is very difficult to differentiate between beggars who are part of large-scale organized networks and which are due to other reasons stated above, this can boost crimes like kidnapping, drug abuse etc. Even Gandhi ji was always opposed to giving free meal to a healthy person. According to him it degrades the nation and encourages laziness, idleness and even crime.

NITI Aayog recommendations:

It has called for a 3C Framework (**Clean, Convenient and Congestion free**) for transforming mobility in India. To achieve this, it has laid down the following action-agenda:

1. **Connect Bharat:** NITI Aayog calls for a Safe, Adequate and Holistic Infrastructure (SAHI) for the Indian population including women, elderly and the disabled. Major recommendations for achieving this include **increased emphasis on safety and accessibility**; leveraging multiple modes of transport – road, rail, coastal and inland waterways, small regional airports, ropeways etc.; higher usage of data for holistic mobility needs.
2. **Optimize travel footprint:** It calls for increased emphasis to reduce congestion caused by passenger and goods flow in urban areas. Major recommendations include **Integrated land use through planning** residential and commercial complexes in an integrated manner so that travel time is reduced; focused policy-based measures for optimizing travel; and data-based measures such as intelligent transport systems.
3. **Promote seamless public transport:** It calls for an efficient and convenient public transport to address the issue of air pollution and congestion in Indian cities. Major recommendations include **Data-driven planning and urban transport, with a clear hierarchy amongst different modes**- from non-motorized (pedestrians, cycles) to public and lastly private transport; focus on multi-modal systems; make public transport affordable, comfortable and accessible for urban India; ensure better adoption.
4. **Adopting green modes and technologies:** It calls for rapid adoption of electric vehicles and non-motorized transport (NMT). Major recommendations include to improve adoption of non-motorized

transport, the routes and paths should be planned so that they integrate seamlessly with public transport. To ensure safety for NMT users by outlining norms & dedicated traffic signals should be a key priority. There should be a clear push towards clean technologies. This has to be enabled through ecosystem development which includes domestic manufacturing, deployment of charging infrastructure etc.

To sum up the discussion, urbanisation in India is trapped in the paradox of rise in working age population and decrease in generation of employment especially in the primary and secondary sectors. This has resulted in stress on built environment as the supply of both land and infrastructure is falling behind demand. Fractured planning structures are incapable of integrated planning for land use, infrastructure planning, and finance across metropolitan areas. Poor land management hinders the capacity of the private sector to be competitive and the ability of the public sector to use land based financial instruments to finance infrastructure investments. Poor urban services like drinking water, wastewater and solid waste disposal especially in non-notified slums result in severe health and sanitation issues. Inadequate services and incapacity of public transport lead to traffic chaos.

The failures in land markets and regulations are compounded by limited access to housing finance resulting in proliferation of slums. Weak and unpredictable financing frameworks limit the ability of ULBs to manage their resources effectively. Overlapping institutions across three tiers of government diffuse accountability across agencies undermining the development of coherent regulatory frameworks and sustainable service delivery models. ULBs and local service entities have neither clear responsibility nor the fiscal and operational autonomy to deliver adequate urban services. Weak Urban Local governments crippled by lack of systems and trained human resources result in mismanaged infrastructure.

Urbanization as a double-edged sword for women:

While the urbanization process has been hailed as a symbol of growth, it has been a two-edged sword for women in India with both positive and negative impacts. With advent of modern values and economic opportunities for women in urban areas, their socio economic status has improved vis-a-vis rural women. Greater independence of women in urban areas is the result of better opportunities for paid employment outside the family, better access to services, lower fertility rates, and some relaxation of the rigid social values and norms. Women in urban areas are comparatively more educated and aware about her rights. Easy access to health services in urban areas has also reduced health risks among women. Modern and increased transportation facilities too have made it easier and safe for working women to commute. Urban centres provide also access to economic resources and institutional support to help women cope with violence.

However, poor living conditions- increasing cost of urbane living, has led to springing up of slums, insanitary living conditions, absence of potable drinking water, etc. Urban centres are also marked with very high incidence of violence. Eg. Delhi is also called the rape capital of India. There is dual workload on women- managing jobs as well as household chores together, results in fatigue, anxiety disorders and other health problems. Aged women experience an intensified empty-nest-syndrome after the children grow up and get busy in their lives due to lack of communitarian lifestyle in cities. Many women become victims of trafficking by touts who lure them on the promises of better opportunities in urban areas.

For the women who are left out of urbanisation, inadequate educational facilities in rural areas hinders their accessibility. Security and other patriarchal factors prevent them from being sent to cities for better education. As a greater number of working age men move to cities to earn more, agriculture is eventually becoming feminized- forcing women into low productivity back breaking work. Health indicators for women in rural areas- Maternal mortality, anaemia, etc. are poorer as compared to those in urban areas.

Rural women are also more perceptible to dogmatic discrimination and violence such as seen in incidences involving khap panchayats, caste-based violence against women, etc.

The Union Urban Development Ministry has asked Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Rajasthan, Punjab and Uttarakhand to prepare detailed plans for the development of **counter magnet cities** in a time bound manner. Counter magnets are cities developed to reduce the mass migration of people to big cities. The Ministry has said the National Capital Region Planning Board, which was set up to formulate a plan for the region, has identified several counter magnet cities including Ambala and Hissar in Haryana, Bareilly in Uttar Pradesh, Dehradun in Uttarakhand and Patiala in Punjab. These cities are sought to be developed to disperse economic activities as well as migration from Delhi.

Sustainable urbanization is key to sustainable development. Understanding the key trends in urbanization likely to unfold over the coming years is crucial to the implementation of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. As the world continues to urbanize, sustainable development depends increasingly on the successful management of urban growth, especially in low-income and lower-middle-income countries where the pace of urbanization is projected to be the fastest. Many countries will face challenges in meeting the needs of their growing urban population, including for housing, transportation, energy systems and other infrastructure, as well as for employment and basic services such as education and health care. Integrated policies to improve the lives of both urban and rural dwellers are needed, while strengthening the linkages between urban and rural areas and building on their existing economic, social and environmental ties. To ensure that the benefits of urbanization are fully shared, policies to manage urban growth need to ensure access to infrastructure and social services for all, focusing on the needs of the urban poor and other vulnerable groups for housing, education, health care, decent work and a safe environment. Finally, efforts should be made to forge a new framework of urban development, with focus on **urbanism**.